Love Is Magic, And Magic Is Love

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/24293356.

Rating:	Explicit
Archive Warning:	No Archive Warnings Apply
Category:	F/F
Fandom:	She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)
Relationships:	Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Perfuma/Scorpia (She-Ra), Bow/Glimmer (She-Ra)
Characters:	Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Scorpia (She-Ra), Perfuma (She-Ra), Hordak (She-Ra), Wrong Hordak (She-Ra), Entrapta (She-Ra), Micah (She-Ra), Mermista (She-Ra), Frosta (She-Ra), Melog (She-Ra), Angella (She-Ra), Huntara (She-Ra)
Additional Tags:	What Happened Next, catradora, catdora - Freeform, Fluff, Romance, Comedy, Drama, Everyone Is Gay, Eventual Smut, Scorfuma, Glimbow, Angst, Happy Ending, Post-Traumatic Stress Disorder - PTSD, Smuff, Love Confessions, Idiots in Love, Catradora is CANON, Post-Canon, Self-Harm, Blood and Injury, Intimacy, Useless Lesbians, Melog is a perv, Fluff and Smut, Smut, Mild Smut, Mild Sexual Content, Mild Language, Catra (She-Ra) Redemption, Catra (She-Ra) Needs a Hug, Catra Goes to Therapy (She-Ra), POV Catra (She-Ra), no vulgarity, no crude terms
Language:	English
Collections:	She-Ra, Dark Poetesses Favorites, She-Ra, fanfics so good they deserve a podcast episode, Banco Fic
Stats:	Published: 2020-05-20 Completed: 2020-08-16 Words: 120,171 Chapters: 18/18

Love Is Magic, And Magic Is Love

by silkarc

Summary

This story continues straight after the finale of She-Ra and far, far beyond - all the way to the farthest reaches of space. The clones are still out there, somewhere, and so is Angella, but before Catra can deal with any of that she must learn to live with the terrible mistakes of her past. Only then will she feel worthy of Adora's love, as well as the unwavering friendship of the Best Friend Squad.

Notes

Cover art by: BewilderedBird

See the end of the work for more notes

Claws and Cuteness

Chapter Summary

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

I can't believe I'm sitting here, next to her; Adora, the woman I love. Just sat here, shoulder to shoulder, hand in hand - because that's a thing now, apparently - relaxing at Glimmer's palace. I look across at her, she smiles at me, squeezing my hand tightly, and I feel myself filled with warmth. She's just so beautiful, which isn't news to me but for the first time I'm allowed to stare, and allowed to enjoy looking at her.

"Cat got your tongue?" Adora asks, smirking. I can't believe it was just a few hours ago that I was holding her in my arms, and she was so weak, dying, right in front of me. When I thought I was going to lose everything, and this time for good, without any more chances to make anything right.

"Very funny," I say, nudging her shoulder with mine. It feels surreal that I finally told her how I feel, after all this time. And I'm struggling to accept she feels the same, but it must be true because that's how she pulled herself together in the end, instead of just giving up and sacrificing herself. She stayed, just like I asked her to, just like I *begged* her to.

Normally I'd be ashamed of opening up like that… but it worked. That's all that matters. She's here… she's really here.

"Hmm. Guess what? I love you," Adora says, placing an arm around my shoulders, pulling me in close while I purr happily.

"Say it again," I grin, still finding it hard to believe.

Adora laughs, "That isn't fair, you have to say it back first!"

"Haha, fine! I love you, idiot," I say. We're really here. I can't believe it, she's here, and she actually loves me back, and I have jaw-ache from smiling all the time like an idiot, like I am doing right now,

and… and loves me too. *She loves me too!*

“Well I mean, I am amazing and all,” Adora says, unlacing our fingers and flexing her left arm.

“Put the guns away, moron,” I say, chuckling, “and give me that back,” I say, grabbing her hand.

“Okay, okay!” Adora says, laughing. She traces her fingers against my palm softly, and sighs. “This is all so new, isn’t it?”

“Yeah. You made everything so bright that it hurts my eyes!” I say, wincing at the horizon past the palace walls. The world is so dazzling now that it’s sometimes hard to even look at it, it’s just too colourful, especially compared to being in the horde. I guess it’s going to take a lot of getting used to.

“Well, I… actually kind of meant, *this*, “Adora says, looking down at our joined hands, and smiling from ear to ear.

Was she always this pretty when she smiles? I think. “Um, yeah. I... I suppose so.” I say, sighing happily and snuggling into the crook of her arm, resting my head on her shoulder. Adora lightly strokes my shoulder and my purrs grow louder.

“You know... I’ve always loved that sound…” Adora says. “It’s always helped me to relax.”

“Well, it’s for your ears only,” I say, waiting for her to mock my sapiness. Instead, she swivels on the bench to face me, and takes both my hands in hers.

“Thank you,” she says, taking a deep breath. “I mean, for saving me. I was so ready to give up, but you were there and I…”

“I did it for me too, you know,” I say, smirking.

“What do you mean?”

“Well, I couldn’t have lived in a world without you in it, could I?”

“Oh, Catra…” Adora says. She places a finger under my chin, looks at me with soft eyes, softer than I’ve ever seen. *Kiss her, you idiot!* is all I can think, the words spinning around in my mind. But I bite my lip and entwine my fingers with hers instead. I don’t know what’s gotten into me; I kissed her first, after all. But it was life or death back then, wasn’t it? And this? This is just scary. I don’t even know what I’m scared of. We’ve only kissed that one time, but I want her to kiss me too. I want it so badly that it hurts.

“Uh, anyway, I don’t know how you ever got used to living like this!” I say, quickly changing the subject and sweeping my arm around the courtyard. Everything is so fancy here, not metal and shiny and full of straight edges like the old place. The whole palace is covered with flowers and marble posts and marble statues. It’s just too much. Too much pink, too much purple. And it smells so damn *nice*! No smoke, no decay. No stink of fear in the air, from soldier after soldier. Just flowers and perfume, and Adora, with her salty-vanilla scent.

“It’s a bit different to robots and rust, isn’t it?” Adora says, thankfully helping me to turn things back to small talk, for now. We haven’t really had any big, serious conversations yet, but I suppose they’ll have to come sometime. For now it’s just nice to be here, with her, close to her. *Safe*. Maybe it’s the same for her.

“Doesn’t it hurt your eyes though?” I ask, squinting at a large horse statue stood inside a fountain, “and how does that even make sense?” I ask, pointing at the effigy.

Adora laughs, “haha what… what do you mean?”

“I mean since when do horses spit out water like that? Constantly?”

“Hmm, you know,” Adora says, frowning and standing up, “I’m not really sure, I’ll go ask Swiftwi-”

“You can stay right here,” I say, pulling her back down to the bench and pouting. “I was just getting comfortable.”

Adora laughs as she lands with a soft *whoomph*. She leans into my vision to catch my stare, laces her fingers in the hair behind my neck, and tips her nose to mine. “I really do love you, you know?”

I feel a grin spread across my face, hurting my jaw again. “Oh yeah? How can I know for sure, though?”

And then she *finally* kisses me, not that I was secretly waiting for her to all along, or anything. And it’s not like I’ll miss it when she pulls away, either. I place my hands behind her head, keeping her in place, kissing her back, and it feels like the longer it goes on, the longer her lips brush against mine, the more my insides turn into mush, until I accidentally scratch her neck and hear a low moan, which makes all of that mushiness inside of me turn... *spicy* somehow.

I pull away, mainly to catch my breath, but noticing straight away that Adora’s cheeks are bright red, and that she’s looking at me in a strange way.

“Uh, are you okay? Did I do something wrong?” I ask, panic tightening in my chest.

“I am…” Adora pauses, blowing out of a puff of air, “*more* than okay, haha. I just need a minute,” she says, shifting herself next to me, wrapping an arm around me and pulling me close. And straight away I start purring again like a big softy, not that I mind… Adora has always had that effect on me.

“You’re so weird,” I chuckle, playfully nudging into her.

“Am not!” she says, then lifts her hand and starts to wave, “Oh, hey Bow!”

Adora’s friends. I’m still trying to figure them out. They seem nice, but maybe *too* nice, especially that flower girl who’s always fawning over Scorpia. They have no reason to be like that, and definitely not with someone like me. But I’ll keep playing along until I figure out what they’re up to.

“Hey Adora!” Bow says, marching towards us, “Hey Catra!”

“Hey,” I say, smiling back at him, slightly twitching my tail.

Glimmer is actually okay, I think. I started to get used to her after all those months with horde prime, and if I’m being honest she really helped me stay sane back then. I just have no idea what’s she’s going to do with me, or any of the ex-horde, or the clones. I just hope she doesn’t kick me out. Not yet.

“Aww, what’s with that serious look?” Adora asks. Her hand tussles with the fur behind my neck and I giggle, which makes her squeal because apparently she can’t get enough of making me do *cute* things. Ugh, I kind of wish I could stop smiling, though. It really is starting to hurt, and it’s

embarrassing! Especially when people gawp at us, like Bow is doing right now, with that stupid smirk on his face.

"*What?*" I ask, frowning at him.

"You two are SO cute," he says, holding his fists to his cheeks, and I swear I can almost see hearts appear in his eyes. I'm half tempted to pounce on him and knock him straight into that stupid horse-fountain.

"Don't you have a girlfriend to pester or something?" I ask, but when he looks genuinely hurt my frown melts away and we both laugh it off.

"She's busy doing queen stuff, like planning out the big post war celebrations, figuring out what to do with uh, people that *may* have been our enemies until a few hours ago, and-"

Bow paces about in front of the fountain while he talks about all the stuff Glimmer is up to. But I stop listening when Adora leans across the bench we're sat on, and puts her lips right next to my ear, causing a tingle in the base of my spine. She holds a hand up and whispers, "he's right, you know…"

"Hmm?" I mumble, closing my eyes, twitching my tail.

"We *are* cute."

"Not you too!" I hiss between my teeth, rolling my eyes. But I love it, and she knows I do. Adora's lips linger at the tufts of fur by my ear, and I feel her breath, warm against the sensitive strands of hair. It sends a shiver down my spine, and before I know it Adora suddenly jumps from the bench and shrieks excitedly, causing Bow to pause with his mouth open in the middle of his never-ending monologue.

Adora makes a weird sound between a laugh and a whine and I follow her gaze behind myself, groaning when I see my tail has puffed out to three times the size, way bigger than a standard scare-puff, and probably bigger than even Adora has ever seen. I huff and scowl, trying to push the fur back into place.

"No no, leave it," Adora says, finally releasing the laugh she'd been trying to hold in, "it's… haha! It's adorable."

"It is NOT adorable!" I seethe, flexing my claws in her direction for good measure.

"It absolutely is," Adora says. She calms down eventually, humming to herself and walking around the back of the bench, where she wraps her arms around my shoulders from behind and pulls me into a tight squeeze. "You know we're just teasing, right?" she says, her lips so close to my ear that I feel the vibration of each word.

I press a single claw into her skin threateningly, then spin and leap on top of the back of the bench, grabbing her hand tightly in mine, "Did you both forget that I used to lead the Horde?" I ask, pointing to Bow and Adora in turn, chuckling, "Do you even know who you're messing with?"

Bow gasps in faux-horror, "Oh no, we're all doomed!" he says, posing dramatically with the back of his palm against his forehead.

Adora jumps up next to me, and is about to say something really dumb I'm sure, except the bench starts to sway under our weight.

“Woah!” Adora says, as the bench falls over and we tumble backwards with it, falling into the hedge behind, landing in a heap, Adora laughing all the way.

“Ow,” I wince, feeling a sharp twig stabbing into my back. But I soon forget about it when I realise that Adora is suddenly right on top of me, appearing dazed, holding herself up with hands either side of my head. I swallow down a thick lump in my throat.

“Are you okay?” she asks, blinking away her confusion. But she doesn’t move, and all I can think about is how much I want her to kiss me again, right here, right now. It would be our third kiss, so soon, and I don’t even care how dumb it is that I’m counting. I lick my lips and raise my hand above my head.

“I think I’ve been mortally wounded,” I say, gasping for good effect. “and I might die if you don’t kiss me right now.”

It’s cheesy and stupid and probably won’t even work, I think. But when I see the smile spread on her lips, watch her eyes light up, and feel her mouth press against mine, I know it was a good call. And I know I’ll make an idiot out of myself again and again if that’s what it takes to get this feeling, the smell of her, filling my senses, and being able to hold her weight against me like this. Nothing could beat this. Nothing...

Except when I catch the tip of her tongue with mine and it’s like a lightning bolt shoots all the way down my tail which is probably now all fritzed out again but I don’t care, not even a little bit, because I want to feel *that* again right now, and I grip my fingers behind Adora’s neck to let her know. She groans into the kiss and I wrap my tail around her right thigh, trying to lock her in place while I search for that feeling again.

“Ahem. Um. Guys?”

I open one eye and groan against Adora’s lips, feeling resentful that Bow just stopped me from feeling more of the best thing I’ve ever felt in my life. Adora laughs, rolls from the top of me, stands up and dusts herself off, and I take a few deep breaths, waiting for my tail to de-fuzz itself before I stand up. I can’t help but think about how good that felt, but then again maybe it was a good job we stopped, since I have no idea what I’m doing with all that mushy romance stuff.

“She was injured from the fall, I was using my she-ra powers to heal her, and- haha!” I interrupt Adora’s lame-ass excuses with a sudden tickle attack at her waist.

“Aww, look at you two,” Bow says, puckering his lips, “you are so-”

“Don’t say it again,” I growl. “Once a day, that’s your limit.”

Bow laughs but doesn’t utter the insult. “I’m going to check on Glimmer, you two have fun!” he says, winking three times towards Adora then striding off.

“Wait, was that meant to be *subtle*?” I ask, raising an eyebrow.

“You know how he is, or I mean you will, once you get to know him,” Adora says, turning around and taking both my hands in hers. “He just likes seeing me happy. And you, too.”

“Pfft, yeah right,” I say, looking away, “I’m sure they all hate me really. And for good reason.”

“Catra…” Adora says, softly. I watch as she tilts her head slightly then steps forward, tipping her forehead to mine, “it isn’t like that. You know it isn’t.”

“Maybe. I… I just-”

“Guuu-ys? Catra? Adora?” Glimmer’s voice, calling from inside. I’m grateful for the interruption this time. I really don’t want to get into all of that, not yet. I want to enjoy Adora just a little bit longer, before she actually remembers all the things I’ve done. Before she comes to her senses and throws me out, like any sane person would.

“Looks like we’ve been summoned,” Adora says, placing her hands by her hips. “We’ll talk about this later, okay?”

“Uh, sure,” I say, taking her hand, and walking up the stairs alongside her, trying to ignore the sinking feeling in the pit of my stomach, the one telling me that I better enjoy this while it lasts, because I bet it won’t last long.

Chapter End Notes

Mermista: Like what is this chapter, even? Did anything actually happen?
Sea-Hawk: Does it matter? Look at them! They're in love!

Mating and Masticating

Chapter Summary

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

We walk into the hallway, spotting Glimmer just ahead. “Hey lovebirds, you’re late,” she says, leaning against the doorway to the meeting room, and peering at us through half-lidded eyes “I was going to teleport to come get you, but Bow said you might be *busy*.”

“I mean there’s a small chance we kind of... lost track of time,” Adora says, laughing nervously and pulling at her collar.

“Yes we were kissing, get over it,” I say, cheeks burning, still trying to ignore that sinking feeling in the pit of my gut. *Sure*, I think, *we said we’d go on adventures together, but they've had a chance to really think this through by now. And there’s only one obvious conclusion - I can’t be trusted. This is some dumb meeting to kick me and any other outsiders out. It has to be*.

Adora squeezes my hand as we follow Glimmer inside. “You okay?”

“Yeah… I’m fine,” I say, smiling reluctantly. “Let’s just get this over with.”

“Get what over with?” Adora asks, slowing her steps down.

“Hah, naive as always,” I say, pecking her on the cheek quickly before we walk into the large circular room, which is packed full of princesses and other equally important people. People who are now staring right at the both of us.

Adora squeezes my hand. “Catra, it’s going to be okay... I prom-”

“Catra! Adora! There you are!” Scorpia says, rushing over, and swooping me into a giant, almost painful hug. “We were just talking about you guys!”

“You were?” I say, gasping for air, “and who’s ‘we’?”

“Um she means me,” Perfuma says, walking towards us, blushing and folding her hands behind her back. “We were just saying how lovely it is to see that you two are finally together.”

Adora beams from ear to ear, then looks toward me, her eyebrows creasing. “Scorpia, I uh… think you’re killing her.”

“Oh, sorry, Wildcat!” Scorpia says, gently putting me down. Sometimes I forget how strong she is, and I’d hate to see anyone get on her bad side. Not that I’m sure that’s even possible. Even after everything I did to her, the worst she could do was abandon me - and I had it coming, too.

“It’s fine. I’m used to it by now,” I say, gently bopping Scorpia’s arm with my fist. “And… it’s okay. You can hug me if you want. From now on I mean.”

“Really!?” Scorpia asks, placing both her pincers below her chin, her eyes growing wide.

I lazilly wrap my arm and tail around Adora’s waist and rest my head on her shoulder, chuckling. “You don’t have to make such a big deal about it, though.”

“Oh! We could all double date sometime,” Scorpia says, her eyes lighting up. “Wouldn’t that be great? I’m so excited just thinking about it.”

Perfuma gasps. “That sounds wonderful!” she says, resting a palm on Scorpia’s arm. “What do you two think?”

“That would be really nice,” Adora says. From where my ear is resting I can hear her heartbeat… it’s strong as always, and makes me feel at peace.

“We haven’t actually had a date yet, at all,” I say, batting Adora’s waist with my tail to see if she gets the hint.

“Oh you need to have a few normal dates first, of course,” Perfuma interjects, smiling. “But let us know when you want to team up, okay?”

“There’s no rush!” Scorpia says, beaming at us before they both turn around and return to their chairs at the other side of the large, oval table.

Flower girl actually seems okay, I think, feeling a little relieved. *After I let Scorpia down so badly it’s nice to see her so disgustingly happy.*

“At least they’ve all stopped staring now,” I mumble, sitting down right next to Adora’s chair. We immediately pull our chairs right next to each other so that there’s no space between us, and I can easily keep my hold on her hand.

“They’re just curious, that’s all,” Adora says, smiling at me lop-sidedly. *Oh man, that’s cute*, I think, feeling my fur stand up just a little more than usual.

I manage to pull my stare aware from Adora’s deep-blue eyes, and look across the room at the others. Everyone’s just calmly sitting, or standing at their chairs talking about everything and nothing from what I can pick up. I don’t even hear my name on anyone’s lips, which is a nice surprise.

“Hey,” Frosta says, leaning into view from my right, “why’d you move your chair away? Do I smell?”

I absent-mindedly rub my hand to my cheek, remembering the weight behind this little girl's ice punch earlier.

"Well you see, Frosta," Bow interjects, leaning forwards on the table, "sometimes adults really, *really* like each other, and then they end up holding hands and kissi-" Bow stops mid-sentence, gulping when I shoot him the meanest glare I can manage.

"Wait, is the angry kitty cat actually shy?" Mermista says, raising an eyebrow in my direction. "Now I've seen everything."

"Oh hi fishnets," I say, growling. "Did you get bored of trying to drown everyone?"

"Weren't you chipped too?" Mermista asks, scowling.

"She doesn't mean it, haha!" Adora says, waving her hands, "do you, Catra?"

"Course not," I say, rolling my eyes. "And yes I was chipped too. Fun times."

"But you're here now, and we're all good. Aren't we?" Adora says resting a hand on my thigh, squeezing my leg and capturing my gaze. "Good, I mean?"

"Yeah we're… good," I say, feeling my cheeks heat up again.

Suddenly, Sea Hawk stomps a large black boot onto his end of the table, sending a few glasses rattling. "Ah, to be young and in love!" he says, twirling his moustache between his fingers, "this deserves a shanteee-"

"No," Mermista says, grabbing his leg and pulling him back down to his seat. "No shanty."

"Not even a rock shanty?" He whines.

Adora chuckles to herself, grabs a pitcher and pours us each a glass of water. "Hey," she says, smiling softly, her fingers touching mine as she passes the cup, "Mermista will come around. Give her time, okay?"

"Sure. Wish they'd just get on with it, though," I say. I take a few sips of water and then lean back, trying to be subtle as I prick up my ears and take a closer listen in on what must be a dozen conversations going on at once. *Why haven't they just done it already?* I think. *Why am I still here?* Then I notice Micah and Glimmer suddenly nod at one another, before taking their seats a moment later.

"Ah, so everyone's here? Good!" Micah says, his loud voice commanding the attention of everyone in the room. "Glimmer and I have been talking…"

"And I've decided that… I'm going to step down." Glimmer says, looking almost guilty at the admission. "I just… I really want to see what's out there, and I can't do that while being Queen. Plus, Dad knows so much more about ruling than I do…"

"I wouldn't go that far, princess," Micah says, chuckling. "You've done an amazing job."

"Dad… thank you… " Glimmer says, tears welling at her cheeks. "But there's so much to take care of before we can even think about heading out."

“Hah!” a loud laugh resonates in the room and I look behind my chair for the source, wondering how the hell Huntara snuck in without me noticing. “You mean like the Horde refugees, the clones you’ve left in space, and you know, working out what to do in this shitstorm you’ve all caused?” Huntara says, picking at one of her nails before raising an eyebrow at Glimmer. “I can find the ex-Horde, round up the stragglers if you want. So long as they want help that is.”

“And if they don’t?” Glimmer asks, leaning forwards and placing her hands on the table.

“Then I’ll just *encourage* them to come join me at the Crimson Wastes. Could always use more muscle out there.”

“So you’re just recruiting people for your own benefit,” I say, speaking quietly. I feel a surge of guilt, wondering how Kyle, Lonnie and the others are doing after everything I put them through. After everything I put *all* of my soldiers through. Double shifts… triple shifts. Riskier and riskier missions. Making them practically kill themselves under my so-called command.

Huntara takes a few steps forward, places a hand on the back of my chair, and peers down at me. “So, you’d rather people with… let’s just say *shadier* backgrounds... had nowhere to go?”

“That’s not what I-”

“And then there are people who *like* the rough life, just like you seemed to, kitty cat. At least for a short while.” Huntara says, drumming her fingers.

Before I can respond again Micah coughs loudly, stands to his feet, then smiles at Glimmer and waits for her to nod before speaking. “My daughter and I both feel that the only way to find a peaceful solution, and to stop the cycle of war, is to give anyone who wants it a second chance, especially if they prove to be a better person today than they were yesterday.”

Anyone? I think, barely stopping myself laughing. *Yeah, right.* I idly scratch a nail against the marble surface of the table, peering down to find my blue and yellow eyes reflecting back up at me. It takes all my willpower to not smash the image away.

“To that end,” Micah continues, “ALL who would seek shelter after the war are welcome in our lands. We will build homes for anyone that needs them.”

“Same goes for my kingdom,” Frosta says, shrugging, “and we already have plenty of spare homes. Can’t promise it will be cosy and warm like here, though.”

“Plumeria also welcomes those who need refuge. We do not hold any grudges,” Perfuma says, smiling at Scorpia. “Besides, I was hoping a certain ex-Horde commander would come and live there with me, very soon.”

“Oh, y-you mean me?” Scorpia says, gulping.

“Of course I mean you, silly!” Perfuma says, giggling and blooming a flower into Scorpia’s white, curly fringe.

Scorpia blushes and re-positions the flower a little with the tip of her claw. “Well then yes! Absolutely!”

“Pfft,” I whisper to Adora, “when’s the wedding?”

Adora elbows me in the ribs, “shhhh,” she whispers, clearly trying to hold back a giggle.

“What an amazing, and humbling response,” Micah says, smiling warmly, “everyone, thank you…”

“I’ll open my gates too, I guess,” Mermista says loudly, folding her arms, “though we might need help repairing the wreckage Catr-… sorry, the *Horde*, left behind.”

And there it is, I think, feeling my fur stand on end and my heart pound in my chest. *But don’t get mad. She has a point, she’s allowed to be angry. They all are. Don’t show them that you’re scared, dummy.*

Adora puts an arm around me, and pulls me close to her, rubbing my shoulder. It helps me to feel better, at least a little.

“Mermista,” Adora says, taking a deep breath, “I get where you’re coming from, but you have to give her a chance. Without her, I wouldn’t even be here...”

“Adora’s right,” Glimmer says, walking towards Mermista and placing a hand on her shoulder. “Please. We’re so close to finally finding peace… like Dad said, can’t we just… start over? All of us?”

“I for one, would greatly appreciate the gesture,” Hordak says, suddenly emerging from the doorway.

The entire room falls silent. Entrapta swings in past Hordak, walking on her giant purple pigtails, seemingly oblivious to the tension. Not far behind, wrong-Hordak stumbles in, carrying three trays piled full of food and a stack of plates.

“Brothers! I have brought delicious tiny sandwiches and cakes!” he says, winking. “Please, enjoy!” He says, carefully placing the trays and plates upon the oval table.

“This is a joke, right?” Mermista asks, staring between Glimmer and Hordak, and part of me feels grateful that I’m out of the spotlight, even if it’s just for a short while.

“Look, everyone... we’ve been thinking about this ever since She-Ra unleashed the magic of Etheria, changing our entire *world*,” Glimmer says, pacing around the room. “If we want to give people a second chance, it has to include *everyone* - otherwise it just won’t work.”

“So you are actually serious,” Mermista says, balling her hands into fists. “Then I take it back, my borders are open to everyone except him,” she says, pointing at Hordak, “and actually, now that I think about it, her too,“ she says, pointing straight at me.

Adora holds my hand beneath the table, stroking her thumb into my palm. *Well, it’s going just like I knew it would*, I think, wondering how much longer before I’m kicked out, right alongside Hordak, who’d probably then try to kill me anyway; assuming he remembers our little disagreement from way back.

“Oh wow! These are delicious!” Scorpia interjects, chomping on a tiny cake, with another one already spiked onto the end of her claw. “You know, I think everyone’s just grumpy because they’re hungry, you should all get in on this.”

Mermista wrinkles her nose and gingerly grabs one of the micro-sandwiches, sniffing it. “Cheese and pickle? Nice,” she says, popping it into her mouth. And then another one. The next thing I know everyone’s hands are reaching out, grabbing at the food. It’s absolute chaos until a few minutes later, when the silver trays have nothing left on them but a few crumbs, and everyone has a plate in front of them.

“You have to eat too,” Adora says, sliding a plate towards me with a small pile of sandwiches and two cakes on it.

“I’m… not hungry,” I say, feeling nauseous if anything. “Hey, you have something-” I say, licking my finger and then wiping the small crumb of cake from her cheek, being careful to keep my claw tucked in.

Adora’s cheeks turn red, and she practically beams at me. “Thanks.”

I wiggle my ears, feeling suddenly embarrassed, not helped at all by Bow giving us those damn heart eyes again.

“Did everyone like them?” wrong-Hordak asks, “I feel like I’ve found my true calling in life!”

“Yes! He’s our tiny food chef!” Entrapta says, clapping her hands together.

“They were delicious, but also so tiny and cute!” Bow says, beaming at wrong-Hordak.

Suddenly Castaspella strides into the room, then quickly appears dejected. “Did I miss it? Did I miss the food? I could smell it all the way from the library.”

“We’ll procure more! Fear not, brother, for the tiny food squad is on the case!” wrong-Hordak says, gathering up the trays and rushing out of the room.

Huntara sighs loudly and frowns, holding up a sponge cake between her forefinger and thumb, examining it closely. “But why does it all have to be so tiny?”

“Smaller food tastes better, and if you like, I can prove it with *science!*” Entrapta says, beaming at Huntara.

“You know what, I’ll just take your word for it,” Huntara says, throwing the treat into her mouth and swallowing it down in a thick gulp.

--

A short while later, everyone’s plates are empty, and the room does actually seem calmer, somehow.

“Soo,” Scorpia says, smiling, “wasn’t that great? Doesn’t everyone feel better now?”

“Ugh, *fine!*” Mermista says, rolling her eyes and flopping into her seat next to Sea Hawk, placing her boots on the table and leaning back. “I’m stuffed and actually feel better now. So I’ll give them a chance,” she says, holding a finger up. “One chance, just to be clear.”

Glimmer beams from ear to ear and claps her hands together. “Then let me make this official. I want to welcome our newest members,” she says, pointing across the table towards me, “starting with Catra, who saved me, and saved Adora’s life.”

“Wait, what?” I ask, sitting bolt upright and nearly accidentally swiping my plate of small food off the table. “You want me in the alliance!?”

“Of course, silly,” Glimmer says, “if you’d like to officially join us, that is…”

“Did you forget how many times I tried to kill you, sparkles? I’ve hurt *all* of you,” I say, standing from my chair, swiping my tail left and right, only barely conscious of Adora’s fingers squeezing

mine tightly, “and Mermista is *right!* Didn’t you see what we did to her kingdom?”

“Jeeze... chill out, furball,” Mermista says, rolling her eyes. “Why don’t you just make the most of your second chance. As in, don’t make me drown you.”

“Hmph. You’re all crazy, but… okay. That would be nice,” I say, sitting back against my chair and releasing the deep breath I didn’t realise I’d been holding. “Thank you.”

Adora squeezes my fingers and I turn to look at her, finding her smiling from ear to ear. Then it hits me… *if I can stay*, I think, *then I can be here, with her, every single day*. I blink back tears, feeling suddenly overwhelmed.

“Now for Hordak,” Gimmer says, appearing to pause and pick her words carefully, “I know it’s hard - it’s hard for me too - but we have to try. And he’s already changed for the better as far as I can see.”

“I… appreciate the opportunity. Just to be clear, I do not intend to rule this planet anymore,” Hordak says, folding his arms. “I have always enjoyed delving into the unknown, and now I can do so, without such distractions.”

“He means we get to do science! In *SPACE!* Hahaha!!” Entrapta says, laughing maniacally.

“We have not yet asked their permission, Entrapta.”

“Oh no,” Entrapa whines, “I jumped the gun again, didn’t I?”

Glimmer coughs, darting a look at Entrapta before brushing her fringe back. “I *wanted* to talk about this tomorrow, but… if we’re going back into space, I think Hordak should come.”

“What!?” Adora says, her fingers tightening around mine. “No way.”

I look between Adora and Glimmer as they stare each other down, quickly thinking through the potential outcomes.

“Well, one on hand we can keep an eye on him if he’s up there with us,” I say, batting my tail against Adora’s cheek. “On the other, he could just kill all of us up there, instead of everyone down here. Have you really thought this through, sparkles?”

“I have no desire to outright murder anyone, nor did I ever,” Hordak says, frowning, “at least, as far as I recall. My pursuits were only ever meant to earn his favour… and now… he is gone.”

I frown, and twitch my ears, realising for the first time that Hordak and I may actually have something in common. “Well, I vote that he comes with us.”

Adora looks at me, wide eyed. “Catra, are you sure about this?”

“If you trust me,” I say, pointing to myself, then Hordak, “then we have to trust him too. Sparkles said so. Haven’t you been paying *any* attention, Adora?” I ask, rubbing my tail beneath her nose.

“You’ve earned our trust!” she says, batting my tail away, wrinkling her nose. “He hasn’t!”

“Nor will he,” Micah says, sighing, “unless we give him a chance. I’m not saying I like it, but we’d be hypocrites if we excluded even one person from this whole clean slate thing.”

“Catra,” Adora says, taking my hands in hers, looking frightened. “Are you okay? Is it the chip?”

“Hah! What?” I say, scratching at the scar behind my neck. “No, I’m just trying out this whole benefit of the doubt thing. Besides, if he does try anything, I know I can take him.”

“More importantly,” Entrapta says, sneaking into view, “I’m going to need my boys if we’re going to pull this off!”

“Your… boys?” I say, squinting. “Pull it off? Pull what off?”

“I never approved of such a term,” Hordak says, frowning, “however, if it serves our purpose, then-”

“We’ll do SO MUCH science together!” Entrapta says, laughing and hopping around. “But, we’ll need to borrow Darla for a couple of weeks!”

“WHAT IS GOING ON?” Adora asks, clearly getting as lost, confused and frustrated as I am.

Hordak strides over to a gap between Glimmer and Scorpia’s chair, then taps the table with his index finger. A hologram flickers into view, showing the now-useless Horde Prime fleet, resembling floating trees rather than spaceships.

“We intend to salvage components from Horde prime’s currently… disabled armada,” Hordak says, “then customise Darla to suit our own needs. Your needs.”

“We’ll upgrade Darla, using tech from the space broccoli!” Entrapta says, squealing with delight, “we can make her bigger, and better, and faster!”

“Well,” Adora says, pinching the bridge of her nose. “I suppose we’ll need everything we can get if we’re headed out into the big unknown...”

“Does that mean we’ll get our own room?” I ask, purring when Adora’s cheeks redden. “Because if it does, I very much approve of this plan.”

“Yes, a room for everyone! And even better, we’re going to install a *warp drive*,” Entrapta says, her voice fading to an excited whisper.

I flick my tail around Adora’s cheeks, trying not to laugh because of how beetroot they’ve turned. *I really do love messing with her*, I think. I find myself just… *looking* at her, letting the chaos around unfold… something about science, yadda ya. Hordak is officially in; woopy-do. Something-something purple crystals. *Whatever*.

I’m staring straight into Adora’s crystal clear, blue eyes, and she’s looking into mine. All I can think about is how I just want to kiss her, more than ever.

“I can’t believe I’m staying,” I whisper, leaning over my chair, towards her.

Adora places a hand on my cheek, and her gaze lowers towards my lips. “Of course you are,” she whispers. She presses her lips to mine, and I hum in response, not even caring who might be watching, I just want this, I just want her-

“Catra?”

A familiar voice distracts me, stops me from forgetting where I am, and I pull away from the kiss with an almost painful sense of loss.

“Melog, there you are,” I say, laughing as they jump onto Adora’s lap, then nudge their head into hers.

“Hey Melog!” Adora says, grinning widely while stroking them.

“Where have you been, huh?” I ask, patting at their mane, sharing an awkward, sheepish glance with Adora. *I can't believe we almost made out in front of everyone*, I think. *Close call.*

“I have been admiring this planet, and the creatures upon it,” Melog, says, staring at me with shining blue eyes. “It is truly fascinating. Have you mated with this one yet?”

I feel blood roar to my cheeks, and I’m sure as hell grateful nobody else can understand my companion. “That’s not up for discussion!” I say, under my breath, trying to ignore the strange looks I’m getting.

“Hey guys!” Netossa says, entering the room with Spinnerella walking in right beside her.

“We came for the food,” Spinnerella says, sighing at the sight of the empty table. “Too late I guess?”

Melog sniffs at the air, then nuzzles into my hand, “those two are hungry because they just mated.”

“I did *not* need to know that,” I mutter, although I almost burst out laughing.

“Wait, she has a pet cat?” Frosta asks, looking suddenly excited, “can I stroke it?”

“They’re not just a pet,” Adora says, grinning, “this is Catra’s buddy, they’re bonded… it’s uh, a long story.”

“They can talk but only Catra understands! And they react to her emotions!” Entrapta says, “it’s all truly *fascinating*, if only I were allowed to study-”

“No,” I say, threading my fingers into Melog’s mane, which shifts colour to a hue of orange. “They aren’t a science experiment.”

Thankfully, we’re interrupted by wrong-Hordak, dashing into the room with his usual frantic energy, placing freshly-stocked trays onto the table. “Never fear, more tiny food is here!”

Entrapta hops away towards Hordak, grabbing a few tiny pastries on the way, then waving them enthusiastically in front of him.

“So let me get this straight,” Mermista says, taking a deep breath and pointing in my direction, “You were a bad kitty but now you’re a good kitty, who has an emotional-buddy-kitty, and oh by the way, it’s clearly, blatantly obvious that you’re in love with Adora?”

Melog rubs the side of their face against a laughing Adora, purring so loudly that it vibrates across the whole room.

“Oh didn’t we tell you?,” Adora says, hugging Melog tightly and appearing smug, “Catra loooves me-”

“Shut up, idiot!” I say, leaping onto the arms of her chair, bending down and slapping my hand over her mouth.

“Oh, is the mating happening right now?” Melog asks, jumping from Adora’s lap, “then I shall make myself scarce.”

“We. are. not. *mating!*” I yell loudly, then gasp and cover my mouth with my hand.

The silence that follows is deafening, and I can't even bring myself to look at Adora right now. I try to worm my way back into my chair, wondering if I can vanish into it somehow. *Thanks a lot, Melog*, I think, shooting them a glare while they sit under the table looking up at me, gently wagging their tail side to side.

Suddenly, Glimmer bursts into laughter, immediately followed by Scorpia. And then everyone's laughing at me, including Adora. I feel somewhere between embarrassed and enraged, and I notice Melog's fur burn bright red which reminds me I'm *supposed* to be working on this. *They're not being mean*, I think. *I don't need to be angry. It isn't the same as all those times Shadow Weaver laughed, every time I failed or hurt myself somehow. It's happy laughter. And… I guess it was kind of funny...*

"Hey, are you okay?" Adora says, appearing concerned. She places her palm on my arm, softly stroking it.

"I'm fine… sorry," I say, taking a deep breath and managing a quiet chuckle. Melog nuzzles into my leg, their fur shifting back to its usual purple-blue sheen.

Once the laughter dies down, Micah stands to his feet. "On that note, perhaps it's time we all retired," he says, winking in our direction and almost causing me to die of embarrassment. "It's definitely getting late, and we can deal with any other business tomorrow morning."

The princesses stand up one by one, and I prick my ears forward, trying to keep track of their conversations.

"-with me tonight? I mean, if you want," Perfuma whispers.

"Oh gosh, I'd love that," Scorpia says, tapping her pincers together, "though I'm a little… inexperienced."

"Those two might be planning to mate," Melog says, looking towards the two of them, then up at me expectantly.

"Okay buddy," I say quietly, bending down under the table and stroking their mane. "This is fun and all, but let's give people their privacy, okay? And I want to take things slowly… with Adora, I mean."

"Your heart tells me otherwise, as do your pheromones, but I shall respect your wishes."

"Right. Thanks."

"Well that looks like it was a deep, meaningful conversion," Adora says, standing to her feet and holding her hand out. "Glimmer says she's put an extra bed in my room for you. Is that okay?"

I take her hand and stand to my feet. "That sounds nice. I'm honestly exhausted," I say, leaning my head on her shoulder while we walk towards the exit.

"Goodnight everyone," Adora says, waving behind us.

"Night Scorpia. Have fun tonight," I shout, grinning wickedly in her direction, laughing when she nearly falls over and Perfuma has to hold her upright.

--

"What was that all about?" Adora asks, once we're further down the corridor.

I think about keeping it to myself, but as soon as I start to think about it at all, I end up laughing. And the more I laugh, the more I can't seem to stop laughing.

"Catra? Haha," Adora laughs along, "what's gotten into you?"

I explain everything as we walk down the corridor, hand in hand, arms swinging, tears of laughter at my cheeks, feeling happier than I have in a long time, especially when I tell her how Scorpia and Perfuma might be getting it on tonight. I leave out the part about Adora and I mating of course, and *especially* the part about my so-called pheromones.

We soon arrive at what I assume is Adora's room, and she pushes open the door. "After you," she says, smiling.

"Should I sleep elsewhere?" Melog asks, butting into Adora's leg.

I bend down and poke a finger into their fur, "No, silly. We've talked about this."

"I am just making sure. I shall leave if the need arises."

"If you say so, Melog," I say, standing up and rolling my eyes.

They walk around the room, which is furnished just as I'd expect from Adora; almost like her room back at the Horde, which ended up being *our* room, since I crashed there most of the time. It's a mix of organisation and chaos; some things piled up neatly or tucked away, others piled haphazardly, like the random pile of odd socks on her dresser. And on the top her drawers, the wreckage of her old sword, and detailed mini-figurines of Bow and Glimmer.

Melog finds a comfy spot on a rug in the corner, and curls into a ball.

"What did Melog say just now?" Adora asks, standing at her dresser mirror and fiddling behind her hair.

"They said you better give me the comfiest bed. And I agree."

"I'm pretty sure both beds are the same," Adora says, chuckling. "Wanna push them together? Just... you know, so we can be closer?"

"That would be nice," I say, smiling at her, feeling a swarm of butterflies dance around in my stomach when she unties her hair and it falls around her shoulders. *I shouldn't feel so unsettled… it's not like we're going to do anything*. *Not so soon*, I think. *Are we?*

"You look nervous," Adora says, pausing while pushing her bed frame towards mine. She looks so beautiful that all I want to do is go over there and trail my fingers through those golden locks, push my nose into them, inhale her scent deeply, then kiss her, and never stop kissing her.

"Pfft," I say, shaking my head to clear those maddening thoughts, flicking my hand dismissively. "We've slept in the same room before, idiot. Have you forgotten how many times I've curled up at the bottom of your bed?"

Adora takes a deep breath, and frowns slightly, "I… suppose. But isn't it different now?"

"Fine, I'll keep my clothes on this time then," I say, chuckling. "Can't promise I won't sweat all over, though."

“The palace does have air conditioning,” Adora says, matter of factly, pushing her bed neatly in place right next to mine, “so you should be okay.”

I laugh, deciding I want to mess with Adora before we go to sleep. Just a little.

“So, Adora,” I purr, flopping onto my bed belly first, resting my chin on my palms, “are you saying I have to wear clothes whenever I sleep from now on?”

“I, uh, haha,” Adora grins towards me, “You know what, you can do whatever you want. I don’t want this to get weird just because-”

I leap to her side of the combined beds, hop to my feet and steal a quick kiss from her lips. “Just because we’re kissing now?”

“Yeah, that,” Adora whispers, placing her palms on my cheeks, and gently kissing me back. It’s a slow, tender kiss, and I inhale deeply, placing my palms over hers, tasting her lips, inhaling her scent, wanting more, wanting her like I always have, but also afraid of that wanting, and not really understanding why. “And, well, you know… other stuff.” Adora says, tipping her head to mine and blushing slightly.

“Wait, are you actually shy!?” I laugh, grinning from ear to ear, flopping down on the edge of her bed and swinging my tail. “The mighty, cock-sure Adora I grew up with, shy! Hah! I’ll tell you what, princess… just for you I’ll keep myself dressed, at least a *little*,” I say, smirking up at her, showing her a tiny gap between my thumb and forefinger.

Adora blows out a puff of hot air, rolls her eyes and turns around, heading towards her wardrobe. “No, it’s not that, it’s more that you are kind of irresistible,” she laughs, pulling her red jacket off, and placing it on a hanger. “But I want to, you know… take things slowly? Now that we’re headed somewhere new.”

“So I… “ I say, licking my lips as she pulls her leggings down, trying to ignore the heat flickering in the pit of my stomach, “I should stop watching you right now, for example?”

“You can watch as much as you like,” Adora says, pulling her shirt over her head and placing it atop her dresser, next to the weird sock pile. “You can touch too, if you want,” she says, stealing a glance over her shoulder, smirking before she yanks her sports bra off, then quickly tugs a night gown over her torso. “I don’t want to ruin this by rushing, that’s all.”

“You seriously think you could ruin this?” I ask, pulling my knees to my chest, trying to ignore my heart pounding in my chest, and trying to ignore the fact that maybe Melog knew exactly what I wanted, as always. “By what, either of us being too naked?”

Adora walks over to me and my heart beats faster in response, which is dumb, because I’ve seen her in her nightwear before but not looking at me like this, never like this. She tips her forehead to mine. “By rushing you. I need to know you’re ready, and right now… I’m not sure you are.”

I prick one ear up, gasping, “and you’re saying you are?”

Adora laughs, “Well, I’ve wanted this since forever...” she says, stroking the side of my face. “Wanted you, I mean.”

“What! Since when!”

“Since I’ve been old enough to think about that stuff, I guess,” Adora says, sitting next to me, and nudging her shoulder into mine. “I just figured you didn’t feel that way, so I… well, ignored it.”

“You mean to tell me all this time we’ve been fighting and we could have been fu-”

“Catra!” Adora laughs, grabs a pillow and hurls it into me with such force that I careen off the edge of her bed. I land on the floor on my back, laughing, feeling utterly defeated. *Well that backfired*, I think, but not in a bad way. *She wants me… that way. And she thinks I’m irresistible? Me!? Wow*.

“So, are you sleeping on the floor?” Adora asks, her head upside down over the edge of her bed, her hair hanging in loose, glorious strands. “I promise I’ll behave myself if you sleep next to me.”

“You are a *lot* calmer about all this stuff than I’d imagined,” I grumble, standing to my feet, walking to my side of the bed and stripping off my outer layers. I’ve soon undressed all the way down to my underwear, which I’d normally remove without a second thought, but my hands freeze in place beneath my sports bra when I notice Adora, staring at me.

“Am I making you uncomfortable?” she asks, her bright blue eyes unflinching.

“No… you dummy!” I say, blushing. “I’ve just decided that if you want to see anything, you’ll have to earn it,” I say, flopping down on top of my covers, and laying on my side, facing her with my head in the crook of my arm.

Adora climbs into bed under her covers, shifts onto her back and holds her hand out, palm open, which I take in my hand. “And how do I do that?” she whispers, locking eyes with mine, stroking my fingers.

“You stay. And you keep on staying. And you never, ever leave me again.”

“I can do that,” Adora says, smiling softly and closing her eyes.

“And a date, like Perfuma said. I want to go on a date. More than one.”

“I can absolutely do that.”

“And then, we’ll see what happens,” I say, yawning, my eyelids growing heavy.

“Can’t wait,” Adora mumbles. “Good night, Catra.”

“Night Adora…”

“I love you.”

I yawn and stretch out, before getting comfortable, keeping my hand in hers, “I love you too,” I say, closing my eyes and purring loudly. *So*, I think, *it turns out I was wrong about how today was going to go down. And it’s never felt better to be wrong about something.*

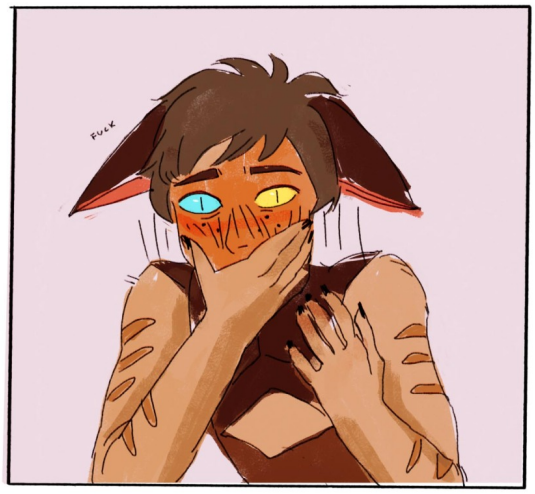
Chapter End Notes

Sea Hawk: I still think we should have done a rock shanty!!
Frosta: Or punched Catra...

Catra: Hey! What did I do?!

BONUS, everyone please thank the incredibly talented & kind dany-illy for making a comic of THAT scene -

dany-illy
tumblr.com



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Scars and Spaceships

Chapter Summary

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Behind my back I can feel the heart of Etheria crackling with energy, threatening to explode at any moment. But it doesn't matter. All that matters to me in this very moment is the feel of Adora's lips pressed against mine, filling me with a warmth I didn't even know was possible.

I can't believe I finally told her how I feel , I think, *and that she loves me too . She'll pull through this. I know she will. She'll turn into She-Ra, we'll survive this, and be together forever from now on...*

Adora's fingers dig into my arms, gripping desperately.

Something's wrong…

Her head falls backward, and my lips feel cold air at the loss.

"Adora?" I ask, shaking her shoulders, fresh tears forming at my cheeks.

Adora gasps. "Catra, I'm… sorry. I couldn't…"

This isn't how it's supposed to be!

Her eyes roll back in their sockets and she sighs. Her chest rises once more, then falls still.

This isn't right! It isn't!

Adora falls completely limp in my arms, and a cold dread chills my heart.

"Adora!"

I place my ear to her chest, frantically listening. There's nothing… not a single beat of her heart. It's the most horrifying thing I've ever not heard.

"ADORA! NO!" I scream, clinging to her lifeless form, sobbing violently, my chest heaving so much that I struggle to breathe.

This can't be happening…

it can't be …

… not when we were so close...

The heart explodes behind us, and I don't even care that I'm about to die.

--

I gasp for air and jump away from the explosion on instinct, landing on the floor and rolling a few times before I stop on all fours, panting, my eyes frantically scanning around for Adora's body. My mind feels foggy but I quickly realise that the floor is soft beneath my fingertips... soft and pink. Not cold and hard. *A dream? PLEASE let it be a dream,* I think, clawing my nails into the carpet, my heart pounding in my ears.

"Catra!" Adora calls out my name, and hearing her voice makes my heart almost shatter. She leaps towards me, and I throw my arms around her.

"Adora," I choke out her name while nuzzling my face into her neck, her skin turning damp from my tears.

"It's okay," she says, gently rocking me in her arms. "It's okay. I'm here. We're safe."

I flatten my ear against her neck, finding the steady rhythm of her pulse.

da-dum...

da-dum...

I inhale a deep breath through my nose, taking in Adora's familiar scent, smelling the salt of her recent sleep, and that subtle hint of vanilla which could only ever belong to her.

"Adora, I... " the nightmare flickers in my mind again. Adora's face, how it looked when she just gave in, and how horrifying it was to not be able to hear her heartbeat. "Damn it," I groan, leaning back and putting my fists against her chest, tugging at her nightgown. "I just want it to *stop* , okay? I just want to stop feeling like I'm going to lose you every two seconds, especially now, especially now that we-"

Adora silences me with a kiss, so gentle that it takes my breath away.

"I'm not going anywhere," she says, tipping her forehead to mine, her eyes searching for my gaze.

"You say that now, but..." I begin, feeling suddenly angry that she came so close to sacrificing herself yesterday. No, not angry. *Frightened* .

"I mean it, Catra," Adora says. She takes both my hands, and laces her fingers between mine. "I'm never going to leave you again. Ever."

I finally look up into her eyes, feeling almost lost in her gaze. “And if we find a planet full of, I don’t know, sentient marshmallows that will die if you don’t sacrifice yourself?” I ask, sniffling.

“Then I-” Adora says, before taking a deep sigh, “then *we* find a way to fix it, without me having to-”

“Don’t you *get* it?” I ask, pushing forward, pinning her to the floor, my fingers tightly gripping hers, “what if there is no fix? I just saw you die, Adora! Okay!? We were at the heart, but this time you gave up,” I choke out the words, “...you gave up on me, and it felt so real...”

Adora manages to free one hand, and she reaches up, touching her fingers to my cheek. “Catra… “

“I love you, but it…” I begin, fresh tears streaming down my face, spilling onto Adora’s cheeks, ”it terrifies me! You’ve always put literally anyone, or anything before yourself and I can’t stop thinking,” I release her other hand and press my forehead to her chest, my ears flattening, “after everything… I’m just going to lose you anyway… so why bother...”

“I’m… sorry,” Adora says. I feel her chest puff out, then hear her sigh deeply, and the whole time I’m listening to her heart, making sure it’s beating steadily. “I’m sorry for putting you through... well, everything. I’m sorry for leaving you without properly explaining why. I’m sorry I abandoned you, that I didn't try harder to see it from your perspective. I’m sorry I gave up on you, even if it was only for a short while; I’m sorry I ever doubted you at all. I’m sorry for so many things,” she says, softly, gently, stroking her fingers through my hair. “I hardly even know where to begin to make it right. But I’m not going anywhere, and I won’t be so reckless anymore, I promise.”

“Do you mean it?” I ask, nuzzling my nose into the crook of her neck, and sliding my hands into the space between her shoulders and the carpet, where I hold her close.

“Yes. I want this as much as you do,” Adora says, her voice instilling me with a sense of calmness. “To live, I mean. With you. And those marshmallows? We could just toast them.”

“Haha!” I laugh, reluctantly pulling away from her neck and propping myself up on my elbows, “as if you could ever-”

“Well you *claimed* they were sentient,” Adora says, a manic grin widening at her lips, “but if they’re in our bellies, who could prove it?”

“Adora! You *do* have an evil side!” I exclaim.

We both burst out into laughter, giggling like idiots, rolling around on the floor and tickling each other, which only makes the laughter worse.

--

Eventually the laughter dies down, and I lay on top of Adora, resting my head on her chest, pressing my ear to her heart.

“Sorry,” I mumble, feeling a little embarrassed. Every breath she takes, and every heartbeat, fills me with warmth, with love. “The dream was just so real. I overreacted.”

“It sounds like it was awful,” Adora says. She places a hand on my right cheek, lightly stroking my fur. “I just need you to believe me when I say I’m here. That I won’t ever leave you again.”

“Ugh, I think we’re turning soft,” I say, nuzzling my lips against her hand, purring.

“I think we are,” Adora laughs. “But I also think you could be even softer, and kiss me.”

“Oh, really?” I ask, giggling. I prop myself up onto my hands and look down, capturing her gaze with mine. But the smirk on my face soon dies, replaced with awe. Adora has such clear, beautiful blue eyes, and the way her golden strands of hair are loosely spread out behind her… I don’t think I’ve ever wanted to kiss her more than I do right now.

Adora’s hands cup the back of my head, and she leans upward, her lips just an inch away from mine, and I couldn’t stop myself even if I wanted to. I close the gap, kissing her slowly, softly, deeply, and I soon find that magical feeling again, her tongue, trailing against mine ever so briefly.

I gasp, and break from the kiss, feeling all of the hairs along my back stand on end.

“Sorry,” Adora says, appearing to panic.

“Less talking,” I mumble, lowering myself down again, “more kissing.”

This time I’m braver and allow my tongue to search for hers, soon rewarded by a deep, guttural sound resonating from Adora’s throat. Our lips stay half-open, and I trail slow, lazy patterns around Adora’s tongue with my own. She must like it because her fingers tighten into my hair, and when I gently nibble her lip, I’m rewarded with a gasp.

“Catra, what-”

“Woops,” I say, the tip of my tail flicking side to side. “Accident.”

“Wasn’t complaining,” Adora breathes, leaning up to capture my lips again, this time with so much force that it almost knocks the wind from my lungs, and I kiss her back aggressively, interlacing my thighs with hers, needing to feel her as close to me as possible.

“Adora,” I mumble, kissing her, again and again. “You feel so good...”

Adora’s hips squirm beneath mine, and she grabs just behind my thigh, pulling my leg between hers. I can feel how damp she is through her shorts, it’s even seeping through into the fur on my thigh, and I can *smell* how turned on she is. Her scent drives me into a frenzy, and I rock myself against her thigh, feeling something start to happen, something weird, but nice, but… *weird!*

“Ah!” I say, jumping away, wondering what the hell that was. I still feel it burning between my legs, but it soon starts to ebb away.

Adora props herself up onto her elbows. “Are you okay?”

“Yeah I just… never mind.” I say, folding my arms, feeling a bit stupid.

“Was that too much?” Adora asks, appearing nervous.

“No, dummy,” I say, crawling back towards her, pecking her on the lips, “something weird happened, that’s all.”

“Something... weird?”

I scratch at the back of my neck, and glance down between my legs, “something… down there.”

“So, bad-weird, or good-weird?”

“Good, I think? I stopped before I could be sure.”

Adora chuckles and plays with a few strands of hair by my ear, “Catra… I think you nearly had an orgasm. You’ve never… ?”

“Oh, is that what everyone used to go on about?” I ask, frowning. I never really did understand all those talks back in the horde about sex-this and sex-that.

“Want to carry on?” Adora whispers, looking at me through lidded eyes, cupping my chin and cheek in her palm, causing me to purr loudly. I’ve never seen her pupils so dilated, nor her cheeks so red, and I have the word *yes* on the tip of my tongue, but…

My ears twitch. Over the sound of my purr I hear something *else* humming in the background.

“What’s that?” I ask, just as Melog jumps up from their slumber, looking suddenly alert.

“What’s what?” Adora asks, following me as I hurry towards her balcony, pushing open the double doors, running to the golden banister and peering below for the source of the ever-growing sound. But it sounds like it’s actually coming from-

“Oh no,” I mutter, squinting towards the sky and noticing a spec appear, rapidly increasing in size. “Adora…”

“Is that…” Adora squints, then gasps. “A clone ship?! We have to warn everyone! Catra!”

“Already on it,” I say, running back into her room and throwing my clothes on. *Maybe they’re retaliating* , I think… *Maybe sleeping was a bad idea, we should have reached out to them first* . The room flickers golden-white, and I pause to watch, wide-eyed, as Adora reaches her hand out, forming her magic blade.

“For the honour of grayskull!” Adora yells. Her form begins to glow, red shorts and night gown soon replaced with She-Ra’s white, red and golden outfit. *This whole transformation thing is really starting to grow on me* , I think, purring and twitching my tail while I watch it play out.

“Catra?”

“Ah, crap! Okay, I’m going,” I say, dashing towards the bedroom door alongside Melog just as Adora jumps on top of the balcony’s barrier. “And you’d better be careful!”

Adora tilts her head, and smirks at me, “Kiss me afterwards, okay?”

“Huh?” I ask, pausing in my tracks.

“Just promise me.”

“Okay. I’ll kiss you as much as you want, dummy,” I say, shaking my head when she grins and leaps from the balcony to the grounds below. “Come on Melog, time to make some noise!”

--

“Wakey-wakey!” I yell, running up the corridor, banging on people’s doors.

Luckily everyone’s rooms are positioned up and down the same corridor as Adora’s room, so it’s pretty easy to rally everyone. A combination of Melog’s roars and my yells seems to do the trick, and

before long most people have been spurred into action, albeit drowsily.

“Catra, what’s going on?” Glimmer asks, standing in her doorway and rubbing her eyes. “Isn’t it still really early? What’s that sound?”

“Clone ship on its way down,” I say, pointing in the rough direction of the noise. “Adora’s already headed there. Go!”

Glimmer grabs my arm and one brief, pink flash later we’re both standing near the western exit of the palace. I stumble a little, thinking I'll never quite get used to Glimmer’s little trick, and then I search upwards.

“It’s crashing!” Glimmer says, pointing, wide eyed. “Look!”

And that’s when I spot the smoke, billowing out from somewhere behind the ship as it groans, plummeting downwards. “Wait, is it gonna crash *here?* ” I ask, my tail-hair standing on end.

“I’ll go grab everyone, one moment,” Glimmer says, popping in and out of vision before I even get a chance to ask if this is the best place for all of us to gather. Scorpia and Perfuma appear, looking a little frazzled, followed by Mermista, Frosta, and then everyone else.

Adora and Swiftwind swoop down, landing next to us. “It’s bad up there,” Adora says, frowning. “I think the vines got caught in the engines, but I don’t understand - weren’t they out in space?”

“The ship must have been in our atmosphere ever so slightly, meaning it was slowly drifting down this whole time!” Entrapta exclaims, sounding way too happy about it. “I wonder if any other ships are going to crash?” she continues, placing a hair-hand under her chin.

Adora covers her face with her palm, “Let’s hope not. First of all, we need to deal with this.”

“By my calculations it will land not far from where we’re standing,” Entrapta says, tapping into her data pad, “but some of the hull will land inside the walls. So we should probably move!”

“I was *going* to suggest that,” I growl, rolling my eyes at Glimmer.

“The forest,” Perfuma says, pointing through the arched doorway and beyond the palace walls.”That’s where it will land, right?”

“Yes - Entrapta’s right,” Bow says, looking up at the ship through his hand telescope, “it’ll land in the forest for the most part, but the momentum will… Glimmer… we need to move.”

“What of the clones?” Hordak asks, and I have to look twice because I swear he almost appears concerned. *That’s new* , I think.

“Don’t worry everyone, It’s fine, I’ve got this,” Perfuma says, smiling and touching Hordak’s shoulder. “Leave it to me.”

“Is she nuts?” I ask, watching as Perfuma dashes towards the forest, right into the path of the giant, deadly, flaming spaceship. “Scorpia, Adora, aren’t you going to stop her?”

Scorpia laughs and places a pincer on my shoulder. “Just you watch. My girl's got this.”

“I’ll go see if she needs backup, just in case,” Adora says, Swiftwind dashing them into the air a moment later.

The next thing I know, the entire ground rumbles loudly beneath my feet, and then a huge pillar of thick, green roots and branches shoot up from the forest, curling around each other, growing in size and reaching impossible proportions, until they spread out at their apex into a wide, giant net of thick vines.

“Okay. I suppose that’s kind of cool,” I say, watching it in awe. It’s so different seeing stuff like this from the other side, where I can actually stop and pay close attention.

“Just in time, too,” Bow says, and we all watch as the clone ship plummets into the makeshift net, metal groaning loudly against crackling wood. The ship’s descent starts to slow, vines creaking under the weight of the hull. But it’s not slowing down enough.

“Move back!” I yell, stepping away, “unless you all want to become princess pancakes.”

But then the foliage that was already attached to the ship springs to life, sprouting vines that shoot downwards, merging with the giant net and whipping around in tight circles until the ship slows further still, finally coming to a standstill, its pointed nose knocking a few bricks loose from the castle wall.

“Never doubted her for a moment,” I mutter, while Scorpia beams with pride.

“Okay, let’s do this!” Adora yells, circling into view from behind the ship. “Mermista, Frosta! Get those engine fires out! Hordak, Entrapta, get in there and figure out what’s going on with the clones. Glimmer, can you-”

“Already on it,” Glimmer says, linking her arms with Entrapta and Hordak, then teleporting them away.

“Want a lift?” Adora says, offering out her hand. I look at Swiftwind, then at Adora.

“No, thanks,” I pout. “I’d rather teleport.”

“Oh come on!” Swiftwind says, shaking his mane, “It’ll be fun! I promise I won’t drop you.”

“Ugh, fine,” I say, taking Adora’s hand, climbing up behind her, and squeezing my arms around her waist, noticing - not for the first time - just how much thicker Adora is as She-Ra. *That’s definitely something I might want to explore one day* , I think, blushing as I snuggle my face against her strong shoulders.

Swiftwind stomps his hind legs into the earth and a moment later we’re up in the air, just me, my eight-foot girlfriend and a magical, talking flying rainbow horse. I try not to think about it too much.

--

“Let’s check the engines first,” Adora yells, looking at me over her shoulder.

Like I have any choice , I think, nodding, then squeezing my eyes shut and clinging on for dear life as we fly around the back of the ship.

We find Mermista and Frosta standing atop a frozen plume of water, with a hint of stale smoke in the air. The engines appear thoroughly drenched, without a flame in sight.

“Looks good,” Adora yells, waving back at them both. “Swiftwind, let’s go help with the clones.” Swiftwind performs a sharp turn in the air, making my stomach heave and giving me serious regrets

about agreeing to this whole ordeal. He flies to the side of the ship and lands on a thick pad of vines by the main entrance.

We're about to head inside, when the metal door opens with a *whoosh* . Hordak steps out with a clone holding an arm over his shoulder, and Entrapta follows just behind.

"We found only this one," Hordak says, helping the clearly-wounded clone outside of the ship. He grunts and buckles over, as though struggling to support the clone's weight, but Adora quickly dashes forward.

"Let me see," Adora says, taking the clone from Hordak and sitting him down, then cupping his face in her hands. I gulp, wondering for the briefest moment how those big, strong fingers would feel if they were rummaging through my fur.

A healing glow surrounds Adora. It seeps out from within her, glowing along her arms and over the clone's arm, torso and head, then across his whole body.

Glimmer blinks into a spot next to me and folds her arms, quietly waiting until the glow dissipates.

"Thank you," the clone says, his head lolling forward. "But please... I must… sleep..."

"I wonder what his story is?" I ask, tilting my head towards Glimmer. "Do you think he'll be okay?"

"Adora's healed far worse," Glimmer says, staring at me pointedly. "For now, we'll take him back to the palace."

"Uh," Entrapta says, pointing her hair in the direction of the slowly-crumbling ship. "Can we…?"

"Knock yourselves out," Glimmer says, smiling. "Just be *careful* ."

"YES!" Entrapta exclaims, "Come on Hordak, we've got work to do!" she continues, pulling down her visor, and summoning a blow torch from who-only-knows-where.

--

A few teleports and a terrifying horse ride later, everyone apart from Hordak and Entrapta are gathered together, just outside the medical ward.

"We'll take good care of him," Castaspella tells a very distraught-looking wrong-Hordak, before heading into the room and closing the door behind her.

Wrong-Hordak places a hand on the door, and tears fill his eyes. "Brother..."

"Hey, wrong-Hordak, it's okay. He'll be fine," Bow says, reaching a hand onto his arm.

"Isn't it time we gave him a name?" I ask, scowling.

"A… name?" wrong-Hordak asks, immediately placing his hand on his mouth. "Wait, I am allowed one now?"

"Sure, what do you wanna be called?" I ask.

He sighs, looking dejected. "I do not know."

"Well if you need any suggestions let me know... I bet I could think of a few *fun* ones."

“Catra,” Adora warns, trying but failing to hide her smirk.

“What? It could be entertaining,” I say grinning.

Wrong-Hordak suddenly reaches out and pulls me into a hug. “Thank you, Catra. I will consider your offer.”

“Ugh, what is it with everyone being a *hugger* ?” I ask, rolling my eyes while the others just stand there laughing.

“Maybe you’re just so cute that people *need* to hug you,” Bow says, puckering his lips.

“You got a death wish or something?” I ask, shaking my fur back into place the second I’m released from wrong-Hordak’s arms.

“Gotta admit, I do love hugging Catra,” Scorpia says, beaming. “I mean, she’s so cute and fluffy.”

“Really?” I ask, scowling, “Scorpia, don’t make me take back what I said earlier.”

“Aww, but-”

“And I know what you were up to last night,” I say, pointing a claw first at her, and then at a suddenly very red-faced Perfuma. “So I’d tread lightly if I were you.”

Adora hums to herself and looks away, clearly struggling to restrain herself from adding to this nonsense. So, I walk up to her, wrap my hands around her waist and look upwards to catch her gaze. “You know, it was kind of hot watching you tell them all what to do,” I say, speaking quietly so that only she can hear.

“I’m not sure I believe that,” she whispers back, though she appears smug all the same, “You always hated it back in the horde.”

“Well that’s because I was busy competing with you back then,” I say, shrugging.

“And you expect me to believe that you’re not now?”

“Nah. I won, it’s over, Adora.”

“Huh?”

I stand on my tip-toes, and kiss her, only realising right at the last second that this is my first time kissing Adora as She-Ra. Doesn’t feel any different really, other than it hurts my neck having to reach up like this. “I won, because now you’re mine, dummy.” I say, pressing a finger into the middle of her chest.

“Hmm. Is that so?” Adora says, grinning from ear to ear. Her form dazzles briefly and she shrinks down to a far less intimidating size, and I can't help but burst out laughing at a sudden realisation.

“Hey, Adora,” I chuckle, raising an eyebrow and pointing my finger first to her nightgown, and then to her red boy-shorts. “Aren’t you forgetting something?”

“Oh, okayyy,” Bow says, blushing and looking away, covering his eyes with the side of his hand.

“Woops!” Adora says, blushing brightly. “I’m just gonna... go get changed.”

I hook my arm through hers and burst into a fit of giggles. “Come on, let’s get out of here!” I say, yanking her away.

--

The two of us are practically crying with laughter by the time we end up back at Adora’s room.

“That was *hilarious* !” I laugh, almost doubling over. “Did you see their faces?!”

“Phew,” Adora says, panting as she closes her door behind. “Could have been worse, could have been naked!” she says, grinning awkwardly.

I walk towards her and fold my arms, purring. “So... when we actually do have sex,” I say, guiding my tail under her nightgown, stroking my tail around her midsection, “am I going to have to remind you to get dressed before you go off on your little adventures?”

Adora blushes at the contact, but then her lips twist into the smuggest of all smirks. “When?” She asks.

“Huh?”

“You said *when* we have sex. Not *if* .”

“Shut up, dummy!” I say, swatting at her arm. “You haven’t even taken me on a date yet, so don’t get your hopes up.”

“Well you haven’t given me my kiss yet,” Adora says, lidding her eyes. “Remember?”

I close the gap between us, cup my palm behind her head and kiss her, slowly. I can still pick up traces of her scent from earlier, sweet and salty, but I try to ignore it otherwise we might have to break all of the rules we agreed on last night.

“Done,” I whisper, lightly biting her lower lip, delighting in the groan Adora makes as we part from the kiss. “Now, where’s my date?”

“I could give you a tour of the palace, if that counts?” Adora asks, pushing herself away from the door and playfully bumping against my shoulder as she walks past. I notice a mark on her back, barely visible through her nightgown, so I follow her and pull the cloth back, taking a closer look.

“Catra, are you trying to *undress* me?” Adora asks, snort-laughing.

Then I notice five distinctive lines, dark red, puffed out slightly, and I feel my heart sink.

“Adora… did I…” I whisper, pulling my hand back, opening my palm, and looking down at my claws.

“Hey, at least it’s not as bad as last time,” Adora says, fixing a few loose strands of her hair. “Those ones took a looong time to heal.”

A knot forms in my throat, and tears spring to my eyes at the distant memory. I’d somehow convinced myself that I hated her so much, or at least hated She-Ra, that it would be okay to rake both sets of claws down her back. I still remember the stink of dried blood beneath my nails, how I washed my hands over and over again afterwards, washed them until they were raw, telling myself again and

again that it was She-Ra I'd hurt, not Adora. But they'd both always smelt the same, their sweat, their tears, and definitely their blood. So I knew it wasn't true. I knew all along.

"But I kind of like these ones, since they-" Adora pauses, probably noticing my silence. "Since they… Catra, hey, what's wrong?" Adora asks, turning around to face me, then placing her hands on my shoulders and giving a gentle squeeze. "I'm sorry, I shouldn't have mentioned the other ones. They're gone, see? It's fine, Catra. Don't be upset..."

"I… made you *bleed* …" I say, grinding my teeth together. "I almost forgot…"

"Bah, we were always hurting each other, even before then. Don't you remember all the training drills?"

"That was different and you know it!" I say, pricking my ears back. "I tried to hurt you, I mean, really, *really* hurt you... What's *wrong* with me?"

"Hey, come here," Adora says, opening her arms. "Please."

I take a slow, reluctant step forward and lean into her embrace, keeping my arms by my sides, feeling numb inside. "You were a different person, going through a *lot* of things. But these new marks? They remind me how hard you fought for me, to protect me…"

I rest my forehead just above her collarbone, sighing. "I'm a monster. I go out of my way to hurt people, even when I love them…"

"You know I forgave you long ago for all that, right? You need to forgive yourself, Catra. Otherwise how can you ever move on? How can you ever be happy?"

"I don't *deserve* to be happy," I snap, knowing it's true.

"Okay that does it," Adora says. She pushes my shoulders back and forces me to return her gaze, "you can mope here and feel sorry for yourself, *or* we can go out on the best date ever."

"Hah… what?"

"There'll be kisses, and food, and… uh, more kisses?" Adora says, grinning. "Have I mentioned kisses?"

Adora wipes my cheeks dry, and I feel my heart warm because she's trying *this* hard just to cheer me up. "You're an idiot."

"Correction, I'm *your* idiot," Adora says, leaning forwards and kissing my forehead.

I prick my ears up and smile. " *Mine* ? Hmm. Has a nice ring to it."

"So, it's a date?"

"Fine, but," I say, reaching behind her hair, and pulling her hair tie loose, "wear it down?"

"You prefer it that way?" Adora asks, blushing. "Well, I only need to keep it out of my eyes if we're fighting, or flying, and a date shouldn't involve-"

"You're *such* a dummy," I say, bursting into laughter as I lean forwards, wrap my arms around her waist and press my mouth into the crook of her neck, a hum of approval greeting my lips.

I stay there a while, holding Adora tightly and purring, feeling so lucky that I have her. And maybe, maybe… that's all that matters right now.

"Feeling any better?" Adora asks, stroking the fur behind my ears.

I sniffle, pulling away to smile at her. "Much."

"Then it's time for our hot date!" Adora exclaims, suddenly tickling my sides.

"S-Stop it, haha!" I screech, running away from her.

"Fine, fine. Anyway, I'm gonna need a shower," Adora says, wrinkling her nose, "I'm feeling a bit... clammy."

"Is that from all of today's heroics," I ask, flashing a wicked grin at her, "or from our little *tussle* earlier?"

"Both," Adora says, wiggling her eyebrows, stealing a quick kiss, and then heading towards the bathroom.

I dive onto my bed, cross one leg over the other, then fold my hands behind my head, yelling "You'd better hurry up, I need to clean up too... and I'm starving."

"Will do!" Adora yells back, just as I hear the sound of running water.

Chapter End Notes

Bow: In hindsight, maybe standing underneath a falling spaceship *wasn't* the best idea...
Catra: Thank you!

Figurines and Frivolity

Chapter Summary

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

I must have dozed off, because when I next open my eyes, I find Melog pacing around the room, sniffing at the same spot where Adora and I were getting a little carried away earlier. Melog notices me watching, and sits on their hind legs, staring at me, with one ear twitching.

I sit up and fold my arms over my knees. “Before you even ask, the answer is no, we didn’t.”

“That is unfortunate,” Melog says, wagging their tail. “The noises have stopped from outside. Is all well?”

“Yeah, sorry for leaving you behind. It was all a bit chaotic.”

“I am not offended. But if you need me next time, be sure to tell the pink one to take me with you.”

“I will. Hey, come here,” I say, patting a space on my bed. Melog jumps up and nuzzles against my hand, purring loudly. “You’re weird, Melog. You know that?”

“But this is a good thing?”

“Honestly,” I say, stroking their fur, my eyelids growing heavy, “weird is something I’m kind of starting to like these days.”

The bedroom door suddenly cracks open, and Adora walks in, beaming towards me, carrying a paper bag. “Oh hey, you’re finally awake!” she says, giggling when Melog rushes from the bed to her, almost knocking her over. “Did you have a nice nap?”

“Yeah,” I say, stretching out and yawning. “Did I miss anything?”

“Well, you were out for a while,” Adora says, walking towards me. “We had another meeting with Micah, just a quick one. Then I came back, and watched you snore for a while. It was kind of cute.”

“I don’t snore,” I grumble, folding my arms, ”and I’m not cute.”

Adora sits next to me on the bed, and places her lips to my forehead. “You do, and you are.”

“Bah, if you say so…” I say, failing to hide my smile. I’m about to ask what happened at the meeting when my belly rumbles, loudly, and the words die in my throat.

“Hah! It’s a good job I brought you this,” Adora says, delving into the paper bag and pulling out a small box from it. A spicy, salty aroma fills my nostrils, and my mouth fills with saliva.

“I love you so much right now,” I say, eagerly grabbing the cardboard box and tearing it open. “Ooh, it’s fish?” I ask, picking up a small, battered ball from within the box, and swallowing it without bothering to chew.

“Yeah, just like we used to steal,” Adora says, giggling.

“No. this is *better*,” I say, throwing piece after piece into my mouth, remembering back to when Adora and I used to take food from villages during Horde raids. I mean it was fun and all, but we actually did it so that we could eat something, *anything*, beyond the rations that they fed us back then.

“I knew you’d like it,” Adora says, puffing her chest out proudly, “just don’t tell Mermista.”

I groan, tossing Melog a couple of the fishy treats, “Adora, I’m already on her bad side…”

“I’m kidding, don’t worry. She’ll never find out,” Adora says, wincing.

--

It doesn’t take long for me to empty the contents of the box, including the bed of rice that was tucked away beneath the seafood. I release a loud belch, and then pat my stomach.

“Woops,” I say, grinning. “That was really good. Thanks, Adora.”

“I’m glad you liked it,” Adora says, leaning forwards and peering at my lips. “You have something just”, she says, kissing a crumb from the corner of my mouth, “here.”

I seize the opportunity, turn my head and catch her lips with mine, humming at the contact, wrapping my arms around her shoulders, and then recoiling in disgust. “Ugh! Is that me!?” I ask, lifting up my arm, sniffing under it and wrinkling my nose.

“The bathroom’s all yours if you want it,” Adora says, showing a thin-lipped smile, wafting her hand below her nose.

“Oh, I’m too stinky for you, am I?” I ask, smirking, and then pouncing on her without warning.

“Haha! Catra, no! I just got clean!”

“And now you’re gonna get *dirty!*” I yell, laughing while I tackle her onto her back, holding her wrists, and trying to press my gross smelly armpit into her face.

“Stop it!” Adora shrieks, “That is *disgusting!*”

I release my grip, sit up straight, and - with some difficulty - manage to keep my expression neutral. "You're supposed to love me no matter what, Adora."

"You can't be serious…"

"It's fine. I knew you didn't want me all along," I say, sighing and standing up. "I'll go get washed then, just so I can be good enough."

"Catra, wait, I didn't mean-"

"Hah!" I turn and grin widely, "that was *way* too easy, Adora."

"Oh just you wait," Adora says, blowing out a puff of air, and folding her arms.

I head to the bathroom door, laughing all the way, then pause to lean against the doorframe. "Okay princess, I'm going to make myself smell delicious, just for you."

"You're too kind."

"I know. Won't be long."

--

Adora's bathroom is meticulously clean compared to her bedroom, light-pink tiles glimmering beneath the magical spots of silver light in the ceiling. There's a porcelain sink, with a large oval mirror above it. To the left of that, a couple of shelves stacked with various colourful bottles, and beneath those, a small set of drawers with towels on top.

I run my hand across the fluffy, white towels, marvelling at the softness of the material, then I pick up a few choice bottles from the shelves, and place them onto the shower cubicle floor. There's a couple of unopened boxes with toothbrushes in them, so I help myself to one, grab the small tube of toothpaste in a cup next to the sink, and brush my teeth and tongue until my mouth tastes like something other than ass.

I look at myself in the mirror and check my teeth, then tug my sports bra off, pausing to puff my chest out proudly. I pause for a moment, wondering how it'd feel to have Adora's mouth there, and her tongue...

I watch my own pupils dilate at the thought of her, touching me that way. I used to fantasise about Adora all the time back in the Fright Zone, but when she left me I made sure to sever those thoughts completely. And now, everything's moving so quickly that my brain can hardly keep up. One minute I've convinced myself that we're sworn enemies and that she hates me. The next, she tells me I'm irresistible, that she loves me, and that she wants me.

Maybe I did die when prime caused me to fall from that platform, I think, remembering the terror I felt when I fell, and then the sudden, devastating impact of the steel floor. *Maybe this is some weird post-death fantasy. If it is, I hope it lasts forever*.

I pull my underwear off, and step into the shower cubicle, twisting the small, circular handle in the centre of the tiled wall.

"Ah! Cold!" I hiss, jumping back and waiting a few seconds. I gingerly reach my hand forwards, twisting the knob to the left a bit more, until I find a suitable temperature.

I take a step forward and sigh contentedly, a shudder pulsing through my body the moment I feel the water cascade over my shoulders, soaking into my short fur. Then I turn the heat up a little more, close my eyes, and tilt my face into the stream, enjoying the sensation of the hot water trickling down the contours of my nose and chin.

I stretch my fingers behind my neck, feeling the edges of my scar, and within it a small, rough, diamond-shaped patch of skin. *One day my fur will grow back*, I think. *And even if it doesn't, my hair will cover it up soon enough.*

My hair…

I groan and tip my forehead to the square tiles in front of me, squeezing my eyes shut, feeling water stream over my neck and between my shoulder blades. *I miss my hair,* I think, knowing that it was never my choice to have it this short. *It was his decision*, I think, picking at the scar with my nails, *and I'm pretty sure he did it just so that he could see that stupid chip on display, like a damn trophy.*

The memory assaults my senses with devastating clarity. The clones, stood all round me, chanting some crap about their great *cleansing*. About how I'd be *free*. Horde prime, reaching out his steel-tipped finger and slicing through my hair in a few messy strokes, then pushing me headfirst into the luminous green pit. And that awful, gut-wrenching pain; violent, never-ending jolts piercing through me, drilling right to my marrow. When the pain got to its worst, I remember feeling sure I'd either drown or disintegrate.

I swallow thickly, opening my eyes and blinking away tears. *But it doesn't matter*, I think. *I survived. I saved her. We're here and he isn't.*

"And we're going. on. a. date! So snap out of it!" I say to myself, banging my forehead against the tiles with each word.

I take a deep breath and focus my thoughts on my immediate priorities; getting clean, and kissing Adora. I bend down and look through the three bottles I placed here earlier, picking out the lavender one. "Hope she likes this one," I mutter, squirting the soap into my palm and getting to work, scrubbing myself from head to toe. The water runs gritty and brown and I suddenly realise it must have been days, maybe weeks, since I had a proper wash.

Once the water runs clear I grab for the next bottle and squint at it, reading just enough of the label to know it's the shampoo I brought in, and not the conditioner. I squirt a blob of the contents into my hand and lather it onto my hair, a scent of coconut and lime filling the cubicle.

Once I rinse I notice the water washes out brown again. "Ugh, nasty," I say, squeezing more shampoo into my palm and getting to work again, washing through my hair a second time.

--

Four more rinses and a thorough conditioning later, I twist the faucet to the right with a quiet squeak, shutting off the stream of water.

Then I twist around, running my hand in a fist along the length of my tail to dry it out. I grab a towel from the pile on the drawer and bury my face into it, thinking it must be the softest thing I've ever felt, then wrap the full sized cloth around myself.

I pause to wipe some condensation from the mirror, gasping at just how much cleaner I appear without all those layers of grime. "Unbelievable", I mutter, drying my feet off. I tighten the towel

around myself and open the door, releasing wafts of steam through the doorway.

“Oh, Brr!” I shiver, feeling the cool air from Adora’s room caress my damp skin.

“That was a long shower,” Adora says, putting her hairbrush down, then turning away from her dresser to face me. “Did you enjoy it?”

“Uh….” I croak, my throat turning dry at the sight before me. “Adora, you…” Her hair is hanging loosely, and she’s wearing a flowing, white dress with a gold trim framed below her collar bone.

“Oh, this? Do you like it?” she says, spinning to reveal the cloak hanging over the back of the dress. There’s a v-cut behind both the dress and the cloak, which runs deeply enough to show off Adora’s toned back.

“You look... beautiful,” I say, feeling my heart almost jump into my throat.

Adora blows a raspberry. “Catra. Did you just pay me a compliment?”

“Well can you blame me?” I ask, looking her up and down, “Show me the back again?”

“See something you like?” Adora asks, pulling her hair over to one side, exposing her back and shoulders in all their glory.

“Yes, actually,” I mutter, leaning forwards and placing the tip of my nose between her exposed shoulder blades, inhaling deeply before pressing my lips to her flesh. “I do.”

Adora hums at the touch, and leans forwards, planting her hands on her dresser. “That’s not fair,” she says, peering around her shoulder.

“What isn’t?” I ask, smirking as I pepper kisses up her spine, all the way to the base of her neck. “This?”

“*Catra...*” Adora says, the neediness in her voice sending a hot pulse below my belly.

I gulp, thickly, wondering how to coax even more of those sounds from her. I kiss behind her neck again, and fold my arms around her waist, pulling her frame against mine, then sucking at her skin, nibbling it lightly, quickly finding myself lost in her taste, in her scent…

“You… better… stop that,” Adora growls, her knuckles turning visibly white where she grips the edge of the dresser.

“Or else?” I whisper, breathing hotly against her skin.

“Or else,” Adora says, spinning in place and folding her arms around my shoulders, “We won’t be going out at all. And I got dressed up all nicely for you.”

“Uh…” I can’t find any words, because Adora’s cheeks are flushed, her pupils are dilated, and her heart… I can hear it from here, racing just as quickly as mine is. It would be so easy to kiss her again, and see how far I dare take this.

“Or,” Adora says, lidding her eyes, “We can stay. But you better finish off what you started...”

Adora traces a finger down my cheek and I blink a few times, swallowing thickly. “F-finish?” I ask.

Adora leans forward and whispers into my ear, “Finish me off, since you’ve gotten me so nicely warmed up.”

“Finish you off? What, like kill you?”

Adora suddenly bursts out laughing, slaps me on the shoulder and shakes her head. “Are you being serious? You are, aren’t you?”

“Pfft, whatever,” I say, blowing strands of my fringe from my face. “I knew exactly what you meant, Adora.”

“Okay,” Adora says, coughing, and straightening her expression. “What did I mean?”

“You meant-” I pause, twitching my left ear, “ugh, never mind. Just take me on this date already. And where’s Melog?”

“They went to nap on the balcony,” Adora says. Then she smirks and points to my torso, “and aren’t you forgetting something?”

“Ah crap!” I say, folding my ears down, feeling crestfallen. “Adora… I don't have anything to wear…”

“I kind of like you just as you are,” she says, wiggling her eyebrows.

“So just me, wrapped in a towel? Classy, Adora.”

Adora giggles, then suddenly sidesteps to her wardrobe and dramatically flings open the doors. “Ta-daaa!”

I frown, follow her over there and peer inside. There’s a bunch of Adora’s outfits hung up on a rail, then in the middle a set of drawers. On the top of the drawers, a huge box full of random stuff. *Wait*, I think… *that’s my stuff!*

“But, when did you…”

“You slept for a few hours,” Adora says, appearing very pleased with herself, “so Glimmer and I went to salvage what we could from the Fright Zone…”

“Adora,” I say, fighting back sudden tears, my hands rummaging through the contents. Pretty much all of my clothes are here, as well as my old half-broken brush, and the nicknacks I’d keep on my dresser. There’s even some of the dumb pictures of the two of us here that I’d hidden away in my locker. “Did you seriously think of *everything?*”

“See? This is what happens when you say you love me,” Adora says, beaming at me.

“Then I’m gonna say it a whole lot more,” I say, grinning from ear to ear as soon I discover a certain purple bow-tie. “Hey, should I wear this?” I ask, dangling it on a hooked finger.

Adora bursts into laughter. “You were such a brat at that ball...”

“But I bet you were *dying* to kiss me, even then,” I say, picking up the purple and pink suit in question, as well as fresh underwear, and placing them in a pile on the dresser’s surface.

“Yeah… Maybe,” Adora says, scrunching up her nose. “But you can’t prove it.”

“Don’t need to,” I say, wiggling a finger at her, “turn around.”

Adora looks me up and down, bites her lip into a grin, and then turns away, folding her arms.

“Since when have you been so shy?” She asks. I run my gaze over her bare back, admiring the dip between her shoulders all over again.

“I’m not shy,” I lie, towelling myself completely dry. “Like I said before, you’ve got to earn this.”

“And saving your life doesn’t count?” Adora asks, beginning to slowly tilt her head backwards.

I jump towards her and plant my fingers against her scalp, pushing her head forwards again. “I saved yours too, princess. Just stay still, okay? I won’t be long.”

“Can’t blame a girl for trying,” Adora says with a shrug, chuckling.

--

A few minutes later I check myself over in the mirror, straightening my tie. “Ok. I’m ready,” I say, running my fingers through my damp hair, stealing one last look at the crevice between Adora’s shoulder blades before she turns to face me.

“Hmm, you look very…” Adora pauses, strides towards me and pulls me towards her, dragging me by the collar. “Handsome,” she says, kissing me.

“I was going for sexy,” I mutter against her lips.

Adora kisses me again. “That too,” she says, her mouth twisting into a grin. “And you smell *amazing*.”

“It’s *your* shampoo, idiot,” I say, chuckling.

“Then I have great taste in hair products,” Adora says, “Who knew?”

“Okay, I’m fed and I’m washed, so,” I say, clearing my throat and hooking my arm through Adora’s. “Ma’am,” I say, gesturing towards her door.

Adora giggles and gestures in the exact same way. “Ma’am.”

“No no,” I say, wiggling my ears. “after you.”

“Oh but I couldn’t possibly!” Adora says, making her voice sound as snooty as possible and clearly holding back laughter. “After you, m’lady.”

I burst into laughter, and kiss her on her cheek. “You’re *such* a moron. I love you.”

“Hmm, love you too, stinky,” she says with an evil grin, bumping me out of the way with her butt, and heading out of the bedroom just ahead of me.

“Stinky!?” I say, grabbing her hand, closing the door behind us. “You’re not seriously going to call me that, are you?”

“Why not?” she asks, laughing. “I think it’s perfect.”

“Because I don’t stink!”

“Well, you did. They could smell you from all the way in the crimson wastes. Glimmer kept receiving formal complaints.”

“Wow, you’re really milking this one aren’t you?”

“Yup.”

--

“So, where are you taking me?” I ask.

“There’s a market in the central square, just a couple of minutes away.”

“We’re shopping? You do realise I have no money.”

“We can still peruse their wares,” Adora says, drawling the words out for comedic effect.

“*Peruse?* Haha, did you swallow a thesaurus or something?”

Adora giggles and tugs at my hand, pulling me through a couple more archways until we’re outdoors. It’s a really clear, sunny day, and the air is cool and crisp. Ahead of us is a large, open area, packed with rows and rows of colourful stalls. The paving stones beneath are detailed with swirling patterns of small white stones embedded into the larger grey slabs.

“Wow, this place is packed,” I say, feeling suddenly nervous. “You’d never guess we were all in the middle of an intergalactic war a few days ago…”

“I like it here,” Adora says, closing her eyes, and inhaling deeply. “All the sights, sounds, and smells… it makes me feel normal again after everything that’s happened.”

“I guess this has been your new normal for a while then,” I say, trying to catch any interesting conversations going on around us.

I can’t believe they let Hordak in!

So that’s it? We just forgive and forget? I lost my Mother!!

Adora pauses, squeezing my fingers. “I… never thought about it that way. I know it’s very new for you, so if you hate it just let me know, okay?”

Marvin cheated on me, again. And with Silah, can you even believe it?!

Well at least this way we can all stop fighting. I’m so tired of fighting...

“I don’t hate it,” I say, smiling at her, pricking up my ears. “I’m with you, aren’t I?”

“Aww, look at you being sweet,” Adora says, pecking her lips against my cheek. “Hey, come look at this!”

Adora’s eyes sparkle with excitement, and it makes my heart swell in my chest just watching her act like this, so happy, so carefree. A small part of me might even envy it, if I weren’t so deeply in love with her.

“What are we looking at?” I ask, scanning the stall in front of us. There’s lots of small figurines, each intricately detailed. “Oh, you have some of these already!” I say, noticing the same Bow and Glimmer

statues that Adora has on her drawers.

“Yes, I have lots of them actually,” she says, scanning around but then looking dejected.

“Hey, what’s wrong?” I ask.

“I was trying to find one of you, but they only had this,” she says, holding up a tiny figure. I take it from her, and study it closely. They got the hair and outfit pretty much spot on, but some things are definitely out of place, like the fangs. There’s a dark red base beneath the figure, which says ‘*Catra, the evil horde’*.

“Hmm, it’s really detailed,” I say, passing it back. “But my teeth are *not* that big.”

“Yeah, I think they tried to make you look more evil,” Adora says, putting the piece back with a small sigh. “Sorry.”

I lean forwards and kiss her, “It’s fine, I kind of liked it anyway.”

“Well I already own it, so you can have mine if you like.”

“Interesting. You claim to have *Catra, of the evil horde*,” I say, smirking, “but I don’t remember seeing it on top of your drawers. As usual, I’m just not good enough for you.”

Adora smirks at me. “I’m not biting this time.”

“Hah, fast learner”, I say, giggling when Adora peppers me with sudden kisses.

“Force-Captain Catra?” I don’t recognise the deep voice, but turn to face the direction it comes from. *Looks like he’s a Salinean*, I think, scanning over the brushed bronze scales on his outfit. “Surely not. Not here, in this palace, daring to show her face. I must be imagining things.”

“Don’t think I’ve had the pleasure,” I say, placing a hand on my waist and scowling.

Adora pales, appearing pensive while holding out a hand. “Hi! I’m Adora. Also known as She-Ra. How are you?”

The aged man frowns deeply, first squinting at me, then back at Adora, then back at me. “And you’re with her?”

“Yes. Very much so,” Adora says, squeezing my hand.

“Oh! Well in that case, any friend of She-Ra is a friend of mine,” he says, beaming widely. “You enjoy your day now, Force-Captain Catra.”

“It’s actually just Catra…” I mutter, watching as he hobbles away.

“Adora, what the hell was that?”

Adora speaks quickly. “Okay so don’t be mad but some people really like She-Ra, as in really, *really* like her. I know, it’s crazy I mean I don’t understand it either, hah! Anyway, I think it worked to our advantage this time.”

“You’re abusing your popularity?” I ask, feeling proud somehow.

“Hey, it worked didn’t it?” Adora says, pouting. “I don’t want our date to be ruined.”

“Oh I’m loving it so far, *She-Ra*. I have to say, I did wonder why people were leaving me alone.”

“Hey,” Adora says, placing her hand on my cheek, “Once they find out how much good you’ve done, they’ll love you too. I know it.”

“I didn’t do that much good, Adora. I saved two people.”

“Saving anyone is good, you know. And you helped us to beat Horde Prime.”

“I guess.”

“Are you going to start sulking in the middle of our date?” Adora asks, placing her hands on her hips.

I grin at her, “You know, I do love a good sulk.”

Suddenly, the old plumerian lady behind the tiny-figurine market stall hurries towards us, holding out a figurine. “Adora! Catra! I didn’t realise it was you two. Here, I have this. It’s new!”

I pick it up and look at it, widening my eyes. “You made the base blue? And my teeth are normal now?”

The old lady grins. “You’re on our side now, no?”

“I… yeah. Looks like it,” I say, admiring the figure. On the base, this one says *‘Catra - Hero’. That’s a bit of a stretch*, I think, smiling anyway. It looks just like me, even down to the telltale smirk, but with an entirely different energy to the other figurine.

“*How much?*” Adora asks, appearing crazy-eyed.

“Oh don’t be silly, you can have it. Gosh, you two look so good together… reminds me of me and my wife, long ago.”

“Thank you,” I say, grinning widely. “This is really nice.”

“No, thank *you*, Catra,” she says, winking. “Some of us know about your deeds. So you just keep your chin up!”

“Hah!” I say, beaming back at her, “Yes ma’am. Thanks again.”

--

“Catra,” Adora says, smirking. “I think you just gained your first admirer.”

“Hah! Don’t be ridiculous.”

“I’m not. She literally fangirled over you.”

“Really? So if she likes me, do you think I could get more freebies?”

“Ah yes, of course. Tactical mastermind Catra.”

“Yeah, and don’t you forget it,” I say, elbowing Adora, then pocketing the mini-me. “First of my collection.”

“And it’s rare too!” Adora says, grinning.

“Don’t you find it all a bit weird, though?”

“Hmm?”

“They’re figures of *us*, Adora. People are making miniature versions of us. Why?”

“Because we’re heroes!”

“And villains!” I say, raising my arms, splaying my fingers, feigning excitement.

“Ah but no, see, you’ve changed sides,” Adora says, giggling. “The villains lost.”

“We did not loo-” I begin, lifting my hand and lacing my fingers into my fringe, “Ugh, never mind.”

“You know, if you want to play out some scenarios later, I could always let you win if that’ll make you happy…”

“Really? You’re really going there?”

“You’re taking this way too seriously. Look. They’re cute! Look at how cute they are!” Adora says, grabbing the mini Catra from my jacket pocket, then clashing her little She-Ra against my little Catra.

“Wait, where did you get that from?”

Adora thins her lips into a line, and looks away. “Nowhere.”

“Adora-”

“Shhh.”

“Adora,” I say laughing, “you seriously carry that around with you?”

“Maybe”

“You absolute… you…” I laugh, throwing my arms around her, “why are you like this?”

Adora pecks my lips. “I don’t know. Why are you so stinky?”

“Shut up… I smell good. You said so.”

“Hmmm, you do,” Adora says, sniffing into the fur at my neck, causing my fur to ripple down my back.

“So,” I say, quickly changing the subject, “what else is there to do around here?”

“There are oh, about fifty stalls here,” Adora says, grinning maniacally.

I hold my arm out, and she hooks her elbow with mine. “We’d best get a move on, then,” I say, not mentioning the fact that I only want to watch *her* look at the stalls, and see how her eyes light up at the smallest, most idiotic things she finds in them.

--

“So,” Adora says, sitting on the bench next to me, and resting an arm around my shoulder. “What was your favourite?”

“This. This is my favourite,” I say, grimacing at the aches and pains down my legs. “I never knew shopping could be so hard! That was worse than our training drills!”

“Aww, did I wear you out?” Adora asks, puckering her lips.

“Two hours, Adora. Two hours of shopping.”

Adora laughs. “You’re such a lightweight.”

“I dread asking,” I say, rubbing my sore thighs, “but where to next?”

“I want,” Adora says, bending over and pulling a plush mouse from one of her bags, one of the many weird or random things she bought today, “to give Melog their new toy.”

“I’m sure they’ll love it,” I say, smiling when I remember how excited Adora became at the pet stalls in particular. “Although the cynic in me feels you’re just looking for an excuse to get me back to your bedroom.”

Adora chuckles. “Busted.”

“Given how irresistible I am,” I say, twitching the end of my tail, “I can’t say I’m surprised.”

“You really are, though.”

“Is that why you wanted me to *finish you off* earlier?” I ask, smirking.

“That offer’s always open,” Adora says, reaching for my hands. She lifts them to her lips, and slowly, deliberately kisses each finger tip.

“I’m... definitely considering the offer,” I say, my throat becoming dry. “Or, we could just kiss and stuff.”

“Kisses are good too,” Adora says, leaning across, placing her hand behind my neck and tussling her fingers into my short strands of hair. Her lips rest lazilly on mine, and I kiss her back, purring.

--

We head back to Adora’s room, her fingers squeezing around mine, her thumb rubbing against my palm. I glance at her nervously a few times, unsure of what I’m getting myself into… *but it’s Adora*, I think, *so I’m safe*. *Besides, we’re just going to kiss.*

“We can just drop the bags off and go get food, if you want?” Adora asks.

“So no kisses after all?” I ask, pouting.

Adora laughs, and elbows her door open while carrying all the crap she bought today. She places the bags next to her drawers, then looks around briefly. “Okay, that’ll do for now. No sign of Melog, though.”

I close the door quietly behind myself and shyly look at Adora, feeling my heart race. “Saves me having to kick them out.”

“Are you saying we’re going to need privacy?” Adora asks, her usual smug grin making an appearance. She walks towards me, slowly and deliberately. “If I didn’t know any better, I’d think you

were flirting with me."

"What do you expect?" I say, taking a step forward, sliding my arms behind her frame, and pressing my palms against her bare shoulder blades. I nuzzle my face against the pulse-point at her neck, and inhale deeply. "You've been wearing that damn dress all day, Adora," I mumble, absent-mindedly running my tongue against her skin, just to taste her.

A needy, desperate groan escapes Adora's throat, and it sets all of my fur on edge.

"Catra…"

I run my lips around her neck again, kissing softly, sucking lightly, biting gently, and Adora gasps hotly against my ear, digging her fingers into my scalp, tugging at me desperately. I pause to tilt my gaze upwards, finding Adora's lidded eyes looking down at me, her pupils dilated, and her cheeks flushed pink.

It's fine, I think. *We're just kissing...*

"Catra," Adora says, placing both her palms on my cheeks, looking directly into my eyes. "I love you, but the neck thing is driving me a little crazy."

"Oh, is that so? Hadn't noticed," I say, grinning wickedly.

She tips her forehead to mine, chuckling. "Okay, that does it. I think we should probably stop now, and go get something to eat."

"Chickening out, are we?"

"I'm doing this for your own good."

"You don't scare me, Adora," I say, smirking. "Besides, I haven't had enough kisses yet."

"Oh, you need more kisses, huh?" Adora says, peppering my face with wet kisses and giggling, until I'm laughing along with her, my cheeks damp with a mix of Adora's kisses and my own tears.

"Hmm," I purr, "That's better. But I still want more."

"What more could I possible give y-"

I quickly kiss her again, and a second time, this time parting my lips and slowly, roughly rolling my tongue with hers, moaning with her at the contact. It's like I'm becoming drunk, my senses flooded with everything that makes Adora, Adora. Her deliciously sweet flavour, and her salty-vanilla scent, so strong now, telling me just how turned on she is.

I kiss her hungrily, groaning when her fingernails trail narrow lines across the back of my neck, just above my scar. We stumble against the bed, and I fall on top of her on all fours, panting, holding her wrists against the mattress.

"Catra," Adora growls my name, breathing heavily. "If you don't stop this, I might not be able to."

I lower myself until I'm pressed fully against her, breathing heavily against her cheek. "You taste too damn good, so this is really all your fault."

Adora watches, wide-eyed, as I prop myself up on my elbows and guide a hand up her dress, my palm brushing against the soft, supple skin of her calf. Higher and higher I search, moving all the way up her muscular thigh, watching Adora's face, watching her eyes flutter closed when my fingers reach her underwear.

Instead of finding the usual boy shorts, I feel something lacy. "Hmm," I purr, trailing my thumb nail atop the fancy trim. "You really did dress up for me today, didn't you?"

"Yes I did," Adora says, biting her lip into a grin. "But I didn't think you'd find out…"

"I'm pleased to have made the discovery," I say, licking my lips. I take a deep breath, knowing I'm about to pass the point of no return.

"Catra, wait," Adora says, rubbing her palms up my back, along the smooth material of my shirt.

"What's wrong?"

"I just... want to know you're sure?"

"I love you, idiot," I say, nuzzling my lips against the side of her face. "And right now, you're driving me a little crazy."

Adora chuckles. "But I didn't even do anything…"

"You didn't have to," I whisper, lightly stroking my fingers over her underwear, watching those beautiful blue eyes widen, feeling her hand grasp knots into my shirt. "You're stunning, Adora. I can't even control myself around you."

"Then don't," Adora whispers, writhing up into my touch. *She's already so wet*, I think, glancing my fingers across the damp fabric, teasing her with the barest of touches, knowing I have all day to enjoy this.

Looking at her in this state, her pupils blown, her cheeks flush, her whole body quivering, makes me wonder what she'll feel like when she's naked and wet against my touch, and what she'll sound like when I dive my tongue into her, tasting everything she can give.

Suddenly, there's a knock at the door.

"*Seriously!?*" I exclaim, flattening my ears.

"Catra…" Adora gasps, grabbing my right arm and holding it in place, "ignore it. Please."

"O-Okay," I say, sneaking the tips of my fingers beneath the hem of her underwear, licking my suddenly-dry lips in anticipation. I reach the top of her golden curls, just as there's another knock, this time louder.

"Urgh," I growl.

"*YES?*" Adora yells, sounding more pissed off than I think I've ever heard her.

"Guys? It's Glimmer. The clone woke up."

I roll my eyes. "That clone has some great fucking timing."

Adora suddenly giggles hysterically, and dives her face into the crook of my neck.

“This is in no way funny, Adora,” I say, rolling off from the top of her, and trying not to laugh. “I’ll go let your friend in, shall I?”

Chapter End Notes

Adora: Baby, were you always this weak for my shoulders?
Catra: What sort of a question is that, love? Hmm, come here. Now, turn around.
Glimmer: Uh, guys... you were supposed to comment on the chapter... not make out...

BONUS1, thank you so much to arcadediamond for this incredible illustration! Love the little figures <3

BONUS2, my crops are flourishing and I'm gay screaming because Marin drew a comic of this scene. I don't think I'll ever be over this...

YOU'RE STUNNING, ADORA...
I CAN'T EVEN CONTROL MYSELF
AROUND YOU...
THEN
DON'T.

Despair and Dumplings

Chapter Summary

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"One minute!" Adora yells.

I pause on my way to the door to watch Adora leap to her feet, frantically straighten her dress then dash to the dresser to grab her brush. She manages to make barely any improvement to her hair, grimaces at me and then shrugs, throwing the brush back down.

I can't help but burst out laughing, opening the door mid-giggle. "Hi Glimmer," I say, fastening my tie back up, feeling almost dizzy when I notice Adora's scent, still fresh against my fingers.

"Oh," Glimmer blushes, looking from me, to a very red-faced Adora, to the clearly ruffled bed sheets. "Did I disturb you guys?"

"Not at all, princess," I say, running my claws through my fringe, and smirking across at Adora.

"Nope we were just, ah, uh," Adora says, thrusting her arms towards her mountain of paper bags, "Unpacking! We went shopping, and look here!" she says, pulling out a yellow rubber duck and squeezing it with a loud *qwaaaak*, "We bought stuff!"

Glimmer raises an eyebrow. "That's… a *lot* of stuff, Adora."

"Oh you don't know the half of it," I say, groaning. "My legs are still sore..."

"She does get a bit carried away, doesn't she?" Glimmer asks, chuckling.

"I'll have you two know," Adora says, pulling some weird puzzle-cube thing from a bag and waving it at us threateningly, "I only buy things if I absolutely need them."

“Okayyy,” Glimmer says, crouching down and peering into the bags. “I’m pretty sure you don’t need these,” she says, pulling out a pair of bright-pink, fluffy ear warmers.

“Hey! They’re pretty!” Adora says, pouting, “and they were on sale.”

“They were on sale because we’re in Brightmoon,” Glimmer says, rolling her eyes, “and it’s the middle of the warm season.”

I chuckle to myself, watching their interaction play out for a short while, with Glimmer pulling out increasingly idiotic things from Adora’s bags one at a time, my personal favourite being the box of air, which is literally a box... with nothing inside of it.

“Uh, guys?” I ask, eventually letting curiosity get the better of me. “The clone?”

“Ah, yes,” Glimmer says, standing up. “That’s why I’m here. He’s asking for you, Catra.”

“Me?” I ask, feeling my fur bristle. “Why on Etheria would he want to see me?”

“Maybe,” Glimmer pauses, wincing. “Because you all had a connection?”

“Yeah, right. Count me out,” I growl. “I’d rather stick claws into my eyes.”

“Catra,” Adora rests her hand on my forearm. “We should hear him out.”

“Pfft, easy for you to say,” I say, pacing the room. “Why should I? And where did they all go anyway? One minute they’re here, the next, poof!” I say, raising my hands, “They’re probably back at their fleet, you know, the massive, deadly one we snuck past.”

Glimmer pinches the bridge of her nose. “If we talk to him, we might be able to get some answers at least…”

Adora pecks my cheek, helping to calm me, even if just a little. “Do it for me?”

“Urgh! Fine,” I say, throwing the bedroom door open and storming out ahead of them both. “If he does anything to piss me off, then don’t blame me when things get ugly.”

--

I storm down the hallway with my hands balled into fists, and my teeth tightly clenched, feeling conflicted; on one hand annoyed with myself that Adora has me wrapped around her little finger, but on the other, very much enjoying that she asks me to do stuff for her, especially if it means I get kisses.

“Let’s get this over with,” I grumble, tapping my knuckles against the smooth metal surface of the medical bay door.

Castaspella greets us. “Ah, you’re here!”

“How is he?” Glimmer asks.

“He seems fine, but he still won’t talk to us,” Castaspella says, pouting. “Are you sure I can’t use a truth spell?”

“Not unless we absolutely have to,” Glimmer says. “Thanks for the help, Aunty.”

“Anytime, princess,” Castaspella says, ruffling her hand into Glimmer’s hair. “So…”

“I know,” Glimmer says, grinning. “You need to get back, right? We’ll be fine.”

“Yes, can’t leave Mystacor too long,” Castaspella says, chuckling, “someone might blow themselves up!”

“I’d laugh if it weren’t actually true,” Glimmer mutters, hugging her Aunt.

“Take care, kids,” Castaspella says, waving before she wanders away down the hall.

--

“Do they really blow themselves up?” Adora asks, wide-eyed.

“Looong story,” Glimmer says, rolling her eyes. “Shall we get this over with?”

“Fine,” I say, folding my arms and following them inside.

There’s almost a complete absence of smell in here, except for a small trace of disinfectant. The walls are spotless, and lined with cupboards packed with various medical supplies. *Why don’t they just use magic*, I think, scrunching up my nose.

“Ah, little sister.”

I stare at the source, finding the clone sat up, propped against several pillows. His green eyes shine, staring into mine.

“What did you call me?” I ask, my fur standing on end.

“Little sis-”

I unsheathe my claws and pounce on the edge of the bed without a second thought, holding my nails to his throat. “Call me that again, and I’ll give you a makeover.”

“Catra, no!” Adora and Glimmer each grab one of my arms, dragging me away from the bed.

“I… apologise. I meant no offense,” the clone says, frowning.

“What do you want? Spit it out!” I say, pulling my arms free, and shooting daggers at my two capturers.

The clone sighs. “We thought, more than anyone, you would best understand our turmoil. We have all been slaves to prime, some of us for years.”

“What does that have to do with anything?” I ask, holding my palms upwards. “Yeah, we’ve all suffered, big deal.”

“We hoped you would listen. We are trapped, and we have nowhere to go.”

“Who’s *we*?”

“Myself, and the twelve others that I rescued.”

The clone tells his little tale, and I listen, feeling more and more agitated the longer he speaks. Their ship was a small scouting vessel, and it got caught in Adora's magic when she zapped prime's flagship. It crashed, he teleported his friends to prime's vessel, and now, here he is, fouling the palace with his presence.

"So, there's no other ships?" Adora asks.

The clone looks towards Adora, then back at me, without speaking.

"What are you looking at?" I ask. "I'm not your negotiator and even if I were, I'd vote we just kill you all."

The clone sighs. "There are no other ships left in your system. The entire fleet has returned to headquarters, as our protocol dictates."

"Why didn't you go with them?" Glimmer asks.

"The protocol orders that on Prime's demise we leave at once. Nobody paused to rescue us, nor would we have expected them to."

"I don't like the sound of this protocol," Glimmer says.

"Well maybe you shouldn't have let them get away!" I snap.

"Catra…" Adora says, frowning, "there's nothing we could have done. There were hundreds of ships out there."

"*I don't care!*" I say, placing my head in my hands, swatting my tail around.

The clone blinks slowly and looks towards the ceiling. "You need not worry. Without prime, they will be as lost as we are."

"If that's the case," Glimmer says, "what's the point of your protocol?"

"Usually prime would be able to resurrect, eventually… but...."

"Hah!" I laugh, resting my hands on my hips. "So She-Ra foiled your plans? What a shame."

"Yes. Prime is gone, and this time for good."

I place my hands on the bed frame, and lean forwards. "Well, since you're all better now, how about we send you back to the flagship so you can stay up there with your *brothers*."

The clone turns away, looking almost despondent. "The flagship is beyond repair. All systems are down, including life support. They have a few hours left at most. "

I grit my teeth, the word *good* on the tip of my tongue. "Tell me one thing," I say, wrinkling my nose. "Were you there?" I curl my lips into a snarl and leap forwards again, almost managing to rake his face before Adora's strong hands pull me backwards.

"Did you watch what he did to me? *Did you?*" I yell, wriggling in Adora's grip, ignoring her pleas.

The clone looks at me, no emotion visible in his eyes. "We were one. We saw all. And… we are sorry that we could not act any differently."

“Sorry won’t fix anything!” I spit, feeling the scar behind my neck burn.

“No, it will not,” the clone says, looking at me, then Adora, then Glimmer. “So. Nobody will help us?” he asks.

The room falls silent, although Adora’s grip on me loosens.

“Very well,” the clone says, shifting his position to one side of the bed. He swings his feet over the edge, and stands up, slowly. “Please send me back, so I may die with my kin.”

“Seriously,” I say rolling my eyes. “Let me go, Adora.”

“But…”

“It’s fine, he’s too pathetic for me to even want to kill him.”

Adora releases me, and I stare into the clone’s eerie gaze. “It isn’t my choice,” I say, pointing to Glimmer, “it’s hers! I don’t even know why you brought me here, unless you have some kind of death wish.”

Glimmer speaks, quietly. “I think we should help them.”

“*What?!*” I ask, spinning on the spot to face her.

“I can’t just let living, sentient beings die if there’s a way to help them.”

“They’re. His. Clones!” I say, spitting the words out. “Stop being a soft touch for once in your life, and make the right call. The hard one.”

“Catra,” Adora says, placing a hand on my shoulder. “They can’t hurt you. I won’t let them.”

“So you agree with her, then?” I ask, feeling suddenly nauseous at the thought of all those glowing green eyes, staring, at me, chanting.

Cast out the shadows…

Cast out the shadows...

“Not entirely,” Adora says, “but I feel like we’d be kind of… murdering them if we didn't do anything.”

All beings must suffer to become pure…

All beings must suffer to become pure...

“Any one one of them could turn out like Prime, or worse!” I yell, raising my voice, threading my fingers into my fringe. “Are you both seriously going to be this *naive?*”

All beings must suffer to become pure.

Just calm down, I think, my heart pounding in my chest, my breathing rapid. *Don’t make a scene. I’m safe now. I’m safe, Adora’s here, we’re back at the Palace.*

“Catra, are you okay?” Adora asks, rubbing her palm down my back.

I take a deep breath, and exhale shakilly. “No, I’m not. I want no part in this.”

“We’re running out of time,” Glimmer says, “I’m sorry, Catra, but we have to do this - with or without you.”

“You don’t need me anyway, Sparkles,” I shrug.

I look towards Adora, noticing how torn she appears. “I’ll catch up with you later, okay?” I say, kissing her on the cheek.

“Sure. Hey,” Adora says, raising a hand, lightly trailing her thumb over my lower lip. “I swear to you... it’ll be okay.”

“You don't know that, Adora,” I sigh, kissing the tip of her thumb. “But I guess we’ll have to wait and see.”

--

I walk down the corridor, taking a few deep breaths to try calm my rapid pulse. *Fucking clones*, I think, feeling my fur stand on end just at the idea of twelve, no, *thirteen* more of them down here, being anywhere near me.

“Ah, Brother!” wrong-Hordak calls from further up the hall, waving his hand.

“*What!?*” I snap.

“Oh no, did I do something wrong?”

“No,” I say, batting my tail around.

Wrong-Hordak winks. “Perhaps it would lift your spirits if you joined me for food?”

I’m about to reject the offer, when I hear a familiar patter of paws from behind. “Melog” I say, bending down and laughing when they jump into my arms. “Where have you been this time?”

“Exploring. I found some tiny pink birds.”

“Did you eat them?” I ask, folding my ears down. “Melog, don’t eat the pretty birds.”

“I did not eat them. But I am hungry.”

“Well, I’m not. But I guess Adora’s gonna need something, so…”

wrong-Hordak grins toothilly, “So you will join me?”

“Sure. Maybe we can come up with a name for you at last.”

--

We all walk down the eastern hall, with wrong-Hordak already knowing the way. Eventually, I notice a strong aroma in the air, and spot a large open archway on the left wall, with people coming out of it carrying boxes; the same kind that Adora brought me earlier.

“We are here!” wrong-Hordak exclaims.

We walk inside and the first thing I notice is how packed the place is, not to mention how noisy. I couldn't pick out a conversation even if I tried. And then, there's the myriad of scents. I lift my nose up, sniffing into the air. There's various kinds of foods, from all the races as far as I can tell. The salty-sweet tang of Salinean noodles. The pungent, earthy smell of plumerian salads. Even the meaty, spicy aroma of the snows stews, almost stinging at my nostrils.

My belly growls, despite my insistence that I wasn't hungry. I look around, spotting that thankfully one or two tables are free, then turn to scan the counter running across the entire northern side of the room.

One of the three people standing behind the counter takes a sudden interest in me, frowning, and pointing towards Melog. "Hey, no pets!"

I look down at Melog and tilt my head, shrugging. They grin smugly, and fade into nothing, turning completely invisible. But I still feel their presence, as always.

The irate man blinks a few times, rubs his eyes, then shrugs and carries on mopping the floor. Once he's done he walks up to the counter, glaring at me suspiciously. "What can I get you?"

"I don't have any money," I say, pouting. "Is anything free?"

"It's all free, so long as you're hungry."

"Really?" I ask, my eyes lighting up. "Then I want to try this, this, this," I say, pointing to the various morsels laid out in the counter. "Oh, definitely those," I say, pointing to the same fish balls Adora brought me.

"I thought you were not hungry?" Melog says from somewhere to my left, and I can almost see their accusatory glare.

"Most of this is for Adora, I'll have you know," I mutter from the corner of my mouth, before lifting my head back up to the server. "Hey, can I get it in boxes? Um, please."

"No problem. You sure must be hungry," he says, frowning.

"It's for my girlfriend," I say, blushing when I realise it's the first time I've called Adora that.

"Then *she* must be hungry."

"You don't know the half of it," I say, taking the two large boxes from him and placing them into a bag. "Thanks."

--

I manage to find a vacant table and a few minutes later, wrong-Hordak joins me.

"What did you get?" I ask, peering at his dish.

He lifts a lid from his bowl, grinning. "It's from the Snows. They call it stew and dumplings! It's my favourite."

I watch wrong-Hordak stuff tiny balls of meat and bread into his mouth for a while, before an idea hits me. "Hey! That's it!"

He tilts his head at me.

“Dumpling. I’m calling you Dumpling.”

He chews a few times, then swallows and smiles widely. “I like it. It is my favourite food, after all!”

“So, Dumpling,” I say, grinning, “why aren’t you helping Entrapta and Hordak with the ship?”

“They sent me to get food. But they can wait a little longer,” he says with a wink, licking his lips then popping the lid off a second bowl.

“Hey. Wanna see something funny?” I ask, smirking.

“Yes! Always!”

“Watch this,” I say, fumbling my hand to my right until I figure out where Melog’s sitting. I nod in their direction. “Open up!”

Melog fades into view very slightly, so that only I can see. I take a small morsel of fish from one of my boxes of food and toss it towards them, and they catch it with ease in their jaw, gulping it down.

“Hah! That is your cat friend, is it not? You can’t trick me,” Dumpling says, winking. “I saw them vanish earlier.”

“Do you have a tick in your eye or something?” I ask, tossing Melog more food while staring over at the guy behind the counter. *Look here*, I think. *Come on, look over here*. He turns around and I grin widely, then slowly, deliberately throw the biggest piece of food yet towards Melog.

It vanishes halfway down Melog’s throat with a satisfying gulp. The poor guy turns pale, drops his mop and runs from the room, shrieking.

“Hahaha! Did you see that?” I ask, leaning over to watch him leave, grabbing the edge of the wooden table. “I think he wet himself!”

“You are a terrible person,” Melog says, phasing back into view, their tail wagging side to side.

“Yeah, I have my moments,” I chuckle. “What about you, Dumpling? Not entertained?”

“Brother,” Dumpling says, looking a little concerned. “I am not sure it is a good idea to agitate those who provide our food.”

“Yeah. I suppose I didn’t think of that,” I say, shrugging and picking up my bag. “Oh well. I’m gonna take these back to the room so Adora can eat later.”

“Why is she not with you?” Dumpling asks.

“We’re not attached at the hip you know,” I say, blowing out a puff of hot air. “She and Sparkles went to save some of your so-called brothers from Prime’s ship.”

“Some of them remain?” Dumpling asks, raising his eyebrows. “But what of the protocol?”

“Long story buddy, come on. I’ll fill you in.”

--

“I see,” Dumpling says, appearing excited. “Then I must go and help!”

“Aren’t you going to feed your friends first?” I ask, pointing to his two bags of boxed up food.

Dumpling appears crestfallen. “Ah, yes.”

“Ugh, fine, pass them here,” I say, adding his bags to my own, and carrying all three in my arms.

Dumpling clasps his hands together and forms a toothy grin. “Thank you, brother. We shall speak again soon?”

“Yeah. Oh, before you go,” I say, tightly clutching all three bags to my chest “Can I ask you something?”

“Anything.”

“When you… lost contact with Prime. What was it like?”

Dumpling’s ears point downward. “It was… terrifying. I thought I would die.”

“Don’t suppose you’ve had any urges to take over the galaxy or anything?”

“I love to cook,” he says, shrugging. “And I like being with my friends, and learning new expressions, like this one!” he says, opening both eyes wide and sticking his tongue out.

“Hah! You’re a weirdo,” I say, laughing. “But I don’t get it. Why aren’t you more like Prime?”

“Ah. You are wondering if any of my brothers will take his place?”

“That’s very insightful, but yes.”

Dumpling pauses, placing a hand to his chin. “I believe we are not the same, despite the fact that we were created from him. Hordak and I are not the same. Prime and I are not the same.”

“But you were… when you were connected.”

“Were we?” Dumpling asks. “You have experienced Prime’s control, no?”

“I… guess,” I say, slumping my shoulders. I had no control, none whatsoever. It felt like I was a puppet, with a tiny voice at the back of my own mind, screaming at myself to fight back. But all I’d ever hear was Prime’s voice, forcing me to move, to talk, at his command. “So it was the same for you?”

“Yes.”

“Oh.”

“Was there anything else, brother?”

“No, go find them. And.. um... tell Adora and Glimmer I say hi.”

“I shall!” Dumpling says, turning to sprint down the west hall.

Not the same, huh? I think, sighing.

--

Thankfully Glimmer had mentioned that Darla was parked down at the Southern courtyard, at the end of the south hall. I walk up the ship's ramp, finding the bridge to be about as chaotic as I'd expected, with scrap metal from the scout ship stacked all over the place. It makes me have serious doubts as to whether we'll ever take off at all.

"Catra! What an unexpected surprise!" Entrapta yells, flipping up her visor. "And you brought food!"

She hurries over and takes the bags from me, opens the boxes, then sighs. "It's so big."

"Can't you just cut it into smaller pieces and pretend it's tiny?" I ask, folding my arms.

"That…" Entrapta says, placing the end of her hair under her chin, "is a brilliant idea!"

I roll my eyes, chuckling, then spot Hordak bent over in the corner, busy with a blowtorch beneath a metal panel. He pauses and turns around, looking at me, then Entrapta, then the food. "Ah, it is about time. I was becoming ravenous."

"Hi Hordak," I say, wincing at how strange it feels that he isn't trying to blast me with a canon or something by now.

"Catra… I appreciate you bringing this. But where is my brother?"

"He's gone to help rescue a few of your *other* brothers."

"Some remained here? But why? What of the protocol?"

"Ugh, you too? Fine, listen up-" I begin.

--

"So we're getting more clones?" Entrapta asks, her eyes wide, glistening in excitement.

"Those are my people, Entrapta," Hordak says, wiping his chin with a napkin, then standing up. "I shall go and help, too."

"Suit yourself. They're probably almost done by now," I say, shrugging. "Oh and by the way, your boy wrong-Hordak has a name now."

Entrapta beams at me. "A name?"

"You'll have to ask him yourself," I say, chuckling.

I hug the remaining bag of food to my chest, jump down the side of Darla's ramp, and head back through the southern entrance of the Palace, figuring I may as well just head to our room and wait for Adora.

--

Hopefully she won't be long, I think, cracking open the door, and walking inside.

There's a large, round bed in the corner, with fancy, swirl-patterned covers, surrounded by a purple mesh curtain, and I immediately think I must have entered the wrong room. "Sorry," I say to nobody in particular, closing the door and then trying to find my bearings in the hall.

Well, the rooms all look kind of the same, *but this must be the right place*, I think, recognising the same scenic paintings that I know are just opposite Adora's room.

I walk inside again, place the food bag onto Adora's dresser, and walk over to the bed, running my palm across the smooth duvet. "What on Etheria..."

"Do you like it?" Glimmer asks, blinking into view to my right.

"*Hey!* Don't just pop out on people like that!" I yell, my fur standing on end.

"At least I knocked earlier today," Glimmer says, appearing smug. "I know what you two were up to, you know."

"Then why did you have to interru- ugh, nevermind," I grumble, pointing to the bed, "Did you seriously just magic this into here?" I ask, twirling my hand.

"Yup."

"Why? Aren't you busy with clones and stuff?"

"Not really. They're all settled, and She-Ra's healing them. Besides, I wanted to do this for you two. Seems you and Adora are getting on *really* well, after all."

I press a palm to my face, shaking my head. "You shouldn't have."

"You don't like it?"

"It's not that, okay? We're just… we haven't…"

"Really?" Glimmer says, appearing perplexed, "Oh no, was that going to be your first time? Did I-"

"Look, princess," I say, placing my hands on my hips, grinning wickedly, "just because you and our boy Bow are banging each other's brains out, doesn't mean the rest of us are so perverted."

"There's nothing perverted about it," Glimmer mutters, blushing. "You don't have to be so mean, I'll just put it back how it was."

"Nah, leave it," I say, shrugging. "A bed's a bed, and it looks comfy anyhow."

"Are you sure?"

I reach my arm out and lightly fist-bump Glimmer's shoulder. "I was just messing with you. It's really nice… So thanks."

"You're welcome. I'm just sorry that I couldn't find more pillows."

"Huh? But there's two," I say, wondering how many people Glimmer thinks I'm sharing a bed with.

"Yes? And it's Adora?"

"Um?"

Gimmer gasps, placing her hands to her chin. "She *loves* pillows, didn't you know?"

“We only got one each in the horde…” I say, furrowing my brows. “But now you mention it, she did always steal mine when I slept on the edge of her bed.”

“When you…” Glimmer blinks, her lips thinning into a line.

“Do *not* tell anyone I told you that,” I say, scowling at the slip up.

“I pinky-promise,” Glimmer says, hooking her little finger with mine, “so long as you promise to tell me more about baby Adora.”

“Hah, like old times huh,” I say, remembering how our chats soon became the highlight of my day, back on Prime’s ship.

“Yes,” Glimmer says, tilting her head. “You know, I never really thanked you…”

“For?”

“Saving me? I mean, I know it was for Adora, but-”

“It was for Adora,” I say, shrugging. “But I guess some small part of it was for you, too.”

“See? You’re not all bad,” Glimmer says, grinning. “Anyway, I’d best go check on our new residents.”

“Wait,” I say, grabbing her arm. “I’m... sorry about before. I should have helped.”

Glimmer places her hand on my shoulder. “We all understand. I can’t even begin to imagine what you went through...”

“Yeah,” I say, folding my ears down. “It wasn’t the best.”

“Look, if any of those clones show a single sign of hurting you,” Glimmer says holding up a finger, “I’ll teleport them over the edge of a cliff before you can say ‘*this clone is evil!*’”

“Hah, thanks Sparkles,” I say, placing my hand over hers, “but I can take care of myself, you know.”

“Oh trust me,” Glimmer says, rolling her eyes, “I know. But it can’t hurt to have friends.”

“Yeah,” I say, waving as she leaves, then looking down at my hand. “Friends.”

--

I sit down on the new bed, bouncing up and down a few times before laying onto my back. “Hey, Melog, check this out,” I say, patting the bed sheets.

“Soft.” They say, prancing around. “Will you be mating tonight?”

“This again?!” I say, shoving my foot into their fur. “I told you, we’re taking it slow. Maybe. Stop looking at me like that!” I say, batting my toes at their nose.

Melog makes a sound that almost sounds like laughter, before hopping off the bed and heading outside the balcony doors.

“Where are you going?”

“For a walk. I shall rest with the purple-haired one tonight.”

“Entrapta? Aren’t you worried she’ll try to dissect you?”

Melog pauses mid-step and turns to look at me. “No, she is very nice to me. She gives me small food.”

“Of course she does. You’ll put on weight, Melog.”

Mating, seriously, I think, chuckling to myself and shaking my head. *I may be open to the idea of touching Adora, but that’s all. That’s not much scarier than kissing her really. It’s just kissing her in different places. And touching her in those places*.

I loosen my tie, feeling a sudden knot in my throat.

I really don’t get what all that sex stuff is about anyway, I think, peering down between my legs, *but I guess it doesn’t hurt to...* I glance around the vacant room and at the closed door, before laying back onto the bed, unfastening my slacks, and sliding my fingers beneath my shorts.

Hmm, no big deal, I think, probing around. *I mean, I guess it’s okay. Oh, wait, that was definitely something*, I think shifting my fingers back to the newly-discovered bump. I frown, applying pressure, then rolling my fingertip. *Okay, that’s really not so bad*, I think, rubbing my finger a little more firmly, feeling somewhat warmer, thinking *hmm, this feels kind of great actually*.

Suddenly, I hear footsteps outside of the bedroom door and quickly yank my hand away, tucking my shirt back in, fastening my button and sitting upright.

--

My heart leaps in my chest when Adora’s face appears in the doorway. “Hey. You’re back.”

“Yeah,” Adora says, smiling and closing the door, “we managed to save all of them.”

“None of them attacked you then?” I ask, looking down at my previously-occupied hand, hoping Adora’s sense of smell isn’t half as good as mine.

“Far from it,” Adora says, sitting on the bed next to me, and bumping my shoulder. “How are you holding up? I know this mustn’t be easy.”

“Honestly? I had a chat with Dumpling about some things and I’m... feeling a bit better.”

“Dumpling?” Adora asks, arching an eyebrow.

“Hah! wrong-Hordak,” I say, beaming proudly. “Finally given a name by yours truly. That boy sure loves his dumplings.”

Adora laughs, shaking her head. “So, you’ve been quite productive while I’ve been gone...”

“Yeah. I got you food, too,” I say, pointing at the boxes atop her dresser. “It might be a bit cold now, though. Sorry.”

“Aww, look at you looking after me,” Adora says, leaping up to grab the boxes then jumping back onto the bed, crossing her legs, and exploring the contents. “Good choices too! You know me so well.”

“What’s to know? You like meat. You like fish. You like vegetables. Basically, you like food.”

“Mmm,” Adora says, busy filling her mouth with a meat-filled pastry, “Yes I do.”

I watch Adora eat for a while, trying not to stare because as usual she’s way too beautiful, even when she’s stuffing her face. I notice that her dress looks a little soiled in small patches now, probably from doing all the heavy lifting today.

“Adora,” I say, feeling guilty.

“*Hmmf*?” She asks, her mouth full.

“I’m sorry I freaked out before,” I say, sighing, and pulling my knees to my chest. “I should’ve come to help.”

“I just wish you’d tell me what’s in your head,” Adora says, tapping her forehead mid-chew. “I worry about you.”

“It was nothing. I’m okay now.”

“Uhuh,” Adora says, rolling her eyes. “You know, Perfuma’s really good at this sort of thing. Why don’t you talk to her?”

“What sort of thing?”

Adora swallows, then takes a sip of water. “Well, talking. Figuring stuff out.”

“Ugh. I’ll think about it,” I say, frowning. “I don’t really *do* talking.”

“No, really!?,” Adora says, smirking. Then she looks down and sighs. “I’m sorry too, by the way.”

“For what?” I ask, tilting my head.

“I shouldn’t have made you visit him.”

“Bah, as if you *made* me.”

“Fine, *encouraged* you.”

“It was probably for the best. They’re alive, right?”

“Yeah. Barely.”

“Barely?” I ask, twitching my ears.

“I had to heal them all,” Adora says, taking a deep breath. “Their life support was almost gone by the time we got to them.”

I listen as Adora tells me more about her adventure. They managed to get the newly-equipped short-range teleporter on Darla working, making life a bit easier. But up on Prime’s ship the air was really thin, so it took a few hops there and back to get everyone out safely. And it sounds like the clones were basically half-dead, until She-Ra intervened.

“Good job you went then, I guess.”

“Yeah,” Adora says, leaning over to peck me on the cheek. “This food is great by the way.”

“Glad you like it but,” I say, wincing at a sudden memory.

“But?” Adora asks, pausing mid-chew.

“I think I might have scared one of the guys that works there.”

“Catra…”

“What?! He was mean to Melog!”

Adora frowns. “Uhuh. So... what did you do?”

“Fed an invisible giant cat in front of him?”

“You didn’t.”

“I did. Adora, his face… it was…” I burst out laughing, unable to help myself.

“Maybe you should still be *‘Catra of the evil horde’*,” Adora says, failing to hide her smirk.

“I keep telling people I’m not that great, not my fault they don't listen,” I say, grinning.

“You should apologise to him.”

“Bah.”

“Catra… these people feed us.”

“Yeah, that’s what Dumpling said.”

Adora picks out a few crumbs from the first box, then opens the second and snaps open a pair of chopsticks. “So that’s seriously what we’re calling him now?” She asks, twirling together some noodles. “And he’s okay with it?”

“He loves it. I’m a great name-picker, I’ll have you know.”

“Riiight. I bet it took you ages to come up with *idiot* and *dummy*.”

“Pfft, those are my extra-special terms of endearment.”

“Sure, sure,” Adora says, wrinkling her nose. “Hey, can I take you out for a meal tomorrow? To my favourite restaurant... Cranky Crab.”

“What sort of a name is that,” I say, snorting.

“You’d be cranky too if people ate you,” Adora says, stuffing a large mixture of noodles and vegetables into her mouth.

“Oh I don’t know,” I say, slowly swaying my tail. “I might quite enjoy it.”

Adora pauses mid-chew and covers her mouth with her hand, almost losing the contents from laughter. “You are such a tease.”

“Oh am I now?”

“Yes, you are. You’d run a mile if I took you up on that offer.”

“Hah, maybe,” I say, smirking.

Adora puts the empty box down and suddenly jumps onto me, pushing me back onto the bed, wiping noodle juice off her lips with the back of her hand. “You’re all talk,” she says, leaning down to kiss my cheek, then my neck, where she blows a loud raspberry against my fur.

“Hah! Stop it!” I yell, trying to push her away but that only seems to spur her on, attacking my neck with soggy kisses until I’m almost crying from laughing. “Hahaha, A-Adora!”

She giggles but finally relents, flopping onto her back next to me, and patting her belly. “You know,” she says, staring up at the bedroom ceiling. “This is a nice bed.”

“Uhuh, And why don’t you seem surprised by it being here?” I ask, raising an eyebrow.

Adora turns to face me, sticking her tongue out. “No reason.”

“You’ve been conspiring with Glimmer, haven’t you?” I ask, and this time I jump on top of her, quickly assaulting her neck with my fingers, lightly touching her ticklish spots with the tips of my nails.

“Catra, haha! *No!*” Adora shrieks, “Okay, okay, I give in!”

“Spill it,” I growl, holding my fingers still for a moment.

“She offered, I said yes, that’s all,” Adora says, looking up at me. She raises her hand and strokes a few strands of my fringe to one side. “Is that okay?”

“Well it’s a lot comfier, so no complaints here,” I say, shifting off of her and bouncing on my butt on the edge of the mattress a few times.

“You know,” Adora says, sitting up, resting her hand over mine, “if you’re not tired, I have one more request for our date…”

“Hmm?” I ask, feeling suddenly warm again.

Adora’s smile spreads into a wicked grin. “I thought it would be fun if we raced up to the spire. For old time’s sake.”

“Pfft,” I laugh, nudging her with my shoulder, “you’d lose.”

“Nope. I know the palace. You don’t.”

“Are you saying you’ve already done it?”

“Maybe.”

“Doesn’t matter either way,” I say, jumping to my feet, lacing my fingers together and stretching my arms out. “You’re on.”

“Okay,” Adora says, standing up, unclipping her cloak and tugging her dress over her head, “give me a minute to get changed?”

“Um,” I say, running my gaze over her bare back, feeling every single one of my hairs bristle. “Sure.”

Chapter End Notes

Mermista: Whatever. He'll always be wrong-Hordak to me.
Catra: Right. So we'd call the others wrong-wrong-Hordak? wrong-wrong-wrong-Hordak?
Entrapta: *Recursive Hordaks!* that's such a great idea!

Rooftops and Regrets

Chapter Summary

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

It's dark outside, and almost silent save for the occasional rustle of wildlife nearby. The stars are glowing brightly in the clear deep-blue sky, and Etheria's moons shine as brightly as always. Framed by one of the moons, the largest of the three, is Brightmoon's main spire; so high up that you can barely see the peak from the palace grounds.

"Ready to lose horribly?," Adora asks, smirking. She lightly tugs at my jacket collar. "I can't believe you're still wearing that."

"I'm going to win in style, princess," I say, loosening my tie.

"If you say so," Adora says, crouches down, appearing smug for some reason. "Ready, steady…"

"Go!" I yell, sprinting ahead of her.

I jump against the first thick stone pillar, gripping my claws into the concrete and leaping vertically, higher and higher, until I land on all fours on the angled rooftop above.*It's been a long time since I did something like this just for fun,* I think. *Just to play, or in this case, just to wipe that smug grin off Adora's face.*

I hop swiftly across the rooftop, loving the feel of the breeze as it whips through my hair and fur. When I reach the next set of pillars I chance a glance backwards, finding that Adora's already quite far behind, and if I wasn't so exhilarated by the climb I'd take a moment to feel sorry for her. There's no way she'd ever be able to beat me at something like this, afterall.

She pauses atop the rooftop and smirks, then I notice a maniacal grin spread on her lips, and moments later she holds her arm out, and a golden glow spreads around her form.

"That's cheating!" I yell, wasting no more time in staring. *So, she wants to make this difficult, does she?* I think, clambering up a smooth, domed rooftop, and almost losing my grip. I hear noisy

footsteps stomping closer and closer, causing adrenaline to surge through me, and I can't help but giggle while I pounce away, barely maintaining the lead as I jump on all fours from one rooftop to the next.

Suddenly, a pair of gold-trimmed boots stomp down loudly in front of me, and I peer up, scowling.

"Hey, Catra," Adora purrs, looking so smug that I'm seriously tempted to push her from the rooftop. Instead, I stand up, curl my tail tightly around her thigh and yank her close.

"Hey, Adora," I purr, standing up on my tiptoes, reaching a hand behind her neck, and lightly trailing my nails across the flesh there. *Sucker*, I think, listening as Adora's breath catches in her throat.

I quickly scale up the next wall, laughing while Adora stands there, stunned.

"That's cheating!" I hear Adora yell eventually, from the distance.

"Says you!" I yell back, grabbing onto a window ledge, then leaping to another, hopping onto a balcony and climbing up to the purple dome above.

We're not far from the peak, where a pair of ornate, golden wings surround the large central spire. I leap to the base of the thin granite tower and quickly clamber up, climbing as quickly as I can, the golden peak soon within reach. A few moments later I reach my hand out, grab the pole and cheer triumphantly.

"I win!" I yell, flicking my tail around.

"Are you sure?" Adora's voice, her breath hot against my ear.

"*WHAT?*"

She suddenly materialises into view, with Melog curled up in the crook of her left arm, and her right arm gripping the spire, just above my fist.

"You little traitor!" I exclaim, pointing a finger into Melog's fluffy belly. "Just you wait."

"She promised me fish."

Adora starts to laugh, and once the adrenaline starts to fade I can't help but burst out laughing too, slowly sliding back down the spire on my butt. The steep slope flattens out and my descent slows, coming to a stop on a flat part of the rooftops, where I lay back and fold my hands behind my head, staring up into the stars.

Melog hopes down right behind me, then nuzzles against my elbow, purring.

"Oh, so now you're being cute?" I ask, stroking their mane.

I peer over the top of Melog, and watch as Adora walks into view with a huge grin on her face. Her form shimmers for a short while then shrinks down in size, and she looks at me, appearing more smug than ever.

"Enjoy yourself?" I mutter, pouting.

She laughs, sits down next to me, then lays on her back and turns her head to face me. "Aww come on, didn't you have fun?"

“Yeah… okay. Fine,” I say, watching the stars twinkle up above, feeling the gentle breeze ripple through my fur. “That was pretty exhilarating,” I say, grinning at her. “Even though you’re a lousy cheat.”

“I thought you’d be proud of me, being sneaky and all,” Adora says, reaching her hand to mine. I take hold of it, and squeeze her fingers.

“I am. I just can’t believe can’t believe Melog agreed to it,” I say, glaring at the cat in question.

“But… fish,” they say, looking sorrowful.

“I’ll forgive you if it’s Adora,” I say, ruffling their mane again, “but don’t you ever do this for anyone else.”

Adora giggles, and the sound of it warms my heart. Her beautiful blue eyes meet mine and I can’t help but feel drawn in. I gently unlace our fingers, prise her hand open and start to trail idle patterns against her palm with my fingertip, wondering what to say. *Hey Adora, want to continue where we left off?* Or *hey Adora, let’s go get busy-*

“Oh, you are finally going to mate?”

“Seriously?” I ask, twitching my right ear. “Get out of my head, Melog.”

Melog makes a sound that’s passable for a laugh. *He’s messing with me*, I think. *The little shit*.

“I shall return to Entrapta’s abode. Good night, Catra.”

“Night, Melog,” I say, waving. “And don’t eat any cute little birds!”

Adora flips onto her side, her eyes sparkling with amusement. “It’s so much fun watching you two talk but only hearing half the conversation.”

“Oh, why’s that?” I ask, sitting up and crossing my legs, peering down at her.

“I kind of make stuff up,” she says wrinkling her nose. “Like just now, judging by your reaction they probably said something embarrassing about how you want to bang-”

“Did you just use the word *bang* unironically?” I ask, flattening my ears in disapproval. “Adora, this relationship won’t last with that kind of behaviour.”

“So, I’m close then? Is that what they said.”

“Melog doesn’t say *bang*, Adora. Melog has more class.”

Adora bursts into laughter and sits up, raising an eyebrow, “Fine, but how is *mating* any better?”

“Wait, you can understand them?” I ask, feeling my fur stand on end.

“No, silly. But you told me all about the mating thing the other day, and I filled in the blanks. I’m kind of working you two out.”

“Yes, they’re a pervert,” I say, scowling.

“And you’re completely innocent? I know you two are connected, Catra,” Adora says, biting her lip into a smile. “Maybe there’s a reason they keep talking about this stuff. Just what’s in that head of

yours, hmm?"

I open my mouth, trying to find some kind of witty retort, but the words die in my throat the second Adora places her palm just below my cheek, cupping my jaw. I'd be embarrassed at how quickly she can make me purr, but her touch feels so good that I'm really past caring.

"So, shall we do the mating?" Adora asks, mischief plainly showing in her eyes.

"You're as bad as they are!" I say, laughing loudly. I place my hand over hers and nudge into her hand a little more, purring louder still. "You're such a dummy."

"I think we need to work on your pet-names," Adora says, pretending to pout, and pulling her hand away.

"But-" I say, reaching my hand to hers, feeling an immediate sense of loss.

"Come here," Adora says. She crosses her legs and pats her thigh, and I smile from ear to ear, remembering how we always used to sit like this back at the barracks, late at night. I yawn and stretch my arms out, then twist around and lean back, resting my head on Adora's lap.

Adora peers down at me, quietly stroking both of my cheeks with her thumbs. My purrs grow so loud that I'm almost worried I'll wake some people up.

"Are you trying to seduce me, Adora?" I ask, nudging against her fingers.

"Nope. We're going to stay here until you come up with a nice name for me."

"I'm no good at all that sappy stuff. Besides, you don't have one for me either."

"Hmm," Adora says, looking down at me. "Pretty sure I gave you one."

"Stinky doesn't count."

"Okay, fine. Then…"

I watch Adora's face, peering into my eyes while she's deep in thought. Then I look just behind her head, scanning my gaze across the vast reaches of the night sky where I'm as amazed as always by the sight of hundreds, maybe thousands of tiny lights, flickering away up there. Adora twists her fingers at the tufts of fur below my ears, and suddenly smiles brightly.

"I've got it," she says.

"Oh?"

"You're my stargazer."

"Hmm." I say, blinking, "I think I like it. But, why?"

"Watching the stars reflect in your eyes like this," Adora says, speaking softly, "I think it's the most beautiful thing I've ever seen..."

I feel my cheeks burn hotly, and I'm about to insult her like always but something holds me back this time. Maybe it's the way she's looking at me, her eyes soft, full of nothing but love. "Okay… well," I say, purring loudly while reaching a hand up, stroking her cheek, "I don't think I can beat that."

Adora chuckles, then shakes her head, “It wasn’t meant to be a competition, not this time at least.”

“Well, give me time. I’ll come up with something, although it has to be *sweet*, apparently.”

“How about for now,” Adora says, leaning over, her hair tickling my face, “You just call me yours.”

I grin up at her, “what’s gotten into you tonight? You’re being such a sap.”

“Don’t pretend you don’t like it,” Adora says, sitting up and resting her hands in mine. “I know you better.”

I hold her palms against my chest, and close my eyes, enjoying the warmth of her touch. “Hey, Adora…”

“Hmm?”

“Should we go back to the room?” I ask, opening my eyes, feeling my pulse quicken.

“Sounds good. I’m looking forward to trying out the new bed.”

“Hah, I bet you are,” I say, wrinkling my nose.

“I didn’t mean it like that!” Adora says, laughing, then scratching her hand behind her neck awkwardly. “Um, unless you did, I mean.”

“Well,” I say, jumping to my feet, holding out my hand. “I was a bit pissed when Glimmer stopped us before…”

Adora takes my hand and stands up. “Really?”

“Yeah… it was… nice.”

“Nice?” Adora asks, raising an eyebrow. “Catra, you are such a charmer.”

“Shut up, idiot,” I say, playfully nudging her shoulder. “And don’t push it, okay.”

“Duly noted,” Adora says, suddenly putting on a snooty voice. “Well then, shall we?” She asks, gesturing over the edge of the roof with her palm. “After you, ma’am.”

“Hah, this again?” I ask, grinning widely. “No, not at all. After you!”

--

We land just by the south entrance to the palace, with Darla’s plated hull gleaming under the moonlight. I prick my ears up, listening for anything of interest, but it seems like the whole place is dead.

“After you?” Adora says, gesturing to the southern entrance.

I shake my head, laughing, and swoop forwards, placing my hands upon her cheeks and kissing her. “Why are you like this?”

“Because I love you?”

“Oh,” I say, kissing her lower lip, stroking my thumbs against her cheek. “Good reason.”

Adora's arms snake around my waist and I carry on gently kissing her, while she walks backwards up the short set of stairs and into the palace proper. I turn to bump her against the nearest wall and trap her there in a slow, sensual kiss,

"Catra…" Adora breathes my name against my lips, and it makes me feel like I'll float away, somehow.

"Come on," I say, taking her hand, and striding purposefully up the hallway.

I look across to find Adora staring back at me with a bashful smile, and I just can't help myself. I lunge forwards again, pressing her to the wall, kissing her while we slide across the surface, bumping paintings on the way, until suddenly Adora falls backwards, and I land clumsily on top of her.

"Haha," I laugh, blushing, "Woops. Where are we?"

"On the floor of the library," Adora says, blowing her fringe from her flustered face. "We won't make it to the room if you don't stop this."

"Can't help it," I say, leaning down and capturing her lips with mine again, and again.

"Catra," Adora says, placing her hands on my jaw, holding me back. "We are not doing this in the library. Come on."

"Pfft, you're no fun," I say, standing up and straightening my jacket. "It's not like there's anyone here."

I help Adora to her feet, feeling so lucky to have her here, so lucky to have her look at me this way, and so lucky that I'll soon be exploring her in all the ways I've always dreamed about. Then I notice something behind her, brightly illuminated on the back wall of the library.

"Hey, what's that?" I ask, slowly walking towards the painting. When I get closer I realise it isn't a painting at all, but a mosaic, lots of tiny tiles laid out in almost-impossible detail, with what looks to be an angel as the main feature, pink wings spread wide, and the moonstone depicted behind her head, held aloft in the sky. Her eyes appear closed, and long hair cascades around her shoulders.

"Isn't that the old Queen?" I ask, trailing my fingertips across the grooves between the finely detailed tiles.

"Queen Angella," Adora says, placing a hand on my back.

"What happened to her, anyway?" I ask, looking over my shoulder at Adora. But she looks away, frowning, and I hear her heart start to beat faster. "Adora? What's wrong?" I ask.

"Nothing. We should just head back."

"Hey!" I say, tugging at her arm, "What is it?"

"I said it's nothing…"

"Why can't you just *tell* me?"

Adora sighs, and shakes her head. "I will, but do we have to talk about it right now? I'm getting kind of tired."

“You’re being weird, and I need to know why. Right *now*.” I say, folding my arms and angling my ears back.

“She…” Adora places both her hands on my shoulders, appearing conflicted. “She sacrificed herself, so that we could close the portal.”

“Portal?” I ask, feeling almost bowled over by a sudden wave of nausea. “Oh. *That* portal.”

The portal I created, activating it even knowing full well it could kill us all - and it almost did, too. Adora squeezes her fingers against my shoulders, but I turn rigid at the touch. “Catra…”

“What happened?” I ask, my voice a whisper, my ears folded.

“I tried my best to fix it, but one of us had to stay behind. It was supposed to be me, but... ”

“So not only did I kill Glimmer’s Mother, but it could have just as easily been you?” I ask, batting Adora’s hands away. “I don’t get it!”

“Catra-”

“*No!* None of this makes sense. She’s seriously letting me live here, and playing all nice, when… I… her own *mother!?* No, I can’t do this. I *can’t*.”

My heart feels as though it will pound out of my chest, it’s beating too quickly, and I need air, right now. I need space. So I turn around, and I run out of the library, skid around the corner and sprint towards the southern exit on all fours.

I ruin everything I touch.

I run, and I keep running, even though I can hear Adora chasing just behind, calling my name. I run, tears stinging at my cheeks. I swear I’ve never run so fast.

I hurt everyone I love.

“What is the matter?” Melog asks, pouncing to my side and sprinting alongside me.

I deserve to be alone.

“Long story,” I sob, hopping onto their back, “can we please just get out of here, Melog? Please!”

“Of course,” Melog says, their coat shimmering, magical energy coating us both until we turn invisible.

I take one long, lingering look behind me, watching Adora run after me, reaching a hand out. She appears so hurt that it breaks my heart into a thousand tiny pieces.

Better to be hurt than dead, I think, knowing this is for her own good.

--

We run, faster and faster, and the whole time I’m gripping onto Melog’s fur as tightly as I can, my heart pounding in my chest.

I killed her.

I actually killed Angella!

We run, and I don't know how long for, until the undergrowth starts to thicken, forcing Melog to slow their pace.

I hop off of their back. "Come on," I say, jumping onto a branch above, climbing higher up the thick bark, then leaping to the next tree.

"Catra," Melog says, keeping pace with me as we dash through the thick foliage. "We have already run very far."

"Not far enough," I say, panting, pouncing from branch to branch. "Not even close."

--

Eventually my whole body starts to tire, and I'm forced to slow down. My calves are numb. My legs and feet are sore, bruised and scratched. It isn't long until I'm forced to slow to a stop, gasping for air.

"Melog?" I ask, panting, worrying that I must have lost them.

"I am here," They say, leaping onto a branch next to me.

"How long were we running?" I ask, still struggling to breathe, noticing the night sky isn't so dark anymore.

"Several hours."

"Oh," I say, feeling weak from a sudden loss of adrenaline. I clamber slowly up the tree, ignoring how much my legs protest at the exertion, until I find a good vantage point. There I find a couple of thicker branches to support my weight, and lean my back against the thick trunk, swallowing in huge gulps of air until my lungs stop screaming.

Melog hops onto an adjacent branch, whining. "You are hurt."

"I'm fine," I say, closing my eyes and taking a few deep breaths, feeling a cool breeze dance around my sweat-drenched fur. "We should be safe here."

The invisibility shroud fades away, and Melog's eyes bore into mine. "You are bleeding."

"I said I'm fine!" I snap, looking at my grazed hands and feet. "It's just a few scratches, Melog. Stop being a baby."

Melog crawls closer, and manages to nuzzle against my hand without either of us losing balance. They sit there in silence, and eventually, I relent, placing my hand against their mane and enjoying the warmth, radiating through their fur.

"You should rest," They say.

"We are resting."

"Here? What if we fall?"

"I've done this before," I say, gently patting them. "We won't fall."

Melog twitches their ear, looking first at me, then at the ground far, far below.

“Didn’t take you for a scaredy-cat,” I say, chuckling.

Melog pushes further into me, and I adjust my position so that we’re both rooted properly against the tree. *Not the comfiest bed in the world*, I think, *but I’ve had worse*.

I close my eyes, thinking I’ll never find sleep because I’m too highly strung. But then Melog starts to purr softly, almost like they’re snoring, and it brings a special kind of peace. The knot deep within my chest unravels just a little, and the tears streaming down my cheeks slow to a trickle.

--

The next morning, I crack open my eyes slowly, and wipe away the gunk from crying all night. My heart feels heavier than ever, but lightens a little when I notice Melog curled half-against me, their jaw resting on my abdomen, snoring lightly. Part of their belly hangs down in a gap between branches, and I watch the bump rise and fall with each breath they take.

“You are awake?” Melog says, lifting their head.

“How did you know?”

“Your pulse quickened.”

“Hah, good ears, buddy,” I say, scratching into their mane. I stretch my arms and peer upwards into the canopy, guessing it’s almost midday.

Melog tilts their head to one side, but says nothing.

“Don’t look at me like that.”

They sit up and butt their head into my cheek. “I worry, that is all.”

“I’m fine.”

“You are not.”

“Ugh. Look, I just had a long-overdue reality check, that’s all.” I say.

Melog rests their head on my lap again, and I choke back a loud sob.

“I can feel your pain, Catra,” Melog says, their fur turning a darker shade of purple. “Is there nothing I can do?”

I sigh, idly swirling a finger around the blue aura of Melog’s mane. “Don’t suppose you can turn back time?”

“I cannot.”

“Melog, I-” I say, gritting my teeth. “I... killed someone. Someone important to one of my friends.”

“I see.”

“The thing is, I had no idea until yesterday.”

Melog exhales with a loud snort. “How is it you could kill someone, and not know?”

“I didn’t do it on purpose or anything. It was just,” I say, frowning, “it was caused by something I did. Something really, really idiotic.”

“So you feel responsible?”

“It’s my fault, no question about it,” I say, feeling the lump in my throat grow in size. “But the weirdest thing is, nobody told me,” I say, lowering my voice to a whisper. “Why would they keep it from me?”

“Perhaps they knew you would react this way?”

I choke out a single laugh, and wipe away more tears. “You’re a smart ass Melog, you know that?”

Melog falls silent, probably contemplating if they want to hang around with me anymore.

“I would never leave you.”

“Hey, stop reading my mind.”

“I do not read your mind. I feel your heart.”

“Hah, lucky you,” I say, shaking my head. I clamber to my feet, gently guiding Melog from my lap, wondering what to do next. *The Fright Zone is probably abandoned now*, I think. *How we’ll get all the way there I have no idea. Maybe I can steal transport from one of the abandoned horde bases nearby.*

“Wait here,” I say, climbing a little higher into the tree, eventually finding a way to push through the thick foliage above.

I lift my hand to block out the sun and scan the horizon all around. A thick, lush canopy spreads in every direction, like a carpet of orange and green. The sky is clear, with sunlight warm against my fur. In the distance, Brightmoon, about a day’s walk from here. I can barely see the spire, and knowing I was standing right there with Adora just yesterday makes my heart sink.

“I miss her,” Melog says.

“Hah, how did you get up here?” I ask, nudging my shoulder into them.

Melog huffs, as though offended. “I am able to traverse any terrain.”

“Anyway,” I say, taking one last look at the palace, managing to hold back tears, somehow. “Let’s get a move on,” I say, hopping down one branch at a time.

My descent is clumsy, probably because I’m so damn bruised and sore. In comparison, Melog jumps down with such grace that they may as well be weightless. They look at me, then tilt their head sharply in the direction of their back.

“You’re a lifesaver,” I say, hopping on.

“Where to?”

“Let’s head west. There’s a horde camp nearby.”

Melog sets off at a steady pace, careful to avoid thick roots winding up from the earth. “What do you hope to find there?”

“I don’t know. Supplies? Maybe transport, if we’re lucky.”

“So you really intend to run as far as possible?”

“I’m not running, I’m... relocating. I’m doing this for their own good.”

“But they love you.”

“I-” I begin, my words trapped by a sudden lump in my throat. Fresh tears spring to my cheeks. “Can we please just keep going?”

“Of course,” Melogs says, their fur turning translucent, and mine along with it.

--

We travel for roughly two hours until the trees finally start to thin out, where we quicken our pace somewhat.

“Should be just a bit further ahead,” I say.

“Yes, I see it,” Melog says, adjusting their pace to a sprint, until we’re almost at the gate.

“Wait!” I hiss, noticing activity just past the base entrance. “Someone’s here. Damn it!”

“Then these bases are not abandoned?” Melog asks.

“Guess not. Let’s check it out,” I whisper.

I jump from Melog’s back and we prowl through the open doors side by side, careful not to make a sound.

--

I spot three forms gathered around a horde skiff, near the center of the courtyard. *Wait, is that...* I squint my eyes, trying to see. *Fuck!* I think, realising it’s definitely them; Lonnie, Kyle and Rogelio.

“What are they doing here,” I mutter under my breath.

I tap Melog’s back and tilt my head towards the building at the north side of the base, which we carefully, quietly move towards. We arrive at the bunker, and I slowly prise open the door with a quiet creak, wincing. *They shouldn’t hear me from over there, anyway*, I think, opening the door fully, and walking inside.

“Okay. Should be safe,” I say, and moments later, we’re both visible again. “Can you watch the door?”

Melog nods, then silently trots to the exit, peering through the gap.

I head to the changing room and count four lockers across, not that there’s any need since mine is marked with three clearly defined scratches. I punch it once, and it opens with a quiet *thunk*.

After a short rummage around I find one of the spare uniforms I'd kept here. So I quickly get changed, leaving what's left of my shredded suit on the floor. I thread my legs into the purple leggings, and pull the red vest over my head.

I look down at the horde badge on the collar, hiss in disgust and unpin it, throwing it onto the floor. Then I pick up the last piece, the red mask, and turn it around a few times, studying it. *So many painful memories*, I think. *And yet wearing it always gave me a sense of comfort; made me feel like I was in control*.

I head into the washroom, and look at myself in one of the small mirrors above each sink, then slowly lift the helmet and push my face into it, until it brushes my fringe back.

I stare at my reflection, gasping as I suddenly remember everything I did back when I wore this damn thing. Three memories flash through my head, with dizzying speed.

In the first, I stun Entrapta and ship her off to Beast Island like she's nothing more than garbage.

The second, I physically threaten Scorpia, clawing deep grooves into the wall just beside her face. And I watch her expression, for the first time ever, shift to one of disappointment.

And lastly, I'm gouging my claws down Adora's… no, She-Ra's back, watching her cry out in pain. But I'm so gone, so far gone, that I actually laugh.

And I seriously pretended that I didn't care. Every single time.

I watch my eyes widen, and I take slow, shaking breaths, gripping my hands against the sink, knuckles turning white as I remember everything else.

The battles at Salineas and Brightmoon, with so many injured or killed. *And for what?* I think. *What was I ever actually trying to achieve?*

Then I remember the portal… that *fucking* portal, and how I pulled that lever feeling so desperate to end everything. And all just because I couldn't have the one thing I wanted.

And look what it cost, I think, hearing the porcelain crack beneath my grip as I remember Glimmer, so proud about getting us that new bed, and all those times she smiled at me, joked with me, actually *hugged* me.

And this whole time her mother was dead, because of me.

The sink cracks in half, and I raise my right hand, balled tightly into a fist, yell loudly and punch the mirror with all of my strength.

"I'm a fucking monster," I whisper, kneading my knuckles into the shattered fragments of glass.

I grab hold of my wrist, looking at my lacerated hand, then fall to my knees, ripping the helmet from my face and hurling it across the room, clutching at my chest, gasping for air. It hurts. *It hurts so much*, I think, my lungs feeling as though they'll cave in.

I flex out the fingers of my wounded hand, not even caring how much it hurts, unsheathe my claws, and stab them viciously into my thigh, gouging and pulling upwards, enjoying the searing burn, especially enjoying how my scream manages to loosen the thick knot in my throat.

"*Stop!*"

Melog bowls me over, knocking the breath from my lungs, until I'm held captive beneath their belly, unable to move my arms or legs.

"Let me go," I whisper.

"No."

"Melog. Let me go."

They whine, and lower their form more firmly onto me, grounding me beneath their weight. "No."

"You're an idiot," I say, sighing, resigning myself to my warm, fluffy captivity.

"You are the idiot."

"Hah, when did you get so sassy?" I say, sniffling. Melog licks my face a few times, until the tears flow more freely, and then suddenly... I can't seem to stop them.

"Melog, I-"

"I know."

I feel my thigh burning from the fresh wound, and my hand, pulsing from around a dozen cuts or more. "I don't know what to do."

"It will be okay."

"How…?"

Suddenly, the locker room door bursts open and I tilt my head back, grimacing.

"Just what the hell is going on here!?" Lonnie asks, with Kyle and Rogelio charging in right behind her. "Is he attacking you? Catra?"

"No!" I yell, managing to free my wounded hand, waving it in her direction. "Leave them alone. It's fine."

--

Lonnie and the others help me into the medical room, where I sit on one of the wooden benches inside, running my hand across the polished wooden slats. Melog hops up next to me, whining quietly, and I pat my hand against their haunches reassuringly.

"Relax. It's okay," I say, ruffling their fur.

"So, they're connected to you somehow?" Lonnie asks, sitting beside me and unfastening a medical supply box. She pulls out a roll of bandages and tape.

"Yeah. Long story," I say, sighing.

"Here, let me see," she says, taking my hand in hers and then grimacing.

"Oh, yikes," Kyle says, turning pale, while Rogelio places his hand on Kyle's shoulder, and growls a few times.

“Why…” I whisper, feeling barely able to speak, “why are you helping me?”

Lonnie starts to pick out tiny shards of glass from my hand, one after the other. “You mean after you treated us like shit?”

“Yeah,” I say, sighing. “Something like that.”

“We still grew up together,” Kyle says, placing his arm around Rogelio’s waist. “You just… went kind of dark for a while. We were worried.”

“Wait, are you two-” I begin, looking between Kyle and Rogelio, and only then noticing the baby harness strapped to Rogelio, with a small sleeping infant inside of it. “Did you steal a baby!?”

“His parents died, now they’re his Daddies,” Lonnie explains, frowning. “This one will hurt. You ready?”

I look down, seeing her fingers hover over a large silver shard that’s pierced all the way through. “Yeah. Ready.”

She rips it out and I snarl in pain, but manage to keep my hand held in place. Then she wipes an antiseptic pad around the wounds, and unrolls a bandage, wrapping it tightly around my palm several times before sealing it with tape. “Hopefully I didn’t miss anything,” she says.

“Thanks,” I mutter, holding my hand up, examining the clean bandages around the front and back.

“So. Are you gonna tell us why you’ve started punching mirrors again?” Lonnie asks. “Or let me guess, it’s none of our business.”

I chuckle, shaking my head. *Yeah, that’s right*, I think. This isn’t the first time. How many times did Shadow Weaver get into my head? How many times have I hurt myself like this? I guess somewhere along the way I lost count.

“Catra?”

“Hmm?”

“What’s going on with you?”

“With me?” I mumble. “Nothing. Why aren’t you guys in Brightmoon?”

“In Brightmoon? Why the hell would we- Wait, what happened to your leg?!” Lonnie exclaims, pointing down.

“Oh yeah, forgot about that,” I say, shrugging. I look down, noticing my right thigh is drenched, with four deep gashes soaked in a crimson stain. *Guess I must have cut deep*, I think, my vision blurring.

--

“You went too far this time,” Lonnie says, tying up the final bandage, then smoothing it down gently with her palm. “Fourteen stitches, Catra. Seriously? You’re lucky I’m trained in all this.”

“Yeah. Lucky me,” I say, holding up my wounded hand, looking at the congealed blood beneath my claws.

Rogelio suddenly exhales a few short grunts, followed by a long growl.

“He says you need to snap out of it,” Kyle says, shrugging. “He’s right. This isn’t like you.”

“Wait. You understand what he’s saying?” I ask, raising an eyebrow.

“Most of it, yeah,” Kyle says, blushing and rubbing his hand behind his neck.

Rogelio chokes out a few more growls and reveals what looks like a smile, before blushing and pecking Kyle on the cheek.

“Hah. I love you too,” Kyle says, wrapping an arm around Rogelio’s thick waist.

Lonnie rolls her eyes. “They’ve been like this ever since that crazy mission you sent us on.The one that almost killed us.”

“I-” I begin, folding my ears down. “I… should’ve listened to you guys. Sorry.”

All three of them pause and look at me, turning wide-eyed.

“Catra, did you just,” Lonnie says, frowning. “Was that an apology? From *you*?”

“Ugh, blame it on them,” I say, waving my hand back in the direction of Brightmoon. “They’ve turned me soft.”

“Yeah, we heard you’d switched sides,” Kyle says, carefully taking the baby from Rogelio’s harness, sitting on an adjacent bench, and placing them on his knee. “Not that there’s really any sides anymore.”

“Why don’t you go there?” I ask, tilting my head in the direction of the palace.

“Okay, that’s twice you’ve said that,” Lonnie says, frowning. “Do you want us to get captured?”

“You didn’t hear?”

“Hear what?”

“Glimmer and Micah have given everyone a clean slate. They even have Hordak back there, walking around freely.”

“Hordak?!” Kyle and Lonnie exclaim, with Rogelio grunting what I assume is his equivalent of some kind of curse word.

I blow out a puff of air. “Long story. I need to eat - are there any rations left here?”

“Yeah, we just grabbed the last of them,” Kyle says, tossing me a few bars from his satchel.

--

“So you’re serious?” Kyle asks, holding a bottle up while the baby gently suckles on the teat. “We can just walk in there, no questions asked?”

“Yeah. Pretty much,” I say, shrugging.

“So that brings us to the obvious question,” Lonnie says, pointing towards me. “Why are you here, and not there?”

I place an arm around Melog, and hold them closer to me. “Does it matter?”

“Let me guess,” Lonnie says. “You hurt someone - *again*. And now you’re on the run?”

“Actually yeah that’s pretty much it,” I say, grinning, ignoring the pain biting in my chest. “But you guys will be fine there. Seriously, they even have free food. It’s nuts.”

Rogelio’s ears prick up and he launches into a barrage of excitable growls.

“Yeah babe,” Kyle says, leaning up and kissing his chin. “Free food. I like that idea too.”

I tilt my head. “Hmm. You two actually make a cute couple. Who knew.”

“It’s weird but you kind of brought us together,” Kyle says, beaming at me. Then the little babe gurgles and throws up a stream of yellow fluid, half of it dripping down his knee. “Oops, gotta deal with this.”

“Ugh, babies are so gross,” I say, wincing.

Lonnie snorts. “You know you were a baby once, right?”

“No idea,” I say, shrugging. “Can’t remember much from before the horde.”

“That’s kind of sad.”

“Whatever,” I say, taking a deep breath. “So, are you going?”

“Yeah,” Kyle says. ”It’s not far so… we could leave the skiff, if you want?”

“You’d do that for me?” I ask, frowning. “Why?”

“Because unlike you,” Lonnie says, packing up her stuff. “We’re not heartless.”

“Hah, touche,” I say, shaking my head. “Well, I owe you one.”

“I’ll take you up on that offer if we ever see you again. Which to be honest, I kind of hope we don’t.”

I hug my knees to my chest, and shake my tail. “That’s fair.”

Melog whines, and prods their snout into my left thigh. We wave our goodbyes and I watch them leave the building, feeling a strange sense of loss once they’re gone.

--

“They were kind to you,” Melog says.

“Yeah, they were,” I say, limping out of the barracks. “And I really don’t know why.”

Melog whines. “You are hurt.”

“This again? I’ll live. It’s a scratch.”

“And the next time?”

“It’s fine. You’ll stop me,” I say, marching towards the skiff, and then clumsily climbing aboard.

“Catra, you are not well.”

“I’ll heal.”

“That is not what I meant.”

“Ugh, whatever. We’re going to get some quality rest and relaxation time soon, don’t you worry.”

Melog groans loudly, then jumps onto the skiff. “Will nothing I say change your mind?”

“No. You go back, if that’s what you want,” I say, wincing in pain as I unfold the sail.

“As I already made clear,” Melog says, sitting upright. “I will not leave you.”

“That’s your call.”

--

I shift the skiff’s gears, gradually accelerating until we’re almost in the open plains. Faster and faster we glide, until the breeze blows through my hair, the sheer force of it distracting me at least a little from the pressing lump in my throat, and the weight inside my chest.

But then, the skiff suddenly jerks violently and flips almost ninety degrees vertically, sending Melog and I careening backwards into the soft dirt.

I cough a few times, dazed, and look up to find rough, scarred purple skin, white hair, and a wide, toothy grin.

“You leave a trail bigger than a horde of wild bears, kitty cat.”

Chapter End Notes

Perfuma: Yay! Thank goodness!
Scorpia: Oh! I remember this part! Phew!
Catra: You guys are enjoying this wayyy too much.

Hurt but Healing

Chapter Summary

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"*Huntara?!*" I exclaim, trying to leap away. My right leg buckles at the exertion, and I land in a heap, grabbing my thigh and wincing in pain.

"Wow," Huntara says, tipping her head towards my leg. "Someone sure did a number on you."

I prick my ears back and hiss. "What do you want?"

"I'm not the one who wants anything," Huntara says. She bends down, grabs my wrists and quickly ties them together. "This is for my own protection. Nothing personal."

"You're lucky I'm hurt," I say, stretching my fingers, unsheathing the claws on my left hand. My right hand doesn't respond at all, and my fingers throb with the effort.

"Yeah," Huntara says, rolling her eyes. "Lucky me."

Suddenly, Melog roars and pounces towards her.

Huntara grunts, lifts an arm and shoots some kind of projectile which spreads into a large net, halting them mid-pounce. "Nice try."

Melog growls, and begins to glow an angry shade of red.

"You should ask them to calm down, otherwise they'll hurt themselves."

"It doesn't work like that," I seethe, trying to yank my bound hands apart, but soon stopping when the pain in my wounded hand flares up.

"So. How are we gonna do this? Want me to carry you?"

I stand to my feet, wobbling a few times on the way up. “Absolutely not.”

Melog growls louder, thrashing around erratically while Huntara grabs one end of the net. “I said make them calm down. Otherwise I’ll have to get my tranquiliser gun.”

“Fine,” I say, taking deep breaths, convincing myself this will all somehow be okay. *If she wanted to hurt us, she already would have*, I think. Melog’s colour gradually shifts to a more neutral purple, and I breathe a sigh of relief.

“Good. Follow me,” Huntara says, heading towards a large boulder, dragging Melog’s net with her.

“Wait,” I say, limping behind. “Can’t you release them?” I ask, tipping my head towards the net. “Please?”

“I’d rather not get mauled, if it’s all the same to you.”

“They’ll play nicely if I ask.”

“And I should trust you?” Huntara laughs, dragging the net further.

“I am unhurt, worry not,” Melog says, visibly relaxing within the net. “You should try to discover her intentions.”

I nod towards Melog, and limp alongside Huntara for a while, before clearing my throat. “So, are you going to tell me what this is about?”

Huntara glances at me, rolling her eyes. Then she lifts a communications tablet up. “Yeah. Yeah. She’s here. Right. Gotcha.”

“What the hell is going on?” I ask, holding my wrists up, “And is this really necessary?”

“The Queen wants a word with you,” Huntara says, crouching down to face me. “And yes, it is. I know what those claws can do.”

I scowl, lowering my arms.

Huntara folds her thick forearms and glares at me. “Just a little further, and we’ll be on our way to the rendezvous,” she says. “Then I’ll be gone, don’t you worry.”

I scan up and down her huge form, sizing her up. *Sure, she’s stronger*, I think. *But faster? Smarter? I doubt it*. I look down at my hands, thinking that with a few bites I should be free. But then again with my injuries, I might not get far.

“I know what you’re thinking,” Huntara says, peering at me from the corner of her eye. She pauses, and crouches down again to stare into my eyes, holding a finger up. “One little talk, that’s all Glimmer wants. And then you’re free to go. So shall we just get it over with?”

“I could escape if I wanted to,” I say, scowling, kicking a small pebble away.

“Oh, I know,” Huntara says, laughing. “And then I’d have to catch you all over again, and we’d just keep at it, over and over. Doesn’t that sound like *fun?*”

“Not particularly,” I say, following her around the boulder until her skiff comes into view. “Okay, look,” I say, feeling agitated, “We’ll come with you, willingly. Just unbind us already.”

Huntara looks between Melog and I, before shrugging, and crouching down to the net, carefully releasing Melog. “Remember what I said, fluffball. If you run, I’ll only come for you again.”

Melog walks out of the net unscathed, shakes their fur, and then softly butts their head against my calf. “We should play along.”

“Yeah, I know buddy,” I say, sighing. Huntara holds her hand out and I raise my arms, allowing her to cut away the binds. I rub my wrists a few times, then climb aboard her skiff, with Melog following just behind.

“Well, we’re off,” Huntara says, unfolding the sails. “You two behave, now.”

--

“So where are we going again?” I ask, watching the ground blur by as we speed further north.

“Hell if I know,” Huntara says, holding up a scouting glass. “I just got the coordinates. We’re not far.”

“That’s incredibly useful,” I say, folding my arms, then quickly unfolding them and grabbing the central mast when the skiff starts to wobble. “Whoa!”

Huntara folds away her scope, turning to look at me. “You’d better be careful with your leg in that state,” she says, peering down at my thigh. She clears her throat. “You gonna tell me what happened?”

“No.”

“Pfft, suit yourself.”

--

The land flattens out the further north we travel, until there’s nothing but sand and gravel all around, save for the occasional stretch of green. *Guess Adora’s crazy magic didn’t reach everywhere*, I think.

“Ugh, how much longer?” I ask, wincing when we go over another bump.

“We’re here,” Huntara says, slowing the skiff to a standstill. “This is where we part ways, kitty cat.”

“Right. Bye,” I huff, jumping off the skiff, then groaning in pain as soon as I land.

“Yeah. Bye,” Huntara says, sighing. “And get that looked at, okay?” she says, nudging a thumb towards my leg.

I fold my arms. “Whatever.”

Melog and I watch as Huntara glides into the distance on her skiff.

“Ugh, why here?” I ask, shuffling my toes into the dirt. There’s nothing here other than a flat boulder webbed with moss, and a tiny algae-coated pond.

“Because,” Glimmer says, blinking into view next to me, her arms folded, “There’s nowhere for you to run.”

I prick my ears upwards, glancing in all four directions. Sure enough, there’s miles of open terrain with nothing much in the way of cover.

“Did you forget about Melog?” I say, crouching down, scrunching my fingers into their mane.

“Can they fly?”

“Fly?”

Glimmer shrugs, smirking. “Paw prints.”

“Ugh, whatever. What do you want, Glimmer? You just cost me my ride.”

“I’ll take you back to your skiff,” Glimmer says, sitting on the boulder and crossing one leg over the other. “But first…”

“Already heard,” I say, pacing in front of her, trying to ignore the pain burning in my thigh, “you want to talk. Don’t you people have anything better to do?”

“One whole conversation, then you’re free to go.”

“Bit of a cheap trick using Huntara, don’t you think?” I scowl, kicking my foot into the dirt, then cursing when my bad leg buckles and I fall onto my ass.

“You’re hurt!” Glimmer exclaims, jumping to her feet, and rushing over to me. “What happen-”

“Don’t wanna talk about it,” I interrupt, straightening my leg out and applying pressure to the bandage.

“But-”

“Just leave me alone!” I hiss, gritting my teeth. Melog settles next to me, and rests their chin just by my feet.

“Fine, be like that,” Glimmer says, frowning. “I used Huntara because I had to find you.”

“Pfft. *Had* to?”

“Yes. Adora, Bow and I tried, but…”

My stomach twists at the mention of Adora. “Did you ever think maybe I didn’t want to be found?”

“We couldn’t just leave you,” Glimmer says, sighing. “We’ve all been worried sick.”

“Then you all need to find better ways to make use of your time.”

“Catra,” Glimmer says, sitting down in front of me. ”Just give a few minutes of your time, that’s all I’m asking for.”

“Are you ever going to shut up if I refuse?” I ask, frowning.

Glimmer smirks. “Nope.”

I groan loudly, rolling my eyes and shifting, somewhat painfully, into a cross-legged position. “Fine. So talk.”

Glimmer smiles sadly, then takes a deep breath. “You’re probably wondering why nobody said anything.”

“Amongst other things.”

“It’s not really the kind of thing you can bring up in conversation,” Glimmer says, sighing. “The more I thought about saying something, the more out of place it felt.”

“You had plenty of chances on Prime’s ship.”

“I was going to bring it up, so many times…” Glimmer says, fiddling with her fingers. “But then you started being *nice* to me. And you were the only person actually talking to me that whole time.”

“And after that? Once we’d won?”

“By then, I’d already decided that I liked you.”

“Liked me?” I say, gritting my teeth, standing shakily to my feet. “What’s *wrong* with you?!”

“Well, I saw the good in you,” Glimmer says, also standing to her feet. “We all did-”

“I. KILLED. YOUR. MOTHER!” I yell, so loudly that a few birds scatter from behind the boulder, and Melog’s fur starts to glow with a burning-red hue.

Glimmer steps forwards and rests her hands on my shoulders. “Catra…”

“Working on it,” I mumble, closing my eyes, taking a few deep breaths in through my nose, and out through my mouth, until Melog settles. “It’s one thing to keep this from me,” I whisper, opening my eyes again. “But another entirely to fuck with me, and pretend you’re my friend.”

“I was never pretending!” Glimmer says, turning wide-eyed.

I swat her hands away, and grit my teeth. “What the hell, Glimmer? *How can you just forgive something like that!?*”

“I HAVEN’T!” Glimmer shouts, balling her hands into fists, and turning around to face away from me. “Sometimes I look at you and I can’t help but feel I’d do literally anything to change what happened. I get so, so angry...”

“You know, the irony is I genuinely wanted to try to make things up to everyone,” I say, laughing at the absurdity. “But this? There’s just no way.”

“I hate you,” Glimmer says, sniffling, “for everything you’ve done. But I love the person you are now. You have a kindness to you that I never really saw before.”

“I’m not kind,” I mutter.

“Yes, you are,” Glimmer says, turning to face me again. “You may try to hide it, but I see it.”

“You have no idea what you’re- Ow,” I grimace and fall down again, my thigh suddenly buckling under my weight. An ugly, red stain starts to seep out from the middle of the dressing, and through my leggings.

Glimmer bends down and reaches her hand toward my wound. “Okay, we need to get this looked at-”

“I’m fine!” I snap, shuffling backwards, “don’t you *dare* show me sympathy. The only thing you should be trying to do right now is to kill me!”

“Why?” Glimmer asks, frowning. “How would that help anything?”

“It doesn’t matter if it helps or not,” I mumble, tears springing to my cheeks, “it’s what I deserve. So just get it over with.”

Melog whines and raises their head, as though detecting Glimmer might actually take me up on the offer. Or at least, realising that’s what I want to happen.

“There was a time where I might have,” Glimmer says, leaning forwards. “But that time is long gone. And if I can accept that, then why can’t you?”

She wraps her arms around my shoulders, and I hold back a sob, feeling any fight that was left in me drain away. “Why? Why can’t you just-”

“Kill you?”

I nod my head, sniffling.

“Well for one thing, Adora would kill me.”

“Hah,” I snort out a laugh.

--

Glimmer pulls away, kneels down and places her hands on her lap, smiling sadly. “You know, you aren’t the only person who’s done things that they regret.”

“Hmm?”

“Do you remember when I helped Light Hope to activate the heart?”

I swish my tail. “Doubt I’ll ever forget.”

“I had no idea. I just wanted to defeat you all, and I...”

“Teleported our whole planet out of Despondos, almost wiped out the universe, and summoned Prime?”

“Lucky for me Adora stopped the wiping out part,” Glimmer says, wincing. “If she hadn’t…”

“We’d all be dead.”

“Exactly. I messed up. And I thought nobody would ever forgive me, especially Bow.”

“But they all did, in the end, right?”

“Yes.”

“I see where you’re going with this you know,” I say, hunching forwards. “Friends will forgive you so long as you work for it. Yadda ya.”

“You,” Glimmer says, standing up, “are the most stubborn, bratty magicat I’ve ever met.”

Melog huffs and rolls onto their back, exposing their belly, and I’m sure I hear them laugh.

“That’s not very nice,” I say, pricking my ears up as I watch her walk behind me. “Besides, I can’t imagine you’ve met many others.”

Glimmer sits down and pushes her back against mine. “Just one other. Where did they all run off to, anyway?”

I pull my knees to my chest. “Beats me.”

“Maybe we should go look for them one day. Your family.”

“Hah!” I laugh, “even if they’re alive, they abandoned me. Why would I care?”

Glimmer tips the back of her head against mine. “But you do care.”

“I guess,” I say, fiddling with the end of my tail.

Melog starts to snore lightly, and I reach down to stroke their tummy, watching as the sun starts to set on the horizon. I feel myself begin to relax, helped by Glimmer’s warmth at my back, reminding me of all those time’s we’d talk on Prime’s ship, sharing dumb stories, keeping each other company. Keeping each other sane.

--

“Catra?”

“Yeah?”

“If you do come home,” Glimmer says. “You’d have that nice new, comfortable bed waiting for you.”

A snort out a laugh. “It’s huge. A bit overkill, don’t you think?”

“I imagine Adora’s the sort of person who could get carried away. So, you know,” Glimmer says, chuckling. “Extra space could be handy.”

“Hah, you’re a bigger pervert than Melog.”

Melog snorts awake, lifts their head and groans at the insult. “Mating is not perverted.”

“I’m just messing with you, buddy,” I say, patting their light-purple belly fur.

I look up at the evening sky, inhale clean, crisp air through my nose, then close my eyes and exhale slowly. “Okay. Say I come back,” I say, bumping the back of my head against Glimmers, “Aren’t we forgetting one tiny detail?”

“Adora?”

“Adora.”

“You know she’ll forgive you, right?” Glimmer says.

“Are you sure?” I ask, laughing sarcastically, “because the last I checked, I had zero strikes left on the whole running away thing.”

“I’d say it can’t hurt to try, but,” Glimmer says, and I feel her shrug against my back. “We both know that’s not true. Nobody can hurt us more than those we love.”

Melog stands up and nudges up against my face, licking beneath my chin. “I will follow wherever you go. But, home… the palace. The people. I miss it.”

“You just want to see Adora,” I say, ruffling my hand against their mane.

“I only feel what you feel,” Melog says, a smirk appearing at their lips.

“Smart ass,” I mutter.

Glimmer shuffles behind me and I twist my head around, watching her stand up. She walks in front of me, then holds out her hand. “Everyone misses you, dearly. But if you still want to leave, a promise is a promise.”

I look down at my hands, feeling my throat tighten, folding my ears downwards.

“Just come home. We love you, idiot,” Glimmer says, and I can’t help but laugh.

“That’s mine, you can’t use it.”

“What, idiot?” Glimmer says, grinning. ”Dummy?”

“Glimmer. Are you flirting with me?,” I ask, grinning and taking her hand.

“Pfft, haha, no,” Glimmer says, helping me to my feet and then playfully nudging her elbow into my ribs.

“You and Bow though,” I chuckle. “I saw that one coming a mile off.”

“He’s my best friend. I don’t know what I’d do without him.”

“Best friend who happens to sport a mean six pack…”

Glimmer blows out a puff of hot air. “Says the person who dates She-Ra, literally the strongest, most muscular person on the planet.”

“Adora has pretty great abs too, you know.”

“Hmm. Really?”

“Not that I’ve ever looked, or anything.”

“Uhuh,” Glimmer says, wrapping an arm around my shoulder. “Are you ready?”

“Wait, Sparkles,” I say, folding my arms. “Are you sure about this? I could live somewhere else, and still visit Adora...”

“I’d rather be able to keep my eye on you,” Glimmer says, grinning widely, “Horde scum.”

“Pfft,” I laugh, shaking my head. “Okay. Let’s go, before I change my mind.”

“Come on, Melog,” Glimmer says, holding open her other arm. They trot towards her, and nuzzle up against her hand until she has a firm grip on their mane.

--

A couple of blinks later we're stood in the western courtyard of the palace, and the first thing I notice is Adora, sitting at the foot of the stairs. She glances up at me, and her face contorts, tears springing to her eyes.

I reach my hand out and walk towards her, but she grimaces, spins around and storms up the staircase, heading back inside with her hands balled into fists.

"I think she's mad at me," I mutter.

"So go talk to her," Glimmer says, nudging my shoulder with hers. "And, be patient, okay? She's had a rough time with all this."

"Yeah. I bet," I say, slumping my shoulders. "Okay, wish me luck…"

"Wait, shouldn't we get that fixed up first?" Glimmer says, pointing to the stain on my bandaged leg.

"It's fine," I shrug, feeling a familiar, itchy burn. "It's already healing. Magicat thing, you know?"

"Oh, of course. You all heal so freakishly fast," Glimmer says, smiling brightly. "Good luck," she says, pecking me on the cheek, before blinking away.

"I shall sleep elsewhere tonight," Melog says, butting their nose against my hip.

"No need," I say, folding my arms. "We definitely won't be mating tonight, I can promise you that."

Melog appears to smile. "Regardless, you have much to discuss, no?"

"Don't remind me."

"It will be okay."

"Hah, thanks, Melog," I say, stroking their fur roughly. "Where is it you actually go off to, anyway?"

"Sometimes to Entrapta, as you know. Other times, high up the rooftops," they say, yawning. "I enjoy watching the sun set, and rise."

"Okay. Well you do you, buddy."

"And you do Adora."

"Melog," I say, gasping, "did you just make a joke?"

"I am learning," they say, puffing their chest out proudly. "See you tomorrow, Catra."

"See you tomorrow," I say, taking a deep breath, then heading into the palace.

--

I knock on the door quietly, but there's no answer. So I crack it open slowly, peering inside, half-dreading that Adora won't even be here. I feel a wave of relief wash over me when I spot her, curled up on the left side of our new bed.

"Hey," I say, closing the door behind, and walking towards her. I sit on the end of the mattress and reach a hand out.

“I’m sleeping,” Adora says. Her voice has a chill to it that I’ve only heard once before. “You should do the same.”

I snap my hand back, and stand up, grabbing onto my upper arm, unsure what to do next. “I… can go sleep somewhere else, if you want.”

Adora twists around to glare at me. “Sure. You’re great at running.”

“That’s harsh, Adora.”

“Is it?” she asks, sitting upright, her brows creased with anger. “You do this *every* time!”

“This wasn’t the same, and you know it!” I say, backing away from the bed, balling my hands into fists.

“It wasn’t? You heard something you didn’t like, and you were gone. Just like that.”

“Didn’t like?!” I say, the words stinging my throat. “I found out I killed my friend's mother. How can you not see why that would-”

“You could have stayed, we could have talked about it!”

“*I’m messed up, Adora, okay?*”I yell, my voice breaking, tears stinging my cheeks. “I keep having flashbacks, from Prime, from everything I've done… *all* of it,” I say, my lower lip trembling. “Nothing is okay, and the last thing I needed was to find out I murdered a person that you all loved. So please, give me a break. Just this once,” I say, placing my hands over my face, leaning back against the door, sobbing.

“Catra, your hand-” Adora says, jumping from the bed and walking up to me. She takes my wounded hand and examines it. “What did you do?” she asks, looking me up and down. “You’re covered in bruises! And your *leg*!” Adora gasps, bending down, running her palm over the stained material.

“I’m fine…” I say, tears streaming down my cheek. “Please don’t hate me, Adora. Please.”

She stands up and pulls me into her arms. “Why would you ever say something like that?”

“Because I messed up, *again*. I don’t deserve you-”

Adora silences me with a gentle kiss, resting her palms on my cheeks. I choke back a sob at the sudden intimacy, and place my hands over hers, holding them in place, feeling her warmth.

“I’m sorry I snapped,” Adora says, tipping her forehead to mine. “It’s just… I get scared too, you know?”

I nod, sniffling.

“I keep thinking one day you’ll run away, and I’ll never see you again.”

“I’m sorry,” I say, moving one of her hands to my lips, kissing her fingertips. “I’m so, so sorry…”

“It’s okay,” Adora says, leaning forwards and pulling me into her arms. “To be honest, I forgave you the second you came back.”

“Adora,” I sob, threading my fingers into her hair and burying my face into the crook of her neck, inhaling her scent. Relief washes over me and I can’t stop the tears, can’t stop myself from crying, holding her tightly, overwhelmed that even after all this, even after everything, she still wants me.

--

Eventually the tears stop, and a quiet, comfortable calmness takes their place.

“Why didn’t you tell me sooner?” Adora asks, trailing her fingers across the short hairs behind my neck.

I sniffle. “Tell you what?”

Adora pulls back slightly, then gently wipes away my tears with her thumb. “About the flashbacks?”

“Oh. I kind of hoped they’d stop…”

“I want you to tell me if it happens again, okay?”

“I will. I promise.”

Adora takes a step back and smiles, holding out her hand. “Let’s get you cleaned up.”

“Uh, okay,” I say, taking her hand, and following her into the bathroom.

--

Adora reaches into one of the two drawers below the mirror, and pulls out a small pair of scissors. She bends down, quietly examining my thigh.

“Is it okay if I take these off?” Adora asks, tugging at my leggings. I nod, gripping onto the edge of the sink while she carefully pulls them down, slowly peeling away the part that’s stuck to my bandage with congealed blood.

“Okay, you’ll need to sit down for the next part,” she says, and I oblige, sitting on the small chair in the corner of the room.

Adora kneels down before me. “This might hurt. You ready?”

“Yeah,” I say, gripping the edge of the chair. But Adora’s movements are incredibly gentle, and I barely feel her at all as she carefully snips a couple of layers of bandages away at a time.

“Almost done,” she says, furrowing her brows in concentration.

I quietly watch her work, noticing how incredibly tired she appears. Dark circles are framed below her eyes, and red marks are visible around her eyelids. *I caused that*, I think, feeling my gut wrench.

“Hey, what’s wrong?” Adora asks, standing up and kissing my forehead, then tossing the bandages into the bin.

“Adora,” I say, folding my ears down. “When did you last sleep?”

“Two days ago.”

I grit my teeth, feeling tears spring to my cheeks. “I’m such an idiot…”

“You’re my idiot,” Adora says, nuzzling her nose next to mine and pressing her lips to my cheek. “And I already forgave you. Now sit still,” she says, moving her lips to my ear, whispering, “so that I can heal you, and we can both go to bed.”

I nod and gulp thickly, watching her step over to the sink, and then run some warm water.

--

Adora unwraps a fresh sponge and soap, returns to where I’m sitting and then slowly, gently, washes away the dried blood matted around the wound. Then she rinses the sponge and washes the area a second time, and then a third time, until everything appears to be clean.

“Wow. Those are tidy stitches,” Adora says, closely scrutinising my thigh. “Who did them? Are they dissolvable?”

“Yeah. Standard military grade,” I say, scratching at the scabs around one of the cuts. “And it was Lonnie, believe it or not.”

Adora bats my hand away and tuts. “Sounds like you had quite an adventure out there.”

“That’s one word for it,” I say, sighing.

“Fill me in sometime?” Adora asks, walking back to the sink, and rinsing the sponge out a few times.

“Sure.”

“Okay,” Adora says, shifting to her knees in front of me, holding a palm above the stitches.

“Wait,” I say, and she pauses, looking up at me. “Don’t heal it. Please.”

“But-”

“I’m past the worst of it. It’s a scar I want to keep, so I can remember.”

“Remember what?”

“What’s waiting for me,” I say, grimacing, “if I keep running.”

Adora nods, takes a deep breath, and slides forwards until she’s kneeling between my legs. She places her left hand around my waist, and looks up at me. “Catra...”

“What’s wrong?” I ask, stroking my fingers through her hair.

“I know you used to sometimes hurt yourself before, but this is... something else,” she says, delicately running her fingers around the outside of my scratches. “You cut deep.”

“Yes, but magicat healing, tada!” I say, grinning.

“It isn’t funny.”

I fold my ears down. “Yeah. I suppose it isn't.”

“I want you to talk to Perfuma.”

“... Okay,” I say, slumping my shoulders.

“Tomorrow?”

I nod.

Adora leans down and gently kisses my thigh, taking a deep breath. “Okay. I don’t like it, but if you want to heal by yourself, it’s your choice,” she says, standing to her feet. “But your hand? I’m going to have to insist,” she says, with one corner of her mouth rising. “Unless you’d rather not touch me anytime soon, that is.”

I prick up my ears, and feel heat rise to my cheeks. “Okay. You can heal the hand,” I say, thrusting it forwards.

Adora unfastens the bandages and places her lips to my knuckles, kissing them gently. Then she takes my palm between her hands, where a soft light glow materialises, quickly sealing the myriad of cuts closed, even the big one down the middle of my palm.

“You didn't need to transform?” I ask, studying my newly-healed hand, flexing my fingers a few times.

“I worked out that my powers all come from the same place,” Adora says, beaming. “A while ago, actually.”

“Which is?”

“Well… emotion. But mainly love.”

“Oh,” I say, feeling my heart warmed. “When did you figure that out?”

“Recently,” Adora says, pressing her lips to my forehead. She walks to the sink and starts to rinse the sponge out with hot, soapy water.

--

“Okay, give me that back,” she says, reaching for my hand.

I smirk. “Can’t get enough of my fingers, huh?”

Adora takes my digits in hers, squeezing them lightly. “I’m hoping to find that out soon,” she says, biting her lip into a smile.

“Hah, uh,” I swallow thickly. “*okay*,” I squeak.

Adora’s eyes light up with amusement, but then her brows dip as she concentrates on my claws. She dabs the wet sponge against my fingertips, getting rid of most of the blood that’s stuck around the nails. “Stretch them out?” she asks, raising an eyebrow.

I oblige, flexing my fingertips and pushing my claws out by half an inch.

“Thanks,” Adora says, gently cleaning into the tiny grooves at the back of my nails. “Okay, done.”

I retract my claws, and smile, sighing. “You didn't have to do all that, you know.”

Adora leans over and kisses me on the forehead. “I wanted to. You should probably have a shower for the rest,” she says, tracing her fingers over the tiny scratches and bruises along my arm.

“Ugh. I’ll do it in the morning,” I say, standing to my feet and yawning. “I’m exhausted.”

“Okay then. Come on stinky,” Adora says, taking my hand and guiding me out of the bathroom, then towards the large, circular bed.

“What happened to stargazer?” I ask, tugging my top off over my head, throwing it onto the carpet, then diving under the bedsheets.

“Stargazer needs a wash.”

I stretch out, enjoying the softness of the duvet, then turn on my side to face the balcony doors, curling into a ball. “Shut up and get in here, dummy,” I groan, patting the mattress behind me. I twist my head around and notice Adora quickly undressing, before she dives into bed next to me and pulls the covers tightly around us both.

“You’re naked?” I ask, feeling her bare skin press against my back.

She presses her lips to my ear, whispering. “So you don’t need to undress me in the morning.”

I blow out a puff of air, ignoring the heat rising from my abdomen. “Thought I was too stinky?”

“I can always hold my nose,” Adora says, chuckling. She wraps her arms around my waist and rests her palms below my ribs, holding me tightly against her, and I purr loudly, loving how soft and warm she feels against my back. It feels safe. It feels like *home*. And if I weren’t so exhausted, I’d listen to the throb between my legs, nagging at me to turn around and kiss her.

“Night, Adora,” I say, resting my hands above hers. “I love you.”

Adora places her lips to my neck, just above my scar. “I love you too.”

Chapter End Notes

Huntara: That was way too easy, honestly
Catra: Yeah, I'd like to see you try again
Perfuma: I think now is a good time for us to sit, meditate, and find our happy place.

Love Is Magic

Chapter Summary

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

I wake up hearing the most beautiful sound; Adora's heart, beating slowly, each beat fluttering softly against my ear.

I crack my eyes open, met with a blur of pink. I blink a few times to clear my vision, realising I'm face to face with Adora's smooth skin, and her breast is right in front of my nose. *Wait, how did I get here?* I think, feeling my fur bristle up along my tail.

I risk a glance upwards only to find Adora staring right back at me, sporting a large, smug grin.

"Morning," She says, raising her eyebrows.

I feel heat rush to my cheeks. "Gotta shower!" I say, pushing myself away, and leaping from the bed.

"Want me to join you?"

"Uh…"

"I'm kidding, sheesh." Adora says, yawning loudly, turning onto her side and pulling the covers over her shoulders. "I'm gonna nap some more."

Two seconds later she starts to snore, and the sound of it makes my heart melt.

I hurry into the bathroom and strip off my underwear, then jump into the shower and rinse through my fur with soap a couple of times. The whole time my heart is pounding in my chest, because I know what Adora wants from me but I don't know if I'll be any good at… well, *any* of it. *What if I mess up*? I think. *What if she hates it*?

I step out of the shower, shake the excess moisture from my fur, grab a towel and look at myself in the mirror while wringing my tail dry.

“You can do this,” I mutter, quietly. “You can.”

I vigorously towel myself dry but it makes my fur frizz up, and I scowl, trying to flatten it back down again. Then I pat the towel around the stitches on my thigh, pleased to find everything has fully healed, and I'm left with four faint lines. I carefully pick out the stitches and throw them away, knowing it’d take a week for them to dissolve naturally.

Once satisfied, I wrap the towel tightly around my body and walk back into the bedroom.

Adora is still out cold, snoring lightly. Seeing her like this, so at peace, and so beautiful, makes me wonder why I’m wasting time worrying when I could be right there, holding her, loving her.

I let the towel fall away and climb into bed behind her, folding my arms around her waist, resting my hands upon her abdomen, and settling my belly against her back.

“Catra,” Adora mumbles, placing her hands over mine. “You smell nice.”

“I de-stinkified,” I say, resting my lips on the back of her hair. I shuffle closer to her, until my breasts are pressed against her back.

“Wait. Are you naked?”

“Maybe.”

Adora spins around to face me, beaming. “So I finally got naked Catra privileges?”

“Pfft, idiot,” I laugh, placing my hands upon her waist, and shifting closer to her, close enough that our noses touch.

Adora’s cheeks flush pink. She closes the remaining gap between us, slides her hands around my hips, and rests her palms at the base of my spine.

“So, what do you want to do today?” Adora asks, stroking the fur just above my tail.

We’re close enough that I can feel her every breath, her chest rising and falling against mine. I gulp thickly, my hands frozen in place.

“Do?” I ask, blushing. “I thought you wanted to… you know...”

“But you’re nervous,” Adora says. She raises her hand and slowly strokes my cheek.

“Of course I’m nervous, dummy.” I say, pouting. “This is all very new for *some* of us.”

“Hey, it’s new for me, too,” Adora says, bumping her forehead to mine.

“Really?” I ask, frowning, “Then why are you so calm?”

“I’m not,” she admits. And only then do I notice her heart, racing at almost three times the normal speed.

“Oh.”

I look down at her lips, and I'm suddenly so desperate to feel them against mine that my chest aches.

"Catra, we really don't have to-"

"Shut up," I whisper, cupping the back of her head in my hands, then leaning forwards and kissing her, slowly, until her lips part and I find her tongue, Adora gasping at the contact.

I kiss along her jaw, beneath her ear, and to the crook of her neck, savouring the sounds my lips coax from her.

"Catra. If you're planning on stopping," Adora mumbles, rummaging her fingers through my hair, "now would be a good time."

"I'm not messing around," I say, rolling on top of her, settling my thighs between hers, then leaning down for another kiss. "I want you, Adora."

I feel her smile stretch out beneath my lips. "Promise?"

"I just hope you know I have no idea what I'm doing," I mumble.

"That's not going to be a problem," Adora whispers, gliding her palms down my back, parting her legs wider, until I'm able to sink down against her.

I push my torso up, straightening my arms and flicking the end of my tail, running my gaze up and down Adora's form. Tiny beads of sweat coat her skin, and her scent fills my senses, as strongly as ever, making me want her, no, *need* her. All of her.

"You're so beautiful," Adora whispers, tracing her own gaze up from my abdomen to my torso, past my chest, resting at my eyes.

I feel my cheeks warm. "It's weird, isn't it?"

Adora tilts her head and blinks. "What do you mean?"

"We've seen each other naked so many times… but..."

"Not like this."

"No. Not like this."

I lower myself to my elbows and meet Adora's lips again, kissing her slowly, lightly rolling my hips, enjoying how Adora's fingers tense against my shoulder blades with each motion.

"Tell me what to do," I say, breathing the words against her lips.

"Just this," Adora says, sliding her hands to my lower back, pulling me against her. "This feels good." She lifts her hips earnestly and the contact dampens the fur beneath my abdomen.

"Yeah," I say, pushing my hips down, enjoying the friction. "It does."

I close my eyes, dipping my waist and kissing her, over and over again, until our kisses become more demanding, open mouthed, hungry.

I feel Adora's rapid breaths against my lips between each kiss, hear her gasps turn to groans, reverberating down my throat, mingling with my own guttural sounds, sounds I didn't even know I

could make.

Adora splays her fingers against my lower back, pulling at me, tugging, until I can't take it anymore. *I need to touch her*, I think. *Now*.

I prop myself up on one elbow and trace my palm across her soft, warm skin, feeling the contours of Adora's body, from shoulder, to breast, to ribs, to the dip of her waist. I pause just below the small ridges of her abdomen, where I notice Adora's breath is held, and her body trembling.

I meet her gaze. "Can I?"

Adora releases her breath in a long, shaking sigh. "You don't need to ask."

I take a deep breath, shift onto my knees and raise one leg over Adora's thigh, straddling it. Then I guide my hand dowards slowly, my heart racing as I pause once more above her thick, golden curls. "But are you sure?" I ask, smirking.

Adora huffs. "Now you're just being mean."

"Me? Wouldn't dream of it," I purr, sliding my hand down another inch, quickly finding the same little bump I discovered on myself earlier. Except Adora's feels swollen, and damp.

"Finally," Adora gasps, bucking herself into my hand, forcing my fingers lower, where I realise just how wet she is. I groan loudly at the discovery, falling to my elbow and burying my face into the crook of her neck.

I slowly fumble around, my fingers soon becoming drenched. "I don't know what to do," I whisper against her neck, feeling both afraid and excited.

One of Adora's hands shifts from behind my back, and she places her fingers above mine. "I'll show you," she says.

I pay close attention, watching Adora press her fingers against two of mine, encouraging them to roll in delicate circles, slowly at first, until Adora pushes my fingers a little harder, writhes just a little more, and her breathing turns shallow.

"Okay, I think I get it," I say, though a part of me wants her to leave her hand right there.

Adora's palm returns to my back, her fingers kneading into my shoulders. "That's right," she gasps, gently bucking under me, and I feel my breath taken away by how much power I have over her right now, how just my touch, just my fingers, are doing this to her.

And it's all for me. *She wants me*, I think, grinding atop her thigh, a low growl rumbling in my throat.

"Catra," Adora gasps, digging her nails into the skin beneath my fur. "You're wet…"

"Hmm," I mumble, looking down, noticing Adora's leg glistening between my thighs. "So I am. That's a good thing, right?"

Adora bursts out laughing.

"What!" I exclaim, pouting. She sits up and kisses me greedily.

“It’s a *very* good thing. You’ll see,” Adora says, biting her lower lip into a smile. “Just keep going and… do it harder now.”

“Uh, okay,” I say, following her head back to the pillow, and trapping her in a long, lazy kiss. I add more pressure beneath my fingers, rolling them just a little faster.

“Mmm,” Adora mumbles against my lips, “more.”

I prop myself up on my elbow, keeping her neck cupped against my palm, while I concentrate on every movement I make with my fingers, greeting each push of her hips with the pressure she’s asking for, begging for. Her scent is so strong now that I start to feel dizzy, and I growl, needing more. More of this. More of her. *More*.

I roll my hips, pushing, grinding, starting to feel overwhelmed by a new maddening need, a need that I don’t fully understand, burning between my legs.

“You feel amazing,” Adora says, her eyes fluttering closed, her hair splayed out across her pillow

“You… ah-” I pant, feeling a strange, pleasant pulse throb between my legs, “ah... “

“I love you. Love you.” Adora mumbles, trailing her hands up my back, threading her fingers into my hair.

“I-” I say, feeling another surge, this time more intense, “Ah! I love you too,” I gasp, diving down and kissing her, groaning into her open mouth as a third pulse floods through me. This time it’s enough to make me cry out. “Shit, Adora, what…”

“It’s okay, I’m here,” Adora says, slowing her pace, placing her hands on my cheeks, staring at me with her beautiful, bright-blue gaze. “I’m here. I love you.”

I kiss her again, gently rocking my hips, sliding my fingers against her wet, swollen bud. Soft, tender touches soon become more desperate, more frenzied, until Adora groans loudly, digging her nails into my scalp.

“Catra... Inside…”

“Huh?”

Adora’s hand leaves my back and I lean up, watching. She guides two of my fingers downwards, this time pushing, curling, until my digits are surrounded with her wet, soft warmth.

“Adora,” I gasp, turning wide-eyed.

“Like this, okay?” Adora says, pushing the heel of my hand against her bud, keeping my fingers curled in place, writhing into my hand, showing me when to push, and when to pull.

I nod my head, my heart threatening to beat out of my chest, my throat dry. “Okay.”

Her hand returns to my shoulder, and I copy the movements she taught me. With every rise of her hips I run the tips of my fingers against the small ridges inside of her, and offer friction with my palm, again and again until she’s groaning, gasping for air, digging her fingers into my shoulders.

“Don’t stop,” Adora gasps, panting, thrusting into my hand.

I writhe my hips, soon feeling another hot pulse spread from between my legs. But it's not enough. I need more. "Touch me," I say, grinding myself against her thigh. "Now."

"But-"

"It's not up for discussion," I growl.

Adora nods and quickly moves her hand to where I want it, gliding her fingers between her thigh and my core, offering pressure where I need it the most.

"*Yes*," I whisper, closing my eyes, gasping, pushing myself shakilly against her fingertips, curving my own digits into her slickness, over and over, my whole hand becoming drenched.

"Catra, ugh-" Adora gasps, violently rocking her hips. "Don't stop!"

I open my eyes to find hers staring back, full of desperation, and I growl, darting my lips to her neck, running my tongue along her skin, tasting her, and Adora's response, a throaty, deep groan, forces a hot pulse to shudder between my legs, and then another.

Adora thrusts herself roughly against my hand, forcing my fingers into her, over and over, until she suddenly cries out, clawing her hand into my back.

"Catra!"

Adora's leg folds around my waist, almost trapping me in place, but it doesn't stop me from writhing against her fingers, not when I can feel something so amazing building up, not when I'm so hot, so close to whatever this is…

"AH!" I yell, panting, scrunching my eyes shut, my body quivering as the most intense, most sensual thing I've ever felt in my life rocks through me from Adora's fingertips to my core, to my gut to my chest, to my lungs, to my heart. "Adora… oh, *fuck*…"

And suddenly, I'm so connected to her, feeling her shudder around my fingers, hearing her groan, having her cling to me as though she'll die without me. It's everything that I'm feeling, the same sounds I'm making, the same way I'm shaking, gasping, clinging to her. And I know, I just know, in this moment, this very second, she loves me every single bit as much as I love her.

Just like I've always loved her.

Just like she's alway loved me.

I release a long, drawn-out sigh, collapsing into a heap on top of Adora, feeling gentle tremors run through me, until I become so relaxed that I don't actually think I can move.

--

I listen quietly as Adora's heart slows from a thundering roar, to a slower, more steady beat. Her hands gently stroke down the fur on my back, causing my throat to rumble with a contented purr.

Suddenly, Adora's chest rises sharply, and I hear a sob.

"Adora?" I ask, lifting my head up. "What's wrong?"

"I'm just…" she sniffs. "I'm so happy."

“You sap,” I chuckle, shifting upwards, and quickly kissing her. “Don’t. You’ll start me off. Adora, you know I hate crying.”

“I know,” she says, smiling from ear to ear, brushing loose strands of my fringe to one side. “I can’t help it though.”

“Pfft,” I blow out hot air, then bury my face into the crook of her neck, hiding my own tears.

We lay like that for a while, Adora stroking a hand lazilly up and down the fur at my back, while I continue to purr, idly swishing the tip of my tail.

Adora’s heartbeat slows further, and she starts to shiver.

“You’re cold?” I ask, reaching behind myself, pulling the covers over us both.

Adora hums. “Not really,” she says, chuckling. “You’re like a volcano, Catra.”

“But you’re shaking…”

“Yeah. I’m a little overwhelmed.”

“Sorry,” I say, nuzzling my lips against her cheek. “Did I do something wrong?”

Adora snorts out a laugh, “You’re kidding, right? I don’t think I’ve ever felt this happy.”

“Hmm,” I purr, closing my eyes, and folding a leg over her waist. “I think I finally get it.”

“Get what?”

“Why everyone goes on about the sex thing,” I say, wrinkling my nose.

“Feels good, right?”

“Understatement.”

Adora takes a deep breath. “But… was that okay?”

“What do you mean?” I ask, frowning.

“Well I, you know,” Adora says, holding a hand up, wriggling her fingers.

I snort out a laugh. “You’re ridiculous. Why wouldn’t that be okay?”

“Because you wanted to go slower?

“That’s still slow. Besides,” I say, raising an eyebrow. “I let you clean my claws last night.”

“Huh?”

I shake my head. “You do realise that’s probably the most intimate thing you can do to a magicat?”

Adora gasps, appearing mortified. “Why didn’t you say something!”

I laugh, and kiss her quickly. “Because it’s you, idiot. You’re allowed.”

Adora smiles, and fresh tears form below her cheeks.

“What did I just say, Adora!” I say, grinning, swallowing back my own tears. “Stop. It.”

I settle myself against the crook of Adora’s arm, resting my head on her shoulder, lazilly trailing my hand around her torso, while Adora strokes her hand up my arm.

“How are you feeling?”

“Pretty great actually,” I say, yawning.

“Good,” Adora says, leaning over and pickling up her communicator for the bedside table, “But I still want you to talk to Perfuma.”

“Kind of hoped you’d forgotten,” I grumble.

“Nope,” Adora says, pulling the blankets around her shoulders. “This is happening.”

“Fine. Then I’m going to freshen up.”

I hop from the bed, watching Adora watch me as I walk towards the bathroom. I raise my eyebrows, and exaggerate my movements so that my hips swing widely and my tail sways provocatively.

“Behave,” Adora says, throwing a pillow right at me, giggling. I grab it mid-air, swing in a full circle and hurl it back, laughing as it hits her square in the face, just as Perfuma answers the call.

--

I close the bathroom door and lean my back against it, sliding downward, my legs suddenly feeling as though made of jelly. *Well, that was something else*, I think, blowing out a long puff of air. I tip my head back against the door, closing my eyes and taking a deep breath, trying to calm down.

It doesn’t work. I feel giddy, ecstatic even, like I need to laugh, or yell, or dance, or run a marathon.

I look down at my hands, noticing they’re trembling slightly. My right hand is still wet, glistening under the bathroom lights. I can’t help but raise it to my nose, allowing Adora’s scent to flood my senses. And I can’t help but run my tongue against my fingers, finally tasting Adora properly.

She tastes amazing, I think, closing my eyes again, wondering how good she’d taste if I had her against my mouth.

“Maybe I can find out,” I mutter, licking my lips and standing up.

I freshen up quickly, flushing the toilet, washing my hands and face, and looking at myself in the mirror. For the first time in as long as I can remember, I’m not instantly repulsed. Maybe because all I can think about is Adora’s taste, still fresh on my tongue, making me feel almost drunk with desire.

I open the bathroom door and smirk to myself, noticing Adora is still on the call. I stride towards the bed, jump under the covers at the end, and slide up on all fours until I’m past her calves, looking at her thighs. There I notice her scent, stronger than ever, and my eyes widen at the sight of her, still so wet, so pink, so beautiful.

“Uh so, hah,” Adora says, her leg jumping when I place my lips to her inner thigh, “I’m gonna have to go. So, it’s hah!”

I flatten my tongue against her skin, licking upwards in a long stroke. Her scent is everywhere down here, and I can't get enough of it.

"Okay-I'll-let-her-know-bye!" Adora says. She lifts the blankets up and peers down at me, her cheeks bright red. "Catra."

"Hmm?" I mumble, my mouth still pressed to her thigh. "Should I stop?"

Adora flings the blankets away from us both, grinning. "I never said that."

"Good," I mutter, pressing my lips to her thigh again. She smells so good. *Almost too good*, I think, nuzzling my mouth across her flesh, her taste only growing stronger. I still have no idea what I'm doing, or at least some small part of me tells me that, but a far bigger part tells me I shouldn't care.

And it's the second voice I listen to, moving my mouth towards her centre, breathing hotly against her pink, glistening skin, inhaling her scent deeply, and feeling my fur bristle all the way down my back in response.

"Catra-"

I look up, twitching my left ear. "What?"

Adora smiles softly, resting her hand on my head. "I love you."

"I love you too, idiot," I say, grinning.

I lower myself, flattening my tongue against her. She cries out the second my tongue makes contact with that precious, swollen bump, and her fingers thread into my hair, her nails tracing across my scalp.

I roll my tongue against the spot, figuring it can't be that much different to when I used my fingers, yet the sounds Adora's making are higher pitched, and far more desperate-sounding than before.

I wrap my hands around the back of her thighs, gliding my tongue more firmly against her, and her hips raise sharply, inviting me to explore further, to lick against the folds there. I raise my gaze to watch Adora's head collapse back onto her pillow, watching as she moans loudly and tightens her grip into my fringe, raising her hips again.

It's the only encouragement I need. I take her completely into my mouth, pushing my tongue deep to search for the source of that irresistible flavour, and I soon find it, just inside of her; those sweet, thin ridges that I touched earlier. I lap my tongue against them, between them, desperate to taste as much of her as possible.

"That's… wow… how are you… oh… *don't stop*..." Adora gasps, and hearing those sounds, tasting her like this… it's better than anything I could ever have imagined.

I peer upwards again, noticing Adora's eyes are lidded as she peers down at me. Her jaw is slightly parted, and her cheeks are flushed. She releases a throaty groan, tilting her head backwards, and I smile with my tongue inside of her, knowing I'm definitely doing something right.

I shift a hand from her thigh to her lower abdomen and roll my thumb against her swollen bud, the whole time running my tongue against my new favourite place, those tiny bumps inside of her that taste more like Adora than anything else.

I'm soon rewarded with a new sound, almost a growl. "That feels a-amazing," Adora gasps, her fingers scrunching into my hair, holding my head in place tightly as she writhes against my mouth, "ugh, don't stop… Catra… I'm-"

I groan into her, rolling my thumb harder, faster, barely able to keep up to the pace of her thrusts, my jaw aching from how quickly I'm flicking my tongue, until Adora's whole body becomes rigid, her back arches up from the mattress, and my lips are flooded with her salty-vanilla taste.

"-coming, I'm coming!" Adora groans, violently thrusting against my mouth, over and over, until she releases the longest, deepest sigh.

And then, her body collapses to the bed, and her fingers relax their hold against my head.

I pant against her for a while, catching my breath, before slowly, delicately kissing my way up her abdomen and torso. Then I rest my ear against her chest, listening to her heart pound. Adora takes deep, shuddering breaths, and tussles her fingers into the hair behind my ear.

"Did I do okay?" I mumble, purring against her chest.

"You're… *really* good at that," Adora says, her chest rising and falling quickly.

I stretch out and prop myself up on my elbows, until we're face to face. "So I'm a natural, huh?"

"You are, but," Adora says, furrowing her eyebrows.

"What?"

"Just out of interest, how long is your tongue?"

"What, this?" I ask, extending it fully, easily touching the bottom of my chin. "Magicat thing. Did you forget?"

"Wow," Adora says, laughing, then thumping her head against the pillow. "I didn't forget, I just... forgot. Okay. That explains it."

I chuckle, remembering the crazy shit we did as kids. "I guess this was different to our little competitions."

"Yeah. Who can touch their chin with their tongue?!" Adora says, chuckling. "I always wondered why you kept winning."

"Hmm," I mumble, narrowing my eyes. "You taste amazing, by the way."

"Really?"

I nod, looking down to her lips, hoping she'll take the hint. And she does. Just a moment later she reaches up, wraps her arms around my shoulders and kisses me deeply.

I roll from the top of her until we're side by side, never breaking the kiss, and knowing that she can taste herself on me fills me with need all over again. It's a new kind of need. Like I want to lay back and have her touch me, devour me, *take me*.

I find myself breathless after the kiss, wondering where that came from.

“You okay?” Adora asks, bumping her forehead to mine.

“Yeah. More than,” I say, chuckling. “I can’t believe we’re actually having sex.”

Adora laughs, tears springing to her eyes, then clears her throat. “I can’t believe how much better it is with you.”

I twitch my ears. “Better? Compared to what?”

Adora suddenly blushes, her lips straightening to a thin line. “Um, well…”

“Hmm? Did you lie to me, Adora?” I ask, scowling. “Who was it? I’ll kill them.”

“Actually, it was…” Adora grins awkwardly.

I feel my stomach knot knowing that I wasn’t her first after all, and worse, she actually lied about it.

“Well, myself.”

“Oh. Hah!” I say, grinning. “You little pervert.”

“It’s not perverted,” Adora pouts.

“Wait!” I exclaim, laughing at a sudden realisation. “I knew I’d heard those sounds before!”

“Oh no,” Adora mumbles, scrunching her eyes closed as her cheeks turn redder.

“Adora, Are *you* the night wailer? You are, aren’t you! I can’t believe it, that’s *hilarious!*”

Adora covers her face with her hands, turning a brighter shade of red, shaking her head, “I was lonely, okay? And I couldn't have you, so...”

“Maybe you should have just *asked*,” I say, chuckling. I lightly kiss the bottom of her chin, and wait patiently for her to remove her hands.

“What, like, hey Catra, let’s have sex?” Adora mumbles into her hands, before opening them up, showing her beautiful blue eyes. “Would that actually have worked?”

“It might have,” I say, grinning. “I can’t believe you fabricated that whole ghost story. Night wailer, hah! Kyle was terrified and all along it was just Adora being horny in the bathroom,” I say, doubling over in laughter. “Hahaha, I love it!”

I flop onto my back, waiting for the tears to stop, my belly feeling ticklish from all the laughter.

“It was usually the storeroom, actually,” Adora mumbles.

“Haha, it gets better!”

“I’m never going to hear the end of this, am I?”

“Hah, pfft. You’re ridiculous.”

“Only around you,” Adora says, smiling softly. “Also…”

“Hmm?”

“I love you, so much.”

“I love you too,” I say. “Aha, that’s it!”

“What is?”

“You’re my love,” I say, smirking. “That’s my pet name for you. See? It’s nice and mushy.”

“I like it,” Adora says, smiling lop-sidedly. “But I bet you daren’t use it in public.”

“Depends. What’s it worth?”

“Um,” Adora says, frowning. Then she grins widely. “I’ll give you full access to naked She-Ra?”

I prick my ears up. “Interesting. How public are we talking, exactly?”

Adora giggles. “At least four others have to hear you say it. And clearly, too.”

“Four random people?”

“No. Four people we know.”

“Bah,” I say, scrunching my nose up. “I’ll think about it.”

--

I doze for a while with my head on Adora’s chest, half sleeping, enjoying her warmth.

Eventually, Adora shifts beneath my weight. “Hey, Catra,” she says, and I open one eye, peering up at her.

“Hmm?”

“I promised I'd help Glimmer and the clones with some stuff today,” she says, wincing. “Is that okay?”

“Can’t we just stay here?” I ask, wrinkling my nose.

“No,” Adora says, sighing. “But I really, really want to.”

I raise my head and smirk, then shift onto all fours above her, pressing my nose to hers. “I bet I can make you stay.”

“Oh really,” Adora breathes, lidding her eyes, trailing her fingers down my back. I lean down and kiss her, then run my lips along her cheek towards her neck, where her hands stop me. “Wait. Catra. No.”

“Because you know you can’t resist?” I ask, slowly swaying my tail.

“Yes.”

“Hmm,” I purr, “Good to know.”

“Don’t make me break my promises, Catra.”

I wrinkle my nose. “Fine, you can have it your way. Just this once.”

“How generous of you,” Adora says, grinning toothilly.

I’m about to answer when Adora’s communicator buzzes loudly, interrupting me.

“It’s Glimmer,” Adora says, quickly wrapping the bedsheets around herself. She stares at me, smirking. “Try to keep your tongue to yourself this time.”

--

I hide under the covers, listening in.

“Hi Adora, just checking in,” Glimmer says, talking quickly. “Is Catra there? Did you guys make up? Please tell me you made up.”

I pop my head up from beneath the covers, scrunching up my nose. “Hi Sparkles.”

Glimmer squeals. “Bow! Come see this!”

“Urgh... here we go,” I say, snuggling up next to Adora, awaiting the inevitable.

Glimmer makes a few muffled sounds and drops her tablet. The next thing I know, Bow is looking at us both, his eyes wide and sparkling.

“So you two kissed and made up? That’s fantastic!”

Adora’s expression shifts to one of supreme smugness and I get a feeling of dread, creeping all the way up from the base of my spine. ”Adora. No.”

“Oh, we kissed alright,” she says, lidding her eyes. “In fact, Catra kissed me pretty much everywh-haha!”

I snatch the tablet off her, keeping the blankets scrunched around my shoulders. Glimmer appears on-screen, right next to Bow, hiding her mouth behind her hand, clearly laughing. “Okay this is fun and all,” I drawl. “But I’m starving.”

“I don’t know why, you just had plenty to eat,” Adora sings the words, grinning from ear to ear. Bow and Glimmer burst out laughing.

I place my palm on my face, noticing how hot my cheeks are. “Why are you like this…”

“Hey,” Glimmer says, leaning closer to the monitor. “Why don’t we meet in the canteen? Then Adora can fill us in.”

“Funny you should say that,” Adora purrs, wiggling her eyebrows. “Catra is *really* good at filling in. Maybe I’ll let her do it.”

“Seriously?” I ask, twitching my right ear. “There will be no filling in. Of any kind. And can you stop with the innuendo for like two seconds?”

Glimmer bursts out laughing again, Bow turns bright red, and Adora wraps her arm around me, pulling me into a hug while I’m still processing the trauma she's putting me through.

Bow clears his throat. “So, food. Everyone good to go?”

“Yeah. I’m starvi- do NOT start that shit again Adora,” I say, slapping my hand over her smug little mouth. “I’m starving, and I need to eat something other than my girlfriend.”

Adora bursts out laughing, and rolls over to the side.

“You called her your *girlfriend*” Bow says, whispering the last word. He turns to peck glimmer on the cheek. “They’re girlfriends!”

Glimmer claps her hands, grinning from ear to ear, then they both start chanting. “Girlfriends! Girlfriends!”

“Okay, I can’t deal with your friends,” I say, scowling, throwing the tablet at Adora.

She catches it, but loses her balance and falls out of bed. “Whoa!”

“Yikes! Naked Adora!” Bow says, covering his eyes. “Did not need to see that.”

“Speak for yourself,” Glimmer says, smiling smugly.

Adora squeals and hurls the tablet at me, which I catch mid-air. “Hey!” I say, “Stop perving on my girl.”

“Aww,” Bow says, resting his hands on his cheeks. “You called her your *girl*!”

“Whatever,” I mumble. “We’ll see you guys soon. Gotta get ready and stuff.”

“Okay,” Glimmer says. “See you later!”

“Laters,” I say, pressing the disconnect button.

I lean over the bed, looking down at Adora, who’s sprawled out on the floor. “What are you doing now?”

“Help!” she says, placing her palm over her head. “I’ve fallen, and I can’t get up!”

“Then you can stay there,” I say, jumping off of the bed. “Oh and after that little show, I’m withholding sex for a week,” I say, flicking my tail around.

“Like you can resist this,” Adora says, sitting up and flexing her arms. I roll my eyes but can’t hide my smile. “You’re an idiot. I’m going to get changed”

“Hey, Catra.”

“Hmm?”

“Are we really girlfriends?”

“Are you dense? After everything we just did, you’re seriously asking that?”

Adora giggles. “Wow. We’re girlfriends. Wow.”

“Yeah well, get used to it,” I say, smirking. “And get a move on, dummy!”

Chapter End Notes

Catra: Wait, please tell me you added a password to this part. Adora?!
Adora: uhm...
Mermista: Hmm. Sea Hawk, come read this. You might learn something.
Catra: ADORA!

Therapy and Trauma

Chapter Summary

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Adora and I walk down the east hall, hand in hand, until I smell various delightful aromas drifting down the hallway, causing my stomach to growl.

“Wow,” I say, placing a hand on my abdomen. “I really am starving.”

“Worked up an appetite did we?” Adora asks, appearing as smug as ever.

“Yes but I would have liked to work up more of one,” I grumble, squeezing her hand.

“You’re insatiable.”

“Well, now I know what I’ve been missing out on,” I purr, wrapping my tail around her waist. “I want more.”

“Yeah,” Adora says, biting her lip, “me too.”

--

We walk into the canteen but I stop mid-stride when I notice that one of the larger tables is surrounded by clones, their pale skin, green eyes and white hair making me feel nauseous.

I grit my teeth. “Great. Why are they here?”

“It’s okay,” Adora says, rubbing her hand behind my shoulder. “We’ll come back later.”

“No, I’m done running,” I say, watching one of the clones stand up and walk in our direction. My heart starts to race, the hairs down my back stand on end, and the scars on my thigh itch.

“Catra,” the clone says, holding an open palm in front of me. “I am sorry for before. I did not stop to consider your feelings, nor your turmoil. I merely assumed that since you suffered the same horrors we did, you would be on our side. This was wrong of-”

“Wow, are you ever going to shut up?” I ask, twitching my right ear. “So you got it wrong. Doesn’t matter, since we’ll never be friends.”

“I see,” the clone says, appearing crestfallen. “I understand.”

“And can’t you just dye your hair or something?” I ask, twirling my hand in the direction of his friends. “It makes sick how you all look the same.”

“Dye… our hair?”

“Yes, you know,” I say, kneading my fingers into my hair, “It’s called col-our. Heard of it?”

“Very well, Catra.” the clone says, tilting his head to one side. “Where can I find this… col-our?”

I place my palm over my face, wondering why I’m playing nicely. “At the market. It’s up the north hall, in the square.”

The clone nods, appears to attempt something almost resembling a smile, then hurries back to his creepy flock.

“Well that could turn out interesting,” Adora says, placing her hand on my cheek, appearing concerned. “Are you sure you’ll be okay?”

“I’ll live. Come on, let’s grab some food,” I say, heading to the counter with her, then wincing. “Oh no.”

“What? Oh, is that the guy?” Adora asks, nodding in the direction of the same ginger-haired man I terrorised before. “Oh that’s Gregor, he’s really nice!”

“He wasn’t lovely to Melog.”

“It isn’t his fault they have a no-pets rule here. You should apologise to him.”

“I’ll do no such-”

“Hey, Gregor!” Adora says, grabbing my hand and yanking me across. “This is my girlfriend. And she’d like to tell you something.”

“Huh? Oh, hi Adora!” Gregor says, waving and walking over, wiping his hands on his apron. “What’s up?” he asks, nodding at me.

“I wanted to inform you that your no pets thing can kiss my as- Ow, Adora!” I say, pouting. “Fine. I’m sorry for before. They aren’t a pet, they’re a sentient being who can turn invisible and I was feeding them. That’s all.”

“That’s no… problem?” Gregor says, raising one of his thick, bushy eyebrows. “You could have just said. We get weird stuff all the time in this place.”

“Okay. So we’re all good?”

“Sure,” Gregor says, shrugging and putting on a pair of gloves. “What can I get you two?”

--

“So come on,” Glimmer says, sitting next to Adora, stealing a sly glance towards me. “I want details.”

I swallow down my food. “Some things are supposed to be private, Sparkles. And you shouldn’t encourage her, because she will literally tell you everything. In fine detail.”

“Is that supposed to be a bad thing?” Glimmer asks, unwrapping her food.

“Well, if you ask me it is. Bow?” I ask, turning my head to the side.

“I uh well,” he says, grimacing. He leans over to whisper. “They do tell each other everything. I try to keep out of it.”

“So she tells Adora all about your shenanigans?”

“I guess so,” he says, shrugging.

“And you’re okay with that?”

“It doesn’t matter. I still get Glimmer all to myself, and I’m more than okay with that,” he says, beaming.

“Damn right you are,” Glimmer says, her mouth half full.

I bite into my sandwich, watching Adora on the other side of the table as she whispers away to Glimmer. I’d try to stop her, but she looks so beautiful, and so, so happy, that I can’t seem to get mad at her, especially not when I’m the reason she’s happy in the first place.

“You okay?” Bow asks, gently nudging me with his elbow. “I can make them stop if you want.”

“They’re gonna talk about it anyway, right?” I ask, twitching my ears. “At least I can keep an eye on her this way.”

But when Adora sticks her tongue out and points to her chin, and Glimmer’s cheeks turn bright red, it's a step too far.

“Adora,” I huff. “If you’re going to tell her *everything* then you could at least try to be more subtle.”

“Is it true though?” Glimmer asks, her eyes sparkling.

Fine, I’ll play along, I think, slowly sliding my tongue out towards my chin, feeling my cheeks heat up.

“Um wow,” Glimmer says, her eyes turning wide. “No offense Bow, but I think I might need to date a magicat.”

“Hey!” Bow says, pouting. “I try my best.”

Glimmer smirks, and blows a kiss across the table. “Your best is amazing. I’m just playing.”

“Seriously,” I say, pausing with my sandwich an inch from my mouth. “Get a room. Is nothing sacred with you guys?”

“If it’s bothering you we’ll stop,” Glimmer says, sticking her tongue out. “We’re just really happy for you two.”

“If you say so.”

“Sorry,” Adora says, wincing, pressing her fingertips together. “I got over-excited.”

“Wouldn’t be the first time,” I say, raising an eyebrow, my lips curling into a smile just before I bite into my food.

“Haha!” Glimmer laughs. “Catra, are you actually playing along?”

“Maybe. Haven’t decided.”

“Oh, that reminds me,” she says, reaching into a paper bag on the floor, and pulling out a small cardboard box. She places it on the table and flips the lid open. “Surprise!”

Inside the container is a small, round, white cake, with red wavy icing around the border and bold, silver letters in the middle.

I narrow my eyes, reading. “Congrats, you had sex,” I mutter, my cheeks burning. “Seriously?! You idiots actually have a cake for this?”

“We had it custom made,” Bow says, starting to slice through the icing. “We celebrate things like this all the time.”

“You celebrate… other people… having sex…” I say, feeling a vein twitch in my lower eyelid.

“It’s usually more about celebrating love, but Glimmer wanted to mess with you,” Bow says, grinning.

“Oh, you tattletale,” Glimmer says, shooting him dagger eyes.

“Sorry,” Bow says, putting the knife down and turning to face me. “So, was the Horde different?”

“The Horde was… something else,” I say, sighing, folding my ears down. “Haven’t you told them, Adora?”

“Not everything,” she says, her shoulders slumping.

“I know they didn’t celebrate or throw parties,” Bow says, his eyebrows creasing. “But were they uptight about romance too?”

“Romance, hah!” I say, raising my ears. “Shadow Weaver would fling you out on your ass if you said shit like that.”

“Yeah, it was best to keep those things to yourself, honestly,” Adora says, finishing the last bite of her sandwich.

“Or fabricate ghost stories if you had an itch to scratch,” I say, laughing when Adora kicks my shin beneath the table.

“That’s awful,” Bow says, looking as though he’s about to cry. “So you weren’t even allowed to cuddle?”

I scrunch up my nose. “Not really. We were soldiers, end of story.”

Adora bites her lip, catches my gaze and blushes slightly. “We can cuddle now, though.”

“We can definitely cuddle now,” I say, slowly sliding my foot up Adora’s leg, my throat turning dry when I think about all of the *cuddling* we were doing earlier.

Glimmer gasps. “Oh no, I’m taking Adora away from you today!”

“Yeah, thanks for that, Sparkles.”

“I wasn’t thinking. I’m so sorry! Adora, why don’t you just leave it to us?”

“Um…”

I roll my eyes. “No, because then it’ll be my fault if things don’t get done. Besides, Adora’s going to make it up to me later,” I say, pushing my foot further up until my toes rest between her thighs. “Aren’t you, Adora?”

“I uh,” Adora blushes. “I am. I mean, I will,” she says, shuffling ever so slightly until she’s pressed up against my toes. She smiles smugly, as though she thinks she’s won our little game.

“And how do you intend to do that?” I purr, lidding my eyes and resting my elbows on the table, cheeks in my palms. I twitch my big toe. “Be. Specific.”

Adora leans forwards, resting her chin between her hands, staring into my eyes, whispering loudly. “*Well, first I’m going to-*”

“Should we leave you two alone?” Bow asks, wincing. “Glimmer, I feel like we should leave them alone.”

“Oh I don’t know,” Glimmer says. “I’m enjoying this.”

“*-and then I’ll trail my lips along your-*”

“Hmm,” I purr, biting my lower lip, barely aware of anything Bow and Glimmer are saying, only imagining how fantastic it’s going to feel to have Adora’s mouth against me for the first time.

“Cake! Don’t forget we brought cake!” Bow says, shoving the box to the middle of the table.

A sudden waft of sugar distracts me, and I blink a few times, snapping back to reality and quickly removing my foot from Adora’s crotch.

“What just happened?” I ask, blushing.

“Oh wow, Catra’s got it baaad,” Glimmer says, grinning.

“Don’t start that shit again,” I growl, grabbing a piece of cake and lifting it to my nose, where I can smell sugar, lots of it. *We hardly ever got sweet stuff in the Horde*, I think, taking a bite. “Oh. Wow,” I say, my mouth filling with saliva, and my eyes turning wide. “Adora, have you tried this?”

Adora smiles from ear to ear, taking a piece. “It’s good, isn’t it?”

“The Horde didn’t have *cake*?!” Bow says, raising his palms to his cheek. “How are you even alive?”

I frantically finish my slice, then suck the frosting from my fingers. “Got any more?”

Glimmer nods, pushing the last piece forwards. “Have mine. I’m full.”

“Aww thanks Sparkles,” I say, greedily taking the remaining piece. “But you know, stealing Adora from me will cost more than a slice of cake.”

“Oh! Glimmer,” Bow says, reaching into his pocket, “for Catra, remember?”

“Woops, I almost forgot,” Glimmer says, pushing the small leather purse across the table. “You get a salary now, same as Adora.”

“Wait,” Adora says, wiping icing from her cheek. “Don’t I get more for being She-Ra?”

“Nope,” Glimmer says, sticking her tongue out. “Sorry.”

“I’m being paid? For what?” I say, furrowing my brows, peering into the bag and finding dozens of coins, which should be enough to live off for a month or two.

“You’re a royal guard.”

“Pfft, a guard from what?”

Glimmer purses her lips. “You saved me and helped save Etheria, so you’re a royal guard, okay?”

“Hah fine,” I say, swiping the bag, and hooking it into my belt. “I won’t say no to cash. Just don’t expect me to slave around like Adora does.”

“I’m sure we’ll find something else you can do,” Glimmer says, appearing smug.

“Oh, is that so?” I ask, slatting my eyes, leaning back and folding my arms. “You know my tongue is for Adora only, right?”

Glimmer and Adora burst out laughing, and Bow raises his eyebrows.

“Catra,” Adora says, grinning widely. “Are you high on sugar or something?”

“Something like that,” I say, looking into her eyes, and blinking slowly.

Adora smiles softly, then blinks back just as slowly. *Hah, so she finally gets it*, I think, grinning so widely that my jaw aches.

“Well, we’d best get started,” Glimmer says, starting to tidy up. “We have lots to get done.”

“You better not tire her out,” I say, pouting.

Bow laughs. “I’m not sure if that’s even possible.”

“I’ll be fii-ine,” Adora says. She puts our rubbish into a bag, then walks around the table until she’s beside me, where she reaches her hand out. She looks across at Glimmer. “I’ll meet you there, okay?”

“Hmm?” Glimmer says, puckering her lips. “Are you two going for a quick *cuddle*?”

“Hah, no,” Adora says, pouting. “I’m going to show Catra where the gardens are.”

“Oh, Adora,” I say, standing and twisting around, pulling her palm to my chest, and leaning my head back against her shoulder. “That sounds *so* romantic.”

Adora chuckles and kisses my forehead. “I won’t be long.”

--

Adora and I walk towards the center of the palace, pausing at the next intersection. One passage leads into the central gardens, and the other two lead around it, into the north and south halls.

“Perfuma said to meet by the pond,” Adora says, turning to face me. “Try to be nice to her?”

“Hah, I’ll try,” I say, smirking. I place a hand on Adora’s cheek, and kiss her. “Promise you’ll be quick?”

“I’ll work double-time,” Adora says, kissing me back with a smile on her lips. “Come see me as soon as you’re done.”

“Hmm, okay,” I mumble. “What’s Glimmer making you do, anyway?”

“Entrapta figured out a way to salvage clone tech and set up teleporters.”

“Huh?”

“It means we’ll be able to travel between kingdoms, *in the blink of an eye*,” Adora says, holding her hands wide, mimicking Entrapa. “But she needs muscle to set things up.”

“Oh. Neat,” I say, furrowing my brows. “Where will I find you?”

“Third room up the North hall. Can’t miss it.”

“Okay, but if I do come and get you,” I say, wrapping my tail around her thigh, smirking, “then I’ll be taking you straight to bed.”

“You’re a tease,” Adora says, rubbing her thumb across my smile.

“Get used to it.”

“I don’t think I ever will,” she whispers, kissing me quickly, then taking a step back. “Ok. Gotta go. I love you, stargazer.”

I glance around to make sure nobody is in earshot, then fold my arms, grinning. “Don’t make me wait too long, my love.”

Adora’s eyes widen, then she laughs. “Doesn’t count. Nobody heard.”

“You did.”

“Yeah,” Adora says, a light blush creeping to her cheeks. “I did.”

I lean forwards, flatten my palm upon her chest, and kiss her one more time. “Okay, go. Before I change my mind and drag you back to bed.”

Adora bites her lower lip into a smile, before she sharply turns and walks away. She pauses once, turns around to blow me a kiss, and then trips on her own feet and almost falls over. *She’s such an*

idiot, I think, grinning widely.

--

I walk through a large, curved archway into the central gardens, figuring a pond shouldn't be too difficult to find. After taking a few paces I detect a familiar presence following me, and I smile.

"So. You are finally mated?"

I roll my eyes and turn around, crouching. "Hi Melog."

They sniff around me a few times. "I smell her on you."

"Hey! I washed!"

"Adora is all over you. You mated," they say, appearing smug. "More than once."

I blush, darting my eyes around, talking quietly. "Fine. We *mated*," I mutter.

Melog grins widely, and appears to laugh. "This is good. Are you happy?"

"Yes, actually," I say, standing up, folding my arms and smiling smugly. "Though I would have been happier if we could have stayed in bed."

Melog tilts their head. "You have all the time in the world. Savour it."

"Listen to you being all wise," I say, chuckling. I wonder, not for the first time, just how old Melog actually is. "Anyway, I need to do some dumb talking thing. You coming?"

"Talking is not stupid, Catra."

I narrow my eyes. "Yeah. So everyone keeps saying."

I walk a little further and come across a tall hedge wall, with three wide entrances. There's dozens of small peach-coloured tiles embedded into the ground, forming tidy patterns that lead through each archway.

"Hmm, which way?"

"It matters not. They all lead to the center," Melog says, scratching at their ear.

I walk through the central arch. "Pfft, what's the point, then?"

"It is pretty." Melog says, trotting by my side, their claws clicking against the paving stones. "I enjoy napping here."

It's almost like a maze, I think, walking down one of the paths, noticing the canopy overhead thins out the further I walk, until sunlight dances across my face through the branches. Then the path widens out into what can only be described as a Plumerian's wet dream.

"Wow, it's huge," I whisper, looking up at the clear skies above, then scanning the entire square. There's flowers of every colour spanning all directions, and ivy creeping up the surrounding palace walls. In the middle of the grounds there's a large, oval pond, surrounded by white wooden tables and benches, and when I get closer I can see that the water is crystal clear, full of colourful Koi swimming around.

“Ah, Catra!” Perfuma calls out from one of the benches, stands up and hurries over, her golden hair glistening beneath the sun. “It is so good to see you.”

“Um, hi,” I say, looking around nervously at all the other people here.

“How are you feeling?”

“I’m good, but isn’t this place a bit packed for, you know…”

Perfuma smiles broadly. “You needn’t worry about that. Oh, and hello Melog, how are you today?”

Melog purrs and rubs their snout against Perfuma’s hip. “I like this one. She is very kind.”

I pout. “You little traitor.”

“I am very glad you brought Melog along,” Perfuma says, walking past me. “Now, follow me!”

I twitch my ears, watching her walk back along the same path I came in on. “Eh, whatever,” I say, shrugging and trailing just behind her.

Once we’re about halfway back towards the exit, Perfuma pauses in the middle of the path, winks at me and holds her hand out. The thick bushes to the side part open with a quiet groan, forming a doorway, leading into what looks like a fairly deep passageway.

Perfuma steps into the tunnel. “Are you coming?”

“This is weird,” I say, scowling but walking in anyway. A few paces later the tunnel widens up into a small, circular room. There’s thick bushes instead of walls, a grassy, mossy floor, and interlaced branches above, allowing just enough sunlight through to keep the room naturally bright.

“I shall close the tunnel for privacy,” Perfuma says, flicking her wrist, causing the foliage to seal closed. “But if at any time you wish to leave, you need only ask.”

“Wow,” I say, shaking my tail. “What sort of kinky stuff are you planning?”

“Very funny,” Perfuma says, the right side of her lips rising into a smile. “Please, make yourself comfortable,” she continues, waving her hand around the cushions and beanbags scattered around.

I choose the large, yellow, comfy-looking beanbag in the corner of the room. Next to it there’s a small, wooden round table with a jug of water on it, alongside a few stacked glasses.

“Would you like some?” Perfuma asks, pouring a glass.

“Uh, sure,” I say, leaning forwards and taking the cup, while Melog trots over and settles down just next to my seat.

Perfuma sits down on an adjacent cushion and places her hands on her lap, smiling. “Has Adora told you what it is that I do?”

“Yeah. You talk to people.”

“Yes. It’s called therapy. Have you heard of it?” she asks, beaming brightly.

“No but I’ll take a wild guess,” I say, blowing out a puff of hot air, “I just need to learn to love myself, or some bullshit. Right?”

“It’s not quite so simple,” Perfuma says, tilting her head. “We have many, many obstacles to cross first.”

“If you say so.”

“This will be hard, Catra.” Perfuma says, leaning forwards, “and it will be incredibly painful.”

“Well I’m out of other ideas,” I say, shrugging. “So, let’s get it over with,” I say, sinking back into the beanbag, folding one leg over the other.

“Before we continue, I want to assure you that anything we discuss in this room, stays in this room.”

“Good to know.”

“Very well,” Perfuma says, smiling brightly. “Let’s start with a little trivia. Tell me, what do you know about magicats?”

“That’s a very random question,” I say, frowning. I hold up a hand, and start counting off the facts that we were taught back in the Horde, about magicats, and all the other species on Etheria. “One, we’re agile. Two, we’re strong. Three, we heal fast.”

“Yes, all very good,” Perfuma says, interrupting me. “What about your mental attributes?”

“What’s to know? Everyone’s pretty much the same.”

“Well no, not quite.”

“Huh?”

Perfuma holds a hand out and starts counting, mimicking me. “One, Magicats are incredibly emotional. It’s what makes them so proud, and so fiercely loyal.”

I blow out a puff of air. “Whatever.”

“Two, they have heightened senses-”

“I was going to say that,” I say, shrugging. “Fourth on my list. I could probably smell out any flower here, if you asked me to.”

“I am sure you could!” Perfuma explains, grinning toothilly. “But did you know that those heightened senses also affect your base instincts?”

“What do you mean?”

“Well... When something threatens us, our impulse is always to fight, or flee. However, those impulses do vary, especially if you are a hybrid species.”

I stay silent, twitching my left ear, feeling suddenly curious.

“Non-hybrid Etherians are split down the middle on whether they’d stand their ground, or try to escape. It depends on each person and their situation.” Perfuma says, her expression softening. “Scorpioni, being part scorpion, tend to defend themselves,” she continues, her cheeks flushing pink, “or others.”

“Thinking about your girlfriend?” I ask, smirking.

“We are not here to discuss my relationships.”

“I can hear your heart racing. Aww, is someone in lov-”

“Catra.”

“Bah.”

“As I was saying, magicats-”

“Let me guess,” I interrupt. “We run.”

“Typically, yes - just like a cat would! But it’s why you all survive so well.”

“Oh great!” I say, rolling my eyes. “So my people are a bunch of cowards.”

“Survival isn’t cowardice,” Perfuma says, a stern tone to her voice. “Say it back to me.”

“What?” I frown, and Perfuma looks at me expectantly, smiling sweetly. “Uh… survival isn’t cowardice?”

“Very good. Your people are all out there somewhere, very much alive, I’m sure.”

“Because they ran.”

“Yes, from the Horde,” Perfuma says, tilting her head. “Do you hold it against them?”

“Hmm,” I say, narrowing my eyes. “I don’t know any of them. So, no. Why would I care?”

“I suspect you care more than you let on.”

“Ugh whatever,” I say, growing irritable. “So what, you’re going to lecture me on how we’re all cowards and that’s why I run from all my problems, blah blah?”

Melog huffs, their mane shifting colour ever so slightly to an orange hue.

“I’m sorry,” Perfuma sighs, leaning forwards, placing her elbows onto her knees.

“What for?” I ask, stroking Melog’s fur, helping them to settle back down.

“I’m not very experienced at talking to magicats specifically, which is why I did a little research first. If I say things that are inflammatory please just let me know.”

I blow out a puff of air. “It’s fine.”

Perfuma clears her throat. “I was never accusing you of being a coward, Catra. You are exceptionally brave. The fact that you’re here right now tells me this.”

“I don’t see how sitting in a room and chatting is brave.”

“I can assure you it takes real courage to attend these sessions,” Perfuma says, smiling brightly. She straightens her back and raises a finger. “Also, these are all just generalisations; your species does not dictate who you are. Magicats don’t always run from danger, for example.”

“I was gonna say, I’ve always fought.”

“Oh, and don’t we know it,” Perfuma says, wincing. “Interestingly, magicats are almost unstoppable when they choose to fight.”

“Hah yeah we are,” I say, smirking and stretching out my claws, holding them up proudly, “you should have seen what I did to She R-” I gasp, remembering thin streaks of crimson, and Adora crying out in pain. *I don’t even see her as She-Ra anymore. My claws are full of Adora’s blood. Full of it, like it’s pooled so far down the grooves of my nails that I’d never be able to scrub it all out. I love her, so much, and yet she’s bleeding because of me, all because of me...*

“-tra? Are you okay?”

I find myself breathing rapidly, sweating, noticing Melog pacing around, and Perfuma, crouched in front of me.

“I’m fine,” I say, quickly sheathing my claws and balling my hands into tight fists, digging my nails into my palm, willing my heart to slow down. “What were you saying?”

Perfuma’s voice sounds muffled, somehow. “I said I think you’re having a panic attack.”

“What?”

Perfuma places a hand on my shoulder and stares into my eyes, “Listen to me. I want you to close your eyes, and breathe in through your nose while I count.”

I snap my eyes shut and suck air in, until she stops counting.

“Six. Seven. Now out, slowly, through your mouth,” she says, and I exhale. “More slowly than that next time.”

I nod.

“Okay good, now when you breathe in, pull the air down into your diaphragm,” she says, gently taking my hand, and moving it to my gut. “Feel the air filling you up.”

I leave my hand on my gut and inhale through my nose, until my tummy feels huge and my lungs are full.

“Now out again, slowly.”

--

“How are you feeling?” Perfuma asks, gently squeezing my shoulder.

I open my eyes. “Not too bad, actually.” Melog stops pacing, and grunts, sitting down again.

“You just learnt a basic breathing exercise. It can really help with those attacks.”

I arch an eyebrow. “Attacks?”

“Panic attacks,” Perfuma says, patting her hand above her heart. “Your heart beats faster, you feel the walls closing in. You’re terrified and perhaps don’t know why. You might even feel hot, like you need to run, escape.”

“Yeah,” I say, frowning. “Sounds about right.”

“They’re actually quite common, especially in magicats,” Perfuma says, taking a deep breath. “And especially if a person has suffered trauma.”

“I don’t care about any of that,” I say, stroking my palm down my face. “Just tell me how to stop them.”

Perfuma returns to her cushion, pulling it closer to mine before sitting down. “You can start by practising your breathing a few times a day.”

“I’d rather breathe all day if it’s all the same to you.”

“You know what I meant,” Perfuma says, scolding me. “If you feel yourself start to panic, then the first thing I’d like you to do is sit down, and try this technique.”

“And if it doesn’t work?”

“With practise, it usually will, or at the very least it will help. But there are plenty of other things we can try… for example, identifying what triggers the attacks in the first place.”

The room falls silent, and I frown, looking down at my hand. “I remembered something shitty I did, that’s all.”

“Which brings me to,” Perfuma says, holding up three fingers. “Three. Magicats remember things with astonishing clarity.”

“Figures,” I mutter, checking under my nails, feeling sure I can still smell blood on them.

Perfuma pours me another glass of water. “You experienced a painful memory just now, didn’t you?”

I lift my head, meeting her eyes. “It wasn’t my proudest moment.”

Perfuma nods, smiling sadly. “Would you tell me about it?”

“Do I have to?”

“You don’t *have* to do anything,” Perfuma says, shrugging. “I advise that you try, though, since it’s part of the healing process.”

“Ugh,” I pause, scratching against my legging just above my scars. “I remember hurting She-Ra.”

“Are there any specific details that unsettle you?”

“Blood. The stench of it. Adora’s scream. How easily my claws cut through her, like she’s made of paper.”

I shiver, balling my hands into fists, as though I can still feel it happening, again. Melog whines and jumps up, nuzzling their snout against my face.

“Should we stop this?” they ask.

“No. I’m okay.”

“How do you feel while all of this plays out?” Perfuma asks.

“Um,” I say, feeling almost like there’s a glob of wet tar inside my throat. “The whole time we’re fighting, hurting each other, over and over. And I… ugh.”

Perfuma reaches into a drawer beneath the little wooden table, and pulls out a piece of paper, then unfolds it and pushes it in front of me. “Does this help?”

I scan the piece of paper, finding a crude drawing of a circle. In the middle, there’s a few wedges with words like happy, sad, angry written in them… and then an outer circle with more detailed descriptions of each. I focus on the *sad* section.

“I guess... anguish, distress,” I say, moving my fingertip across the other sections, then sighing. “This is dumb.”

“I told you this would be hard.”

“Tsk, fine,” I say, looking at the other sections. “Hate. Loathing. Revulsion. Remorse. Guilt?”

“Would you say that’s how you felt at the time of this incident?”

“Hmm.” I furrow my brows, trying to work it out. “No. Not really.”

Perfuma taps her fingertip on the paper, smiling at me.

I close my eyes and think back, remembering my claws shredding Adora’s back; how I almost laughed at the irony, knowing this was the closest I’d ever get to touching her, knowing I’d never be good enough for her, especially not compared to her new friends. ”Resentment.”

I remember how she rammed me against the cliff wall, and I scrambled away, scratching across her face, knowing for a fact she’d never forgive me after all of this. We’d finally, seriously hurt each other, and there was no turning back, so I’d figured I might as well just get on with it and finish the job. “Hopelessness. Despair.”

“Why?”

“Because I realised I’d lost her, for good.”

“So you loved her, even back then?”

“Always,” I say, folding my ears down.

“Your closest friend, the one you loved dearly, and were most loyal to,” Perfuma says, putting her hand on her chin. “Her leaving would be at best traumatic and at worst... heartbreaking, perhaps even soul-destroying.”

I chuckle. “That’s rather melodramatic, don’t you think?”

“Is it? What happened after Adora left?”

“Oh, you know,” I say, idly twirling my hand, “I tore my room to shreds. Went on a warpath. Pushed all of my friends away. The usual.”

Perfuma thins her lips. “It feels like you aren’t taking this seriously.”

“Ugh, there’s just too much, okay?” I say, scrunching my fingers into my fringe. “I messed up, over and over again, so we’ll be here forever if you want to unpack everything.”

Perfuma shrugs. “It will take as long as it takes. Are you in a hurry?”

“Yes, actually. I want the flashbacks to stop. I want to not feel like I’m gonna die any time something freaks me out.”

“The breathing will certainly help with that, as will the other techniques I’ll teach you.”

“So there’s no quick win?”

“A quick win to undo years of torment at the hands of the Horde, followed by your heart being shattered?” Perfuma folds her eyebrow down, smiling sadly. “Catra, to heal all of this is going to take time.”

I flatten my ears completely and lean forwards, resting my elbows on my knees. “I just want to get better,” I whisper. “For her.”

“And it’s my job to make you want to get better, for yourself,” Perfuma says, smiling brightly.

“Hah, here we go,” I say smirking, lifting an ear up. “Is this the self-love part?”

“Actually,” Perfuma says, taking a deep breath. “The first thing we’d have to do is work on your self-hatred.”

“Oh yeah, I’ve got lots of that,” I say, scrunching up my nose. Melog whines, and I pat them reassuringly.

“You use humour as a defense,” Perfuma says. She leaves her chair, walks over and sits down on the ground in front of me, crossing her legs. “But your recent injury is no laughing matter, wouldn’t you agree?”

“What!” I snap. “Who told you?”

“I’ve had two extremely concerned friends tell me you had several lacerations on your thigh. Claw marks, deep enough that they needed stitches.”

“Adora should learn to keep her mouth shut,” I mumble.

“No,” Perfuma says, shaking her head. “Adora didn’t say anything.”

“Yeah well, it’s all healed now. No big deal.”

“It is a big deal,” Perfuma says. “You severely injured yourself.”

“So?”

“Could you tell me how it happened?”

“No.”

“That’s okay. Have you hurt yourself before?”

“No,” I say, frowning. “Not like that.”

“But you have hurt yourself.”

I fold my arms and slump back in the beanbag, turning away. “What does it matter?”

“You matter.”

Her words sting, but I can’t work out why, so I just shrug, biting back tears. “If you say so.”

“You matter.”

I laugh. ”Heard you the first time, flower girl.”

“Say it back to me.”

“What?”

“That you matter.”

I narrow my eyes. “No.”

“Why is this so hard for you?”

“Because it’s bullshit,” I mumble under my breath.

“I didn’t quite catch that. Why is it so hard for you to accept that you matter?”

“BECAUSE I DON’T!” I snap, quickly taking a deep breath to calm Melog. “So just leave it.”

Perfuma remains silent for a while, her arms folded, appearing deep in thought. “Can I ask you something?” she eventually asks.

“Would it matter if I said no?”

“When you hear a voice saying you don’t matter. Who’s voice is it?”

“What?” I ask, shaking the tip of my tail. “What sort of a dumb-”

“Who’s voice is it? Who is saying those words to you? Who is making you feel so small, so worthless?”

I clench my jaw, hearing *her* voice suddenly, so clearly.

I’m lucky that the Horde took me in, lucky that they feed me. I’m a waste of space, a waste of time.

“Is it your own voice?” Perfuma asks, staring. “Or someone else's?”

I’m not good enough. I’m not worth anything. I’m a distraction, always holding Adora back.

I grind my teeth together, fighting back tears. “Someone else.”

I’m selfish.

I’m incompetent.

I’m a failure.

“Is this person still in your life?”

“No,” I growl. “She’s dead.”

“Yet her words still hold power over you.”

I close my eyes and take a few deep breaths, practising the whole dumb breathing thing, surprised to find it actually does help. “Seems that way,” I say, opening my eyes. “How do I get her out of my head?”

“Well first, you need to recognise when she’s speaking through you.”

“Huh?”

“For example,” Perfuma says, holding a finger up, “telling yourself something mean when you look in the mirror.”

“Oh yeah I do that all the time,” I chuckle, then wince at Perfuma’s stern gaze. “Oh wait, not funny. Right.”

“Then, you replace it with-”

“Something nice? Like how pretty I am?” I ask, puckering my lips.

Perfuma smiles sadly. “I warned you that this wouldn’t be easy. But you must take it seriously, otherwise we may as well end the session.”

I dip my ears down and slump my shoulders. “Sorry. Carry on.”

“Very well,” Perfuma says, beaming. “I want you to tell me a typical thing that you tell yourself. A bad thing.”

“That’s easy,” I shrug. “I’m a monster.”

“What a terrible thing to say,” Perfuma says, appearing crestfallen. “Can you imagine telling a friend such a thing? That they’re a monster?”

“No, but-”

“So that is where we’ll start. We’re going to get you onto friendship terms, with yourself.”

“Pfft.”

“Catra.”

“Fine. How?”

“Stop yourself the second you hear it. Replace it with… something neutral, a fact. Instead of ‘monster’, try ‘person’. Or ‘magicat’.”

“Tell myself I’m a magicat?” I ask, smirking.

“Yes. It is neither positive nor negative, and it is the indisputable truth, “ Perfuma says. “You get the idea. Replace insults with facts. I’m a magicat. I have two eyes.”

“Seems a bit silly.”

“You’ve told me more than once that you want to heal, and I believe you. But you also need to believe in me.”

I take a deep breath, and look down at Melog, ruffling their fur.

“Her advice has been sound so far,” they say, nuzzling into my hand. “And she has already helped you understand many things.”

“Okay, I’ll try,” I say, sighing. “Sorry for being difficult.”

Perfuma’s face lights up and she straightens her back, then unfolds her legs. “It is quite alright. Would you be willing to come and see me tomorrow?”

“So soon?”

“We have a lot to go through.”

“But we’re done for today?”

“Almost,” Perfuma says, opening her palm. A small, pink flower blossoms there and she stands up, then threads it into my hair. “A cherry blossom. Adora’s favourite.”

“Oh. Thanks,” I say, smiling.

Perfuma steps away, and flicks her hand, opening the doorway. “Tomorrow we’ll learn all about gratitude,” she says, clapping her hands together. “Please contact me on Adora’s communicator if you need any help in the meantime.”

“Yeah, um, thanks again.”

“You are most welcome,” Perfuma says, holding a hand open towards the door.

Melog steps through, and I follow just behind. *I don’t know what I was expecting*, I think, my head still reeling, *but it wasn’t that*.

Chapter End Notes

Scorpia: That's my girl... I'm so proud of her that I could just burst!
Catra: Please don't.
Perfuma: She can burst if she wants to. Go right ahead, darling.

BONUS: look at this amazing scene from JustPigeonBlue!

I also drew something on my blog)! Catra needs a hug.

Friendship and Flirting

Chapter Summary

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Melog and I exit the gardens, leaving through the northern archway.

“Did the talking help?” Melog asks.

“I’m not sure yet,” I say, shrugging, “but it was interesting.”

“Magicats are very curious creatures. Did you know this?”

“Seriously,” I ask, rolling my eyes. “Does everyone know more about me than I do?”

Melog huffs, as though laughing. “It appears so.”

We walk further up the north hall, and I hear the commotion long before I walk into the massive room. There are seven large, silver pads placed along the floor near the far wall, almost half of which are fitted with tall, silver beams, stacked in sets of three in a triangle formation. The ceiling is higher up than usual, and the floor appears as though almost black, covered with what feels like a rubber lining.

Where is she? I think, looking around.

“Adora is here somewhere,” Melog says, sniffing. They wander off, following their nose, while I look around.

I spot Glimmer rummaging through a crate, Hordak and the clones doing who only knows what at the partially-built teleporters, and Entrapta hunched down under a u-shaped control panel near the center of the room, busy with a blowtorch. It reminds me of the state Darla was in, with junk all over the place, and various piles of metal crates stacked so high that they almost reach the ceiling.

“Oh, Catra!” Entrapta says, cutting off her torch and lifting her helmet up. “What do you think? We’re making excellent progress!”

I frown, looking across at the teleporters. “Looking good. But why seven?”

“I’m glad you asked!” Entrapta exclaims, moving from beneath the workstation, and raising herself up on her pigtails. “We’re building one for each of the other six kingdoms, and one for the Crimson Wastes!”

“So, uh...” I say, my words catching in my throat when an eight-foot Adora strides into view from behind the mountain of crates. She’s carrying a giant metal rod over one shoulder, and her back muscles are visibly shifting beneath the weight.

“Is everything okay?” Entrapta asks, leaning forwards and peering at me. “Your pupils are dilated. Are you unwell?”

“I’m fine,” I say, swallowing thickly. “Do you really think this will all work?”

“Absolutely. We’re finishing the connection to Dryl first, to try it out. I’m so excited!”

“Hmm, makes sense. I guess you haven’t been home for a while.”

“Oh I’m sure it’s all okay. Now that the Horde are gone, my babies will be looking after the place like usual.”

“A kingdom run by robots,” I say, shaking my head. “What could possibly go wrong?”

“Run by Artificial Intelligence, actually!” Entrapta says, holding a finger up. “It’s a very similar program to the one I gave to Emily, isn’t it girl?” she says, grinning when the large, round bot scuttles over and beeps excitedly.

“I don’t get it though, if you’re setting up for all six kingdoms, does that mean…”

“The Scorpioni are reclaiming the Fright Zone,” Hordak interjects, dropping a crate next to the computer terminal.

“Oh…” I say, my ears dipping slightly. “I guess Scorpia will be headed back there soon, then.”

“How can she do that when she’ll be in *space*?” Entrapta says, her eyes gleaming. She looks at me, eventually registering my confused expression. “Oh. Sorry. We spoke for quite a while, and they’re coming with us! Isn’t that great?!”

“Who’s they?” I ask, arching an eyebrow. Adora catches me staring, grins widely and winks before lowering the chunk of metal in place. She rotates the beam in one direction, until it clicks loudly.

“Her and Perfuma, silly,” Glimmer says, bumping past me with a few cables in her hand, then passing them to Entrapta. “Are these the ones?”

“Perfect!” she says, grabbing them and slapping her visor back down.”Oh, and thanks!”

“Well, the more the merrier, I guess,” I say, staring as Adora flicks her long, golden ponytail over her shoulder, then tightens up the other giant poles, her biceps straining at the effort.

“Seems we found her,” Melog says, appearing by my side, then peering up at me. “I am sensing that you wish to mate again.”

“Don’t start,” I mutter, feeling my cheeks redden.

“Are you okay?” Glimmer asks, waving a hand in front of me. She follows my gaze, then shakes her head, chuckling. “Is someone getting a little distracted?”

“I’m… Yeah. Uh, when are we going?” I ask, twitching the end of my tail. Adora wipes the back of her palm against her forehead, looks directly at me, and smirks. “Into space I mean,” I say, my heart racing.

“The work on Darla is well ahead of schedule,” Hordak says, opening the lid on his crate. He pauses to look up at me, his green glowing eyes causing the fur on my tail to rise. “It should be completed by tomorrow, thanks to the help from my brothers.”

“Oh yes,” Entrapta says, her voice muffled behind her mask. “Between them and Dumpling, our pace has almost tripled!”

“Hah! So the name stuck? “Where is he, anyway?”

“Usually in the kitchen,” Glimmer says, before turning around and walking over to the mountains of crates. “He practically lives there now!”

Hordak takes a screwdriver from the box, and stands up. “Dumpling has acquired quite a fondness over baked goods,” he says, starting to tighten one of the panels on the computer. His lips almost form a smile. “Perhaps one day he will defeat all the other chefs on Etheria, and reign supreme as the master chef!”

“Wow, never thought I’d see you two having a semi-normal conversation,” Adora says. *She’s standing right behind me*, I think, my heart pounding with excitement. I can feel the heat radiating from her, and smell her scent all around, probably from sweat.

I turn around to face her, forcing myself to breathe normally. “Hey, Adora.”

“Hey baby,” Adora says, grinning from ear to ear.

“Baby? Pfft,” I say, scrunching up my nose, laughing, “since when?”

“I don’t know,” Adora says, shrugging. “It just slipped out.”

“Aww, is someone a little love drunk from earlier?” I purr, standing on my toes and lifting a finger beneath her chin. The next thing I know I’m hoisted up from beneath my thighs until I’m staring straight into Adora’s beautiful blue eyes.

“I think I might be,” she whispers. Her forehead is beaded with sweat, loose strands of golden hair are stuck to her skin, and I can’t take my eyes off of her.

“Hmm. Is that so?” I ask, wrapping my arms around her shoulders, feeling my heart throb, barely even noticing that she’s carrying me to a quiet corner of the room

She holds my back against a wall, and presses her nose against mine. “Yes. I’ve been thinking about you all day.”

I glance down at her lips, purring. “Have you, now?”

“Can you stop playing it cool for one second?” Adora asks, pouting. “I’ve really missed you!”

“Fine,” I say, leaning forwards, cupping the back of her head in my hands, and kissing her hungrily. *I missed you too*, I think, parting my lips, seeking her tongue, and groaning at the contact. “Better?” I ask, pausing only to catch my breath.

“Uhuh,” Adora says, peering at my lips through lidded eyes. She captures my mouth in another greedy, open-mouthed kiss, and I suddenly realise *who* I’m kissing, the revelation forcing a moan from my throat. It’s Adora, with her taste and her smell, but it’s also She-Ra who’s making those sounds, Sh- Ra who’s squeezing her fingers into my thighs, She-Ra who so clearly wants me, needs me, and my mind reels with thoughts of what I could do. *I could so easily tease her,* I think, *I could have her writhing under me, begging me not to stop*. I growl at that particular mental image, tightening my legs around her waist, driving my hips forwards, and digging my nails into the skin behind her neck.

Adora groans in response, the sound reverberating down my own throat, and I feel the rest of the world just slip away, barely even conscious of my own hands, sliding down her torso, ready to prise apart that annoying armour-

Suddenly there’s a loud crash from across the room, and I snap to my senses.

“Huh?” I gasp, feeling dizzy, panting against Adora’s lips, my cheeks burning red hot when I realise how close I came to shredding her clothes off.

Adora’s lips curl into a smug little smile. “That was some kiss.”

“Shit-shit-shit,” I mutter, peering around behind her shoulders. “Did anyone see?” Glimmer catches my stare and shakes her head, smiling, while the clones, Hordak and Entrapta seem too preoccupied to have noticed anything. I breathe out a long puff of air.

“Did someone get carried away?” Adora says, her smug smile spreading. “Is that your way of saying you missed me too?”

“Hah, get over yourself,” I say, narrowing my eyes. “You’re such a pain in my ass.”

Adora grins goofily, then peers upwards and widens her eyes. “Oh! Pretty!” she says, raising a hand to my fringe, and running a finger along my little pink cherry blossom. “Did Perfuma make it?”

I nod. “She said they’re your favourite.”

“It suits you,” Adora says smiling, “and they’re definitely my favourite now.”

“Thanks,” I whisper, tucking a few messy strands of Adora’s hair behind her ear, then tipping my forehead to hers,“Hey, how about we go out on a date tonight?”

Her eyes widen, “I’d love that! We can eat out!”

“Pfft, haha!”

“No, not like that,” Adora says, raising an eyebrow. “Well I mean, maybe that as well.”

“Both are good,” I say, laughing. “But are you ever going to put me down?”

“Are you sure you want me to?” Adora purrs, sliding one of her hands beneath my shirt, and stroking it up my back.

Her touch makes me burn up all over again, makes me want to tease her more than ever, and I flick my tail along her arm. “What I want is,” I growl, leaning towards her ear, “to have my tongue inside of you, right now.”

Adora groans, and I feel her fingers dig into my back. “That’s not fair.”

“Isn’t it? Maybe you shouldn't have volunteered for such a long, boring job,” I huff, tightening my arms around her shoulders, and breathing hotly against her neck. “Maybe that kiss would have gone a very different way if you’d stayed in our room like I *asked* you to.”

“But, I-” Adora whispers, her eyes lidded, her cheeks flushed pink, “I had to…”

I notice her heart racing, and I smirk, running my thumb slowly across her lower lip. “Aww, am I making you regret your terrible decisions?”

“Adora, come on,” Glimmer yells, laughing. “You two can make out all you want later, okay?”

Adora groans miserably and squeezes her eyes closed, shaking her head. “I’m sorry. I’ll probably be another hour.”

“Fine,” I grumble, as Adora puts me down. “Then I’ll just have to entertain myself.”

Adora’s lips straighten into a thin line, and I whip my tail against her thigh.

“Oh and Adora,” I say, waving as I head towards the door, “try not to tire yourself out too much.”

--

Melog walks alongside me, appearing deep in thought. Eventually, curiosity gets the better of me, and I reach my hand down, ruffling their fur.

“What’s up, buddy?”

“I was wondering if mating with Adora would be the same as mating with She-Ra.”

“Pfft! Haha!” I laugh, then bend down to face them. “You just never stop, do you?”

“They are the same person, I suppose. But,” Melog tilts their head, “one of them is so much bigger.”

“Between you and me,” I whisper, leaning closer to their ear, “I can’t pretend I haven’t thought about it.”

Melog huffs, their jaw raising into a smile. “Is that why you almost mated with her just now?”

“Ugh, so you saw?” I ask, running my palm down my face, feeling my cheeks burn, “I don’t know what came over me.”

“You are in love.”

“Yeah,” I sigh. “I’ve got it bad, haven’t I?”

“It is the same for her.”

“Really?”

“Adora would do anything for you.” they say, butting their head into my thigh. “I do not understand why you would doubt her feelings.”

“I… I don’t,” I say, shaking my head. “It’s not that. I guess it’s all just a little scary, or at least it is when I overthink things. I mean I’ve never just… lost myself like I do with her, you know?”

Melog’s eyes glow a little brighter. “You are being far more open about these matters now. It is nice.”

“Hmm, so I am,” I say, frowning. “I guess everyone’s rubbing off on me.”

Melog puffs a loud blast of air from their nostrils. “I thought only Adora rubbed off on-”

“Okay, boundaries, Melog. Boundaries.”

I stand up and rest my hands on my hips, looking up and down the halls, wondering what to do to kill time. Then my fingers brush past a small bump on my waist, which jingles at the touch. “Oh, that’s right!” I say, grinning. “Melog, we have money! I forgot!”

Melog gently wags their tail. “This is a good thing?”

“We can buy stuff, I’m totally gonna buy stuff. Come on.”

“You seem excited,” they say, trotting alongside me.

“I can finally buy Adora more pillows!” I say, beaming. “I hope the stall I found is still there.”

--

The market is busier than last time, and for a moment I feel anxious, knowing that there’s bound to be people around here who despise me, or any other ex-horde for that matter.

“You have me,” Melog says, peering up at me.

“True,” I say, smiling, feeling a little better. “Okay, so, I think it was in this direction,” I say, heading down one of the cobbled streets, trying not to get distracted along the way by all the nik-naks for sale.

A few paces later the woman at the figurine stall waves me over, so I oblige, pricking my ears up while I study the various little figures. “I made a new one,” she says, passing a tiny model across. “What do you think?”

“I think you’re giving Bow a run for his money,” I say, twisting the model around between my fingers.

“Hah, who do you think taught him?” she says, smiling proudly, her brown skin creasing into wrinkles. “He does well, but he doesn’t capture the finer details. Such a thing takes patience.”

“Yeah, I can see that,” I say, smiling. I hold the figure up in front of Melog, showing them. “What do you think?”

“It is the two of us!” They exclaim, parting their lips into a toothy smile. “My mane looks perfect.”

“I like the costume,” I say, studying the vibrant white and yellow cloak over my figurine's shoulder, which half-covers the crimson short-sleeved shirt beneath. “Looks like it really suits me.”

“Thank you, dear!” the woman says, tucking a few strands of her white, wispy hair behind her bejewelled ear. “You know, you could always ask the tailors to make it for you.”

“Good to know, thanks,” I say, passing the figure back, and reaching for my purse. “Hey, I never caught your name.”

“It’s Lilly. Oh, you want it?”

“Of course! I actually have money this time!” I say, beaming proudly.

--

“So much for not getting distracted,” I say, wincing as I struggle to carry eight bags at once, all piled up in my arms. “I guess I can’t accuse Adora of buying random shit anymore…”

“At least you managed to find the pillows,” Melog says, carrying two bags by their handles in his jaw, and a larger one alongside their head, floating within a blue glow.

I struggle along the pathway leading to the north palace entrance, apologising to people along the way when my bags bump against them.

“Catra! Hey! Is that you under there?” Scorpia’s voice calls out, and a pair of pincers appear before me, parting the mountain of shopping. “It is you! Great! Let’s grab a drink!”

“Hi Scorpia,” I say, smiling. “Uh, sure, I think I have time. But where?”

“We’re right next to the place,” she says, taking half of my bags from me.

“Thanks. Oh yeah, didn’t see it,” I say, looking at the small stall tucked away in a corner of the street. There’s a sign above it depicting drawings of lemons, apples and other fruits, and a couple of sets of tables and chairs placed around the front.

“I’m surprised you could see anything behind all that,” Scorpia says, smiling as she sits on one of the peach-coloured chairs. “It’s such a hot day, isn’t it? I’m parched!”

The man behind the counter smiles and waves. “You girls want a sharing pitcher?”

“Sounds good,” I say, sitting down. “Um, what flavour?”

Scorpia leans forwards, loudly whispering, “The peach isn’t great, but the lemon is fantastic!”

“Hah, Lemon it is then,” I say, reaching for my coins. “It’s on me.”

“Oh, hey, thanks!”

The man walks to our table and places a round silver tray there, with a large glass pitcher and two glasses on it. He smiles, bows and walks back to the stall.

“Um, would you mind?” Scorpia says, holding up her pincers, shrugging. “Sorry, you know I’m no good at delicate stuff.”

“Hah, lucky Perfuma,” I say. I grab the jug and pour our drinks, noticing that Scorpia has gone quiet, and appears a little crestfallen. “Was it something I said?”

Scorpia gingerly takes a glass between two claws, and starts to drink without spilling a drop, peering over the rim of the glass at me.

“It’s not like you to be so quiet. Spit it out, idiot,” I chuckle, taking a swig of my drink, then smacking my lips from the tanginess. “Mmm! It’s good!”

She blushes. “Um. We haven’t… you know. Done anything like that.”

I dip my ears slightly. “Oh. Sorry.”

“I’m a little worried, what with all this going on,” Scorpia says, looking down at her pincers and spiked armour carapace, then sighing. She tilts her head back, lifting up her tail. “And that.”

“Have you spoken to Perfuma about it?”

“She says not to worry, because there are lots of ways to…” Scorpia says, blushing a deeper shade of pink, “well, you know. But she doesn’t want to rush me.”

I grimace. “I’m not exactly the best person to ask about this stuff.”

“Sorry… sorry. Just forget I said anything.”

“Look, I don’t mind talking about it,” I say, taking another sip of my juice. “But I’m kind of learning the ropes myself. Adora knows wayyy more than me.”

“Really? Wow.”

“Yeah,” I say, grinning, “Oh! And guess what!” I say, leaning forwards and slapping my hands on the table. “She’s the night wailer!”

“Really? Adora? Those were some scary noises, now that I think about it,” Scorpia says, then taps a pincer to her chin. “But, why would she mess with us like that? Wow, sometimes it went on for an hour!” Scorpia says, laughing. “She must have *really* had it in for us.”

I snort out a laugh, “No, Scorpia,” I say, wiggling my fingers. “Let’s just say she was having a very good time, with herself.”

“Oh. Oh!” Scorpia’s cheeks redden. “Well, not like that’s ever been a choice for me,” she says, glumly.

“Hmm,” I say, pouring us each another glass, then peering around to make sure nobody is in earshot. “Would it cheer you up if I told you Adora enjoyed my mouth?” I ask, feeling myself blush at the memory. “As in really, *really* enjoyed it?”

“Your mouth?”

I smirk, then stretch my tongue out.

“Oh. Wow.”

“Fascinating,” Melog says, their ears pointed upwards. “That is a very long tongue.”

“Melog! Go back to sleep!” I say, groaning, placing my palm over my face. “Look, even from my limited experience, I’ve got to say I pretty much agree with Perfuma.”

“Really?”

“Yes but,” I say, shrugging, “you need to talk to her some more. Seriously. You’ll work it out. And your pincers are probably not as big a deal as you think they are.”

Scorpia smiles from ear to ear. “Wow, look at us! Talking about our girlfriends, like we’re best buds at last. I always knew we’d get here one day, I just never thought it’d be outside of the Horde.”

“Pfft. Sure,” I say, smirking, and tilting my chair back onto two legs. “You know, I actually thought you had a crush on me back then.”

“Hah, no,” Scorpia grins awkwardly. “I mean, maybe a little. But we all knew you loved Adora, so…”

“Wait, what?!” I ask, my chair falling back down onto all four legs.

“Yikes! Oh no. I should *not* have brought that up,” Scorpia says, placing a pincer over her lips. “I’m sorry. Me and my big mouth. And this was going so well, too.”

“*Everyone* knew?”

Scorpia winces. “Well, I guess everyone apart from you two… I mean you kept drawing Adora all the time, and there was the way you looked at her, and the way she looked at you,” she continues, tilting her head from one side to the other. “Then there was that time when we were kids, and I caught you drawing a picture of her with lots of hearts everywhere. You ripped up the paper and got really angry, don’t you remember?”

Melog snorts, and I frown at them as they roll around on their back across the concrete tiles, clearly laughing.

“Ugh, unbelievable. And pack it in, Melog.”

Scorpia grimaces. “Well, at least it all worked out in the end, right?”

“I guess,” I say, folding my ears down when I remember, quite clearly, that I did in fact draw Adora with love hearts all over the place, and I did get angry when Scorpia caught me, and of course I had to threaten her, because that's what I always do. *You tell anyone, and you’re dead*.

“You look sad. Don’t be sad. It’s all history now, and everything’s just great!”

“Just give me a minute,” I say, leaning forwards, folding my arms above the table, and taking a few deep breaths.

Melog stands up and rests their snout on my thigh. “You seem anxious.”

“I’m okay, Melog,” I say, ruffling their fur, then looking up at Scorpia. “So here’s the thing,” I say, lightly scratching at my forearm. “I want to apologise... you know, for treating you so badly. It was all pretty much unforgivable, but I’m still sorry. For everything.”

“Hey, you were going through a thing. Or actually, lots of things, all at once, all the time. I get it,” Scorpia says, beaming. “Living in the Horde was rough! And Shadow Weaver was always so much meaner to you than the rest of us...”

“That doesn’t excuse all the shit I’ve done,” I say, running my finger around the rim of my glass. “But I’ll make it up to you someday.”

“You already have,” Scorpia says, before finishing her drink. “All I ever really wanted was to be your friend, and now I get to be! Look at us, sharing drinks, talking, *bonding*,” she says, leaning forwards and winking.

“Hah, you loon,” I say, shaking my head. “Oh, that reminds me.”

“Hmm?”

“I heard you and flower girl are joining us on our little adventure?”

“We are!” Scorpia says, grinning. “Entrapta says there’s loads of room on the ship now, and it’s something Perfuma and I have always wanted to do. Actually, it was mainly her idea, but I’m excited too.”

“Huh. I wonder why she wants to go out there,” I ask, thinking out loud as I look up to the sky.

“She said she wants to see the stars and discover new plants on all those cra-aazy planets,” Scorpia says, widening her eyes. “I heard the last one you went on kind of erupted, but I’m sure we’ll have better luck!”

I tilt my head to one side, frowning. “Okay. I get you not wanting to go back to the Fright Zone, what, after your family sold you out and all,” I say, wincing apologetically when her smile fades. “But doesn’t Perfuma have a kingdom to run?”

“Oh I don’t really get into politics and stuff, you know me,” Scorpia says, smiling sweetly. “I think she said something about her sister taking over, though.”

“Huh, she has a sister?”

“Four actually! She’s the second oldest.”

“Your face lights up whenever you talk about her,” I say, smirking. “Scorpia, are you in love?”

She beams at me and presses the tips of her pincers together. “I am. She makes me so happy, sometimes I think I might actually explode.”

“That sounds messy,” I say, chuckling. “Anyway, I’m happy for you both.”

Scorpia smiles softly. “I’m happy for you too, Wildcat.”

I yawn loudly, hiding the fact that for some reason I’m almost crying, then stand up and stretch out my arms. “Let’s do this again, okay?”

“Definitely!” Scorpia says, placing the tips of her pincers beneath her chin, her eyes sparkling. She starts to pick up the bags, but I walk up to her and grab her arm, stopping her.

“Hey, where’s my hug?” I ask, twitching my left ear.

Scorpia sniffles, her eyes turning watery before she places her pincers gently around my back, and pulls me in for an unusually soft embrace. “Thanks, Catra. You’re a good friend.”

Not yet, I think. *But I will be*.

--

A short while later, I place an additional eight pillows on the back of the bed, spreading them out evenly along the headrest. Each one is a different colour and shape, but my personal favourite is the small round one with a golden star in the middle.

“Think this will be enough?” I ask, looking down at Melog.

They frown. “You only have one head each, do you not?”

“It’s an Adora thing, apparently,” I say, shrugging. “I hope she likes it.”

I unpack the rest of my bags, placing the Catra-Melog statue onto the dresser so that Adora will see it later, and putting the various snacks I want to try there too. Then I open the wardrobe doors and put away two new crimson tops, a thin, black overshirt, new underwear, three new pairs of purple leggings that I’ll need to cut a tail-hole into, and a long, red, sleeveless dress for Adora, which I put up onto a hangar.

“Okay, she better be finished by now,” I say, throwing the bags away, and heading outside of the room, pausing when I notice Melog stops, and sits down.

“Hey, what’s up?” I ask, peering down.

“I feel the urge to go and chase birds,” they say, smirking.

“Is that your way of saying you don’t want to be a third wheel?”

Melog snorts. “Perhaps.”

“You’re surprisingly considerate sometimes.”

“There is no way you will mate with She-Ra if I am present.”

“Oh, so you’re just being a pervert. Should’ve known,” I say, rolling my eyes. “Okay, I’ll see you later, buddy.”

“Enjoy your date,” Melog says, nuzzling their jaw into my hand, before turning around and walking down the hall in the opposite direction.

--

I’m almost all the way back to the teleporter room, when Adora suddenly steps into view, walking out of the doorway. She turns in my direction, and her lips stretch into the widest, sweetest smile. “Catra!” she exclaims, striding towards me.

I don’t even have time to respond, because her lips are already on mine, and her fingers are threaded into my hair. I savour the long, sweet kiss, sliding my hands up her back, grateful that she's no longer in her eight foot tall form.

“Hmm, so you missed me again?” I ask, nudging my nose to hers.

“At least I don’t mind admitting it,” Adora says, pouting.

I roll my eyes. “Fine. I missed you too.”

Adora grins and takes my hand, and before I know it I'm being led back down the hall. "So how was it? Did Perfuma help? Is it too soon to say? WIll you be talking to her again?"

"Wow, what's gotten you so wired?" I ask, chuckling. "So many questions, so little time."

"Are you going to answer any of them?"

"It was good. I think it helped. We're supposed to be talking again tomorrow. Any further questions?"

"Yes. Are we still going on a date?" Adora aks, grinning widely. "I'm starving."

"Let me guess. Crusty crab."

"Haha! It's cranky," Adora says, giggling. "But yes. I'm so hungry I could eat everything in the whole world, twice over."

"*Everything?*" I ask, smirking.

Adora wiggles her eyebrows. "Well, if you're offering…"

"Hah, we'll see," I say, nudging my shoulder against hers, trying to ignore how quickly my heart is beating.

--

We arrive back at our room, where Adora walks in ahead of me. A second later she suddenly gasps, loudly.

"Pillows!" she exclaims, diving onto the bed, and burying herself into the various cushions. "Where did they come from?!"

I laugh, closing the door behind myself. "I told you I'd entertain myself," I say, shrugging.

Adora sits up, her eyes suddenly damp. "You went and got these, for me?"

"Pfft, stop overreacting," I say, shaking my head, walking towards the bed. "Glimmer said you liked pillows, I finally have cash, the rest is history."

"Catra…"

"What?" I ask, blushing, stroking my hand behind my neck. "It's no big deal."

Adora gathers the pillows up in a pile, then shows a slightly manic grin. "Wanna know the real reason I love pillows?"

I arch an eyebrow, and shake my tail, wondering where this is going.

"Ammunition," Adora says, a smirk creeping across her lips, and just a second later she hurls one of the cushions straight at my face, which I neatly dodge.

"Oh, it's on!" I yell, leaping forwards and stealing as many pillows from her mountain as I can, before retreating below the end of the bed.

A couple of seconds later there's a bright glow, and Adora appears over the edge, wild eyed, eight foot tall, and with two pillows in each hand.

“No! That’s cheati- AH!” I yell, leaping away from her vicious quadruple-attack, rolling across the floor and flinging two pillows right at her smug She-Ra face. “Stop turning into She-Ra just cos you’re scared I’ll kick your ass!”

“Spoilsport,” Adora says, shrugging and quickly shrinking back down. She picks up two pillows from the carpet and swings them down at me, but I raise my feet and push my heels into the incoming cushions, kicking Adora away, then jumping to my feet and swiping my remaining pillow in a wide arc, smacking her straight in the jaw.

“Ooof!” she says, falling flat on her ass.

“Shit, sorry!” I say, wincing, crawling over to her, running my palm over her jaw, checking to see if I hurt her. “You know I get carried away when we spar.”

“It’s too late,” Adora gasps, placing her palm against her forehead. “I’m done for.”

I bat her hand away, chuckling. “You’re such an idiot.”

“But you love me anyway?”

“Of course I do, dummy,” I say, leaning down, lacing my fingers between hers, and kissing her slowly, gently, then lightly nipping her lower lip between my teeth.

“Hmm,” Adora smiles, raises her head and steals another kiss, this time parting her lips to search for my tongue, and when she finds it we both gasp. The kiss grows hungrier, more desperate, until I’m almost crawling out of my skin with how badly I need to touch her.

How does she keep doing this to me, I think, my heart pounding in my chest while I lose all sense of control, interlacing my legs with hers, kissing her more urgently, relishing in the groans I can so easily coax from her. I tug at her jacket, suddenly painfully aware of how many clothes we have on.

But then her belly grumbles, and it’s so insanely loud that I quickly withdraw from her lips, bursting into laughter.

Adora laughs too, then rests her weight on her elbows and bites her lip. Her blonde hair is hanging out from her tie in messy strands, her cheeks appear flushed, and my laughter dies in my throat because I realise, maybe for the first time, how absolutely breathtaking she is.

“Sorry,” she says, wincing. “But I might actually die if I don’t eat soon.”

I blow out a long puff of air, then shake my head quickly, trying to clear the daze. “Come on, let’s get you fed,” I say, grinning, standing to my feet and holding my hand out.

“Yay!” Adora says, beaming. “You haven’t seen the leisure plaza yet, have you?”

“There’s a plaza?” I ask, arching an eyebrow.

“Yes,” Adora says, heading to her wardrobe, pulling her jacket off, then lifting her vest over her head and unclipping her bra. “Full of restaurants, bars, cafes, it’s...” she says, shuffling through her hangers, pausing to look at me, bright eyed, “amazing! You’ll love it!”

“We’re getting dressed up?” I ask, watching her, licking my lips at the display of flesh and muscle as she sorts through the hangars. “I bought you something, by the way.”

“Oh?”

“Keep looking.”

“Oh, wow,” Adora gasps, pulling the dress down and examining it. “I love it! Look at you, spoiling me.”

“I didn’t buy myself anything fancy though,” I say, stepping next to her, bumping her out of the way, and rummaging through my clothes, “just more of the same old stuff.”

“You seriously got me this, and didn’t treat yourself?” Adora asks, shrugging into the long red dress, then flattening it down with her palms. *Wow*, I think, looking her up and down. There’s a long slit up her right leg that stretches all the way above her thigh, and a loose belt at her waist. The dress dips into a long v-shape behind, keeping that delicious back of hers on show.

“I wasn’t really thinking about myself,” I say, still running my gaze up and down her form. *She looks stunning*, I think, watching as she pulls her hair tie out, shrugs her blond locks free, and tussles her fingers through her hair, straightening it out.

Adora raises an eyebrow, following my gaze. “Do you like it?”

I nod, my throat turning dry. “Definitely. I kind of want to get you out of it though.”

“Later,” Adora says, smirking.

“So, should I go buy something to wear?” I ask, twitching my left ear. “I’m feeling a little underdressed.”

“What if I told you I’d already got you something?” Adora says, beaming.

“What? How? When?”

“You kind of zoned out for a while on our market date,” Adora says, grinning. She pulls out a paper-wrapped bundle from the wardrobe, and passes it to me.

“Yeah, you were pretty relentless,” I groan, tearing open the thin paper. There’s three items inside; a white, short sleeved shirt, a pair of black, cropped trousers with small v-shapes cut above each ankle, and a crimson, sleeveless tuxedo jacket. “I like it!”

“It’s a little different from your usual thing,” Adora says, grinning. She heads to the dresser and starts combing out her hair. “I mean, I’ve never really seen you in white,” she says, pausing mid-comb to look at me in the mirror and smile. “Apart from when you used to steal my t-shirts.”

“Hey, I was borrowing them,” I smirk, quickly getting undressed. I swap out my red sports bra for a white one, then put on the new shirt, fastening half the buttons. “Hmm, good fit,” I say, pulling up the black slacks. “Oh! You had a hole put in!” I exclaim, threading my tail through the seamed gap at the back of the trousers.

“Well duh,” Adora chuckles, turning to face me. Her eyebrows raise and she takes a deep breath. “Wow…”

“It’s okay?” I ask, buttoning up the red jacket, then looking down at myself.

“You look very handsome.”

“You’re not so bad yourself. Love the shoes,” I say, pointing at the open-toed short heels.

“Good job I had red ones,” Adora says, grinning.

“You could have always gone barefoot,” I say, raising a foot and wiggling my toes.

Adora blows out a puff of air. “One day I’ll find something you’ll wear on your feet.”

“I highly doubt it.”

“Well, I think I’m ready,” Adora says. Then she frowns, sniffs at herself and scrunches up her nose. “Actually, I should probably take a shower.”

I grin. “It’s fine. I like your scent.”

“Even if I’m stinky?”

“Especially when you’re stinky,” I say, batting my tail against her butt. “Some of us like how our girlfriends smell.”

“Hey, I like how you smell too!” Adora says, pouting.

“Sure you do, whenever I have a wash.”

“Nope, all the time. I just enjoy teasing you, that’s all.”

“I bet you do,” I say, lidding my eyes at the thought of her teasing me in other ways. “Let’s go, before I decide to rip that thing off of you.”

Adora takes my hand and squeezes my fingers. “As hot as that sounds, please don’t. This is now my favourite dress.”

Chapter End Notes

Mermista: I'm honestly surprised you two actually made it out of the room.
Glimmer: Guess you've never had to deal with a starving Adora...
Catra: Yeah. Nothing keeps Adora from her food. Not even me. ¯_(ツ)_/¯

Dancing and Desperation

Chapter Summary

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"Woah," I say, gazing around the square. The sun hasn't quite set, but bright lights and holograms of every colour are already illuminated above the various restaurants and clubs. "This is insane."

"Right?" Adora says, beaming. "I haven't even tried half of these places yet."

"Ah, I spotted the crab place," I say, pointing towards a large, holographic sign with animated crab pincers opening and closing. "Subtle."

"Oh crap," Adora says, quickly leading me up the narrow, stone stairs. "I hope they still have a table at this time." She pushes open one of the double wooden doors, where my nose is greeted with a salty, spicy aroma.

"Smells great," I say, my mouth filling with saliva.

"Tastes better."

"Adora. You're actually drooling."

"Don't care," she says, licking her lips.

Just inside the entrance, a tall Salinean man with a long, twirled moustache, greets us. "Ah, my favourite customer!"

"Hey D," Adora says, rushing forwards and pressing her hands together. "Please tell me you have a spare table, otherwise I might die."

“Well we can’t be having that,” he says, laughing, then turning to me, “Who’s your lady frien- oh.” His face turns sour. “We’re full.”

“What!” Adora says, her eyes turning watery. “Come on D, don’t be like that.”

“I lost family to these people, Adora,” he says, folding his arms. He flicks his hand in dismissal.

“But Catra’s different now, she helped save us all and-”

“Leave it, Adora,” I sigh, slumping my shoulders. “Come on, let them keep their crab to themselves.”

Adora follows me outside, to the large, circular courtyard at the bottom of the stairs. I sit on one of the benches down there and rest my elbows on my knees, watching as Adora sits next to me.

“I’m really sorry,” she says.

“Me too,” I say, sighing. “I know you wanted to eat there. You still can, if you want. I don’t mind.”

“Hey,” Adora says, placing her palm on my back. “I’m with you. Nothing on Etheria would change that now, not even crab legs.”

I lean against her and rest my head on her shoulder. “My, aren’t you a charmer,” I say, enjoying the feeling of her hand as it slowly strokes up and down my back. I watch as people in the courtyard go about their business, some of them laughing, others gesticulating wildly, maybe describing their favourite place to eat, or maybe having some kind of argument. I could listen in if I wanted to, but I’m too distracted by Adora’s hand, sliding up my back and then her thumb, rubbing across the nape of my neck.

“Are you okay?”

“I guess, but,” I say, purring at her gentle touch. “This stuff’s always going to come back to haunt me, isn’t it?”

“I was in the Horde too, remember,” Adora says, placing her arm around my shoulders. “But everyone’s forgiven me. It just takes time.”

“And in the meantime, I can’t even take my girlfriend to her favourite restaurant.”

“Oh, say that again.”

“Huh?”

“Girlfriend.”

“Hah, idiot,” I say, leaning up and kissing her cheek. “Okay, what’s our plan B?”

“How about we go somewhere I haven’t been,” Adora says, standing up and holding her hand out. “That way it’s new for both of us.”

“Okay, let’s pick the first place we find,” I say, lacing our fingers together. “I don’t want you starving to death.”

Adora smiles goofily. “Aww, you’re being really sweet today.”

“Don’t push it.”

--

“Have you tried this one?” I ask, pointing to a gaudy, hand-painted sign of a dancing cartoon duck.

“Dancing duck?” Adora asks, scanning over the menu next to the door. “Nope. But they do lots of meat, so it’s all good.”

“After you then, ma’am,” I say, gesturing ahead.

Adora bursts into laughter, and puts on her best Brightmoon accent. “Not at all. Please, after you.”

The wide wooden door suddenly bursts open, and a huge, muscular, blue-furred magicat bursts out. “Don’t just stand there!” he bellows, beaming widely, holding his arms wide. “Come in, come in!”

“Wow, pushy much?” I say, frowning.

“Ah!” he claps his hands together. “So good to see one of my own. Catra, isn’t it? And Adora! Etheria’s new power couple, at my restaurant! I am truly blessed!”

“Power couple?” I say, frowning. I turn to Adora, only to find her eyes are wide, and gleaming with excitement.

“He’s a magicat!” Adora says, clapping excitedly. “It’s fate. Now we *have* to eat here.”

“We’re not *that* rare you know,” I mumble.

“He’s the second I’ve ever seen. Or third, if you count the time Bow got kidnapped by one in a pirate gang.”

“Wait, what?” I ask, walking in behind her.

“Long story,” she says, chuckling.

The large magicat ducks beneath the doorway, takes two leather-backed menus from a table just inside, and nods his head, handing them to us. “My name is Stan,” he says, leading us further inside, towards a vacant table. “I own the place. I’m overjoyed that you’ve decided to dine here, and I guarantee you won’t be disappointed!”

“Like we had any choice,” I mutter, sitting down opposite Adora.

We’re in a large, circular room that’s split into three sections. The outside ring has several tables, one of which we’re sat at. In the dead center there’s a bar, surrounded by several stools all around, and between the tables on the outside and the bar in the middle is a polished, wooden floor, surrounded by a silver bannister.

“What’s that for?” I ask, pointing towrds the large, spacious flooring.

“Ah, the dance floor! We are a club too, yes? Will you be dancing later?”

“No.”

“A magicat, not dancing? What a tragedy,” he says, leaning over to Adora, whispering loudly, “We make the best, sexiest dancers, you know?”

“Well, I do now,” she says, grinning from ear to ear.

I scowl. “Don’t get any ideas.”

Stan saunters away from our table, humming to himself, and I start to scan my fingertip down the menu.

Adora peers over the top of hers, raising an eyebrow. “You were more than happy to dance at the princess prom.”

“Yes, because I was messing with you,” I mutter, slowly batting my tail around. “Also, it wasn’t a date.”

“How does that make it any different?”

“I don’t know,” I say, twitching my ears. “It just does.”

“Are you worried we’ll end up making out in front of everyone again?” Adora asks, leaning forwards and resting her cheeks in her palms. “Because that was really, really hot,” she says.

I feel her toes trail along the exposed part of my calf, before sliding further up, along the inner seam of my trousers. “Behave,” I huff, my cheeks burning as I close my menu. “We’re here to eat, remember?”

“True,” Adora says, stroking her toe up and down my inner thigh. “Although I’m hoping to have you for dessert.”

“That’s uh,” I say, feeling the heat spread from my cheeks down to my ears and neck. “An interesting idea. And also, very direct.”

“You weren't complaining earlier,” Adora says, appearing smug. “In fact, I’m pretty sure you asked me to be very *specific* about what I wanted to do to you.”

“Oh look, Stan is coming back,” I say, forcing a smile, trying to ignore the images Adora’s planting into my mind, mainly involving her lips, and all of the things she said to me in the cafeteria earlier today.

Magicats remember things with astonishing clarity, Perfuma had said. *No kidding*, I think, remembering Adora’s little monologue word for word, and remembering exactly how she looked at me while saying those words, too.

“I’ll have the uh,” I frown, remembering it all, even remembering the tone of her voice.

First I’m going to run my hands, and my mouth, all the way down your body, from your lips, to your neck, to your-

“Yes?”

“DUCK!” I say, thrusting the menu at him, my cheeks feeling as though they’re on fire.

“Oh my, someone is excited!” Stan says, turning to Adora. “And our food is worthy of such joy, you will see!”

-breasts. I’m going to taste you, every single square inch, and then I’ll trail my lips along your abdomen, all the way down-

Adora lids her eyes at me, pushing her foot further. “I’ll try the duck too.”

“I’ll bring some samplers too, okay?” Stan asks, holding the menus at his chest. “Then you can try our other delicacies.”

“Sounds perfect, thank you,” Adora says, beaming and passing the menu to him.

“Adora, pack it in,” I whisper, snapping my thighs closed around her foot the second Stan leaves the table.

“Sorry,” Adora says, reaching an open hand across the table. “I’m going too fast, aren’t I?”

“No,” I say, hovering my hand over her forearm, and trailing my nails across her skin. “If you don’t stop it, we won’t be eating at all.”

“Hmm,” Adora smirks. She lowers her foot, and I release my breath in a long, drawn-out sigh.

“This is going to be a long night.”

Adora reaches her other hand out, sandwiching mine between both of hers. “A long, fun, night?”

“More like torturous,” I say, pulling my hand away, then reaching both hands out and lacing our fingers together.

“You know, we didn’t have to go out if you wanted me that badly,” Adora says, her lips curving into an infuriatingly smug smile.

“Don’t pretend it isn’t mutual, my love,” I say, squeezing my fingers around hers. “I can smell how turned on you are.”

Adora’s eyes widen, and I grin wickedly when a faint blush appears at her cheeks. “You can smell that? Seriously?”

I nod and lean back into the cushioned chair, folding my arms, and this time it’s my turn to feel smug. “Yes. I can.”

Stan approaches our table with a large glass jug full of water, and two glasses, which he sets down. “Is this okay? Or would you like more drinks?”

“Oh! mocktails!” Adora says, clapping her hands. “Catra, have you ever had them?”

“Huh? What, like beer?”

“So much better,” Adora says, grinning. “Can we get a jug of virgin sex on the beach?”

“A jug of *what*?” I ask, feeling my tail fuzz up.

“It’s just mixed fruit juice,” Adora says, grinning. “Virgin means no alcohol, sex on the beach is just a fun name.”

“I’ll bring one right out,” Stan says, winking.

“I never really understood alcohol,” I say, crinkling my nose. “It makes people so dumb.”

“It’s fun sometimes,” Adora says, “but I want to stay sober tonight.”

“So you don’t make an ass out of yourself?” I ask, laughing. “Oh! Remember when you had beer after training that one time? You were all over the place, haha!”

“Hey,” Adora pouts. “I wasn’t used to it, that’s all.”

“Adora. You had a thirty minute argument with a training dummy.”

“It looked at me funny!”

“You’re such an idiot,” I say, smiling softly as I remember how I stayed with her during her little drunken episode. I’d taken her to bed later, then kept an eye on her to make sure she wasn’t sick or anything.

She smiles smugly. “I know you tucked me in that night.”

“I’m surprised you remember anything, honestly,” I say, scrunching up my nose.

“It was one of the sweetest things I’d ever seen you do. In fact, I think that was the first time I realised I loved you as more than a friend.”

“Aren’t you being sappy all of a sudden,” I say, turning Adora’s hands around. I place my fingers beneath hers, and roll my thumbs around her open palms, smiling. “I suppose the Horde wasn’t all bad.”

“Not when we had each other,” Adora says, looking down at our hands, and smiling. “So, when did you realise?”

Stan returns, this time with a tall jug full of yellow-orange liquid, with ice cubes bobbing around inside. He places two glasses down, each with a sugar frosted rim, straw and umbrella, then pours our drinks. “Enjoy, your food will be here soon!”

“Thanks, Stan,” I say, taking one of the glasses and sucking at the straw. “Hmm, wow, it’s good!”

“Mmm!” Adora beams, “I think it’s the best one I’ve had.”

“Hah! Do you try this at every place?”

“Yeah - if it’s on the menu!”

“Let’s hope the food is as good,” I say, feeling my tummy rumble.

“So,” Adora says, resting one elbow on the table, and her cheek in her palm. “Are you going to answer my question?”

“What? Oh, right,” I say, twitching my left ear. “It’s… difficult to say. We had shadow bitch turning us against each other all the time, so everything was messed up in my head.”

“Let’s not talk about her,” Adora says, her face turning a shade paler. “Not tonight. Please.”

“Yeah…” I say, folding my ears down. “Honestly? I never had a lightbulb moment. You’ve always been special to me, it just started to feel different when we got older. By the time I was finally realising what it all meant, you-”

“I switched sides?” Adora sighs, staring down into her drink, fiddling with her straw. “Wow. Lousy timing, huh?”

I laugh. “Yeah, you could say that. But if I hadn’t been such a stubborn idiot, and just gone with you...”

Adora suddenly reaches a hand out. “We’re not going to keep circling around this, okay? What happened happened, and all that matters is we’re here now. Together.”

“Yeah,” I say, tightly entwining my fingers with hers. “And thank goodness for that.”

The middle of the room suddenly turns dark, leaving only the central bar and surrounding tables illuminated. Then, the floor lights all around the dance floor begin to glow, cycling slowly through various colours, and music starts to play.

“What’s going on?” I ask, watching Stan hurry towards us with a large tray and a portable stand.

“You came at the best time,” he says, unfolding the stand, placing the tray on it, and setting out our plates. “At nine onwards is when people can dance, yes? You can watch them while you eat! Free entertainment!”

“Ooh, this smells great,” I say, rubbing my hands together. “Adora. You’re drooling again.”

“I’m so hungryyy!” she says, grinning from ear to ear.

Stan points to a long, rectangular plate with lots of small portions of food on it. “The samplers are burger sliders, sticky chicken wings, vegetable spring rolls, crab dumplings, and battered squid. Enjoy!” he says, folding up the portable stand. “And dance afterwards, okay? Burn it off, have fun!”

“This is a *lot* of food,” I say, looking at my plate. We each have a quarter of a shredded duck on a bed of seasoned rice, with a side serving of salad.

“Not gonna be a problem,” Adora says, immediately shoving a forkful of duck and rice into her mouth.

“Remember to breathe,” I say, chuckling. I take a bite myself, finding the sauce on the duck both spicy and sweet, and the rice to have a very distinctive aroma that helps to bring out the flavour. I swallow my mouthful. “This is *really* good!”

Adora grunts and vigorously nods, shoveling more food into her mouth. *Hah, she’ll never change*, I think, idly swinging my tail. Back whenever we’d scrounge up something other than rations, Adora would always pig out, and I never did quite figure out where she’d put it all.

“Adora, slow down, haha!” I laugh, noticing her plate is half empty when I’m barely on my third mouthful. “Are you even tasting it?”

“Sorry,” Adora says, running her thumb across her lips. “It’s really good, and I’ve been hungry for ages now.”

“I wouldn't normally care, but I don’t want you getting a stomach ache tonight,” I say, pointing a finger at her belly. “You know it always happens when you eat fast. You get too much air.”

“True,” Adora says, burping quietly. “Okay. Good point. I’ll try to control myself,” she says, smirking.

--

“The duck was the best,” I say, digging a toothpick between my teeth. “Chicken wings a close second.”

“Duck, squid, burgers, and the chicken wings. And the crab dumplings,” Adora says, patting her belly.

“So basically everything was your favourite?”

“Pretty much.”

“And are you full?” I ask, smirking. She’s had two thirds of the samplers, not that I mind, since I couldn’t have eaten another thing.

Adora answers with a loud belch, then laughs.

“Ooh, that was sexy,” I say, scrunching up my nose. “Do it again.”

Adora holds up a finger, closes her eyes, and lets rip the biggest belch I've ever heard. It’s so loud that it travels over the music, and the people sitting at the two tables nearest us turn and stare.

I sit back into the chair and laugh loudly, clapping my hands. “I think you just broke our old record.”

“That was easily an eleven!” she says, beaming.

“Rogelio is gonna be so sad.”

“I can’t believe I’ve finally beaten him.”

“And all it took was three portions of food!” I say, resting my cheeks in my palms. “Man, I’m stuffed,” I say, burping quietly, covering my mouth.

“That’s a two, if that. Pathetic,” Adora says, shaking her head.

“My skills lie elsewhere, as you know,” I say, sticking my tongue all the way out.

Adora bites her lower lip into a smile. “Should we get the bill?”

“Yup,” I say, holding my hand up and waving at Stan. He grins, nods, and walks over, dodging out of the way of a couple of dancing couples who’re getting carried away.

“Clean plates!” he exclaims, stacking them up into the crook of his arm. “this I like to see.”

“It was amazing,” Adora says, grinning widely.

“Yeah, not bad at all,” I say, helping him to tidy up.

“Not bad?” Stan asks, raising an eyebrow before looking at Adora. “Is she always this good with the compliments?”

“Oh trust me, that was a huge one coming from her.”

“Hey!”

Stan laughs. “Okay, you will dance now?”

“Nope.”

“Well…” Adora says, smiling.

“Not gonna happen.”

“Your lady looks like she wants to dance, Catra.”

“Hah, my lady?” I ask, somehow liking the sound of it. “Doesn't matter, because I don’t dance.”

Stan looks at Adora. “Aww, she is shy?”

“She’s afraid that I’ll outdance her,” Adora says, appearing smug.

“Yeah, right,” I say, sticking my tongue out.

“But you are both all dressed up,” Stan says, looking between us, “and Catra, the flower in your hair is so lovely.”

“You do look *really* nice,” Adora says, blushing.

“Besides, if you go to bed with full tummies, you will only end up sleeping,” Stan says, winking. “Trust me! I will even take twenty percent off your bill, but only if you dance dance dance!”

“Persistent, aren’t you?” I ask, twitching my right ear. I yawn, reluctantly admitting to myself he might have a point about passing out. “Fine, we’ll dance.”

“Yes! Astounding!” Stan says, clapping his thick hands together once, then quickly scribbling a new number onto the bill. “Just leave it here, I will pick it up later. You ladies have fun, and have a drink on me! Also water is free,” He says, waving as he walks away. “Got to keep my dancing friends hydrated!”

“I can’t believe you actually agreed to it,” Adora beams.

“Ugh, like I had a choice,” I say, rolling my eyes. I take my purse from my jacket pocket and ignore the discounted amount, leaving enough coin for the original bill plus a generous tip.

“I guess I’m getting the next one?”

“Yes, you are,” I say, wrinkling my nose. “I’m thinking of a big, expensive steak restaurant.”

Adora pouts. “That’s mean.”

--

I swish my tail left to right while we walk onto the dance floor, Adora leading the way, her fingers laced with mine. She soon finds an empty spot, then turns to face me and holds her arms wide, beaming.

I stand there motionless, feeling awkward, especially since I don’t know this music, but then Adora grins goofilly, takes my hands and starts to dance like a complete idiot, barely even in time with the song. I laugh loudly, and jiggle along with her, figuring if she’s gonna make an ass out of herself I might as well join in.

I feel my worries melt away until it's just Adora and I having fun, jumping around, thrusting our hips, waving our arms in the air, not caring about anyone or anything else. It's just like it was back in the Horde, just us two against the whole world.

Suddenly the tempo changes and a high energy song blasts out, causing Adora's eyes to widen. "I know this one!"

"Oh?" I ask, watching her, grinning. "Show me."

She bursts into fluid movement, like I've never seen before. I hardly even hear the chorus blare out, because I'm mesmerised, watching her jump around without a care in the world, her loose hair whipping around in messy strands, the lights shining through her dress, her body silhouetted beneath the thin fabric.

I... I don't deserve her, I think, watching her. Adora raises an eyebrow and I realise that I've almost stopped moving, so I quickly lunge forwards, taking her hands in mine, raising my arms with hers and bouncing away, until the tune slows down, then stops.

"I liked that one," I say, smiling.

"Yeah!" Adora says, talking loudly. "They have really good music here!"

"They do, but I'm parched after all that. Let's grab a drink?"

--

I suck at my straw, feeling undecided on whether I like this so-called pina colada. "What about the time Lonnie accidentally ate cat food? Haha!"

"That wasn't an accident," Adora says, pouting. "You set her up."

"Me? It wasn't my fault it looked just like our rations."

Adora laughs, shaking her head. "You're so mean."

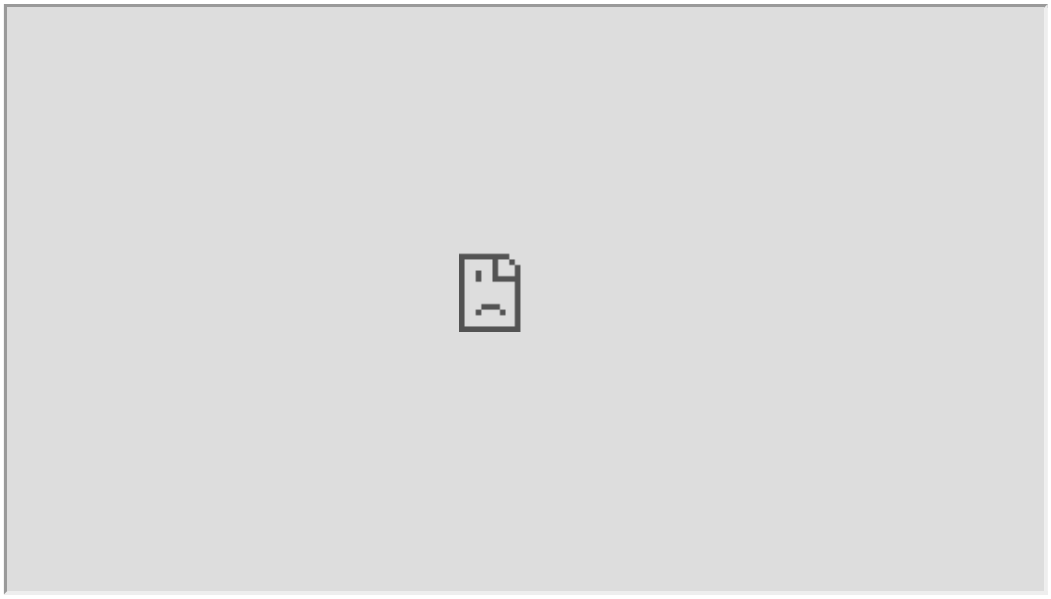
"All part of the charm," I say, sticking my tongue out.

And then, finally, a song comes on that I recognise. It's a tune that Adora and I used to practise dancing together with, back in the Horde. Or *infiltration training*, as they called it.

Adora hops off from her stool, holding out her hand. "Madam?"

"Ah yes," I say, jumping from my stool. "Shall we?"

I rest one hand on her waist, and take her other hand in mine while she puts an arm around my shoulder.



 # Tell me somethin', girl

Are you happy in this modern world?

Or do you need more?

Is there somethin' else you're searchin' for? #

We tip our foreheads together, and start to dance in slow, steady circles, just like we've practised.

 # I'm falling

In all the good times I find myself

Longin' for change

And in the bad times I fear myself #

But this time, the mood is completely different. This time, I feel the heat of her body, pressed so closely to mine. And this time, I know she loves me, wants me, just as much as I do her.

 # Tell me something, boy

Aren't you tired tryin' to fill that void?

Or do you need more?

Ain't it hard keeping it so hardcore? #

 # I'm falling

In all the good times I find myself

Longing for a change

And in the bad times I fear myself #

I tip my nose to hers, capture her gaze with mine, and slowly blink. She returns the gesture, and I wonder, as in really, truly wonder, how we ever got here, and how I deserve this.

 # I'm off the deep end, watch as I dive in

I'll never meet the ground

Crash through the surface, where they can't hurt us

We're far from the shallow now #

Adora wraps both of her arms around my shoulders, and I fold my hands around her waist, holding her tightly, resting my chin in the crook of her neck.

 # In the shallow, shallow

In the shallow, shallow

In the shallow, shallow

We're far from the shallow now #

“I love you,” I whisper, nuzzling my cheek against hers.

Adora finds my lips with hers and kisses me, the music distorting beneath the sound of my racing heart, my senses spiralling from the feel of her tongue. I push a thigh between her legs and dive over her, supporting her weight in my arms, her surprised but loving expression taking my breath away.

 # I'm off the deep end, watch as I dive in

I'll never meet the ground

Crash through the surface, where they can't hurt us

We're far from the shallow now #

Adora grins and leans up, pressing her forehead to mine, tussling her fingers into the hairs behind my neck while she sings to me.

 # In the shallow, shallow

In the shallow, shallow

In the shallow, shallow

We're far from the shallow now #

“I don’t think I’ll ever get used to you saying that,” Adora says, wiping away a few tears.

“You’re supposed to say it back,” I say, pouting.

Adora wraps her arms around me. “I love you, so much that it hurts when you’re not around. Happy?”

“Very,” I say, butting my head softly against hers. “Let’s go home.”

--

It doesn't take us long to arrive at the west hall, with the door to our room already in sight.

"Hey, Adora," I say, squeezing her fingers. "I had a really nice time tonight. Thanks."

"Me too," Adora says, blushing lightly. "I think that was our first date-date."

"Yeah," I say, kissing her cheek. "I'd say it went pretty well."

Adora nods "Oh! And I think I've found my new favourite restaurant!"

"So dancing duck beats crumb-filled crab?"

Adora laughs, "I told you, it's cranky. And yes, it does. By a long way."

"Because of the food, or the amazing company?" I ask, raising an eyebrow

"Well, as amazing as the food was," Adora says, pushing open the bedroom door and heading inside, "I got to dance the night away with my gorgeous girlfriend. It doesn't get any better than that."

"Are you sure?" I ask, raising my ears and eyebrows before I lean against the door, closing it. "Because I'm pretty sure it can."

Adora grins and kicks her shoes off. "First things first, I'm having a shower. I'm feeling super stinky now."

"Hmm, I think I'll join you."

"You know I actually have to have a wash, right?"

"So? I won't stop you."

"Uhuh," she says, pulling her dress over her head, exposing her toned midriff, and the subtle, sweet ridges of her abdomen.

I start to get undressed too, watching As Adora strips down to nothing, throws her clothes into the laundry basket, then looks over her shoulder once, winking before she heads into the bathroom. She leaves the door open, and I dash in shortly afterwards, just as she's twisting the shower handle.

"Pass me some shampoo and conditioner?" She asks, holding a hand out.

I oblige, passing a couple of random bottles across. "Are these okay?"

"Anything other than my own sweat is good," she says, drenching her hair under the jets of water. She starts to lather shampoo into her hair, and I lean against the wall of the bathroom, content to just watch her for a while.

She rinses her hair, twisting it at the ends, before lathering it up all over again, then starts to scrub herself with a sponge and soap. I watch as the suds flow down her naked body, licking my lips.

"Are you ever going to join me?" Adora asks, running the bar of soap slowly around her breast.

I swallow thickly. "I, uh, thought you wanted to get clean?"

Adora smiles smugly, and holds out the bar of soap. “Just make sure you don’t miss anywhere.”

I bite my lower lip into a smile and step into the large cubicle, wincing a little when the water drenches into my feet, then the rest of my fur. “Hand it over then,” I purr, taking the bar from her, and starting to lather it across her chest, then waist, enjoying the sight of her drenched, soapy body.

“Catra.”

“Hmm?”

“Are you ever going to kiss me?”

“Thought you’d never ask,” I say, leaning forwards and finding her lips with mine. Barely a second later our mouths fall open and I roll my tongue with hers, groaning while running the bar of soap along her back, dropping it the moment that Adora’s thigh slips between mine.

“Sorry” she says, her breath hot against my lips. “But I’ve been thinking about this all day… about you. About all the things that I want you to do to me.”

“Adora,” I gasp, looking into her eyes, feeling the embers flickering below my pelvis erupt into white hot heat.

Adora threads her fingers into the back of my hair, her pupils fully dilating as she stares into my eyes. “I need you.”

I lunge forwards, trapping her lips in mine, feeling all of the passion from the day reignite, all of her teasing and flirting bubbling to the surface, and now she’s naked and wet in front of me, and she’s all mine. *And she needs me*, I think, savouring the words as they spin around my mind. *Adora actually needs me.*

Adora moans into the kiss, digging her fingers into my back, and I nudge her forwards, pushing her against the tiled wall, sliding my leg between her thighs. I kiss along her jaw, trailing the tip of my tongue down to her neck, where I suck in a small fold of flesh and nibble at her skin.

“Mmm, Catra,” the word spills out in a low moan as Adora’s fingers tense, and so I do it again, this time sucking harder, licking and biting, drawing out more of those delicious gasps and groans, until there’s a few blemishes peppered around her neck.

I place my hands on her waist and kiss my way down her neck, along her collarbone, pausing to look up at her. “You’re very quiet,” I say, my lips twisting into a smirk. “Other than all the moaning, I mean.”

Adora chuckles. “So you prefer it when I talk?”

“I like hearing your voice,” I mumble, kissing further down, pausing by her breast. “Besides, I’m still new at all this. Tell me what you want.”

“Your mouth, here,” Adora says, resting her hand on the back of my head and lightly tugging, encouraging me towards the small, pink peak. I oblige, wrapping my lips around it, exploring the shape with my tongue. “That feels r-really good,” Adora gasps, arching her torso against my lips, and it’s so exciting tasting her like this, touching her like this, hearing those short, shallow breaths with every circle of my tongue.

I trap the stiff point lightly between my teeth, wondering if it'll have the same effect as biting her neck, and sure enough I'm rewarded by fingers digging into my scalp, and my name falling from her lips.

"Catra, please…" Adora whimpers, coaxing my head south. "Down."

I reluctantly abandon her breast, bite my lower lip into a smile, and run my tongue further down her damp torso, taking my time, admiring the shape of her. I glide my hands down the dips of her waist and over the small bulge of her hips while licking, kissing, and trailing the tips of my fangs across her defined muscles. I taste each ridge of her abdomen, where even beneath the narrow streams of water there's still the faint flavour of salt.

"You feel amazing," Adora says, and my heart warms at her reassuring words. "Just… keep going..."

"Is someone feeling impatient?" I ask, smirking while running my hands down her thighs, and eventually lowering myself to my knees.

I trail my lips lazilly towards her navel, pausing to kiss the tiny mole just above it, before lowering myself towards the place I know she wants me, the same place I've wanted to taste all night, the same place she's going to taste on me later, or so I hope.

I take a moment to look up at her, finding her pupils blown, her hair hanging in wet, messy strands around her shoulders, and her lower lip trapped in a firm bite. "Mine," I growl, placing my mouth upon her.

"Catra!" Adora cries out my name, her fingers turning rigid against my scalp, and her legs trembling. I lean forwards and wrap my hands behind her thighs, keeping her back firmly pressed against the tiles while my mouth goes to work.

Adora slides one leg over my shoulder, writhing her hips against my tongue as I stroke it around her pink little bud, delving deeper with each stroke, until I dive fully into her soaked entrance, hitting those special, tasty ridges inside.

Adora actually *whines*, and the sound of it does something to me, makes the heat below my abdomen become almost unbearable. She scrunches her hands into my hair, and I feel her warm, wet flesh flutter against my tongue, just like this morning when she said she was coming. *Is that what it's called?* I think, looking up at her. *That amazing feeling?*

She returns my gaze, her chest rising and falling rapidly. "Need… your fingers... " she mumbles, her lips barely forming the words.

I nod and slowly ease my tongue out of her, then curl two digits inside, digging deeper with every thrust of her hips, and running my tongue across her sweet little bud in long, thick strokes.

"You're a-amazing," Adora gasps.

Her movements become wilder and wilder, until she's bashing against my tongue and fingers, fisting knots into my hair, whimpering, and I groan against her, losing myself in the sounds she's making, in how wet and warm she feels around my fingers, in how her flavour is spilling out, all over my wanting mouth.

Suddenly she cries out, tugging my head forwards, holding my head and tongue in place while she thrusts roughly, her body trembling with the strain. And then, she releases a long, quiet moan,

gradually sliding down the wall until we're nose to nose, where she stares at me, panting.

"I… I honestly can't believe how good you are at that."

"Heh," I grin, tipping my nose to hers. "Let's just say I'm very motivated."

"So," Adora whispers, tussling the hair around my ear. "My turn?"

"Um…"

Adora leans forwards and kisses me gently, "If you don't want to, it's okay."

"I want you," I say, blushing at the admission. "But not here."

"I could hold you up, you know," Adora purrs, lidding her eyes.

"I'm sure you could," I say, standing up and turning the shower off. "But I'd prefer a nice, dry bed. You know how I feel about water."

"Oh, sorry," Adora winces. "Sometimes I forget."

"Well, you made it worth my while this time," I say, stepping out of the shower and grabbing a towel. "I just need a minute to dry off."

Adora wraps her arms around my waist from behind, and places her lips around the bottom of my ear in a light nip. "Why? I'm only going to make you wet again."

Oh, fuck, I think, squeezing my eyes closed, hearing a low growl rumble in my throat. I spin around and capture Adora's lips in a fierce kiss, suddenly forgetting all about drying off, dropping the towel, not caring at all that we're still soggy, or that I'm being pushed backwards through the door, towards the bed.

Before I know it I'm flat on my back and Adora is above me, appearing smug, her damp, blonde hair hanging down in messy strands. She smiles, and strokes my cheek with her palm. "If you change your mind, just tell me to stop."

"I'm telling you to *go*, Adora," I say, rolling my eyes and shuffling further up the bed. "Sheesh, you've been teasing me all day."

"Hmm," Adora purrs, lowering herself to my lips for a long, sensual kiss. She wastes no time, kissing her way along my jaw, then my neck, until I feel her lips and teeth trail along my collarbone, peppering me with gentle kisses and nibbles, each touch and stroke making my body tremble, *but it isn't enough*, I think. *Not nearly enough*.

"Adora. I'm gonna need you to go faster than that."

"Is that so," Adora says, nudging her nose against my breast, and a moment later I feel a warm, wet heat there, peering down to find her mouth is open, and her tongue is pressed against my brown, stiff peak, rolling around in long, rough circles.

"A-Adora," I whimper, nestling my fingers into her hair, taking in short, shallow breaths. My heart races while I watch her, each brush of her tongue sending a flicker of heat surging past my abdomen. She kisses to the centre of my torso, stroking her hands down my sides, then along the dips of my

waist while she lowers herself, kissing ever so slowly downwards, nudging my short fur away with her nose so that I can feel her lips against my skin.

“Please…” I groan, feeling desperate for some kind of release.

She pauses beneath my abdomen, just above my darker patch of fur, then folds her hands behind my thighs and looks up at me, smiling.

“You really are beautiful, you know.”

I bite my lower lip. “Save the pillow talk for later,” I growl, tugging at her head. “I need you. Now.”

Adora’s pupils dilate and she suddenly lunges forwards, where I feel the hottest, wettest pressure against my bud, and I cry out, clenching my fingers into her hair.

Adora pauses. “Too much?”

I shake my head vigorously. “No! Why are you stopping?”

She returns to that sweet, glorious spot, and I feel her tongue glide around in long, laborious strokes, each movement taking my breath away. Watching her do this, feeling her tongue against me, and knowing that just moments ago I was doing the same to her, *it’s... too much*, I think, squeezing my eyes closed as a hot pulse shoots up from my core.

“Adora…” I gasp, feeling another flicker of heat, right at the point of her tongue. “I can’t… ah!”

“Should I stop?”

“No, idiot!” I say, fisting my hands into her hair. I feel warmth rush to my cheeks. “I was saying, I can’t stop.”

“Oh,” Adora says, smirking smugly. “Already?”

“Shut up,” I pout, tugging at her head, “and get your tongue back there, now.”

Adora makes a deep sound in her throat and lowers her mouth, this time licking faster, pressing harder, and if I thought I was losing control before it’s nothing compared to now, feeling that rough wetness stroke around, and when she dips her tongue just a little lower, towards my core, I’m almost blinded by the hot wave it forces through me.

“A-adora, I… I... ah!” I fold my legs behind her back, rocking into her, but Adora is ready, keeping her tongue pressed to all the right places, keeping my thighs pinned down, no matter how much I writhe.

She’s so strong, even without She-Ra, I think, watching her shoulder muscles tense while her fingers dig into my thighs, and she pins me down, keeping me grounded despite my hips bucking beneath her. I watch her busy mouth, buried right against me, and when her blue eyes suddenly peer up, full of nothing but love, it sends me spiralling over the edge.

“*I’m coming,*” I choke out the words, a violent peak erupting from the burning point of Adora’s tongue, blossoming outwards with dizzying speed. Spasm after spasm rocks through me, and I knead my fingers into her scalp, throwing my head back, thrusting myself against her mouth over and over, choking out half-words that don’t even make sense.

A long, final surge washes over me, and once it fades away I feel myself become limp, my hands falling to my sides. Adora slows her tongue, then kisses her way up my abdomen, across my neck, my chin, and then finally meeting my lips.

“Are you okay?” she asks, stroking her hand up and down my waist.

I wrap my arms loosely around her shoulders and raise my head, tipping my forehead to hers, panting. “Just… need a minute..” I say, trying to get my breath back.

“Was that too much? Was it too fast?”

“Adora,” I say, meeting her gaze. “Stop worrying. It was amazing.”

Adora blows out a puff of air. “You were… wow…”

I raise my eyebrows and prick my ears up. “Me? What did I do?”

Adora places a hand on my cheek. “Watching you come like that was the most beautiful, amazing thing I’ve ever seen,” she says, moving her lips to my ear. “And you taste better than I could have ever imagined.”

I feel heat rush to my cheeks, and twitch the end of my tail. “Well it’s good that you enjoyed me so much, because I’m going to need more."

Adora bites her lower lip into a wide, surprised smile. “Really?”

I nod. “After all the flirting today? Really. Now get your mouth back down there.”

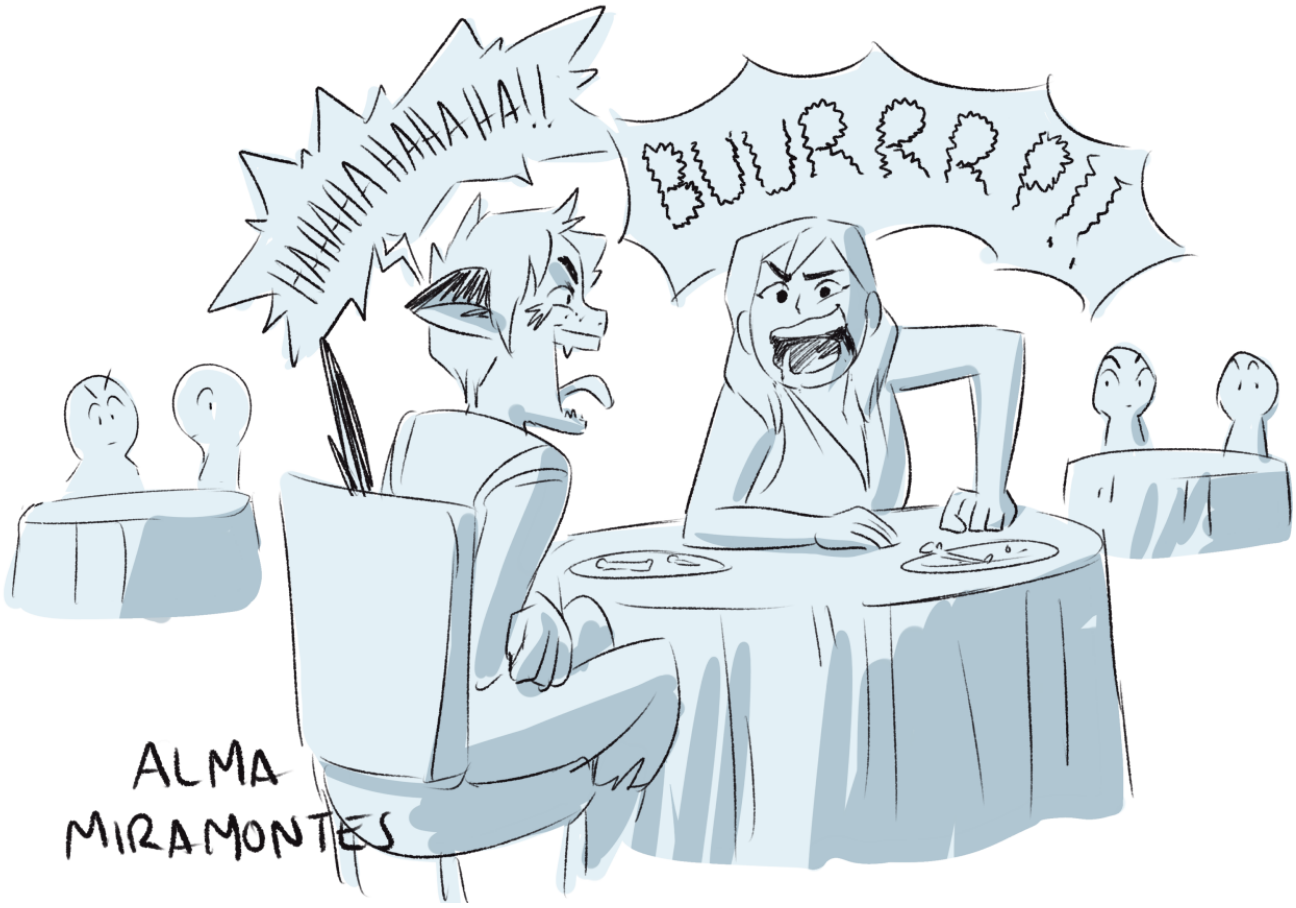
Chapter End Notes

Mermista: So did you guys just carry on all night, or...?
Catra: Adora, do not answer that.
Adora: Hmm. I think I lost count after twelve... no, thirteen...
Catra: Adora!!

BONUS! Alma Miramontes (dessertsoul1217) has very kindly created this super freakin' awesome fanart for this chapter! I'm not worthy!!

ALMA
MIRAMONTES

ALMA
MIRAMONTES


HAHAHAHAHAHA!!
BURRRP!!
ALMA
MIRAMONTES

Lift Off!

Chapter Summary

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

I feel Adora's hand slowly ruffling into my hair, and I bump my head against her palm while a rumble erupts from my throat. "Mrrp?"

Adora gasps, "That was so cute! Do it again. Please, please do it again."

"Pfft, what are you talking about," I say, yawning and stretching out. "Do what?"

Adora frowns and starts making weird noises. "Prup? Prapp?"

"Hah! You loon, what's gotten into you?"

"You made this really cute noise! I swear!"

"If you say so," I say, crawling on top of her, then touching my nose to hers.. "Hey, Adora."

"Hey Catra," Adora says, blushing lightly. She leans up and kisses me. "What time is it? We need to get ready."

"You're not going anywhere," I say, smirking. "Not until I've had breakfast."

"Breakfast?" Adora asks, frowning. "But we don't have any… Oh," she pauses, then bites her lower lip. "I don't think we have time," she says, reaching for her communicator.

"We'll *make* time," I growl, batting her hand away with my tail.

--

Some time later, after I've had my fill, we hurry down the west hall.

"Glimmer is gonna kill me," Adora mumbles.

"But it was totally worth it," I say, smirking.

Adora peers at me sideways and blushes. "Yeah. It was."

"Haha-"

My laughter catches in my throat when we walk out of the exit, into the west courtyard. "Wow!" I exclaim, shielding the sun from my eyes and peering up at the giant silver and purple spaceship.

It's hard to recognise the vessel at all, but I'm fairly sure I can see the original parts of Darla higher up, and it's like the entire old ship is basically just the bridge of the new one. The chassis is completely re-built, with silver plating reaching from the tip of the nose near the palace stairs, to the tail of the ship at the other end of the courtyard.

"She's huge," Adora says, taking my hand, and running down the stairs.

"Understatement," I say, as we jog into the shade beneath the gigantic hull. "She's at least four times bigger."

"Oh, there you are!" Glimmer says, waving from the bottom of Darla's ramp. "Finally!"

"Sorry we're late," Adora says, fumbling her hand in the back of her hair. "We were uh..."

Here we go, I think, rolling my eyes. But Adora actually keeps quiet for once, and I raise an eyebrow, wondering what's gotten into her.

Glimmer folds her arms, and frowns. "Cat got your tongue?"

I watch while Adora appears to physically restrain herself from retorting, before deciding to put her out of her misery.

"She got the cat's tongue, actually," I say, twitching my tail, "and I'd say she quite enjoyed it, too."

Glimmer raises an eyebrow, and then bursts into laughter, pointing at Adora's neck. "I can see that!"

"What?!" Adora exclaims, patting her neck, then leaning back and peering into the reflective surface of Darla's shiny exterior. "Catra!"

Payback, I think, watching Adora get flustered. "You weren't complaining at the time, Adora," I say, yawning. "In fact I'm pretty sure you were asking for more."

Adora pouts and stands next to me. "Shall we just give Glimmer all the details? I don't mind, you know."

"Me neither," I say, shrugging. "You'd just tell her everything anyway."

"Urgh, it was cuter when you got flustered," Adora says, her shoulders sagging.

"Aww, did I ruin your little game? I'm sooo sorry."

"Guys," Glimmer says, tapping her foot, "Come on, you have a lot of catching up to do."

--

We follow Glimmer up Darla's ramp, into a large cargo area packed full of crates. Everyone else is already here; Entrapta is with Emily, checking over the labels on a stack of crates. Scorpia is further ahead waving at us excitedly, standing next to Perfuma who smiles and dips her head in greeting, and Bow is sat cross-legged on the floor, biting the tip of his tongue while fiddling with the tip of an arrow.

"Now I feel bad for making everyone wait," Adora says, running her hand across the back of her neck.

"I'm sure they'll forgive us," I say, watching as Melog bounces over from the far side of the room. "Hi buddy," I say, crouching down and butting heads with them. "Miss me?"

"Of course," they say, sniffing around me.

"Yes we did, before you ask."

Melog huffs, and sits next to me, yawning. "I wasn't going to ask."

"Sure you weren't."

Glimmer coughs. "Okay, everyone's *finally* here," she says, narrowing her eyes at the two of us.

"Everyone?" I ask, looking around. "Where's Hordak?"

"He's decided to stay behind and help Dad with some new projects."

"Plus he wants to stay with his brothers," Entrapta says, hopping into a spot next to me. "I've been observing all of them, and I believe they're actually bonding!" she says, her eyes widening.

"Entrapta," Glimmer says, smiling. "Are you ready to show us around?"

"Yes! Oh boy, you're gonna love this!," she says, bouncing up the next ramp and through the wide doorway. "Follow me!"

--

"This is the mess hall," Entrapta says matter-of-factly, shooing us all into the room. There's an oval, silver table in the center, with ten cushioned stools placed around it, and around the edge of the room are various cupboards, appliances and a sink. "You can eat here. Oh! And look what I made!"

She scuttles over to one of the appliances, a tall, rectangular machine with a few narrow slots in the middle, and a receptacle on the bottom, in which Entrapta sets a plate.

Entrapta places her lips closer to the small slots. "Tiny cupcake."

The machine makes a subtle, electrical whirring noise, there's a soft glow, and two seconds later, a small cake appears on the plate.

"Tadaa!" Entrapa says, holding the frosted treat up. "It's tiny, and delicious!"

I twitch my ears. "You seriously made a tiny cupcake dispenser?"

“Oh no, that would be absurd,” Entrapta says, chomping the cake down. She places the plate back into the machine, and puts her mouth near the hollow grooves again. “Tiny tuna sandwiches.”

A small pile of teeny, tiny triangle-cut sandwiches appear, and Entraptra holds up her plate, grinning widely. “I’ve programmed it to understand most Etherian recipes. You should try it!”

“Oh, me, me!” Adora says, dashing forwards and shoving a plate in. “Beef burgers.”

- *Error. Query unrecognised.* -

“What? Aww... “ Adora says, appearing crestfallen.

“You’re doing it wrong,” Entrapta says, leaning over. “*Tiny* beef burgers.”

The machine whirrs and pops out three very small morsels onto the plate, which Adora removes and holds to her face, squinting at the burgers.

“Oh, this is so wonderful,” Perfuma says, smiling sweetly and clasping her hands together. “But what if we don’t want our food to be… well, miniature, as cute as it is?”

“Not tiny?” Entrapta says, scratching a pigtail on her head. “I don’t understand, what are you trying to say? Hang on let me get a pen and paper so you can write it down.”

“I think she means what about *big* food, Entrapta,” Glimmer says, rolling her eyes and holding her hands apart to show a normal portion size. “You know, something that might actually fill us up?”

“Oh,” Entrapta says, wincing. “Well, if you want weird stuff like that there’s always a workaround,” she says, taking Adora’s now-empty plate, and placing it back into the receptacle. “Tiny beef burgers. Tiny beef burgers. Tiny beef burgers.”

“I don’t believe this,” I say, placing a palm on my face. Entrapta hands the plate back to Adora, which is now stacked with over a dozen tiny burgers stacked on top of one another.

“Hey, at least it works?” Scorpia says, beaming. “And there’s always ration bars,” she says, opening a few of the cupboards. “See?”

“Plus we can cook!” Bow says, finding another cupboard stacked with dehydrated ingredients. “I think we’ll be fine.”

“Oh we have plenty of that stuff,” Entrapta says, shrugging. “The Cargo bay has enough supplies to last us for years.”

“Um,” I say, frowning, “we’re not going out there for that long, are- oh, Hi Melog.”

Melog suddenly brushes against my legs, and sits in front of the new machine. “I wonder if it will understand me?” they ask.

“Hah! You should give it a try.”

Melog raises his snout. “Tiny steak.”

The machine hums to life, and spits out a miniature steak, which Melog jumps up and grabs with their jaw, appearing very pleased.

“Wait, what?!” I say, taken aback. “Entrapta, how did-”

“Oh, the machine understands many languages. It’s all part of the clone technology. Isn’t it incredible!?”

“Tiny steak,” Melog says, catching the next portion in their mouth.

Scorpia takes a small bowl, puts it into the machine, and leans over. “Tiny ice cream sundae. Oh look at that! It actually worked!”

“Anyway,” Entrapta says, swooping across to the next machine, “you can get drinks here!”

“Please say it isn’t tiny drinks,” I say.

“Of course not,” she says, grabbing a glass from one of the cupboards. “It’ll dispense fizzy drinks. Any flavour you want.”

“Tiny Steak,” Melog says.

“And water?” Glimmer asks, shaking her head.

“Ummm… Is sparkling okay?” Entrapta asks, smirking. “That was a joke. I’ve been practising the whole humour thing, did I do okay?”

“Actually, that was almost funny,” I say, grinning.

Entrapta beams at me. “Over here we have your boring water dispenser, and here, a hot drinks machine! Tea, coffee, hot chocolate…”

“Tiny Steak.”

“Where does it all come from?” Adora asks, her eyes glimmering. “Is it magic?”

“Hahaha! No! It’s *science*!” Entrapta says, before launching into a monologue about dehydrated, compressed nutrient sources and how the machines laser print food or some such. I lose interest, especially at the part about liquid versus gas, and I roam around the kitchen, looking through the cupboards and drawers.

“Tiny Steak.”

“Melog!” I scold. They turn to face me, their cheeks engorged as they chew on the contents inside their mouth.

“All this tech is blowing my mind!” Bow says, his eyes wide. “Entrapta, you have to show me how this stuff works, please!”

“I’ll consider it, but only if you show me how all those crazy arrows of yours function,” Entrapta says. She wraps a pigtail around Bow’s shoulder, and they both walk out of the room, engaged in a lengthy, animated conversation about who only knows what.

“I guess the tour’s over, then,” I say, shrugging.

“Ugh, I’ve already had a look around, while you two were *busy*,” Glimmer says. “Come on, I’ll show you the rest.”

“Oh this is so exciting!” Scorpia says, pressing her pincers together. “I can’t believe we’re really doing this, this is going to be the best adventure *ever*!”

“I’m sure it will be, sweetheart,” Perfuma says, pecking her on the cheek.

“Tiny Steak.”

--

“I’ve got to say, it’s pretty impressive,” I say, folding my arms.

Adora and I are sitting in our room on one side of the double bed, looking through a large, domed window which currently faces the west palace walls, while Melog is zonked out on the middle of the mattress, dead to the world after eating approximately six thousand tiny steaks.

“It’s a lot more than I expected,” Adora says, lightly nudging her shoulder against mine. “What do you think of our room?”

“The bed is comfy,” I say, smirking. “That’s all that matters.”

Our bedroom is quite a bit smaller than the palace room, but I like snug spaces, so I’m okay with it. We have the bare essentials, several secure compartments built into the wall for clothes, drawers beneath the bed for extra storage, and a large mirror embedded into the wall above a long, silver shelf.

“I can’t believe how much bigger she is,” Adora says, leaning forwards. “I honestly have no idea how they did this.”

Darla now has three floors. On the ground floor there’s the huge cargo area, which we saw as we walked in. The next floor up has the bridge at the front side of the ship, with the mess hall, medical bay, and bedrooms - six in total - towards the rear. As far as I could tell, the second floor was somewhat bigger than the others.

“I can’t wait to try out the observatory,” I say, standing from the bed, and walking towards the window. “Although the view from here is gonna be pretty awesome too.”

The observatory is on the third floor, facing the front of the ship. It has a huge wide window, stretching from the floor to the ceiling, then halfway across the length of the room. Directly beneath the window there’s a dipped section of flooring, with a couple of small ramps leading down into a square area with a sofa all around the edges, and a polished, wooden table in the middle.

“Yeah, it will be,” Adora says, moving next to me, and wrapping an arm around my shoulder. “I like the rec room, although I’m surprised Entrapta thought of it.”

Located opposite the observatory, at the rear of the ship, the recreation area is full of various board and card games stored away in secure compartments, with a short-legged table in the middle, surrounded by beanbags and two three-seater sofas.

“For all we know it was Hordak’s idea,” I say, grinning at the ridiculousness of the thought. “In either case, it’ll be nice having somewhere to kick back and relax between our space adventures.”

“Are you nervous?” Adora asks, “about going back out there, I mean.”

“A little. I mean, the last trip could have gone better…” I shudder, the memory of Prime’s voice suddenly echoing through my mind.

You grieve, sister. I can feel it, swirling around in your chest. You grieve for her, for your Adora, for the loss of what could have been. Your pain runs so deeply that I can practically taste it.

Adora's hand tightens on my shoulder, and I feel her lips on my cheek. "Are you okay?"

"Yeah," I lie, walking back to the bed, sitting down, and resting my head in my hands. I take a few deep breaths, trying to stop the memories, trying to drown out his voice, still so clear.

Worry not, sister. When you step into the light, she will be but a distant memory. You will finally be free from all of your pain, and all of your suffering.

"Just get it over with," I say, walking down the stairs, into the pit.

I squeeze my eyes closed, feeling nauseous at the sudden realisation that I was never pushed into that damn pit of his. *No*, I think. *I went in there willingly, just like he knew I would*.

Melog shifts upon the bed, and moves next to me, resting their snout on my thigh. Then I feel the bed dip as Adora sits next to me. She says nothing, just rests a hand on my other thigh, and waits. Having them both so close like this soon helps me to ground myself, and a few deep breaths later I open my eyes and raise my head, blinking a few times.

"Want to talk about it?" Adora asks.

"It's nothing," I say, turning to face her, and noticing she appears concerned. "Okay, it's something but I… I think I'll talk to Perfuma first, if that's okay?"

"Okay," Adora says, frowning slightly. "But you'd tell me if it was something I'd done?"

I chuckle while I raise a hand and swiftly tug her hair tie out, releasing those lovely shoulder-length locks from their unfortunate prison. "Tying this up is the only thing you keep doing wrong," I say, running my fingers through her soft hair.

She smiles softly. "So, what do you think of the new bridge?" she asks, and I'm grateful for the distraction.

"Well, It's good that we can all actually sit down now," I say, turning to Melog and ruffling their mane. "Plus it seems you have lots of new toys to play with."

"So many new buttons," Adora says, grinning and holding her hands out, wiggling her fingers. "I can't wait to fly her."

"Please don't press the buttons, Adora. Or at least find out what they do, first."

"Aww but…"

Suddenly there's a loud crackle, followed by Entrapta's voice coming from a speaker in the corner of the room that I hadn't noticed until now.

"Hello! I forgot to show you the communications devices! Each room has one, just look over in the corner, on the wall."

Adora runs over to the device, a small round pad with a single button and a few slotted grooves, and lifts it from the receptacle it's slotted into. "Testing, testing, one two three," she says, standing bolt

upright and deepening her voice. “This is your captain speaking. All hands on deck. Roger roger. Over and out.”

“Hello, captain Adora! Engineering here,” Bow says, laughing. “The ship appears to be in tip top condition.”

“Oh this is so much fun!” Scorpia says, “Don’t you think so, beautiful? Oh, you want a turn?”

“Hello everyone,” Perfuma says. “Greetings from room number four.”

Glimmer coughs. “Okay, now that everyone’s familiar with Darla 2.0, we’d better get ready for launch.”

“Eight pm!” Bow says, “I can’t wait!”

I swipe the microphone from Adora, pricking my ears up. “Wait, we’re going today!?”

“Yup,” Glimmer says. “If you’d been present at the meeting you could have raised any concerns.”

I pass the microphone back to Adora, “Crap, we need to get ready!”

“Okay, we’ll see you at the launch, over and out,” Adora says, putting the microphone down, and grabbing onto my shoulders, shaking them. “Ooh, this is so exciting!”

“Is it okay to just… go?” I ask, scratching the fur under my ear. “Don’t people have stuff to do?”

“Not everyone’s a disorganised mess like we are, you know.”

“Guess we have been a little distracted lately,” I say, smirking.

Melog huffs. “An interesting choice of words.”

“Ugh, come on,” I say, grabbing Adora’s arm, “we have to get all our stuff!”

--

After packing everything up, pausing to grab a bite to eat, then moving and unpacking seven boxes packed with clothes and other stuff that I’m fairly sure we won’t need, we’re finally ready.

“Made it with ten minutes to spare!” Adora beams, shifting from She-Ra’s white and gold garb back to her usual uniform.

“Remind me why we needed to pack almost your entire bedroom,” I groan, my shoulders feeling stiff.

Melog trots alongside, appearing amused. “She even brought four extra pillows.”

“Yes. I know.”

“Hmm?” Adora tilts her head, peering down at Melog. “Hey, I did most of the lifting, I don’t know why you two are complaining.”

“How do you know they’re compla- you know what, never mind,” I say, suspecting more than ever that Adora secretly understands Melog. “We’d better get a move on, everyone’s probably waiting in the bridge.”

“Well it’s not like they can go anywhere,” Adora says, pressing a thumb proudly to her chest, “not without their captain!”

“We are not calling you that.”

“Spoilsport.”

--

“Okay, so… ideas?” Adora asks, looking at the star map that’s projected in front of us from Darla’s dashboard.

“First things first, we should stock up on thulite,” Entrapta says, pointing her pigtail to a specific point on the map, which rapidly zooms in until a planet is rotating around in the middle of the display. “This planet has plenty, and unlike the last one, it isn’t falling apart!”

“Are you sure?” Glimmer asks, narrowing her eyes.

“Yes, all of this new technology is amazing,” Bow says, pressing a few buttons on the dashboard until some charts pop up. “Look at these readings! There’s a breathable atmosphere, meaning there’s probably life.”

“Ooh, so there’ll be plants?” Perfuma asks, clapping her hands excitedly.

“Most certainly!” Entrapta says, “or at least, according to our short range scans. And perhaps even creatures of some kind,” she continues, raising her hand and swiping the display left, until we see numerous pictures of the planet’s surface. “Although, no signs of sentient life.”

“Amazing,” Scorpia says, peering up, her eyes glistening. “How can you tell?”

“I’m guessing because there are no buildings,” I say, shrugging.

“Yes, the planet appears completely untouched,” Entrapta says, turning to Adora. “So, Captain, what do you think?”

“Please don't call her that,” I say, placing my palm over my face. “Like her head isn’t big enough.”

Adora chuckles and sits in the large chair in the center of the room. “I think it sounds like the start of an adventure. But, um... how do I work this thing?”

“Everyone should get strapped in!” Entrapta says, swinging across to a chair on the left side of the bridge, just in front of the main dashboard. She taps a few buttons on the panel.

- *Coordinates are set. Please initiate lift off procedure.*

Bow and Glimmer take the two seats behind Entrapta, while Scorpia and Perfuma hurry across to similarly paired seats on the opposite side of the bridge. I choose one of the two chairs next to Adora’s, so that I’m sitting within arms reach of her.

“What about Melog?” I ask.

“There’s four chairs left,” Entrapta says, beaming. “Or they can sit on your lap.”

“Come on then, buddy,” I say, patting my leg. They jump up and I wrap my arms around them.

Entrapta turns to face Adora, grinning. “Over to you, captain! Just put your hand on the panel there.”

- *Pulse cannon activated. Please select a target.*

“No not that one. The other one.”

“We have a canon?” Bow asks, his eyes glistening.

“Here’s hoping we never have to use it,” I grumble.

“Aha, got it,” Adora says.

- *Administrator detected. How may I be of assistance?*

“Uh, hi Darla,” Adora says, grinning. “Can we lift off, please?”

- *Acknowledged.*

I feel my weight press into the bottom of the chair as soon as Darla leaves the ground, though it’s far smoother than I expected. I wouldn’t even know we were airborne if not for the view outside of the window, where I can see the ground hurtling away.

“Darla, take us to the… uh, coordinates.”

- *Acknowledged. Heading to target coordinates, estimated time of arrival is-*

“Ooh!” Entrapta says, “Darla, tell us a joke!”

- *Joke request acknowledged...*

- *Don’t trust atoms. They make up everything.*

“Haha! Clever girl,” Entrapta says, patting the top of Darla’s dashboard.

“You made it tell jokes?” Scorpia says, widening her eyes, “That’s fantastic! Darla, tell another one.”

- *Joke request acknowledged...*

- *Why should you never eat a clock? Because it is too time consuming.*

“Pfft that’s terrible,” I say, chuckling. “Entrapta, what have you done to our poor ship.”

“Oh it’s one of her many new *amazing* features,” Entrapta says, lidding her eyes. “Darla and I have been very, very busy.”

Adora runs her a palm down her face. “I’m not sure I want to ask, but what other *features* are we talking about here?”

“Oh, too many to say. I’ll tell you when we need them.”

“What? But-”

“It will be fine, commander Adora,” Entrapta says, saluting with her pigtail. “Darla is in better shape than ever!”

“Riiight,” Adora says, shaking her head. “Darla, what’s our ETA?”

- *Eleven hours.*

“Why don’t we just warp?” I ask, twitching my ears.

“Actually, I think it’d be better to test basic ship functions first,” Bow says. “And it’s getting late anyway, we all need to sleep, right?”

“Wait, what do you mean test?” I ask, batting my tail around. “Haven’t you already tested the ship? Glimmer?”

“Uhhh…”

“We’re testing it right now!” Entrapta says, beaming from ear to ear. “And she’s doing fine, aren't you Darla?”

- *Personal enquiry detected...*

- *Yes. I am fine. There are currently no hull breaches, which is good, otherwise you would all be dead.*

“See! We’re perfectly safe.”

“Okay, I’m having regrets,” I say, leaning over in my chair to look at everyone, folding my ears down. “Is anyone else having regrets?”

“I’m sure we’ll all be absolutely fine,” Perfuma says, resting her hand above Scorpia’s pincer, “so long as we have each other.”

“Yeah I don’t think the power of love will help us much in the *cold vacuum of space*,” I say, pointing out of the hull window to the starry skies just above the wide curve of Etheria’s surface.

“Hey, you have me,” Adora says, stretching over and resting her hand on my forearm. “And She-Ra has some kind of magical breathing barrier thing, who knew?”

“You mean you went out into space before without actually knowing this?”

“Well… it’s She-Ra. So I figured it’d be okay.”

“Remind me again how you all aren’t dead by now,” I say, shaking my head.

Melog huffs. “I cannot work out whether you are excited or afraid.”

- *Exiting planet atmosphere. Please fasten your safety harnesses.*

“Both. Hold on tight,” I say, wrapping my arms around them. *Please don’t blow up*, I think, gritting my teeth. Melog whines and pushes their head into my chest, and Adora turns to grin at me manically. *How can she not be scared?!* I think.

- *Coordinates locked. Engaging thrusters.*

Entrapta gasps. “Oh I almost forgot! I upgraded the-”

“Argh!” I feel myself shoved backwards into the chair, watching as the view of the planet’s surface falls lower and lower until it dips out of view altogether, and over the sound of the roaring engines

and everyone else's screams I hear Adora, giggling. “Adora! This isn’t funny!”

- *Maximum velocity reached. Cutting thrusters. Thank you for flying air-Darla.*

All of a sudden the feeling of being pushed back subsides, and Melog hops off from my lap, shaking their fur.

“That wasn’t so bad,” they say, tilting their head to one side.

“Yeah, I guess,” I say, standing up and walking towards the window. “Woah, how fast are we going?” I ask, watching the stars fly by.

Entrapta leaps into a spot next to me. “About six times faster than before! Just wait until we try the warp drive, haha! We’re going to *fold space*!”

“Yay!” Adora says, clapping her hands. “Warp drive! Folding space! Ooh I wonder if it’s like origami?”

“Seriously,” I say, trying but failing to hide my smile. “Are you drunk?”

“I think our captain is just a little over-excited,” Glimmer says, chuckling.

I peer around at the view outside, finding nothing but blackness, stars, and the moons of Etheria which we’ll shortly pass by at this rate.

“Let’s go to the observatory!” Scorpia says, unclipping her harness and standing up.

“What a wonderful idea,” Perfuma says, wrapping her arms around Scorpia’s thick claw. “I can’t wait to see it!”

“Let’s all go!” Bow says, taking Glimmer’s hand. ”Come on guys, this is the start of our big adventure!”

“The view should be *phenomenal*,” Entrapta says, bounding after them through the doorway.

“Hey, wait for me!” I exclaim, twitching my left ear. I peer at Adora, who’s still sat in her big dumb chair, wide-eyed with excitement. “Are you coming?”

“No,” she says, lidding her eyes. “I’m just very, very excited.”

Melog snorts out a puff of air. “That was a good one.”

“Haha, you idiot,” I say, holding out my hand. “Come on.”

--

“Woah,” Scorpia says, her eyes wide open as she stares out into space. “This is amazing!”

“It’s absolutely breathtaking,” Perfuma says, casting her gaze around, “there must be so many wonderful things out there...”

“They might not all be so wonderful,” I say, walking towards the front side of the room, and pressing my palm to the glass. “We don’t know how many planets Prime destroyed.”

“Maybe we can fix them,” Adora says, standing next to me, placing her hand on my shoulder.

“Even if we can, it won’t bring back the dead.”

Adora appears crestfallen. “Oh. Of course not.”

“Let’s concentrate on our calming, happy thoughts,” Perfuma says, pressing her hands together. “I’m sure there are plenty of planets that are thriving out there, just waiting for us to discover them.”

“Actually, there are!” Entrapta says, beaming. “And lots of planets with first ones tech, too!”

“Speaking of which, the long range scans have picked up a planet with a really unique energy signal,” Bow says, furrowing his brow. “Along with lots of life signs. It might be worth a look.”

“We’ll go there after we get the thulite, then,” Glimmer says, grinning. “This is so exciting!”

“So everyone keeps saying,” I mumble, watching as the last of Etheria’s moons moves across the window, until it’s out of view.

“Are you okay?” Adora asks, nudging her shoulder against mine.

“Yeah,” I say, forcing myself to smile despite the uneasy feeling gnawing at me.

--

A few hours later, after snacking on several plates of tiny food while theorising what kind of creatures we’ll find on our first planet, everyone’s resting on the large sofa in the descended area within the observatory floor. Scorpia is snoozing against Perfuma’s shoulder, with Perfuma slowly stroking her white strands of hair, and Bow and Glimmer appear to be drifting off, with Bow resting his head on her lap.

The only person who’s still wide awake is Entrapta, who’s busy tapping away at her data pad, sticking her tongue out, clearly busy with something.

Adora’s thumb starts to trail lazy circles into my palm, and I turn to look at her, finding a gentle sleepy expression.

“Darla, what time is it?” I ask.

- *It is time you got a watch.*

“Seriously?” I ask, narrowing my eyes at Entrapta, who beams with pride.

- *Ha. ha. Ha. That was a joke. It is half past ten.*

Bow yawns. “An early night isn’t the worst idea. We should all get some rest.”

“It’s a big day tomorrow after all!” Glimmer says.

I look across at Perfuma, swallowing thickly. “Got time for a chat first?”

“I was about to ask you the same thing,” she says, smiling. “I’ll be with you soon, sweetheart,” she says to Scorpia, who nods with a wide smile before standing up.

“Take as long as you need,” Adora says, pecking me on the forehead. “I’ll warm up the bed.”

Melog walks across the sofa and flops down next to me, yawning before resting their snout on my thigh. We watch as everyone else leaves the room, until it's just we three, and the stars above.

"Beats meeting in the middle of a bush, right?" I ask, grinning.

"Oh absolutely," Perfuma says, shifting herself closer to me on the seat, one corner of her lips raising, "Although a little bit of bush never hurt anyone."

"Perfuma… haha… did you just-" I begin, raising an eyebrow. Perfuma's expression remains neutral. "Never mind."

"There is no way that wasn't innuendo," Melog says, peering up at me. I shrug, feeling unsure either way.

"So… do you like it?" Perfuma asks, peering upwards through the massive overhead window. "Space, I mean?"

"Yeah. I don't know why," I say, twitching my left ear. "It's just really… pretty."

"Yes. It is beautiful."

"Hey," I say, a sudden thought coming to mind. "How was this gonna work if you didn't come with us?"

"Long range communication" Perfuma says, beaming. "I actually had everything ready, just in case. But this is so much better."

"Hmm, yeah. It is."

"So," Perfuma says, resting her hands on her lap, "how have you been feeling?"

"Fine."

Melog huffs and raises their head, glaring accusingly. "You were not fine earlier."

Perfuma looks at Melog, then back at me. "Is there something you'd like to discuss?"

I frown, feeling conflicted.

"You should tell her," Melog says. "She can be trusted."

"This really goes no further?"

Perfuma shakes her head. "Of course not."

"Well…"

I tell Perfuma about my latest revelation, about how I basically just gave up on Prime's ship, and more or less *let* him turn me, in the end. I'm surprised to feel some of the weight lift while I spill out the words, with Perfuma nodding between each sentence, and listening attentively the whole time.

"I haven't told anyone else," I say, sighing. "In fact I didn't even tell *myself* it until earlier, technically."

“After traumatic events, our minds can play tricks on us. It’s a defense mechanism, in your case your mind probably thought that anger would be easier to process.”

“Sounds about right.”

“But all along, it was despair. To feel that way must have been absolutely terrible,” Perfuma says, the edges of her brows lowering. “All hope gone, and nowhere left to turn. You surely don’t blame yourself for your actions?”

“I don’t know. I could have fought harder. I just... hate that I let him win,” I say, gritting my teeth. “I *hate* it.”

“Yet he is gone, and you survived.”

I bite back tears and nod, stroking Melog’s mane. “Thanks to Adora.”

“How does it make you feel, knowing that she did come for you in the end?”

“Mainly confused. I just… I don’t understand why she did it.”

“Because she loves you, of course.”

I sigh, folding my ears down. “Right.”

Perfuma stays silent, as though waiting for me to continue.

“I don’t get it. After everything I’ve…” I pause, squeezing my eyes closed, trying to ignore the memories that flicker through my mind, one terrible act after another, and my hand, tightly gripping that lever. “I keep thinking that I don’t deserve this. I don’t deserve her.”

“I see,” Perfuma says. She places a hand on my shoulder, and I open my eyes. “What if I told you that love isn’t earned? That it isn’t a prize or a reward?”

I tilt my head. “Huh?”

“A person either loves you, or they don't,” Perfuma says, withdrawing her hand and shrugging. “Just like you either love them, or you don’t. Did you at any point feel Adora would have to do something to deserve your love?”

“Of course not.”

“And you feel happy, knowing that she loves you back?”

I nod.

“Have you ever stopped to think it’s that simple? And that all of this is exactly the same for her?”

“So,” I begin, frowning. “She’s probably just... happy that I love her?”

“Yes!” Perfuma says, clapping her hands together once. “Just as you are grateful for her love, she is grateful for yours. And gratitude is such a wonderful, healthy emotion!” Perfuma says, reaching into her bag then leaning forwards and thrusting a notebook and pen into my arms. “Let’s explore this!”

“Um… ok?”

“Write down something you feel grateful for,” Perfuma says, smiling. “Oh, and try to add detail. So…” she says, looking up, into the stars above. “Instead of, I’m grateful for the stars.... try, I’m grateful for the beauty of space, the stars, the moons, and all of the wonders it holds.”

“Hmm,” I frown down at the notebook, opening the first, blank page. “Why am I doing this again?”

“Consider it to be a new form of training,” Perfuma says, tapping the side of her forehead. “Just try it! Once a day, for a week. Write three things.”

“Three?!” I exclaim, scowling. “Ugh. This is stupid.”

“I assure you it isn’t. But if it’s too hard, then I understand.”

“I never said it was hard,” I pout, starting to scribble *Adora, and how much she loves me, even after everything I’ve done*.

“May I see?”

“I guess,” I say, handing the book back.

“It’s a good start, but,” Perfuma says, frowning.

“What!” I exclaim, “I did what you asked!”

Perfuma passes the book back. “I want you to cross out the last part, please.”

“Uh..”

“Even after everything you’ve done?” Perfuma says, looking at me expectantly.

“Ugh, fine,” I say, drawing a thick line through the words.

“Now read it out.”

I growl and roll my eyes. “Adora, and how much she loves me.”

“See? Doesn’t that sound nice?”

“Oh. Yeah… I suppose it does,” I say, my heart warming as I re-read the line in my head a few times.

“Good,” Perfuma says, smiling brightly. “Let’s practise this a bit more...”

--

Sometime later I head to the kitchen to get a drink before bed, smiling widely when I find Adora there.

“Hey, how was it?” she asks, peering at me over the rim of her glass.

“Interesting, but tiring,” I say, yawning. “What’s that?”

“Fizzy lemonade. Want some?”

“Nah,” I say, putting a cup under the drinks machine and pressing a combination of buttons that eventually leads to fizzy orange. “How come you aren’t in bed?”

“Couldn't sleep,” she says, sipping at her drink. “I was worried about you.”

“I’m okay, I promise,” I say, gulping down my drink. “In fact, I’ll tell you all about it.”

Adora’s lips curl into a soft smile. “You don’t have to if you don’t want to.”

I kiss her cheek. “I do. Come on, let’s go to bed.”

We head outside of the mess hall and veer right, walking towards our room at the very end of the corridor. Adora nudges my shoulder and tips her head towards the book in the crook of my arm. “What’s that?”

“Oh, yeah. I have to do homework now apparently.”

Adora presses the little button to the side of our door, which slides open with a quiet *woosh*. “Seriously? Homework?”

“Yeah, tell me about it,” I say, rolling my eyes as we walk inside. “But, it might help. So we’ll see.”

Melog yawns and butts their head against my leg. “May I rest here tonight?”

I ruffle their fur. “Sure, just don’t take up the whole bed.”

--

A few minutes later, after we’ve freshened up and changed into our nightwear, we both sit on the side of the bed that faces the window, staring out at the stars. Melog settles down at my side, resting their head against my thigh.

“Okay,” I say, taking a deep breath. “Are you sure you want to hear all this? It isn’t pretty.”

“Of course,” Adora says, putting an arm around my shoulders. “So long as you’re sure, I mean.”

And so, I talk. I tell Adora everything about Prime’s abuse, starting with the forced haircut, where the clones held me down so tightly that I couldn’t move, not even an inch, and there were so many of them, their fingers pressing into me, digging, bruising.

“Get off of me!”

Then I talk about the surgery, where Prime somehow kept me conscious despite my body being limp. How he made sure I felt everything; the deep, slow incisions behind my neck, cutting my skin open. The searing, stabbing pain of the implant, digging itself into my nerves. The tube down my throat, harsh and rough, forcing air into my lungs despite me wishing for it to stop.

I tell her how through it all I wanted to scream, wanted to gag, wanted to rip the tube out, but my body wouldn’t let me.

Then I pause, closing my eyes, feeling my whole body tremble at the memory.

“Catra,” Adora says, rubbing her hand down my back. “It’s okay to stop.”

“No. Let me finish.”

I talk about how just afterwards, when my body was still weak from the ordeal, when I couldn’t even fight back, Prime hovered over me with malice clear in his eyes. How he laughed as he thrust a spiked

tendril into the newly implanted chip, forcing himself into my mind, into my memories, into my heart.

"Don't! Stop it!!"

Lastly, I tell Adora how I gave up. How his voice, spoken directly into my mind, convinced me that forgetting everything, even her, would be so much easier.

"Just get it over with."

I admit to her that I'd stopped fighting altogether, not even caring when I felt sure the pain in the pit would finish me off.

"Adora… I'm so, so sorry for wanting to forget you," I say, studying her face closely. "But I also wanted to forget everything he'd done to me."

Adora's gaze remains focused on the view outside of the window, her eyes wider than usual, and I notice that she now has both her hands tightly gripped on her own knees. *I finally told her*, I think, wondering what she's thinking. Her brows furrow, and I worry that I've upset her.

"Adora?"

She blinks a few times, then turns to face me.

"Are you upset?" I ask, whipping my tail onto the mattress nervously.

She quickly shakes her head. "I'm glad you told me. I always wondered if you would."

I shrug. "Perfuma said it'll help if I share stuff so… I'm sharing. But only with you."

Tears form at Adora's cheeks, and I notice her jaw is clenched. "Is it wrong that I want him to be alive, just so that I can kill him all over again?" she asks, her knuckles turning white. "But this time, make him suffer? As in really, *really* suffer?"

"Adora…" I say, placing one of my hands over hers. "Don't say things like that. It isn't like you."

"He forced himself on you."

I feel the hairs rise on my neck, and down my back. "Yeah, well. He's gone. Good riddance, like I said."

Tears stream down Adora's face. "You shouldn't have had to go through any of that… I should have come sooner. I'm so, so sorry."

"No. Don't you *dare* blame yourself," I say, reaching a hand up, brushing my thumb across her damp cheek.

"But…"

"I said no, Adora. I won't have it. You got there as quickly as you could, and thank goodness you did," I say, replacing my thumb with my lips, gently kissing her cheek. "You're my hero, okay? So shut up."

Adora snorts out a laugh. "I never thought I'd hear you say that."

"And you never will again," I say, smirking. "In fact, did I say it at all? You have no proof."

Melog snorts loudly, and flops their jaw onto my thigh, peering upwards. “I heard it.”

“Doesn’t count, and you can’t tell anyone.”

“Is Melog saying they heard?” Adora asks, grinning.

“It’s freaky how many times you guess what they’re saying,” I say, laughing.

“Hey, Melog,” Adora says, leaning over, “Can you write in Etherian? Want me to teach you?”

“Wait, I don’t like where this is going...”

“What a good idea,” Melog says, moving across to Adora’s side, and nuzzling against her hand. “Tell her I accept.”

“I’ll do no such thing, you can tell her yourself. Oh wait, you can’t. Too bad.”

“They said yes, didn’t they,” Adora says, appearing smug when Melog headbutts her hand. “This is going to be fun, isn’t it Melog? We just need to find a nice pen you can hold between your toes.”

“Okay, I’m way too tired for this shit,” I say, standing up and stretching out. “Off the bed, now. Both of you.”

They oblige, and I dive under the covers, groaning quietly at the comfort of the thick mattress after such a long, hard day.

Adora moves around the other side of the bed and climbs in behind me, wrapping her arms around me protectively, cocooning me in her warm embrace. “I love you,” she mumbles, her lips warming the flesh at the top of my spine, “and I’ll never let anyone hurt you, ever again.”

“I can look after myself, you know,” I purr, stroking my nails across her forearms.

“I know,” Adora says, nuzzling herself closer, until there’s barely any space between us.

“And I won’t let anyone hurt you, either.”

Melog hops onto the foot of the bed, settling down right in front of my shins.

“Yeah,” Adora chuckles. “I kind of feel sorry for anyone that tries.”

“mmhmm,” I mumble sleepily. ”I’d totally… fuck them up.”

“I know. You’re my hero, too, by the way.”

“Shh, I never said that,” I yawn, my eyelids growing heavy as I watch the stars, silently drifting by outside of the window, and listen to the soft, ambient hum of Darla’s engines.

“Night, my beautiful, amazing stargazer…”

“Night, my love,” I whisper, feeling blissfully at peace.

Chapter End Notes

Glimmer: By the way, Adora - how come you don't heal your neck when... you know... you've obviously been up to something?
Adora: *whistles* no reason...
Catra: Because she likes everyone knowing she's mine. Isn't that right, my love?
Mermista: Ugh, you two are so gross...

Special thanks to blueeyesandhair for helping to edit & review this one. x

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Bonus: A steamy one shot from the morning scene, which you may have already read. Adora's POV.
Gotta feed the hungry gays...

Space Adventure Pals

Chapter Summary

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

I wake up lying flat on my back, and the first thing I notice is the weight of Adora's head upon my chest. She's fast asleep but snoring quietly, a sound I've heard enough times to know it's probably just before seven AM, etherian time.

I gently rest my hand upon her head, idly stroking my fingers through her silky hair as I slowly crack my eyes open, where I'm greeted by the sight of her blonde locks strewn messily across my chest. The sight of her sleeping so peacefully floods me with a feeling of contentment, spreading from my heart, down my arms and legs, all the way to my fingers and toes. It's an unfamiliar feeling, but it's so warm and wonderful that I can't help but purr, and when Melog purrs at exactly the same time I barely manage to stifle a giggle.

"Wow," Adora mumbles, opening one eye to peer up at me. "You two must be happy."

"We are, actually," I say, curling a lock of her hair around my finger. "I slept like a rock, and woke up with you asleep in my arms. Doesn't get much better than that."

"Wow, you *are* in a good mood," Adora says, repositioning herself until our heads lay side by side, and her brilliant blue eyes bore into mine. "You're being very sweet. I like it."

I shrug. "It was nice getting some things off my chest yesterday, I guess."

"So the sessions are helping?"

"I wasn't sure at first, but yeah," I say, looking across at my book, which I left on the shelf below the mirror. "Definitely."

I remember the things I wrote down yesterday, while Adora was freshening up.

The sound of Adora's laughter, the way her eyes light up when she smiles, and how it always fills me with joy.

My loyal and closest friend, Melog, and how they are always there for me, no matter what.

Entrapta's hair, and the mystery of how it even works. How does it work, anyway?

Perfuma's help, and how her sessions are helping me to figure myself out / feel less awful in general

Being able to go to space again, and see the stars. How watching them always takes my breath away.

I was only supposed to do three, I think, smiling. But it felt good, so I added extras.

"Are you okay?" Adora asks. She moves a hand to my cheek and gently strokes the fur behind my ear.

"Yeah," I purr, closing my eyes and smiling at her touch, "I was just thinking about my homework."

"Ugh, I'm so curious!"

I rest my hand upon hers, lightly digging my claws into her fingers. "Look inside that book and I *will* kill you."

Adora laughs, "Yes. I know better."

"Hmm, so," I say, stretching out over the top of the duvet, playfully digging my toes into Melog's ribs. "Are we staying in bed, orrr?"

Adora wiggles her eyebrows. "Well, it's still early, and I don't think anyone's awake."

Melog snorts, and raises their head, their eyes half-closed. "Mating?"

I burst into laughter, just as Melog hops off of the bed, then shakes their fur vigorously. They walk to the bedroom door, jump up and bash the button with their paw. "I am hungry, so I shall see you in the kitchen."

"See you later Melog," I say, leaning over Adora and winking at them. They huff, appearing amused before stepping outside, the door closing behind them with a soft *woosh*.

"Sooo…" Adora says, lidding her eyes. "Do they always know when you want a little Adora action?"

I scrunch my face up and shove her away. "For the sake of our relationship do not call it that, ever again."

"Are you saying you don't want me?" Adora asks, smiling smugly. "Because I'm pretty sure you do."

It's only then I realise that at some point I've positioned myself above her, and I'm now straddling her waist, my tail flickering behind. "Ugh! I can't decide if I want to punch you or…"

"Or?"

I lean down, blushing as I press my lips against her ear. "Fuck you."

The response is instant, Adora groans and arches herself upwards, digging her fingers into my thighs, and I feel a maddening surge of *need* shoot up from my pelvis. Before I know it we're undressing each other in a flurry, throwing our nightwear to the floor, and it's a battle of wills to see who can get the upper hand.

I don't care at all that Adora wins, her fingers touching me so perfectly that I can't help but relent, allowing her to roll on top of me. She kisses me softly, and I bite my lip into a smile, raising my hips to her touch, enjoying the sensation of her fingers, with her lightly teasing, featherlike touches.

"Adora," I say, rubbing my palm down her arm, "I won't break, you know."

"I know," Adora says, smiling softly. "I just want to savour this. It's the first time I've really touched you… with my hands, I mean."

"That's very sweet," I say, my heart feeling warm as I lean up for a quick kiss, pulling her neck down with me. I bite her lip, then dart my tongue across it. "But savour it more quickly."

Adora groans at the contact. "Someone's in a hurry."

"Yes, I am. I want you," I say, squeezing her chin between my finger and thumb. "Happy?"

"Very," Adora says, kissing me again, and pressing more firmly, finally offering me some relief.

"Mmm," I mumble against her lips, easing myself into her rhythm. "Better." But I still want more, and I know how to get it, too. I kiss my way across her jaw, until my teeth rest just beneath her ear. "More," I whisper, pressing my tongue to her skin, and trailing my nails across the back of her neck.

"Catra," Adora says, her whole body shuddering. "You'd better stop that."

"Or else?" I mumble, pinching her neck between my teeth, adding just a touch more pressure to my scratch. Not enough to hurt her.

Adora starts to writhe against my leg, and I smirk against her neck, knowing she's mine now. Her hand finally picks up speed, and I groan, pressing up against her digits, feeling heat pool between my legs.

"You're amazing," Adora pants, her eyes staring into mine, holding my gaze while I become wetter and wetter against her fingers. She leans down, trapping my lips in a long, open kiss, and I dig my fingers into her shoulders, barely keeping my claws sheathed, groaning, bucking myself to her hand.

Adora keeps me held in place, never stops those perfect motions, harder, faster, until a hot spike tears through me, rippling from my bud to my core and then through all of me, forcing me to cry out.

"A-Adora," I groan, squeezing my eyes closed. I thread my fingers into her hair while my jaw falls open, and I pant against her cheek, thrusting my hips, feeling waves of delicious heat erupt below her hand, swarming up through my abdomen, then knocking the breath from my lungs. "F-fuck!" I cry out, as a massive, final peak rocks through my body.

The aftershocks eventually ebb away, but the heat doesn't. I lean up and rest my hand behind Adora's neck, running my fingers across the tiny scratches I've left behind. When I open my eyes, I find her peering down at me, smiling.

"Enjoy yourself?" Adora asks, breathing hotly against my lips.

I grab her chin. “I’m going to wipe that smug grin off your face, Adora.”

“Oh, is that so?”

I lean up and push her onto her back, straddling her. “You’d better get ready, because I’m not holding back this time.”

Suddenly there’s a loud crackle from the corner of the room, followed by the sound of Glimmer clearing her throat. “As much fun as this is, can everyone please remember that Darla’s walls aren’t particularly *sound proof*?”

I feel my cheeks burn hotly, made all the worse when Adora completely loses it, laughing so loudly that tears spring to her reddened cheeks.

The speaker buzzes again. “I shall investigate the installation of sound proofing as soon as I’m able,” Entrapta says, humming to herself. “I suppose we should prioritise Adora’s room.”

Adora laughs even louder and I leap from the bed, grabbing the microphone just as she falls off of the bed, still laughing.

“Okay you’ve all had your fun,” I say, rolling my eyes.

“Not as much fun as some people,” Bow says, with Glimmer giggling in the background.

“Just shut up!” I seethe, putting the microphone back. I look down to see Adora staring up at me from the floor, still giggling to herself.

“This is not funny,” I pout.

“It kind of is.”

“Um,” this time it’s Scorpia on the comms, and I groan loudly. “Melog is rolling around in here. I think they’re laughing? I’m not sure. But it’s really cute!”

“Scorpia, where did you go?” Perfuma asks. “I thought you were getting us some refreshing herbal tea.”

“I think I got lost. How do I get to the mess hall?”

“Where are you now?” Bow asks.

“The observatory. Melog is being super adorable,” Scorpia says. “Aren’t you, there’s a good Melog. Aren’t you the best fluffy buddy ever, yes you are, because you help my friend with all her emotions, don’t you-”

I grab the microphone. “Scorpia,” I say, groaning. “Take your hand off the button.”

“Oh, right.”

“You need to go back through the door,” Bow says, yawning. “Then down one level.”

“Okay! Thanks!”

“And don’t forget the tea!”

Adora stands up and walks over, still chuckling to herself, then takes the microphone from me. “Hey everyone,” she purrs, narrowing her eyes.

“Adora. Don’t you dare-”

“You should probably put earplugs in, because we’re just getting start- ah!”

I pounce on her, pinning her to the floor, pressing my hand over her mouth.

“Why do I put up with you?” I hiss, stroking my other palm down my face, peering at her through the cracks between my fingers.

Adora kisses my palm. “Because you love me?”

I blow out a puff of air. “Sometimes I wonder why.”

“How about I make it up to you with breakfast?” she asks, kissing my hand a few more times. “I’ll cook you some eggs and bacon.”

“Hmm. Okay but it better be good,” I say, smirking, “because I’d much rather eat you.”

“You know you can have both, right?” Adora asks, kissing the tips of my fingers.

“Ahem, sorry to interrupt,” Perfuma says, “I think you left your microphone on.”

“Oh for the love of,” I begin, snatching the device from Adora, then standing up and slamming it back into the receptacle.

Adora steps behind me, resting her chin on my shoulder and her hands around my waist. “So, what’ll it be first? Bacon, or me?”

I chuckle, leaning back into her embrace. “I’m actually hungry. Besides, the walls have ears, apparently.”

“Aww, well,” Adora says, nudging her lips against my neck, “I’m not letting you go until you’ve kissed me at least.”

“Is that so,” I say, turning around, and licking my lips. A second later Adora lunges forwards and kisses me, pinning me to the wall, and I grab her waist, squeezing my hands into her flesh, needing to feel her-

“Damn it Adora!”

“What?”

“Why do I have no self control around you?”

“Because I'm irresistible?” Adora says, lowering her gaze to my lips.

“Ugh!” I say, pressing my palm into her face. “I’m gonna go freshen up. Just stop… with all this,” I say, waving my other hand up and down in front of her, while looking away.

“What, you seriously can’t even look at me?” Adora asks, and I can hear the damn smugness in her voice.

I force myself to stare directly into her eyes, the tip of my tail twitching. “I am hungry. I am going to wash. You are going to wash. And then we are going to eat.”

Adora salutes, “Yes, force-captain.”

I quickly turn away from her, trying to blink away the image burned into my mind of her standing there, naked, with an infuriatingly smug smirk, her hair all messed up, and those damn sexy eyes piercing into mine.

What’s wrong with me? I think, pressing the bathroom door button.

--

I check my helmet a few times, making sure it’s sealed properly, before checking Adora’s.

“Don’t worry,” she says, smiling. “We’ll be fine.”

“Yeah,” I mumble, looking over my suit, making sure it’s in one piece. Then I notice a new addition that I’m fairly sure wasn’t there before. There’s a small, oval badge with a pink border, dark-grey background and the word SAP printed in white, bold letters. “What’s this for?” I ask, scowling. “Who’s calling me a sap!?”

“We’re Space Adventure Pals!” Bow says, beaming and tapping a finger on his own badge.

“I modified the suits accordingly,” Entrapta says, placing her hands on her waist and puffing her chest out.

“What?!” I exclaim. “I never agreed to that.”

Adora starts to laugh, and I nudge her in the ribs, pouting.

“I think it’s a great name!” Scorpia says.

“Of course you do,” I say, shaking my head but smiling, wondering what I’m getting myself into with these idiots.

“Okay everyone,” Glimmer says, her hand hovering over the lever above Darla’s exit. “Get ready!”

We all wait and watch, a nervous but excited anticipation hanging thick in the air, while Darla’s ramp slowly slides open with a loud *whirr*, and then extends downwards until it rests upon the red foliage below.

Entrapta walks down first, checking a few readings on her handheld tablet. “Our scans were correct!” she says, untwisting her helmet and popping it off. “The atmosphere is completely breathable.”

Good, I think, twisting my own helmet to the left, then pulling it off. Everyone else does the same, and we leave the helmets behind on top of a crate in the storage room, before heading down the ramp.

The first thing I notice is how cool and crisp the air is, the second is how different the skies are, compared to Etheria’s. There are two suns, one orange, one red, a finger’s width apart in the light blue sky overhead. On the crest of the horizon, framed behind jagged, purple trees, the colour of the sky shifts into a shade of jade green.

“Gosh, it’s so pretty,” Perfuma says, bending down to examine the peculiar red, springy foliage below our feet.

“You mean pretty amazing!” Bow exclaims, holding up his tablet, “These energy readings are off the charts!”

“That would be the thulite,” Entrapta says, pointing one of her pigtails into the distance. “There’s a cave not far from here that should be full of it!”

“And the planet isn’t collapsing this time,” Glimmer says, laughing nervously. “Such a nice change.”

“Away team commander Catra,” Adora says, furrowing her brows and resting her hands at her hips, “What should our next action be?”

“Haha!” I laugh, “You… wait, are you being serious?”

Adora shrugs. “Sure, you keep saying we’re reckless. So why don’t you show us how it’s done?”

“Well,” I say, raising an eyebrow at her suspiciously, “we should head to the cave. It’s why we’re here, right?”

--

We walk for about half an hour until we’re almost at the cave, where the foliage is thicker at our feet, and walking has become more difficult.

Suddenly, a strange but interesting scent floats past my nostrils. It’s an unusual, almost spicy aroma, coming from not far ahead, growing stronger and stronger the further we walk.

“Melog,” I say, wrinkling my nose,” do you smell that?”

Melog sneezes, and twitches their left ear. “I wonder what it could be?” they ask, lowering their snout and sniffing along the ground.

“Right? It’s weird,” I say, following them, crouching onto all fours, “but I kind of like it. No, wait... I *really* like it.”

“Catra?” Adora asks. But I’m too preoccupied with following Melog until we find some leafy bushes, a dark shade of purple compared to the surrounding foliage, and with golden round berries strewn throughout.

“Wow,” I say, thrusting my nose into the bush,” This is amazing,” I mumble, chewing on one of the leaves, my mouth filling with spicy saliva.

“Um, I don’t think we should eat the plants,” Perfuma says.

“Seriously, come smell this,” I say, tilting my head up, and staring at everyone. “Hey, when did you all get so tall?” I ask, before laughing and diving back into the amazing scent, rubbing one side of my face against the rough leaves. But then I feel two hands grip my shoulders, pulling me away.

“No! Hey!” I growl, looking up. “You’re no fun, Adora.”

“I think that plant is affecting you,” she says, bending down and stroking her fingers behind my ear. “Are you okay?”

“I’m great!” I say, shaking myself loose from her grip, then jumping back onto the interesting plant. I put my arms around it and hug it protectively, while Melog rolls around in an adjacent bush.

“Plant plant plant pla-a-a-a-nt,” Melog says, then pauses mid-roll to look at me, their head tipped to one side. ”Bush.”

“You are right!” I say, sitting bolt upright, ”it is a plant-bush, that is a brilliant observation, Melog,” I say, wiggling my finger in the air. “Captain-commander Adora, I demand we promote Melog to the science captain chief-in-command.”

“Oh!” Scorpia says, pressing the tips of her pincers together, “I would totally be okay with that. I bet Melog is so smart!”

Melog snorts and headbutts Scorpia’s thigh. “Yes, I am.”

“Looks like you just made a new friend, Scorpia,” I say, rolling around on the ground a few times.

“Okay, we should go back to the ship and work this out,” Adora says, kneeling down next to me, close enough that I can stare right into those pretty eyes of hers. *Hmm*, I think. *I wanna kiss her, right on the mouth*.

“Hey Adora,” I say, jumping to my feet, standing by her side and wrapping my tail around her waist. “You smell… hmm... *good*. And I know why you want to get me back on that ship,” I whisper, loudly. “You want my mouth here,” I say, pressing a finger to her lips, “and here,” I say, tapping the tip of my tail below her abdomen.

“Yup. We’re going back right now,” Adora says, batting my tail away, “I’m worried this is hurting them.”

“Why would it hurt us?” Melog says, while walking in circles on their two front paws. “It is a plant. It means no harm.”

“Melog says it’s a plant, and also,” I say, placing a finger on Adora’s lip, and flicking it a few times, “he says you’re an idiot,” I say, frowning. “No wait, I’m saying that.”

“Okay, come on,” Adora says, placing my arm around her shoulder. I wrap my tail around her thigh, then nuzzle my face against her face. “Haha, stop it,” Adora says, laughing.

I love making her laugh, I think, nuzzling her again for good measure. “Hmm. You smell so good…”

“You already said that.”

“No, *you* already said that,” I frown, wrinkling my nose and pointing to the other twelve people. “And what are *they* looking at?”

“Don’t bring us into this,” Glimmer says, holding her hands out.

Melog headbutts my leg, getting my attention. “Are you headed back to mate?”

“Hah!” I laugh, grinning widely at Adora, “Melog says we should mate. So let’s go mate.”

“I’ll take you back to bed, but not for that,” Adora says, blushing lightly.

“Uh Huh. Hey, everyone!” I say, grinning, “Did you know, Adora tastes soooo good,” I say, pausing mid-step to face Adora, squishing her cheeks between my palms. “I wanna eat her up, because she tastes amazing, better than anything I’ve ever-”

“You’ll thank me later for this,” Adora says, placing her hand over my mouth and muffling my words while I mumble all kinds of things about her delicious flavour.

We walk a few more paces before I realise that my precious plant is being left behind, and it’s probably feeling quite lonely without me. I remove my arm from Adora’s shoulder and turn around, hurrying back towards it.

“Okay, that does it. *For the honour of grayskull!*”

I rest my head in the lovely purple leaves and watch my tasty girlfriend transform into a giant, muscular goddess. “Hey, Bow,” I say, chewing a leaf, raising an eyebrow, “Did you see that? You’re jealous, aren’t you? I would be too.”

Adora leans down and scoops me up like I’m weightless, and I burst into laughter while she carries me over her shoulder. “LOOK AT THE SIZE OF HER ARMS!” I yell at the others, jiggling my feet in the air, trying to tickle Adora’s nose with my tail.

“Pfft, stop it,” Adora says, batting away my tail.

“You’re being boring.” I pout.

“I’m just worried about you, you’re clearly not being yourself.”

I mimic her in a higher-pitched voice, “you’re clearly not being yourself. Let’s just go to bed, Adora.”

“I *am* taking you to bed, after we get you checked out.”

“Good,” I say, smirking as I run my tail around one of her biceps. “Are you gonna touch me with those giant She-Ra hands?”

I listen, delighted, as Adora’s heart beats a whole lot faster. She coughs. “Okay. You’re *definitely* not being yourself. Just hold on, we’re almost there.”

--

“I don’t like it in here,” I say, scrunching up my nose. The metal table beneath me is cold, and the sight of medical cabinets all around makes me feel uneasy.

“Okay, I’ve got it,” Entrapta says, coming towards me with some weird metal rod thing. “Keep her still and I’ll scan for any toxins,” she says, waving the strange device in my face. I dive forwards, grabbing it in my mouth. “No, not food, bad kitty,” Entrapta says, snatching the instrument away and then waving it up and down a few times.

“What does it say?” Adora asks, keeping me held tightly, and I lick my lips while running my gaze across those huge, sexy arms of hers.

“Well, it’s nothing serious at least,” Entrapta says, humming. “There are no harmful toxins present.”

“But?”

“Looking at her vitals, I’d have to conclude Catra is basically… high. Like really, really high.”

“Oh,” Adora says, appearing relieved as she releases me from her grip. “Then why isn’t it affecting us?”

“It seems to affect Melog too,” Bow says, “So maybe it’s something to do with cat DNA?”

“Or it affects Melog because it affects Catra. We don’t actually know what their DNA is because I’m not allowed to study them,” Entrapta says, pouting.

“They’re my buddy,” I say, holding a finger up and trying to stick it up Entrapa’s nostril, but she bats my hand away with her weird hair.

“So, how long do you think it will last?” Perfuma asks, and I groan loudly, wondering when the boring questions will stop.

“A few hours, so long as she isn’t exposed to the plant again.”

“Oooh, more plant *exposure*,” I say, sitting up and pricking my ears forwards. “That is such a good idea!”

“Nope,” Adora says, picking me up and cradling me in her arms. “You’re going to take a nap and sleep this off, okay?”

“Bah. Boring.”

--

Before I know it we’re back in our room, and I’m laid back on the bed with Adora’s hands on my shoulders, waiting for her to undress me. But she doesn't, which is disappointing to say the least.

“Hey,” I smirk, tapping the mattress at my side. “What are you waiting for? I know you want me.”

Adora smiles softly, then picks up Melog from the floor and places them at the foot of the bed, where they continue to snore loudly. She sits on the mattress, leans over me, and tips her nose to mine, “Ask me again when you’re sober.”

“Booooring,” I say, yawning. “I’m not even tired, and your arms are very large.”

Adora threads her fingers into my hair, messes it up a bit, then kisses me on the forehead. “I love you, my stoned little stargazer.”

“Love you too, giant sexy lady,” I say, stretching out, then curling into a ball on one side, watching Adora watch me for a while. “You have beautiful eyes.”

“So do you,” she says, reaching a hand out and stroking my cheek. “I’ve always loved how different yours are.”

“Really?”

“Of course. Even when we were kids.”

“Hah, you were always so dumb, Adora Goofy Boogerface.”

“Says Catra Applesauce MeowMeow.”

“Pfft, haha, you remembered!”

“Of course I did,” Adora says, leaning down against the mattress, shrinking down to her smaller but sexier size, and resting her head on the other pillow, facing me. “But I always wondered, why Boogerface?”

“You had a huge green booger there once,” I say, smirking and pressing my finger under her nose. “It was so gross.”

“Eww!” Adora says, laughing. “You could have told me.”

I smile while slowly closing my eyes, kneading my palms and fingers into her shoulders a few times, pressing my claws out ever so slightly with each push. Adora makes a weird sound, and I crack my eyes open, just a little. “What?”

“You haven’t done that for a very, very long time,” Adora says, smiling sweetly, gently stroking her fingers behind my ear.

“Done what?” I yawn, closing my eyes while my chest erupts into a loud purr. “Shh, it’s bedtime.”

“Sleep tight, baby.”

--

I crack open one eye, feeling rather groggy, and roughly rub my palms against my face. “Melog?”

“I am here,” they say, lifting their head from the foot of the bed.

“Ugh, what *was* that?”

“Whatever it was, it was very potent. I can still feel some of the effects.”

“Yeah, you can say that again,” I say, looking down at my hand and watching it appear to grow a little, then shrink a little.

Melog hops from the mattress and stretches out their front legs, their claws digging into the grey carpet and pulling a few strands of the material loose. “I am hungry.”

“Hmm, me too. Come on,” I say, standing from the bed, then squeezing my eyes closed when I suddenly feel dizzy.

We head to the kitchen and I stretch my hand under my spacesuit to scratch at my shoulders, feeling clammy from sleeping in the damn thing. *Adora’s fault for not undressing me*, I think, pouting, though a bigger part of me thinks it was sweet that she looked after me.

“Hey, Darla, are you there?” I ask, looking around at the ceiling while we walk into the kitchen.

- Personal enquiry detected. -

- Yes, I am here. It would be difficult for me to be anywhere else, given that my core is installed in the engine room of this vessel. -

“Wow, Entrapta just pumped you full of sass, didn’t she?”

- My personality core is functioning perfectly. Is yours? -

“That’s harsh,” I chuckle, grabbing a couple of chocolate and coconut protein bars from a cupboard, while Melog helps themselves to more tiny steaks.

- Was there anything else? -

“Yes. Where is everyone?”

- My scanners are not advanced enough to detect the location of everyone, but I do detect there are approximately four hundred billion lifeforms within range. -

“The *crew*, Darla,” I say, rolling my eyes.

- Acknowledged. Please review the visual. -

A hologram pops up on one of the kitchen walls, showing an overhead map of the planet, with an overlay of six dots shining brightly inside what looks to be the cave we headed towards earlier.

“They are not moving,” Melog says, whining.

“Oh great, what shit have they gotten themselves into this time,” I mumble, feeling a ball of anxiety well up in my chest. I hop from the kitchen stool, swig down a glass of water, and hurry towards the cargo bay.

--

I stomp down the ramp into the cargo area, and hear a sudden, agitated beep, watching as Emily’s rotund form scuttles away until she’s hidden behind a stack of crates.

Oh, that’s right, I think, folding my ears down. *I was awful to her*.

“Emily?” I ask, taking a chance. “You can come out. I won’t bite, I promise.”

The bot peeps around from behind the crates, and I take a moment to wonder just how advanced Entrapta’s machines are. *Sometimes they almost seem human*, I think, crouching down in an attempt to appear less threatening.

“We’re going out to find the others, I think they’re in trouble,” I say, watching Emily slowly shift into view. “Do you want to come? We might need the help.”

Emily bleeps a few times, then quickly scuttles over and makes a long, whirring sound which I assume to be a *yes*. I peer at the top of her chassis, feeling a pang of guilt at the sight of several deeply-grooved claw marks.

“Sorry about that, by the way,” I say, slowly reaching a hand towards the metal scar. Emily starts to shift away, so I pause my movement. But then she hops forwards into my palm, and I grin, tapping her plated armour a few times.

“It seems you have made a friend,” Melog says, appearing amused.

“Yeah,” I say, standing up and beaming at the two of them. “Okay, let’s go rescue those idiots.”

--

I chew on my second ration bar while travelling on Melogs back, with Emily easily matching our pace, following closely behind. I can't help but feel anxious about what waits ahead, especially when that it's something that can supposedly stop She-Ra.

We follow the same route as earlier, soon coming across those same alluring purple plants, their scent drifting beneath my nostrils. "Shit," I say, feeling dizzy.

"We must ignore it."

"Yeah, totally, we can do that," I say while we speed past the bushes, ignoring the fact I so desperately want to jump back in there. "But…"

"No, Catra," Melog says, their paws digging into the dirt, and their form twisting in a sharp U-turn when I hop from their back.

"Just a little!" I say, leaping forwards and snapping off a couple of branches, before turning to Emily. "Hey, got anywhere you can put these?"

Emily beeps excitedly and rotates to the left, where a small metal compartment pops out from the side.

"Perfect," I say, placing my treasures inside, and breaking off a tiny leaf to nibble on, while Melog glares at me accusingly. "What? I didn't do anything!"

"We should make haste."

"I know, let's go already!" I say, hopping onto their back, feeling less anxious the more I chew at the leaf. "Faster, faster!" I say, grinning as the wind whips through my hair.

"Hold on tightly," Melog says, grunting,and picking up the pace, the huge cave growing rapidly closer until the dark and foreboding entrance looms before us.

"Be careful," Melog says, their ears pricked up. "It is too quiet."

"Emily, stay close," I say, spitting the remnants of the leaf onto the floor, the taste having become stale. "Melog, you know what to do."

Melog nods, and a moment later Emily, Melog and I disappear from view. "Will you be okay?" Melog asks, tilting their head back, watching me as I hop from their back and stretch out. "This could be dangerous."

"I feel great, actually," I say, my heart rate increasing as we step further into the darkness. "I just hope those idiots are okay."

-*ROAR*-

A sudden, ferocious and loud growl echoes through the cave, and I feel all of my fur stand on end. "Oh shit. Shit shit shit."

Emily emits the tiniest, low pitched whine.

"We must remain quiet," Melog says, haunching down.

We slow our pace and carefully explore the depths of the cave, until all natural light has gone, and the only illumination offered is from the thulite crystals, strewn throughout the cave, their purple glow eerie in the darkness.

Grrrrr...

This time I hear a low, guttural growl. “It came from over there,” I say, pointing to one of the two wide tunnels ahead of us. Melog nods, and we pick up our pace a little, heading further in, walking cautiously until the tunnel opens up into a large room, brimming with crystals of every colour.

My jaw falls open. In the center is the largest beast I’ve ever set my eyes on. It slowly turns its three, massive heads in our direction, six nostrils widening as it sniffs the air.

Each gigantic head is covered with red fur and whiskers, and has two glistening eyes with vertically slitted irises, boring down upon us, as though it can see us. The rest of the beast appears similar in shape to an oversized jaguar, with patchy, darker markings along it’s fur. Towards the back, three long tails whip around angrily, each one illuminated by a different coloured flicker of light - red, yellow and green.

The beast growls again, before taking a couple of steps in our direction, and I grit my teeth, taking slow, measured breaths. It pauses in its tracks, and at this proximity I realise that one of it’s paws alone is bigger than I am. I swallow thickly, knowing that it could crush us all in a heartbeat.

Melog nudges me with their nose, and then taps their head towards one of the corners of the large, rainbow coloured cave. And that’s when I finally spot the rest of our dumb little crew, hiding away behind a very large, orange crystal.

They’re alive, I think, feeling relief wash over me. *Now we just need to get them out of here*.

I watch as the mega beast turns away from us, and begins to sniff around the cave, no doubt looking for the others.

“He mustn't have a very good nose,” Melog whispers, once the triple-headed cat is further away.

I wince. “He might have good ears though,” I whisper, as quietly as I can.

Thankfully, the cat doesn’t appear to hear us, and groans loudly before flopping down onto its belly, and licking one of it’s paws.

Melog frowns, and tilts their head.

“What is it?”

“Actually, I do not think it is a he.”

“What? Oh.” I say, following Melogs gaze. Now that she is laid down, the beast is very clearly, very heavily, pregnant, her belly bulging at the sides.

“Okay well, let’s just make sure we don’t disturb her. Come on.”

We carefully, slowly walk around the outskirts of the cave, until we’re next to the crystal the others are standing behind. A small, crazy, and no doubt leaf-inspired part of me wants to jump out from stealth and frighten them, but a sudden loud sniff from the giant kitty reminds me that it’s probably not the best idea.

“Wait here,” I whisper to Melog, knowing that if I startle them, they’re going to make some kind of noise like the idiots they are.

Thankfully, stealth was always one of my greatest skills long before I met Melog, and I have no problem at all hopping across a few high ledges until I’m just above the others. I peer down, feeling my heart constrict when I notice that Adora’s forehead is bleeding, and Glimmer is crouched down checking over the wound.

I tap a stone quietly against the ledge a few times, sounding out one of our secret Horde signals in the hope that Adora or Scorpia are paying attention. Scorpia looks up, her eyes widening, then starts to whisper to the others, and once I know they’re not going to make a scene I hop down and hurry towards Adora.

“What happened?” I whisper.

“She hit her head,” Bow says, wincing. “Hard.”

Adora snorts. “I’m fii-”

“Shh!” I say, placing my finger on Adora’s lips, before turning to face Glimmer. “Why don’t you just teleport everyone back out?”

“Something is blocking their powers,” Entrapta whispers, peering through the crystal at the large, triple-headed cat. “I suspect it’s the creature, somehow, but I would need to run some tests to be sure.”

“Or, we could just leave the giant, deadly monster alone,” I say, rolling my eyes.

“Ooh,” Scorpia says, appearing way too happy, “why don’t we try to talk to him?”

“It’s a her. And pregnant, too,” I say, folding my arms. “So we’re going to leave her alone, and sneak out of here, *quietly*. Do you think you can all manage that?”

--

Moments later we’re all invisible, with Adora riding on Melog’s back and the rest of us quietly walking around the furthest edges of the cave, stopping in our tracks every time the cat makes a sound or pricks a pair of her six ears up.

“Will she be okay?” Melog asks, tipping his head back towards Adora.

I pause to help Adora tighten her grip on Melog’s fur, feeling worried she might pass out of something. “I don’t know. Let’s hurry.”

We shift ever closer to the tunnel that leads outside, when a river of dust suddenly streams down from the ceiling, landing directly onto my face. I cough and sputter, just as Melog sneezes, and the veil of stealth falls.

“Shit!” I say, pricking my ears back.

Everything happens in a blur. The beast jumps to her feet with a terrifyingly loud roar, and she heads straight towards us.

“Everyone out!” I yell. “Now!”

We flee down the tunnel but the beast is fast, too fast, and the ground shakes with every stomp of her paws, causing rubble and dust to fill the air, making it difficult to see what's ahead of me.

We're not going to make it, I think, knowing we have maybe a few seconds before we're all cat food. *Think, damn it, think*. A crazy idea springs to mind, and I rap my knuckles on Emily's secret compartment. "Emily, open up!"

The bot beeps, her drawer shoots open, and I quickly grab the thick branches inside, pausing mid-sprint and twisting to face the incoming beast, then roaring at her as loudly as I'm able. She pauses in her tracks, her front paws kicking up dust as she skids to a halt. She leans down and roars back at me defiantly, three sets of huge fangs glistening with the purple glow of the surrounding thulite, the heat of her breath gushing past my face.

"Catra!" Adora yells.

"Just keep going!" I yell back, before clamping the special branches between my teeth.

The cat raises one paw, swiping her frighteningly sharp claws towards me, and I dash forwards, ducking beneath it, narrowly avoiding the attack before leaping onto her other massive leg and quickly clambering up her form.

Once I'm on her shoulders I pounce onto her middle head, clutching onto the short mane there and holding on tightly while she thrashes beneath me, growing increasingly agitated. She jolts viciously into the air and almost dislodges me, but I somehow keep myself held tight, my muscles straining from the exertion.

Soon afterwards she starts to tire, and I'm able to relax my hold. I remove the bushes from my mouth, spitting out a few loose leaves before thrusting the whole thing down, waving it towards her snout.

"I'm not going to hurt you, okay?" I say, and the cat growls in response, before tipping her snout up and sniffing loudly a few times. She whines loudly, then snorts and flops down to all fours, tipping her head back and peering up at me while the dust around us settles.

"See?" I say, gently placing my palm on her forehead, and stroking her thick fur a few times. She grunts in response, and nudges her head up into my touch. "Good girl," I say, tussling my fingers into her fur, then dropping the twigs to the floor and stroking her roughly with both hands until she bursts into a loud, happy purr, causing the crystals around the cave to rattle.

Then I notice the others just ahead, paused in their tracks with their jaws hanging open. I hop down and walk away from my new friend, but she emits a startled, agitated grunt, so I turn around and stroke her snout again, tipping my forehead into her fur. "It's okay. They won't hurt you. I promise."

Once she's settled down again I walk towards the others. "So... I think I made a new friend."

"Wow," Adora says, peering behind me.

I reach my hand to her wound, and pull her forehead down, kissing the area gently. "Why haven't you healed this yet?"

"We had to come and get you..."

"You need to learn to trust me, Adora."

"I know. Sorry," she says, smiling softly. "I'll fix it as soon as I can transform, okay?"

“Go outside, and fix it now.”

“But-”

“Adora.”

“Fine…” Adora says, turning and walking towards the exit, turning her head one more time just to pout at me.

“Seems you have a knack for making friends lately,” Melog says, appearing amused. They walk with me towards the beast, then sniff around one of her huge paws. She suddenly leans down and licks them, her giant tongue causing their body to leave the ground by an inch. “I like her,” Melog says, huffing.

“Yeah, me too,” I say, smiling.

“Ooh, what are you gonna call her?” Scorpia asks, beaming excitedly while she walks towards us.

“If she’s our friend she must have a name, after all,” Perfuma says, clasping her hands together.

“Hmm,” I say, twitching my ears. “Terra. Because she lives underground, and because she’s a little terror.”

“Little?” Glimmer says, raising an eyebrow.

“She doesn’t seem so big and scary now,” I say, walking back to her and rubbing the tips of my nails into her fur, “do you, girl? No. You were just looking after your babies. Because you’re a good girl, yes you are-”

“Hah! Catra,” Adora says, chuckling as she moves next to me, her forehead thankfully healed up. She slowly holds a hand out, starts to stroke Terra, then turns to look at me. “I’ve never seen you like this. Are you okay?”

I wrinkle my nose. “Well, I was holding that bush stuff in my mouth for a while.”

“Ahhh,” Adora says, giggling when Terra nudges her large snout against her hand. “That explains it.”

“Explains what?”I pout. “I’m always nice, to animals at least.”

Everyone else approaches Terra, slowly and carefully, until she’s purring more loudly than ever, seeming to very much enjoy the several sets of hands stroking her three heads all at once.

“She’s so soft,” Bow says, appearing as though he’s about to burst into tears. “I could do this forever!”

“This is fun and all, but we’re going to go grab some thulite,” Entrapta says, tapping a pigtail atop Emily’s metal chassis. “Come on girl!”

--

“Well, mission accomplished,” I say, whipping Adora’s firm butt with my tail. “You smell great, by the way.”

“Hah, the plant definitely got to you, didn’t it?” Adora asks, her grin stretching from ear to ear.

I hold up my forefinger and thumb. “A bit. Or maybe I just think you smell super nice today.”

“Uhuh,” Adora says, nudging her shoulder against mine, then tipping her head back towards Terra, who’s following us. “I’m really impressed, by the way.”

“Yeah,” I say, shrugging. “I guess I must have a knack when it comes to animals.”

“Hey, I just had a thought!” Scorpia says, grinning.

“Did it hurt?” I ask.

“Don’t be mean, Catra,” Perfuma scolds.

“I’m sorry,” I say, wrinkling my nose. “Scorpia, you were saying?”

“Maybe that’s your secret princess power. You can talk to animals!”

“I am not a princess, Scorpia,” I say, tipping my head up. “I’m way too classy for that.”

“Classy! Hah!” Adora snorts.

I pause mid-step and leap onto her, lacing our fingers and pressing her hands to the floor, tipping my nose to hers. “I’m classier than you’ll ever be, princess.”

Adora blushes and quickly leans up, kissing me. “I don’t care what you are, so long as you’re mine.”

“Hmm, I am,” I purr, slowly swaying my tail to and fro while I lower my lips to hers. “But you’re mine, too.”

“Aww,” Bow says, his eyes sparkling. “You two are so-”

“Finish that sentence and die.”

“Isn’t love wonderful,” Perfuma says, bending down and blossoming a flower in Adora’s hair, then mine.

“Are you all quite finished?” I ask, grumbling to myself as I stand up.

“It appears that the effects of the special plant have finally worn off,” Entrapta says, studying me closely. “Interesting.”

Adora stands up and wraps her arms around me. “She doesn’t need a plant. She loves me anyway, don’t you, baby.”

“What? Adora!” I exclaim, feeling my cheeks burn. “Pack it in.”

She places her lips to my ear, whispering. “That’s what you get for leaving me high and dry this morning.”

“I was hungry,” I mutter, twitching my tail.

“Okay,” Glimmer says, chuckling, “let’s head back so these two can get a little alone time.”

--

I watch as the others head back towards Darla, leaving Adora, myself, and our new giant cat friend.

“You know we can’t take her with us, right?” Adora asks, smirking as she squeezes my fingers. I look down, wondering when we even joined hands. *It just seems to happen by itself now*, I think, smiling to myself.

Terra makes a loud grunting sound, then lifts her three snouts and sniffs the air vigorously a few times before dashing away, until I can see her in the distance, rolling around on the large patch of purple bushes.

“Well, that should keep her busy,” I say, chuckling.

“So what’s it like?” Adora asks. “The effects of that plant, I mean.”

“Hard to explain. Kind of like I'm weightless, and everything is a whole lot funnier.”

“Sounds fun!”

“It was, honestly. Melog was hilarious.”

“You were pretty messed up yourself. Do you even remember what you said?”

“Ugh,” I chuckle, shaking my head. “Don’t remind me.”

Adora thins her lips into a smug smile. “Hey, at least I didn’t take advantage of you.”

I lick my lips, feeling heat flicker below my gut. “I kind of wanted you to, though.”

“Hmm, well,” Adora says, biting her lower lip. “We could go join the others, or…”

“Or what? We are not making out here, Adora,” I say, laughing, “despite what your friends think.”

“They’re your friends too, you know.”

“Hmm, I guess. But seriously, they’d probably watch us through Darla’s scanners. So no thanks.”

“I really don’t think they care that much about our antics. They just like messing with you.”

I wrap my hands around her waist and kiss her swiftly, grinning from ear to ear. “Sounds to me like you want to do it, right here.”

“Are you saying you don’t?” Adora asks, lidding her eyes.

“You’re sure they won’t watch?” I ask, twitching my tail.

“Positive.”

I leap onto her again, pushing her to the mossy, red grass below. “Well,” I purr, lowering my lips to hers, “In that case…”

--

“So,” I say, picking at my mountain of very small cod bites. “I got the overall gist of it, but what exactly happened to you guys in there?”

“More like what happened to *you* guys,” Gimmer says, smiling smugly. “Is this your special way of conquering a planet?”

Adora snorts out a laugh while I pull another twig out of my hair. “That is *not* up for discussion,” I say, elbowing Adora in the ribs when she continues to laugh. “Come on, spill it. How did you mess up so badly?”

“One minute we were grabbing thulite,” Bow says, grimacing, “and the next, a giant three-headed cat was very, very angry with us.”

“We tried to defend ourselves,” Glimmer says, sighing, “only to discover that our powers didn’t work.”

“Even She-Ra only lasted a minute, and then poof!” Adora says, stretching out her hands, “gone.”

I tussle my fingers into Adora’s fringe, remembering the nasty gash from before. “How did you get hurt, anyway?”

Adora blushes, “well…”

“She cracked her head on the ceiling when we ran away,” Scorpia says, frowning. “It was so loud! I’m surprised she didn’t pass out.”

“I almost did,” Adora says, wincing. “Woops.”

“You’re such an idiot,” I say, smiling.

“I’m grateful it turned out this way, though,” Perfuma says, sipping a cup of herbal tea. “Had we used our powers, we could have hurt Terra.”

“Oh and then her babies might have been-” Scorpia says, then chokes on her words, her eyes turning watery.

“Hey,” I say, grinning. “We should come back later, I want to see Terra’s litter.”

Scorpia gasps, almost dropping her spoon in excitement. “That would be amazing!”

“Yes, it would!” Perfuma exclaims, clasping her hands together. “Do you think she will remember us?”

“Of course,” I say, pricking up my ears and smiling. “We’re her friends now.”

“You just want to come back for your new favourite plant,” Adora says, one side of her lips curling into a smirk.

“I can't deny that,” I say, grinning. “Melog wouldn’t complain either, would you buddy?”

“Of course not,” They say, snorting. “The sensation is very interesting.”

“Speaking of which,” Entrapta says, sipping at a bright-purple fizzy drink. “I took the liberty of taking samples. As I already concluded, there are zero toxins present, yet I suspect there are several beneficial properties. I would need to run more tests to be sure.”

“Ooh! Do you need any help?” I ask, grinning. “With the tests, I mean.”

“Yes! That would be extremely useful!”

“Wow,” Bow says. “Entrapta and Catra doing sciencey stuff together? Never thought I’d see the day.”

“She isn’t doing it for science, nitwit,” Glimmer says, gently elbowing him in the ribs.

“Pfft,” I say, chuckling. “Guilty as charged.”

“Oh, I just realised!” Bow exclaims, his eyes glistening, “Catra, you did something totally unplanned, stupid and recklness today, just for us!”

“I… I did, didn’t I?” I ask, twitching my ears. “Ugh, it’s contagious.”

“It was pretty amazing for our first adventure together,” Bow says, beaming. “And I’d say it went pretty well all things considered.”

I raise an eyebrow. “If that’s your idea of things going well, I don’t want to see what things going badly looks like.”

“Well, we have you to look after us now,” Perfuma says, smiling as she tips her head towards me. “So I’m sure we will all be fine.”

“Here’s to our away team commander,” Adora says, kissing me on the cheek.

I rest my head against her shoulder, feeling my heart fill with warmth while I listen to everyone chat excitedly about our first adventure. And I soon wonder, as always, how I even got here, but then I decide that instead of wondering I should simply feel grateful. And so I do, making a mental note to add an entry to my book later.

My friends, old and new. How they’re always so kind to me, and make me laugh, make me squirm, make me angry, happy, and just… so glad to be here.

Chapter End Notes

Perfuma: It is wonderful that you took your homework so seriously. I'm very proud!
Catra: Well, if it seems stupid but it works, it isn't stupid, right?
Perfuma: I... I suppose that's one way of looking at it.

Special thanks to blueeyesandhair again for helping to edit & and trash some parts of this rather long chapter! x

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Marriage and Memories

Chapter Summary

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

“Okay!” Bow says, tapping his fingers onto Darla’s panel. “Here’s what we have so far!”

Several top-down images flash onto the display, each one showing a section of forest in various shades of leafy green.

“So there’s trees,” I say, frowning. “Good to know. Useful.”

“But there’s more!” Entrapta says, shoving Bow out of the way and swiping her hair against the on-screen display, until the green foliage turns translucent, and an overlay appears showing coloured areas ranging from blue to orange, yellow and white. “This view shows us various levels of heat. Observe the warm parts!” she says, tapping her tail onto a few orange-yellow blobs moving around, some of them in pairs.

“But what if they’re animals?” Perfuma asks.

“Unlikely, because there’s also stationary heat points, see,” Bow says, zooming in on a couple of white-hot points. “Those have to be torches, or some other form of artificial warmth. So, definitely some kind of civilisation.”

“More importantly,” Entrapta says, scrolling the overhead map rapidly to the right, “the tech readings are here,” she says, tapping a couple of buttons on the dashboard, until several red, glowing pulses can be seen in a circle formation.

“Oh wow, there’s five of them?” Scorpia asks, placing a pincer on Bow and Entraptas shoulders, “you two must be really excited!”

Entrapta raises herself up on her pigtails until she’s eye-level with Scorpia, “Indeed! These are very unusual readings.”

“So,” I say, slowly swaying my tail, “We’ll land, check out the tech then get out of there?”

“But what about meeting the inhabitants?” Glimmer asks.

“Have any of you considered they might not *want* visitors?”

“Yes,” Glimmer says, sighing. “I suppose that’s a very real possibility.”

Everyone falls silent, even Melog who flops onto the floor and glares at me, and I look from one unhappy face to the next, feeling myself grow increasingly agitated. “Ugh, fine! We’ll try to find them afterwards. But if it goes badly, you teleport us back to Darla no questions asked. Got it?”

Glimmer grins. “Got it.”

“A sound plan. Just what I’d expect from our away team commander,” Perfuma says.

“Okay, can we stop with the bullshit titles?” I ask, shaking my head.

Adora plants a wet kiss on my cheek. “I can’t believe we’re going to meet new people!”

“It is exciting, but,” Glimmer says, furrowing her brows. “I doubt they’ll speak Etherian.”

“Our translators should help with that,” Entrapa says, tapping her earpiece. “I’ve also configured the suits to translate our speech back, if it recognises the language.”

Bow’s eyes light up. “Wow, that’s amazing! How does it-”

“Not now, snugglebum,” Glimmer says, pecking him on the cheek.

“Pfft, snugglebum-haha!” I burst out laughing alongside Adora, while Glimmer and Bow both turn bright red.

“Come on you two, don’t bully them,” Scorpia says, placing her pincers by her side. “I bet you have pet names too.”

“Yeah, she’s my idiot,” I say, smirking.

“And she’s stinky,” Adora says, wrapping her arms around my shoulders.

“While those are certainly unique names,” Perfuma says, placing her fingertips together. “Have you ever considered using sweeter terms of endearment?”

“Hah, we save those for the bedroom,” Adora says, winking.

I shove her shoulders. “Adora!”

“Darla,” Entrapta says, tapping the tip of her hair onto the dashboard. “Could you give me a pet name?”

- Personal enquiry detected -

- Hello Entrapta. I can recommend the following aliases: my maker, my mistress, and little miss handsy.

“Sadly someone in here already uses the mistress one,” Entrapta says, placing a pigtail under her chin. “Thin walls and all. But I like the handsy one!”

- *Change acknowledged. Thank you, little miss handsy.*

“Wait,” Adora says, raising her eyebrows. “What was that about mistr-”

“Well we’d better get a move on,” Perfuma says, her cheeks appearing flushed, “We do have an entire planet to explore!”

I peer across at Scorpia, who thins her lips into a line and quickly looks away, then at Adora who is clearly on the verge of saying something else. “Yes, let’s get a move on,” I say, grabbing Adora’s arm and leading her to her chair. “Come on, captain.”

“Huh? Oh, right. Buckle up everyone!” Adora says, beaming brightly as she sits down and starts fiddling with her chair controls.

Melog hops onto my lap while everyone hurries to their seats, and I peer across at Perfuma, raising my eyebrow. She nods and smiles at me. *You’re welcome*, I think, deciding not to dwell too much on whatever the hell all that was about.

“Commander-captain Adora,” Entrapta says, saluting with both pigtails. “I’ve recommended a landing spot, but entry will be rough.”

Adora leans around to look at me, grinning from ear to ear. “Darla, take us down.”

--

We step out into a lush, green and humid environment, and I wrinkle my nose at the smell of damp moss and wet bark. The floor is spongy and tangled with roots and shrubs, which crack beneath our feet as we walk away from Darla’s ramp.

“That was honestly terrifying,” I say, noticing my tail still is still a little puffed out.

Adora giggles. “I thought it was fun.”

“You think everything’s fun. You’re insane.”

“It was actually a smoother landing than I predicted!” Entrapta says, beaming widely. “I’m so proud of my girl.”

“She did great,” Bow says, peering up towards the green canopy overhead, and pointing to the small blue patch of sky in the middle “I can’t believe she fit through that gap!”

“There’s no hole I can’t squeeze into,” Adora says, folding her arms and beaming proudly, while Perfuma fails to hide the briefest of smirks.

“Could you rephrase that maybe?” I ask, twitching my right ear. “Also, you didn’t do anything! Darla does it all.”

“Oh, good,” Entrapta says, checking a few readings on her tablet. “The air here is completely safe to breathe!”

“You obviously checked that earlier, right?” I ask, looking between one oblivious idiot to the next, then shaking my head. “You know what, never mind. Let’s go find this tech.”

We walk deeper into the forest, heading in the rough direction of the energy readings, until we’re surrounded on all sides by towering trees and thick bushes. Sunlight streams down through cracks in the overhead canopy, and countless creatures can be heard, a symphony of chirps and creaks all around.

Bow nudges me as we walk. “We did check. Entrapta’s learning humour, remember?”

“Yeah. hilarious,” I say, tugging at the collar of my suit, then swatting a bug from my face.

“I thought it was!” Entrapta says, laughing. “You see, we left our helmets behind, so when I pretended that I didn’t know it was safe-”

I push my palm over her mouth. “We get it. Well done.”

“Then why aren’t you laughing?” Entrapta says, tilting her head.

Melog butts their head to my thigh, huffing. “I thought it was funny.”

“Melog says it was funny,” I say, rolling my eyes.

Entrapta crouches down and pats Melog with one of her pigtails. “You really are a fine specimen, not to mention a scientific mystery!”

“And a mystery they’ll remain,” I grumble.

Suddenly something blurs past Entrapta’s face, and I hear a loud thunk in the tree behind me. “Take cover!” I yell, as more arrows whistle past us.

Bow and Glimmer dash behind a thick tree to our right, while Perfuma and Scorpia hop behind an adjacent tree to the left.

“For the honour of grayskull!” Adora yells, summoning her shield and holding it up, protecting Entrapta, Melog and myself while we leap to the nearest tree, just behind the one Bow and Glimmer are at.

“We come in peace!” Glimmer shouts, just as more arrows jolt through the air, stabbing into the trunks of the trees all around.

“I’ve got this, don’t worry,” Perfuma says. She holds out a hand and a moment later a thick web of vines reaches up and around us all in a large overhead dome, deflecting the next volley of arrows. We all hurry beneath the center of the barrier, and huddle up.

“Let’s get out of here,” I say, wincing as more arrows *thwak* into our defenses.

“On it,” Glimmer says, frowning. “Everyone, join hands.”

Just a moment later, we’re all back at Darla, standing underneath her hull.

“I guess they don’t want to be friends,” Scorpia says, sagging her shoulders. “I really wanted to meet them, too!”

“There will be other people out there for us to meet,” Perfuma says, placing her hand on Scorpia’s cheek. “Don’t worry, sweetheart.”

“Aww. I was so curious about those readings,” Bow says, hunching over with his arms hanging down.

Entrapta taps the end of one pigtail on Bow’s shoulder. “There there. It is highly probable that other planets will have similar tech.”

“Come on guys,” Adora says, placing her hands on her hips. “We got unlucky this time, but we have countless planets to explore!”

“Yes! That’s the spirit,” Perfuma says, clapping her hands.

Suddenly a few high-pitched whistles can be heard all around, and the next thing I know something hits my ankles, *hard*, and we’re all flat on our backs with our legs ensnared between rope and rock. I grunt, peering upwards, noticing we’re surrounded by a group of five very tall, reddish-brown skinned women, with glowing spears and swords pointed down at us.

“Why are you attacking us!” Adora exclaims, jumping to her feet, her thick calves snapping the rope with ease.

One of the five women widens her eyes and steps forwards. She appears older than the others, and has braided, red hair tied into a knot behind her head. Across her right eye is a diagonal scar, not deep enough to have damaged the umber iris beneath.

“Why have you come here?” she snaps, peering up at Adora, who stands a head taller.

“We’re just explorers,” Adora says. “We can see you don’t want us here, so we were about to leave.”

“You may *not* leave,” the woman spits, jabbing her spear forwards.

Adora deflects the attack, then quickly morphs her sword into a large shield. “Why not? “We didn’t do anything!”

The woman scowls, readying her spear for another attack, alongside three of the others. “You have trespassed on sacred ground, for which the punishment is death.”

“Sisters, wait!” The fifth woman says. She has long, white hair tied up into a low plait, with sharp, silver eyes that seem far older than the rest of her youthful appearance. She grabs onto the arm of the red-head. “Did you not see that? I told you, they are special.”

“Hmph. Is it true?” The red-head says, slightly lowering her spear. “You know magic?”

“Well dur,” I say, and in the absence of pointy weapons in my face I quickly lean up and slice away my bindings, noticing Scorpia do the same. “Didn’t you see her transform? Or you know, the giant vine dome? Or maybe the fact we all vanished into thin air?”

“Well *I* did, at least,” the white-haired woman says, glaring pointedly at her friends, before staring at Adora, running her gaze slowly up and down her tall form. “Absolutely astounding,” she mutters, before walking towards the other three women, practically dragging the red-head with her.

“What are they doing?” I ask, watching them engage in an animated conversation while Scorpia and I swiftly release everyone else.

“You know, I could quite easily ensnare them,” Perfuma says with a slight smirk, both she and Scorpia appearing way too excited about the idea.

“Let’s not retaliate unless we have to,” Glimmer says, rubbing at her ankles, then standing up.

“We want to make friends, not enemies,” Bow says, wincing, “even though they kind of keep attacking us.”

“Speaking of which,” I mutter, watching the redhead storm over, her brown eyes boring into me as she reaches for the spear behind her back.

“Who said you may release your binds?”

“Woops,” I say, shrugging and flexing a single claw out. “My hand slipped.”

The white-haired woman places a hand on the other woman’s shoulder. “Be at ease, Mauve.”

“But, your majesty, they’ve-”

“They are magical, and thus must be respected. You know our laws.”

Mauve grunts. “You could at least make them prove it.”

“I have seen it three times already,” she says, pecking Mauve on the cheek, then turning to face Adora. “I saw this one transform into someone impossibly tall. She’s even taller than us, isn’t that unbelievable?!” she says, laughing as she points towards Perfuma. “This one moved the forest itself, and then they all teleported somehow. Amazing! And this weapon!” she says, bending down to peer at Adora’s shield. “May I touch it?”

“Um, sure?” Adora says, lifting it up.

“Is it both a sword and a shield? How does it work?”

“Well, it’s whatever I want it to be, really,” Adora says, stroking the hair behind her neck and grinning awkwardly.

Anything, huh? I think, deciding I'm going to circle back on that one sometime, in private.

“I am Zara,” the silver-eyed woman says, taking a step back.

“She means *Queen* Zara,” Mauve says, frowning.

“And, this is my beautiful but overprotective wife Mauve,” she says, kissing her on the cheek.

“*One* of her wives.”

“Must you keep correcting me?”

One corner of Mauve’s lips raises into a smirk. “Sorry, my Queen.”

“I’m She-Ra,” Adora says, shimmering back down to her usual size, “but most of the time, I just go by Adora.”

“Now you are tiny!” Zara exclaims, walking around Adora’s smaller form. “Turn big again,” she says, beaming widely and clapping her hands. “Let us see.”

Adora looks at me, then back at Zara, shrugging. She raises one hand, and goes through the whole transformation thing again. Not that I'd ever tire of it.

Mauve's eyebrows shoot up. "Wow. You were right, babe."

Perhaps you shouldn't doubt your wife," Zara says, jabbing a finger into Mauve's chest, "let alone your Queen."

The other girls start to giggle, quickly stopping when Zara narrows her eyes at them. She turns to face Adora, places her hand on her bicep, then strokes her palm downwards. "Astonishing. Such raw magical energy," she says, and the next thing I know all five of the women are standing around Adora, each of them getting a bit handsy, even Mauve, who doesn't seem to mind that her wife is getting in on the action.

"What is going on?" I mutter under my breath, feeling my claws slide out of their own accord.

"Uh?" Adora says, looking over at me and appearing pensive.

"Fascinating!" Zara says, raising her palm to Adora's cheek. "So beautiful, and so strong. Perhaps you could join us for some-"

"Okay, we're trying to play nice here but that's enough," I say, stepping forwards, grabbing Adora's arm and pulling her away.

"Thanks," Adora whispers.

"Did we cause offense?" Zara asks, blinking in surprise.

"Well, Adora didn't really give you permission," Perfuma says, pressing her fingertips together, "to touch her, I mean."

"Neither did I," I grumble.

"I see," Zara says, tilting her head to one side. "Is touching taboo among your kind?"

"It's a little more complicated than that," Perfuma says, gently dipping her head. "But I'd be delighted to explain it to you!"

"I would enjoy that!" Zara says, her eyes lighting up. "You must stay a while, then. We do not often receive such unique visitors after all."

Mauve coughs into her hand. "We generally kill most of them."

Zara elbows her sharply in the ribs, just as Bow winces. "Well then, lucky us for we're all… magical…"

"Indeed," Entrapta says, folding a pigtail under her chin. "Though my abilities are actually science-based."

"Nope, we're all magical," I say quietly, elbowing Entrapta in the ribs. "Got it?"

"Oooh. Okay then," Entrapta says, waving her pigtails in the air. "Behold my magical haaaair."

“How wonderful!” Zara gasps, her eyes sparkling. “Please, join us in our home. We have much to discuss.”

--

We’re led deeper into the forest, where the trees grow in size and become almost impossibly large, the tips of their roots thicker than my waist.

“Welcome to Deepwood,” Zara says, gesturing ahead, towards a rope bridge that reaches upwards, bending around the thick trunk of an aged tree. Two women guard the bottom, and they dip their heads, greeting their Queen.

We head all the way up the spiralled ramp, then walk across a couple of wooden bridges, stopping on a large, round platform, which suddenly raises upwards, taking us up one, two, then three levels, until we’re at what I assume to be the top floor.

“Interesting,” Entrapta mumbles, crouching to look down the edges of the wooden elevator, while I prick my ears up and take a look around. Golden, ambient lighting glows from torches placed along each side of the bridge ahead of us, and there are several huts secured against giant tree trunks in the near-distance.

“We are almost there,” Zara says, smiling before turning away and leading us across the bridge. I stand on my tiptoes to look at the top of one of the torches, finding a few brightly glowing, dancing spheres there.

“It’s so pretty,” Adora says, and I look up to find her wide-eyed, the small flickering lights reflecting in her eyes, shining almost as brightly as her shimmering golden hair.

“Yeah,” I say, smiling up at her. “Pretty.”

She looks down at me, her cheeks turning a shade pinker, before her usual smug smirk appears. “Are you calling She-Ra pretty?”

“Don’t ruin it.”

“I wonder how they work,” Entrapta says, pausing to wrap her hair around one of the tall torches, shaking it a little.

“You know, we probably shouldn’t do that,” Scorpia says, resting a claw on her shoulders.

“Oh, right.”

“Guys!” I hiss, “come on.”

We walk across a few more of the solidly-built rope bridges strewn through the treetops, and I lose count of all the tall, muscular, bronze-skinned women we pass by, each of them almost as tall as She-Ra, and each with at least four weapons attached on their waist and back. They all seem particularly interested in Adora, some of them blatantly running their gaze all over her shining form.

“Enjoying the attention?” I mutter, grabbing Adora’s arm and grinding my teeth.

“Not really. But I didn’t like being called tiny, so I’ll stay like this for now,” Adora says, pouting, and I can't help but laugh.

“Come in, please,” Zara says, gesturing towards a hut which is far larger than the others. Mauve props her back against the outside wall and folds her arms, while the other three women disperse, but not before one of them steals a long, lingering look at Adora.

“Seriously,” I mumble, tightening my grip on Adora’s arm before we walk inside.

Thick, dark-brown planks form the outer walls of the house, into which four small, round windows are cut, each with vines clinging to the edges of the outside glass. Placed all around the inner walls are various adornments, perhaps trophies from battle. There’s a large, skeletal jaw full of pointed fangs, and weapons mounted on stands, each one more lethal-looking than the last. In the middle of the room lies a wide, oval table, on top of which three small, white stones levitate, each softly glowing.

“Please, be seated,” Zara says, sitting down in a tall, ornate chair at one end of the table. She leans forwards, resting her elbows atop the wooden surface.

“Thank you for having us,” Glimmer says, sitting on one of the several wooden stools that surround the table.

“Are you the leader of these ones?”

“Um,” Glimmer says, looking around at everyone. “Back home, maybe. But out here,” she says, tipping her head towards Adora’s shining form. “Adora kind of leads.”

“We lead each other, to be honest,” Adora says, taking a seat to Zara’s left. I sit beside Adora, and then everyone else sits down all around the table.

“I must apologise for the slightly hostile welcome,” Zara says, sitting back in her chair and flicking her thumb. “We have had... Less agreeable visitors before.”

Moments later two women adorned in gold jewelry and leather enter the room, placing two trays on the table, with jugs of juice and glasses, and a bowl full of strange-looking fruit. One of the women turns to face Adora, then giggles before hurrying away, and I feel my claws stretch out again.

“Please pardon them,” Zara says, smiling. “We do not often see a woman taller than ourselves, let alone magical visitors,” she continues, smiling at each of us before her gaze rests on Adora again. “You seem very special, Adora of…”

“Um, Etheria?”

“And the flower-adorned one, I saw you use magic too, did I not?”

“You did,” Perfuma says, blossoming a flower into Scorpia’s hair, “we all have special abilities.”

“How wonderful!” Zara says, clapping her hands. “I would love to see everything. Tell me,” she says, tipping her head towards me. “What can you do?”

“I’m extremely good at slicing things,” I say, clenching my teeth into a smile. Melog snorts out a puff of air before levitating a green, hook-shaped fruit towards me, where I cut it mid-air and catch both halves in my hands. “Ta-da.”

Adora looks at me in a curious way, amusement glittering in her eyes, and I smirk at her before taking a bite out of my fruit, widening my eyes at the delicious sweetness.

“Fabulous,” Zara says, grinning from ear to ear. “It is a blessing when other magic users find us, since it happens so very rarely. And you even have a golem!”

“Oh, so you use magic too?” Scorpia asks, beaming. “Wait, what’s a golem?”

Melog snorts, tilting their snout up and looking at me.

“She means Melog,” I say, stroking their fur.

“Such a beautiful creature,” Zara says, smiling at them. “And yes, we use magic, although nothing quite as impressive as this one,” she says, biting her lower lip and running her silver-eyed gaze over Adora.

“Um, what…” I say, twitching my ears. I shuffle my seat closer to Adora’s, narrowing my eyes at Zara.

“Behold,” Zara says, smiling before she stands up and holds both hands out, then closes her eyes. Moments later her hands glow, and she brandishes two large, ornate, curved blades, each etched with what looks like first ones writing.

“Wow!” Adora says, jumping to her feet and pointing at the swords. “Can I see?”

“Of course,” Zara says, holding out the blades.

Adora frowns. “This one says… edge of the soul.”

Zara gasps. “You are a first one?”

Adora thins her lips. “Umm...”

“Why don't you just tell her everything, Adora,” I say, rolling my eyes.

“Wait, you’ve heard of them?” Glimmer asks. “Have they been here?”

“Why, yes. My ancestors met them, long, long ago. They helped us to advance our technology to what you see today. I cannot believe this!” Zara exclaims, wrapping her thick, muscular arms around Adora’s shoulders and kissing her on the cheek. “Not only are you magical, but a first one? Here! In my lifetime!”

I dig my nails into my palms, and stand to my feet without even realising it. “Get your hands off of her.”

Zara blinks at me a few times, before removing her hands from Adora. “Sorry. Is this your wife? Are no others allowed to touch her?”

“What?! No, we’re not-” I begin, feeling my cheeks burn while Adora quickly sits down, and takes my hand in hers.

”-Married,” Adora finishes, squeezing my hand as I sit back down. “But we are together.”

Perfuma stands up and smiles sweetly, holding out her hands. “Etherians tend to be quite different from one another. Some are comfortable with touch, whereas to others it’s very intimate and reserved only for those closest to them.”

“Then I have much to learn,” Zara says, grinning at Perfuma while sitting back on her throne.

“We want to learn about you too,” Scorpia says, pressing her pincers together. “I can’t believe you have more than one wife!”

“Oh, that’s fairly normal here,” Zara says, beaming. “How about yourselves?”

“There’s no reason we can’t but,” Glimmer says, resting her hand atop Bows, “Most of us stick with just the one.”

“I see,” she says, tipping her head towards Bow. “Then this one is your wife?”

Bow almost chokes on his drink. “Not quite.”

“I become ever more intrigued,” Zara says, crossing one leg over another. “Tell me how marriage works in your lands, then, and why you act as though you are wed, when you are not.”

I rest my chin on my palm, and we all listen while Perfuma does most of the talking. It turns out that these women, or amazons as they call themselves, do things a little differently. Declaring love is basically the same as marriage, and touch is far less of a big deal here, whether married or not. Nor is running your eyes all over another person, apparently. It seems the only difference to them is that married people form a deeper bond, and may receive some kind of blessing to allow them to bear children.

“Hey, we didn’t actually see any kids on the way in, did we?” Scorpia asks.

“They live in a separate colony,” Zara says, smiling, “with our matrons. I have a wife over there, too. It is a very detailed subject, if you’d care to hear more.”

“Before that, your majesty,” Glimmer says, wincing slightly. “We actually came to your planet to look for something.”

“Is that so?” Zara asks, leaning forwards. “What and where is this thing you seek?”

“We’re not sure what it is, exactly,” Entrapta says, placing her data pad on the table and pressing a few buttons. A hologram pops up of an overhead view of part of the planet. “But it’s somewhere around here.”

“Oh! You mean the ruins?”

“Could you show us?” Glimmer asks.

“Of course,” she says, smiling, and standing up. “But afterwards, you must join us for celebration.”

“A party? On a different planet!?” Bow says, his eyes widening. “Best. Day. Ever.”

--

“They are just through this clearing,” Zara says, raising her hands and prising apart a few hanging vines.

We squeeze through the gap one after the other until we’re all standing in a wide, open clearing, where everything within is illuminated by thin spears of sunlight, and the tiny, glowing wisps that are

drifting around. In the center there are five moss-covered doors which face each other in a circle formation, and the sealed tunnels behind them are surrounded by thick, crumbling stone.

“Good luck getting into any of them, though,” Mauve says, chuckling to herself.

“We might surprise you,” Adora says, winking at me.

“Is that so?” Zara asks, appearing deep in thought until we’re all standing at the intersection of the five doorways, where she waves her hand towards a raised, stone tablet. “Perhaps this is a good starting point.”

Adora leans over the tablet, frowning as more and more people stand over her shoulder. “Guys, can I have a bit of space?”

“Woops,” Entrapta says, taking a step back, along with everyone else. I stay by her side, though, smiling to myself when she doesn’t complain.

“Within these bunkers lie,” Adora frowns. “Ugh, a lot of it is too faded. Lie… something. You may use it once you are ready to... Bah, something. Something. Oh,” she says, sticking the tip of her tongue out. “At that time, open the doorways. Retrieve the relics, and combine them.”

“That’s it?” I ask, twitching my left ear.

“Fascinating,” Zara says, taking both of Mauve’s hands in hers. “I wonder what it could mean!”

“Hmm,” Bow says. “Sounds like they split a device up into five parts, and hid it away. I wonder why.”

“Knowing the first ones, it’s a test,” Adora says, shrugging. “Let’s take a closer look at one of them.”

“Did they build similar ruins on your planet, then?” Zara asks.

“Yes. Seems like a hobby of theirs,” I mutter.

“Ooh, look,” Scorpia says, pointing a pincer up towards the large, stone archway above the metal doors. “That’s more writing, isn’t it?”

“Only the chosen may pass?” Adora says, shaking her head.

“They mean She-Ra, obviously,” I say rolling my eyes. “Chosen my ass.”

“Oh, right. For the honour of grayskull,” Adora says, her form growing and shimmering brightly until she’s all tall and glowy again.

I poke my finger into Adora’s waist. “If you can transform without yelling, then why do you always-”

“She yells for dramatic effect,” Glimmer says, grinning. “Isn’t that right, Adora?”

“What?! I’m not dramatic,” she says, pouting, then nearly falling over when the ground rumbles beneath us, and the doors slowly slide open, followed shortly thereafter by the other four sets of doors at the adjacent temples.

“Oh, goodness,” Perfuma says, placing a hand on her chin. “Which one should we visit first?”

“Why don’t we split up?” I ask, folding my arms. “They’ll probably be pretty much the same anyway. Seen one, seen ‘em all.”

“Okay,” Bow says, grinning. “Glimmer and I will take this one,” he says, pointing south.

“And Scorpia and I will explore this one,” Perfuma says, grabbing Scorpia’s arm and leading her away.

“Hey, wait a sec,” I say, frowning. “Just, be careful, okay? There might be traps and stuff. And spiders,” I say, feeling my spine shudder.

“Aww, wildcat, you *do* care!” Scorpia says, grinning.

“Ugh, get over yourself,” I say, rolling my eyes. “Just get in, grab the tech, and get out. Okay?”

“Affirmative, away team commander,” Scorpia says, pressing one pincer to her forehead.

“Whatever. So that leaves…”

“Emily and I will take this one,” Entrapta says, pulling out her tablet and tapping a few buttons. “She’ll be here in a few moments.”

“Are you sure about this?” Glimmer asks, frowning. “I seem to remember you getting lost in your own castle, Entrapta.”

“Oh it’ll be fiiine, we’ll map the place out as we go.”

“That leaves the five of us, and two ruins,” Zara says, taking Mauve’s hand. “Mauve and I will take this one.”

“Just be careful. I mean it,” I say, feeling anxious when Emily rolls into view, and everyone walks down into their respective ruins, vanishing from sight.

“They will be okay. They are strong,” Melog says, curling up beneath a sunbeam. “I would like to stay here, though. I am not fond of tunnels, or ruins.”

“Yeah, I bet you’ve had your fill,” I say, scratching between their brows, wondering how long Melog was forced to live in the ruins back on Krytis, all by themselves. “That leaves just us, then, my love,” I say, peering up at Adora.

“Doesn’t count,” she says, smirking. “Nobody heard.”

“Hah, so you remembered our little bet?”

“How could I forget?” she says, leaning down and kissing my forehead. “I’m hoping you win, to be honest.”

“Oh, is that so,” I ask, biting my lip. “I’ll see what I can do. Also, are you going to stay in that dumb form forever? Because I’m kind of getting a sore neck.”

“Oh yeah, sorry,” she says, shimmering back down, then gently taking my hand. “Are you ready for this?”

“Honestly, not really. But let’s see what happens.”

--

We walk through the doorway, and then down the steep ramp inside, until we're underground. Just like the ruins on Etheria, there are sharp-edged pink and purple walls with weird engravings of lines and circles all along them, and the whole place somehow feels alive.

I prick my ears forwards. "This one is louder than the others."

"Really?"

"Yeah. There's a constant hum. Can't you hear it?"

Adora closes her eyes. "Yeah, I see what you mean. I wonder if it's magic?"

"Or whatever they use for power, down here," I say, lacing my fingers with hers. "Let's make this quick, okay? And if we find spiders, you have my full permission to go all She-Ra on them."

"Is that so?" Adora asks, squeezing my fingers as we walk into a large, open area.

"Yeah, but don't get a big head on me, oka-"

Hahaha!

Our younger, teenage selves dart past us, running hand in hand until past-Catra pounces on past-Adora, and they both start to play fight, wrestling with each other on the floor.

"I guess we're doing the memory thing again, then," I say, blowing out a puff of air.

Adora laughs. "I think we'll just have to get used to it."

"Hmm," I say, twitching my left ear. "What if we can use it to our advantage this time?"

"What do you mean?"

"We have a three year gap, don't we?"

"Oh, of course," Adora says, placing her hand on my cheek. "And I always did wonder… what was it like? After I left?"

"You don't want to know," I say, trying to stop the memories before they even start to surface.

"I do."

"I'm pretty sure I already told you how things got worse. I just don't want to go into it because I know you, Adora. You'll blame yourself."

"What if I promise I won't?"

"Do you really want to know?" I ask, twitching my ears, wondering if she'll ever drop it if I refuse.

"Yeah. It keeps me awake at night sometimes, wondering what they did to you," Adora says, sighing. "But if it's too hard, that's okay."

"Fine. Then I'll give you the quick version," I say, flattening my ears down, and concentrating.

The room shifts around us, until we're back in the Fright Zone. We watch as Shadow Weaver tried time after time to get to Adora, to manipulate her, and how she'd direct her wrath at me whenever her

plan failed, not to mention how angry she became whenever I tried to hide Adora's new identity.

"You… you lied to her?" Adora asks, her eyes widening. "Catra, that was dangerous…"

"Doesn't matter," I say, sighing. "She knew all along. She was just messing with me."

And then, Shadow Weaver left. I'm almost tempted to stop the memory that came after, of how I was so upset that once again she'd chosen Adora over me. How once again, I'd been abandoned, or so I convinced myself at the time.

"But really, in the end… I abandoned you, didn't I?" I ask, feeling tears spring to my cheeks.

"What? Catra," Adora says, taking my hands in hers, kissing my knuckles. "I thought we weren't going to circle around this anymore."

"No, I have to find my peace with this, okay?" I say tipping my forehead to hers. "I was so hung up on the idea you left me, that I never stopped to think maybe it was the other way around."

"That's not true," Adora says, pressing her lips to mine. "I left you. I couldn't go back to the Horde."

"It's not a competition of who left who, Adora," I say, chuckling. "You gave me plenty of chances to break free, and to be with you," I say, folding my ears down. "So I have to accept that at some point, after rejecting you time after time, I was causing my own pain."

"How about we agree that we left each other," Adora says, kissing one of my cheeks, then the other. "And that we're both idiots."

"Can't argue with that," I say, laughing.

"But look at us now," Adora says, beaming widely. "We're thriving."

"Yeah," I say, feeling my heart warm as I press my hand to her chest. "I like that. Thriving."

"Despite the Horde, despite Shadow Weaver," Adora says, moving closer and resting her cheek against mine. "We won."

"Yeah. We won in the end," I say, chuckling. "I love you, Adora. I really, really do."

"I know."

"Pfft, seriously?" I ask, pulling back and wrinkling my nose. "Does your smugness know no bounds?"

"Hey, you're the one who slept at the bottom of my bed every day."

"Wait," I say, twitching my right ear. "Are you telling me you knew I loved you, but didn't do anything about it?"

"I… hmm," Adora says, furrowing her brows. "I wanted it to be true, but always figured there'd just be no way, you know? It just felt like a mad fantasy."

"Hah, imagine if either of us would've been just a little braver…"

"We might not be where we are today," Adora says, cupping my chin in her palm. "I know we've suffered, but… if it went any differently..."

“I’d do it all again,” I say, without hesitating. “If I knew this is where it all leads, I mean.”

Tears spring to Adora’s cheeks. “I’d rather you hadn’t gone through any of it, though. Especially Prime.”

“All that matters is we’re here now,” I say, nuzzling my nose against her cheek, then resting my lips at her neck. “So shut up and be grateful for it.”

We stand there for a while, enjoying each other’s tight embrace, the quiet hum of the temple’s energy reverberating around us.

“So,” I say, kissing Adora’s neck once, then pulling away to look into her eyes. “I showed you mine…”

“You showed me a small part,” Adora says, scrunching up her nose.

“The rest was war, chaos, Hordak almost killing me a few times, and a mental breakdown. It’s ugly, okay? I don’t think I really need to show you since you were on the receiving end for most of it.”

“Okay… so long as you’ll tell me some day.”

“I will. So, spill it. What happened to you?”

“Hmm,” Adora says, frowning. “I’m not sure I’d even know where to begin.”

I lace my fingers with hers. “Start with how you made friends with Bow and Glimmer.”

“Really?”

“Yes! I always wondered why you didn't kill a princess on sight, especially after all our training.”

--

Adora gets as far as telling me about the sword, her acceptance into the alliance, the ruins, and Light Hope, before I interrupt her, feeling furious.

“So they *all* used you, just like Shadow Weaver?” I say, folding my arms, gritting my teeth. “Then it’s no surprise you’re so messed up. Even your friends kept expecting you to help all the time, like you had to, just because you’re She-Ra.”

“They don’t do that anymore,” Adora says, smiling sadly. “Not really.”

“I always knew things were hard for you,” I say, pacing around and swaying my tail. “It just took me a while to work out *why*.”

“Hmm?”

“Not long before the heart I finally figured it out,” I say, wrapping my arms around her shoulders. “I’d feel frustrated, because it was like you’d always choose the world over me, over us. But it was never like that,” I say, kissing her cheek. “You were just choosing to protect others, no matter the cost. You’ve been taught this your whole life, Adora. Please tell me you realise this by now.”

“I… I don’t know,” she says, tipping her forehead to mine. “Isn’t it a good thing to try to save people?”

“Not if it means you get hurt, idiot,” I say, staring into her beautiful, blue eyes. “I’ve thought about it a lot, actually, and I’ve realised you need Perfuma’s help, too.”

“What? But I’m-”

“Don’t you dare say you’re fine! You aren’t. You were twisted and manipulated, just like I was,” I say, gripping her shoulders tightly. “It’s why you throw yourself into harm's way, like you mean nothing… and it’s so far from the truth, Adora. You mean *everything*!” I exclaim, blinking back sudden tears. “They made you think it’s your job to be responsible. You even did it when we were kids, when you thought you had to protect me.”

“But Shadow Weaver would have hurt you, if I-”

“No, Adora, don’t you get it? It was always a game to her. Me, the victim, conveniently frozen in place with her shitty magic. You, the hero, forced to protect the ones you love. And then Light Hope fucked with you in the exact. Same. Way!”

I watch as Adora’s brows furrow and she clenches her own arm, appearing deep in thought.

“They made you feel like it’s your job to be a hero, but it’s bullshit,” I say, gently pressing my lips to hers. “There has to be a balance, and maybe Perfuma can help you find it. That’s all I’m saying.”

Adora inhales a long, deep breath, and closes her eyes before exhaling. “That was… a lot. But yeah. Okay.”

“Okay? What, that’s it? No backlash?”

“No, you’re right,” she says, wiping away my tears with her thumb. “Even Mara told me to stop sacrificing myself.”

“Mara?”

“Oh. Oh!” Adora says, suddenly grasping my hands tightly. “She was She-Ra! Let me show you!”

--

“How come you didn’t tell me about her before?” I ask.

“I was worried I’d scare you away if I talked about the whole She-Ra thing,” Adora says, wincing.

“Scared you’d burst the bubble?” I ask, smiling. She nods. “Yeah, me too. But I think it’s safe to say our bubble is pretty solid by now.”

“It is, isn’t it,” Adora says, smiling, playing with a few loose strands of my fringe.

“This Mara… she sounds like she was a good person. She gave a lot, for us.”

“She was,” Adora says, smiling. “See? Sometimes the world needs a hero.”

“Um, no,” I say, scrunching up my nose, “I bet if she’d had more help, or you know, never been manipulated in the first place, Mara wouldn’t have had to go through any of that, so don’t you dare assume her sacrifice was mandatory.”

“Hmm, maybe,” Adora says, her shoulders slumping. “Not a lot of it makes sense. I’m not even sure the heart was meant to be a weapon. It just never really… felt that way to me.”

“Well,” I say, smirking. “Let’s find Eternia and figure it out.”

“Oh, it’s that easy, is it?” Adora chuckles. “I’m not sure I’d want to meet my people, even if it were.”

“Are you afraid they’ll be like Prime?”

“Actually yeah, I mean, what if...”

“I doubt they’re like that, Adora,” I say, slowly squeezing my tail around her leg in reassurance. ”There’s no way someone like you could come from something that rotten.”

“Aww, you’re being sweet again.”

“Adora,” I say, twitching my left ear, remembering Mara’s transformation, and how different it was compared to Adora’s. “Turn into She-Ra.”

“What!?”

“Something’s been bugging me for a while. I want to see.”

“I have a better idea,” Adora says, smiling to herself. She steps behind me, and rests her hands against my waist while the scenery shifts around us, until we’re at the bottom of Prime’s pit, the one where I fell to my death, or near-death. I’m not actually sure.

“How is *this* a better idea?”

Adora rests her chin on my shoulder, and whispers. “Just watch.”

I prick my ears up, watching as past-Adora leaps right into that damn pit straight after me, without any hesitation, no doubt breaking both her legs before she crawls towards me.

“You…” I whisper, a lump forming in my throat. “*You idiot.*”

“This was the first time I transformed, since destroying the sword.”

“Oh,” I say, watching her transformation closely, feeling my chest swell when I confirm the small detail that’s bugged me for so long. Then my jaw falls open as I witness Adora literally kick everyone’s ass in about four seconds flat, carrying me around like I’m weightless. *And her eyes*, I think, *I’ve never seen her look that pissed off before, or that determined*.

“You miscalculated,” Adora’s visage says, before the scene fades away.

“Wow, that was pretty hardcore,” I say, turning around to face her, looping my arms around her shoulders. “I still can’t believe you did all that for me. And what the hell, Adora? Jumping into the pit? Seriously?”

“You know I’m a little impulsive,” she says, kissing my cheek. “Besides, I had to take you home. I promised, after all.”

“You’re such an idiot,” I say, blinking away my unshed tears. “And who said you could copy my helmet, anyway?”

“So you finally noticed?” Adora asks, smirking and raising an eyebrow.

“Yes,” I say, pressing my index finger against her forehead. “Your new tiara has a similar shape to it, too. Adora, did you seriously steal a piece of my costume?”

“Is this why you wanted to see me transform?”

I nod, smirking. “Under Etherian law, doesn’t that make us engaged?”

“Haha, no!” Adora says, shaking her head. “I haven’t given you anything, and technically you didn’t share anything with me, either.”

“Well, that’s true,” I say, tipping my forehead to hers. “But for what it’s worth, I don’t hate the idea.”

“Really?” she whispers, the sides of her brows lowering. “Me neither.”

“Good to know,” I say, blinking slowly. “But that doesn’t mean I want you to propose tomorrow, Okay? So don't get any dumb ideas.”

Adora blinks back slowly, then smiles smugly. “So, the day after?”

“No!” I say, nuzzling my lips to her cheek. “Or the day after that. Look, just forget I said anything. You’re an idiot,” I say, grinning against the crook of her neck.

“Okay, I’ll leave it to you.”

“What?” I ask, snapping my head back. “I never agreed to that.”

Adora shrugs. “Too bad, it’s on you now.”

“Bah!” I say, shoving her shoulders. “Don’t be surprised if it never happens, then.”

“We have all the time in the world,” Adora says, snatching up my hands. “Come on. Let’s get this tech and get out of here.”

--

“Fascinating,” Entrapta says, holding up four of the small relics with her pigtails and hands, with the fifth placed in front of her. “I’m sure they fit together, somehow. But I’ll need time to work this out.”

“Do you have any theories on what it actually is?” Glimmer asks, raising an eyebrow.

“Not yet, though I did spot this very small writing underneath,” Entrapta says, holding up the fifth piece.

“Hey, let me see, “Adora says, lifting it up and squinting her eyes. ”Um… Assemble with care. Use at own risk.”

“That isn’t particularly helpful,” Entrapta says, furrowing her brows.

“Come, you can play with these toys back in Deepwood,” Zara says, smiling. “It is time we showed you all some real amazon hospitality!”

“Ooh, I can’t wait!” Bow says, his eyes sparkling.

“This one’s going to be a good one,” Mauve says, chuckling heartily. “I can feel it in my bones.”

“It has been an awfully long time since we had a proper party,” Glimmer says, wrapping her arms around Bow. “We should all make the most of it.”

“I’m excited too!” Scorpia says, grinning. “Not that I’m sure why, but everyone else is, so…”

“You haven’t ever had a party?” Bow asks, wide eyed.

“Actually, we have,” I say, smirking at Scorpia.

“Oh, that’s right!” she says, her eyes sparkling. “The Crimson Wastes was a blast!”

“Hah, yeah it was! I still remember their dumb faces when we took over in what, two seconds,” I say, cackling.

“And then they all got drunk and passed out,” Scorpia says, grinning.

“And puked everywhere, haha!”

“That doesn’t sound like much of a party,” Bow says, wincing.

Glimmer shakes her head. “This is like Adora, all over again!”

“What? We had a party, okay!” I say, scowling.

Perfuma sighs sadly. “Yes. They have so much lost time to make up for. All those years that the Horde stole from them...”

I roll my eyes. “Are you even listening to me?”

Bow holds a fist up, appearing determined. “Then it’s down to us to show them the best night of their lives.”

“Right…” I say, shaking my head, wondering why I even bother.

Chapter End Notes

Mermista: What the hell... you can't just put marriage in the title and then hold out on us like this... this is reader abuse
Catra: Um, you were at our wedding, Mermista.
Mermista: Uh... I was?
Sea Hawk: She had quite a few cocktails if I recall!

Again, I must thank blueeyesandhair! Even with a broken hand (and knee?) they helped me to get this one out early. Show them some love.

Barriers and Bears

Chapter Summary

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"So *these* are the ones everyone is talking about?"

The tall woman peers down at us with a single eyebrow raised. She rests her hands on her hips, and her lips spread into a toothy grin.

"Calisto," Zara says, placing a hand on the other woman's arm. "Would you please lead our guests to their accommodation?"

Calisto takes a few steps closer, her hips swaying side to side. Unlike the other women, her leather armour and boots appear darker, almost black compared to the usual tan shade, and she only has one leather wristguard, placed on her left arm.

"I'd be honoured," she says, bowing and pressing a fist into her palm. "I'm Calisto. Cal for short."

My tail sways side to side as I peer up, meeting her green gaze just for a second. She has dark purple hair, shaved on each side of her head with jagged patterns cut into it, and longer strands of her hair are swept over one side.

"It's a pleasure to meet you," Perfuma says, dipping her head. "I'm Perfuma, and this is-"

I fold my arms, waiting as everyone introduces themselves. Once Calisto turns away to face Glimmer I take a closer look at her right arm, finding it covered in a tattoo depicting all kinds of animals, interlaced with greenery. It spreads all the way up to her shoulder, where there's a profile of a bear's head framed in a flowery circle, it's jaw open, as though roaring.

"Do you like it?" Calisto asks, smirking down at me.

“It’s okay, I guess,” I say, folding my arms.

“I think it’s awesome!” Bow says, grinning.

“Me too,” Scorpia says. “I love the bear. And- ooh! Is that a panther?”

“This is Catra, by the way,” Adora says, grabbing my arm and smiling. “She’s a bit of a grump.”

“Adora!” I say, scowling.

Calisto chuckles, and shakes her head. “Follow me, everyone. I’ll see you in a bit, Zar- uh, I mean, my Queen.”

“Hmph,” Zara says, narrowing her eyes at Calisto. “I will see you all at the festivities,” she chuckles, waving over her shoulder before heading towards her hut.

--

“So,” Calisto says, leading us past several women, and peering at us over her shoulder. “I heard one of you was taller...”

“Oh, Adora! Show her She-Ra!” Glimmer says, grinning from ear to ear.

Seriously, I think, watching Adora comply all too willingly, until she’s smiling smugly in her taller form, and resting her hands at her hips.

“Well that’s…” Calisto says, licking her lips, “impressive.”

“Let’s keep walking, shall we?” I say, twitching my right ear, and grabbing Adora’s arm.

Calisto raises an eyebrow as she peers down at me. “Try to keep up, then.”

“I can’t believe we get our own places,” Bow whispers, loudly, while we hurry across the long, slatted bridge.

“This is going to be amazing!” Scorpia says.

Perfuma giggles. “I am certainly looking forward to it.”

Suddenly there’s a loud *thud* behind us. “Woops!” Entrapta says, leaning over the bridge and grabbing the falling relic with her hair. “Close call!”

“Melog, can you-”

“Of course.”

A blue glow surrounds two of the larger relics, and they float above Entrapta, leaving her to carry the three smaller ones.

“Thanks, Melog!” Entrapta says, patting them with a pigtail.

“What a beautiful golem,” Calisto says, bending down and holding out her hand. “May I?”

I roll my eyes. “Can we get off the unstable, swaying bridge first?”

Melog butts into my leg. “Tell her I accept her pettings.”

We hurry across the last few steps, and step onto a far more stable platform that’s secured around the thick trunk of a gigantic tree.

“Okay, they say you can pet them,” I say, folding my arms.

“I have never seen one take this form before,” Calisto says, stroking Melog’s fur, causing them to purr loudly.

“You’ve seen other Golems?” Glimmer asks, wide-eyed. “Where are they?”

“Now that is a rather long, depressing story,” Calisto says, standing up. “And it is not mine to tell.”

“Then who-” Adora begins.

“Mauve. But I would advise against bringing it up,” Calisto says, shrugging. “Come, the huts are across the next bridge, though it is a rather long one.”

“Great,” I say, gulping thickly.

We step across the wide bridge in pairs, walking side by side. I keep both hands on the side rope, trying to ignore how the planks sway and creak beneath our feet, and especially trying to ignore how far down the ground is.

“Hey, Calisto,” Adora says, causing the woman to slow her pace, much to my chagrin.

“Yes?”

“I hope you don’t mind me asking, but how come you look uh… different to the others?”

“You mean my attire?” she asks, her green eyes glinting, and one side of her lips raising to a smirk. “Or this?” she asks, holding up her tattooed arm.

“Um, both?”

“I am not from this tribe,” she says, shrugging. “I… ah, had a falling out with my last queen. But Zara was glad to have me here.”

“A falling out?” Glimmer asks.

Calisto pauses in her footsteps, presses her fingertips together, and winces. “She… caught me in bed with her other four wives.”

“I thought you were allowed to share?” Perfuma asks, tilting her head.

“Well, I was only married to two of them, so not really.”

“Oh, then I still have much to learn.”

“That all sounds way too confusing,” I say, twitching my ears and tightening my grip on the rope. “Not to mention exhausting.”

Calisto chuckles. “Such things do not tire me. Running away from the Queen and her guard on the other hand was quite draining.”

Bow gasps. “She set her guard on you?”

“Oh yes. I’m an outcast,” Calisto says, turning to one side and resting her forearms on the thick rope, looking into the distance. She releases a long, drawn-out sigh. “I did love her, you know. I just have an insatiable appetite for these things…”

“But you ended up here, and hey, everything happens for a reason!” Scorpia says.

“Perhaps. I have yet to find a wife here, though.”

“You should allow your heart time to heal, first,” Perfuma says, resting a palm on Calisto’s back.

Entrapta yanks a torch up from the side of the bridge, and brings the top of it down to her eye level, staring at the glowing spheres inside. “Fascinating.”

“Entrapta, stop breaking stuff,” I mutter. “And be careful with those relics.”

“I’m just borrowing it,” she says, holding the long pole near her chest.

--

A few moments later we’re standing on another solid platform, and I breathe a sigh of relief.

This platform is huge, with at least forty huts fastened to four interlocked, massive trees. Dozens of women are walking around, some minding their own business, others setting their greedy eyes on Adora. *Yeah, keep looking*, I think, twitching my right ear. I wouldn’t even let it bother me, if only Adora wasn’t peering down at her own arms, then at theirs, as though comparing. When she does it for a third time, I clench her arm tightly enough for her to notice.

“Are you okay?” Adora asks, peering down at me.

“I’m fine,” I say, scowling.

Calisto clears her throat, glancing between us. “None of the guest huts are taken, so please, take your pick,” she continues, bending down towards me and lowering her voice. “You two should take the one to the far right. It has the biggest, comfiest double bed.”

“Huh,” I say, furrowing my brows, “Thanks.”

“You seem confused.”

“I thought… you know what, never mind.”

“If you are wondering if I find her attractive,” she says, grinning up at a blushing Adora. “I do. But it matters not, for the two of you are clearly wed, and in our lands, we try to respect this.”

“Actually, we’re not-” Adora begins, but I elbow her in her waist.

“Yes, we’re wed. Thank you for your understanding, Calisto.”

“Okay, let’s meet out here in an hour?” Glimmer asks, smirking at me before looking up at Calisto.

She nods. “I will come and get you. In the meantime, you will find many outfits to choose from inside your rooms.”

“Ooh, we’re getting dressed up?” Scorpia asks, her eyes shining. “I hope something fits.”

“Thank goodness,” I say, tugging at my collar. “Doesn’t anyone else get itchy wearing these things?”

“Not really. But perhaps the suits don’t work very well with fur,” Entrapta says, tilting her head. “I shall try to modify the design of yours later. For now,” she says, twisting her SAP badge and pulling it off, “don’t forget to keep the translators with you.”

“You seriously built it into those dumb badges?” I ask, shaking my head.

“There’s nothing dumb about the space adventure pals, Catra,” Adora says, sticking her tongue out.

“There’s everything dumb about-”

Bow raises his fists into the air. “Space adventure pals party time! Woohoo!”

“And we have all the more reason to celebrate now that you two are married,” Perfuma says, thinning her lips into a knowing smile.

“I’ll take the smallest hut,” Entrapta says, furrowing her brows. “I’ll need time to analyse these. More than an hour.”

“But you’ll join us later, right?” Scorpia asks, crouching down and smiling at Entrapta. “Come on, it’ll be fun!” “Perhaps. I’ll definitely think about it,” Entrapta says, before heading into her hut.

“I wonder if I should make everyone a flower tiara,” Perfuma says, grabbing Scorpia’s pincer as they walk away. “Do you think they even like flowers? They all look so tough.”

--

As soon as we’re inside our hut, I close the door behind us, and swat my tail around.

“Why are you in that form, again?” I ask, glaring up at Adora.

“Huh? You don’t usually mind,” Adora says, shimmering down to her normal size. “Better?”

“I guess.”

“Catra,” Adora says, resting her hands on my shoulders. “I know something’s wrong. We’re supposed to talk to each other now, remember?”

I sigh, and look away. “It’s dumb.”

“I doubt that,” Adora says, cupping my chin in her palm, and making me look at her. “Talk to me. Please.”

“I’m getting kind of sick of how they all look at you, that’s all. They obviously want to… ugh, whatever.”

Adora frowns. “It doesn’t matter what they want.”

I gulp, feeling a thick knot form in my throat. “They’re all big and strong, and we all know you're into muscles, Adora.“

“What, but I-”

“I’ll never look like that, okay!” I say, swatting her hands away. I clench my arm, and look down at the floor.

Adora bursts into laughter. It causes my cheeks to burn so hotly that they almost sizzle, but before I can question what’s so damn funny her arms are around me and her lips are upon mine, and I'm lost in her warmth.

“Is that what you think I want?” she asks, smiling from ear to ear.

“You like big, strong women,” I say, shrugging. “Tell me I’m wrong. I saw you comparing arm sizes, Adora.”

“I *admire* strong women,” Adora says, tipping her forehead to mine. “But I’m not attracted to any of them. I’ve only ever felt that way about you,” she says, pressing her nose to mine. “Only you. I promise. And by the way, you’re also strong. Like, crazy strong.”

“No need to get all cheesy,” I say, trying but failing to hide my slowly growing smile.

“And for what it’s worth,” Adora says, moving her lips against my ear. “I find you so incredibly, insanely hot, that I keep having to stop myself from jumping on you in front of everyone.”

“Is that so,” I say, closing my eyes, and purring. “What could you possibly find so attractive about a tiny person like me, hmm?”

“Are you digging for compliments?”

“Maybe,” I say, reaching behind her head and swiftly pulling her hair tie out, then flicking it to the floor.

“Why do I even bother?” Adora says, chuckling. She strokes a hand down my back, and traps my gaze with hers, while her lips form a smug smile. “Well, for starters I’ve liked your ass for as long as I can remember,” she says, squeezing her hand into my butt.

I laugh, “Classy, Adora.”

“And I just... love the shape of you,” she whispers, stroking her other hand down my side, and along the dip of my waist. “All of it. And your eyes… Catra, they’ve always taken my breath away, especially when you look at me in a certain way.”

I dip the sides of my brows, staring at her, my jaw parting open, trying to think of something witty to say.

“Yeah. Like that,” Adora whispers, leaning forwards and pressing her lips to mine. It’s a long, lazy kiss, full of love, and more than a little longing. “But more than anything, I love everything that makes you, you. Your stubbornness, and how incredibly smart you are. How you make me laugh… how you make me feel so alive.”

“Hmm,” I say, taking a moment to catch my breath, “I guess none of them have a chance, then do they?” I mumble, running my thumb over her lips. “I still can’t help but want to claw their eyes out when they gawp at you, though.”

“I’m yours,” Adora says, her eyes full of nothing but sincerity. “So let them look at what they can’t have.”

“Hmm, I like that,” I say, feeling the fur on my neck and tail rise up slightly.

“Oh and also, we’re married now?” Adora asks, laughing. “I can't believe you said that.”

“If we apply their rules we *are* married,” I say, grinning, “and so are Scorpia and Perfuma, and so are Glimmer and Bow.”

“Hmm. That’s true,” Adora says, placing a finger to her chin. “I can’t believe it’s as simple as confessing your love here.”

“It took us our entire adult lives and a near death experience, and you’re calling it simple. Really, Adora?”

“... Good point,” Adora says, before pointing towards the various garments that are hung up on the wall at one side of the room. “So, my darling wife... what outfit do you want?”

“Well, my beautiful, delicious wife,” I say, tugging at the zip behind my collar, “why don’t you pick one out for me?”

“Hmm okay,” she says, holding up a leather skirt and breastplate. “This one?”

“Don’t they have anything else?” I ask, peeling my suit down and kicking it off of my feet, breathing a sigh of relief at the sensation of cool air around my fur.

“Doesn’t look like it.”

I take the clothing from Adora and examine it, twitching my ears when I realise it’s the same as what the Amazons wear. The same metal breastplate, loose belt, and toughened leather armour which spans from chest to the knee, hanging past the waist in thick strips of leather.

“How about we go back to Darla and get our actual clothes?” I ask.

“As much as I love my uniform,” Adora says, sighing, “we should probably try to fit in.”

“Hah, I just realised!” I say, squeezing into the leather outfit. “Bow is gonna have to wear this! Haha.”

“I wonder if he’ll cut out a window for his abs,” Adora says, starting to remove her space suit.

“Wouldn’t surprise me,” I say, clipping the metal breastplate into place, finding myself surprised by how light and sturdy it is. Then I sit down and shove my foot into one of the long, heavy leather boots, straightening the metal plates as I pull it over my calf, and above my knee.

“Looks good on you,” Adora says, wiggling her eyebrows.

“But… I’m not sure I can wear them,” I say, glumly looking down at my foot, where my toes feel incredibly restricted.

“Then don’t,” Adora says, crouching down and placing a hand on my knee.

“You don’t think they’ll mind?”

“I doubt they’ll even notice,” she says, leaning in for a quick kiss, “because you look really, really hot in that leather.”

“Oh, do I now?” I ask, narrowing my eyes at her. “Are you ever going to get dressed, Adora? There’s only so long I can watch you prance about in your underwear, you know.”

“I’m on it,” she says, winking before she jumps back to her feet and grabs one of the outfits.

I remove my boot and wiggle my toes, pleased that they’re free of their leather prison. Then I fasten a couple of metal bracers to each wrist, and hook the loose, metallic belt around my waist.

“Oh, and Adora...” I say, walking behind her, and helping her to clip her breastplate together.

“Hmm?”

“Try not to get too drunk and flirty with everyone tonight, otherwise I can’t promise I’ll behave.”

“We don’t even know if they get drunk,” she says, looking over her shoulder. “And I don’t flirt.”

“Oh I’m sure they’ll have something. People always do. And you do flirt, you’re just too dumb to realise it.”

--

Sure enough, the amazons have *something*. In their case, a special, bright pink fruit that they serve up as is, or squashed into juice. I watch as several drinks are poured and placed before us, gulping as I stare into the alarmingly bright liquid.

“To our new visitors!” Zara says, raising a glass.

Mauve raises her glass. “May their magic flow forever.”

We all raise our arms, and after clicking our glasses together I take a sip, wrinkling my nose at the sour flavour.

We’re sitting around one of many outdoor tables which are placed atop a huge platform in the centre of the first floor of Deepwood, and upon each table there are bowls of salad, and plates full of various kinds of meats. There are strings of coloured, magical lights spread around the edges of the area, and also dangling overhead. In the middle of the platform there’s a raised stage, which is currently empty.

“Wow, this is super tasty,” Scorpia says, holding the glass carefully in her pincer. She’s sat to my right, with Perfuma by her side. Adora is on my left, followed by Bow and Glimmer, while Zara and Mauve are sitting opposite, watching us intently.

“What do the rest of you think?” Mauve asks, grinning before she downs her drink and slams her glass on the table.

“It’s a little on the sour side,” I say, taking another sip.

“Oh, you’ll soon get used to it,” Zara says, beaming widely.

“It’s really nice!” Adora says, greedily chugging hers down. I shake my head, wondering if she’s even considered that it might be way too strong for Etherians, but then Perfuma, Bow and Glimmer do the same, and I decide at that point that I’m going to drink very slowly, just in case.

Scorpia leans over, whispering. “Should we hold back?”

“Yeah, let’s take it easy on the drinks,” I whisper, reaching down to stroke Melog’s fur. “And they can be the guinea pigs.”

“So... Adora, Catra,” Zara says, the corner of her lip twitching upwards. “Calisto tells me you are wed after all. When did this occur, exactly?”

“Uh-”

Mauve bursts out laughing. “She’s just fucking with you. Don’t worry.”

“Language, Mauve.”

“Hey, you know what starhooch does to me.”

Our glasses are filled back up again, and I notice that even though I’ve only had a quarter of a glass, there’s a warm tingle in my chest, urging me to drink more and let loose. I ignore it, taking the barest of sips, just to appear social.

“Hey Catra,” Adora says, biting her lip. “You’re sooo beautiful. Did I ever tell you?”

“Hmm, you’ve said all that and more,” I say, wrapping my arm around her shoulder. “But by all means, continue.”

--

By the time everyone is on their fourth drink, the other tables are packed full of other Amazons, raising glasses, talking loudly, and laughing. A couple of them wobble up onto the stage and start to dance, spinning each other in circles before falling over, causing the others to laugh loudly.

“Looks like they are having a good time,” Melog says, appearing amused.

“Ooh, what did they say?” Adora asks, leaning over my lap to peer down at Melog. “Hey Melog, how’s it hanging?”

“How’s the hooch, Adora?” I ask, pushing at her shoulders until she’s sat upright again.

“Starhooch is very, very tasty, I must say,” Perfuma says, resting her head on the table, and smiling up at Scorpia. “Wow. Just look at you. You’re amazing...”

Scorpia blushes brightly before resting her own head on the table, facing away from us, saying who only knows what to Perfuma.

“We only had TWO!” Adora says, suddenly raising her voice for no reason at all. “No wait, three. No. Four.”

“Oh no,” I mutter, shaking my head. “This is like the training dummy all over again.”

“I told you,” Adora says, wrinkling her nose and digging a finger into my chest. “It looked at me funny.”

The noise of a stool being pulled out distracts me, and I peer up, watching as Calisto sits down next to Mauve.

“It’s not like you to join us,” Mauve says, laughing throatily. “Did you get bored of chatting everyone up?”

“Nobody’s biting tonight,” she says, her shoulders slumping. She tips her head towards us and shrugs. “They all keep talking about She-Ra. I just can’t compete.”

“Well,” Zara says, sipping at what must be her sixth drink, although I’m struggling to keep count. “She is rather phenomenal, isn’t she? Adora, will you be transforming tonight?”

“YES! Transformamage!” Adora says, furrowing her brows while holding out her hand, and summoning her weapon in the form of a tiny model horse. “Look! It’s a horsie! I LOVE HORSES!” she exclaims, moving the small toy across the table, making clippity-clop sounds with her tongue.

“Hah, you idiot,” I say, hoping that everyone’s too drunk to care at this point. I look at my own drink, still half full, then shrug my shoulders and swig it down.

“Wow! It really can turn into anything!” Mauve exclaims, her eyes wide. “Make a spear!”

“No, a bear! Calisto says.

“A bear holding a spear!” Zara says, clapping her hands.

“No, a bear holding *two* spears!” Mauve says, jumping to her feet, balling her hands into fists.

“Uhh,” Adora says, frowning. “One sec, -hic-. I have to kind of concentrate first.”

“Just close your eyes and picture it in your mind,” Perfuma says. “Take a deep breath. Clear your mind. Focus.”

“Yeah Adora,” I purr, batting my tail under her nose. “Focus.”

“Haha, stop it,” Adora says, her hands glowing, until a small, intricately detailed figure of myself appears, stark naked and in a very suggestive pose. “Uh. Woops?”

“Adora!” I say, feeling my cheeks burn as I snatch it away.

“You distracted me! It was YOUR fault! -hic-”

“Wait, was that-” Glimmer begins.

“It was nothing,” I snap, leaning closely into Adora’s frame to pass it to her discreetly, whispering. “Change it to a damn bear, Adora. *Now!*”

Suddenly I hear the loud blare of a horn, followed by the banging of drums. Several women with instruments walk onto the raised central platform, and everyone stands up and moves their stools, relocating closer to the stage. We follow Zara, Calisto and Mauve in doing the same.

“You should get your purple-haired friend, she may enjoy this,” Zara says, smiling brightly.

“Oh that’s right, she can’t play with the relics all night,” Glimmer says, leaning over, and almost falling off her stool. “Woops! It’s been ages. I’ll go check on her.”

“No, Sparkles,” I say, quickly standing up and placing my hands on her shoulders. “No drunk blinking. Stay put, Scorpia and I will go get her.”

“Drunk blinking would be baaaad,” Adora says, wobbling on her chair. “She once blinked us into the sky! And that was when she was SOBER! -hic-”

“You’re an idiot,” I say, smiling as I lean down to quickly kiss her forehead. “Slow down the drinking, okay? For me?”

“Anything for my sexy lil stargazer, -hic-.”

Melog bumps their snout to my hip, huffing. “I will keep my eyes on them, worry not.”

“Thanks, Melog,” I say, patting their head a few times. “We won’t be long.”

--

“Oh man, these things aren’t comfortable,” Scorpia says, trying to lift up the leather strap that keeps falling off of her shoulder.

“You should have worn a size smaller,” I say, helping her to fix it, before knocking on Entrapta’s door. “Okay, here we go.”

I hear a muffled voice. “Come in!”

“Oh, hello!” Entrapta says, placing the pieces of the relic on the floor and looking up at the two of us. “Is something the matter?”

“Yes,” I say, sitting down cross-legged in front of her. “We want you to come join us.”

“But-”

Scorpia sits down next to me. “Come on! It’ll be like old times!”

“Yeah!” I say, grinning. “We’re the Super Pal Trio, remember?”

“Well, I suppose...” Entrapta says, furrowing her brows.

“Come on, it will be amazing!” Scorpia says, helping Entrapta to her feet. “We’re going to start by scouting out everyone at this party. Are you in?”

Entrapta gasps. “Wait. Does this mean I can *observe* them?”

“Of course,” I say, hooking my arm with hers. “Let’s go.”

“That sounds more like it!” Entrapta says, pausing to look back at the relics, “I was kind of stuck anyway. Maybe a break will help.”

“When you have a mental block, you should take a break,” Scorpia says, appearing proud. “I learnt that from Perfuma. Isn’t it great? It makes sense, too!”

--

“Fascinating,” Entrapta says, looking around the area in awe, and tapping away at her device. My grip on her arm loosens when Adora comes into view.

She’s turned into She-Ra in our absence, and there are countless women huddled around her, gossiping, giggling, and it takes every ounce of my strength to not pounce over there and gut them all.

But she's mine, I think, whipping my tail side to side. *So nothing to worry about.*

Adora peers over at me and waves. "Catra! Baby!"

She looks so happy to see me that I feel my heart throb, and I chide myself for always thinking the worst. I hurry over to her, wrapping my arms around her waist, and smiling up at her. "Yes, my love?"

"Aww, you two are so cute!" Bow says, grinning.

"Wait," Glimmer says, raising her eyebrows. "Are those your actual pet names?"

"Yeah, so?" I say, reaching up towards Adora's shoulders, standing on my tiptoes.

Adora bends down, and I wrap my arms around her neck as she kisses me, while lifting me up effortlessly. "I missed you."

"I was gone for like two seconds," I say, chuckling. Then I hear a symphony of *aww* and *ooh* sounds, and I prick my ears up, looking around to find dozens of women staring up at us, their eyes glistening. "Adora. What's going on?"

"We were just talking about you," she says, beaming.

"We?"

"All of us. They think we're cute together, by the way. Can't you tell?"

"I, uh-"

Zara claps her hands, demanding everyone's attention. "Now that we are all here… Let the show begin!"

Adora puts me down and changes back to her smaller, leather-bound self (a look that's really starting to grow on me), and we sit side by side, hand in hand, watching while the performers on the stage ready their instruments.

"Get ready for the good stuff," Mauve whispers, winking, while a tall glass is placed into each of our hands, and a dark orange liquid is poured inside.

"Hmm, and you'd just started to sober up," I say, nudging Adora's shoulder.

Suddenly, the drummer bursts into a heavy, loud beat and the other instruments come into play, one after the other, until there are strings, bass, and a steady, loud beat, growing louder and louder. A beam shines down onto the woman in the center, who bursts into song, her vocal chords powerful enough to echo all around, almost hauntingly. She sings a verse about lost love, and no chance at redemption, and then a chorus about her breaking heart, before pausing for an instrumental section.

"Wow…" Adora says, almost spilling her drink.

Glimmer leans forwards, squinting. "Is that... "

"It's Calisto!" Perfuma says, clapping her hands. "I've never heard a voice like that!"

"Oh, so it is," I say, frowning. She's covered in dark purple makeup over half her face, with bright painted stars over it, and is wearing a long, flowing, black, flowing gown unlike anything I've seen

anyone else here wear. I peer across at Adora, trying to ignore the pang of discomfort I feel when I notice her eyes are fixated on Calisto, growing wider still once she starts the second verse.

By the time the song is finished my glass is empty, and I blink my eyes a few times, trying to focus.

“Hey, you beat me!” Adora says, quickly finishing her own drink. “That was amazing!”

“Yeah,” I say, wrinkling my nose. “Amazing.”

--

Five more songs and three more drinks later, I notice that the floor is swaying beneath me, and I wonder for a short, terrifying moment if the whole place is going to come crashing down. But then I realise it’s just me, rocking on my stool.

“Wow. This shit is strong,” I say, belching quietly.

“Hey baby,” Adora says, placing a hand on my arm. “Are you okay?”

“I’m fine, princess,” I say, squinting at her with one eye closed. “Are you having fun? You seem to like this Calisto chick.”

“Of course I do, silly! -hic- She’s… she’s great!”

“Uhuh.”

“Oh look,” Scorpia says, pointing a pincer ahead, “she’s coming over now!”

“Great.”

“Phew, that was exhausting!” Calisto says, snatching Adora’s glass and finishing the contents. “I’m feeling pretty buzzed though.”

“You have a fantastic voice,” Glimmer says, balling her hands into fists.

“You’re amazing!” Bow exclaims.

“Just… breathtaking,” Adora says, smiling at me drunkenly, and I twitch my ears, wondering if that was meant for me, or Calisto.

“How many have you had?” Mauve asks, slapping Calisto on the ass. “You aren’t even walking straight.”

“Mauve!” Zara scolds.

“Do you want a turn, majesty?” Calisto asks, sticking her rear out.

Zara laughs, and slaps it even harder. “Come, let us talk, and drink more!”

“Oh no,” I say, waving my hands, “no more for me.”

Adora wraps an arm around my shoulder, and kisses my cheek. “I meant you, by the way…”

“She did,” Melog says, rubbing their jaw into my thigh.

“You two need to admit you understand each other,” I say, trying to blink my eyes back into focus. “It’s driving me mad.”

“Gather around, everyone,” Zara says, grinning. “The night is young.”

We arrange our chairs into a small circle, facing each other, as more drinks are poured. A jug of water is offered too, and I hold my glass up, thanking the woman as she fills it.

“Why are you so scared of getting too drunk?” Adora asks, squeezing her arm more tightly around me.

“I have pretty sharp claws, Adora,” I say, folding my arm around her waist, and resting my head on her shoulder. “Staying in control is kind of important.”

Mauve clears her throat and leans forwards, resting her elbows on her knees. “You know, you two make quite the couple.”

“They weren’t always like that,” Glimmer says, smirking. “In fact, they’ve tried to kill each other a few times before now.”

“Really?” Calisto asks, raising an eyebrow. “So you were not always together?”

“Long story,” I say, narrowing my eyes at Calisto. “We’re together now. That’s what matters.”

“So how did you go from enemies, to lovers?” Zara asks, hunching over and resting her hands on her knees. “Tell me everything!”

I watch their faces and listen as Bow, Glimmer and Adora give a very short version of the three years of hell that followed Adora finding the sword. Three years where I thought I didn’t need anyone, and did everything in my power to get to the top, only then realising that it didn’t mean an awful lot if I had nobody to share it with.

“Catra?” Zara asks, and I blink a few times.

“Hmm?”

“We have heard their side. What was it like for you? Were you not lonely?”

“I-” I say, gritting my teeth as that old, familiar anger rises up. *Should I joke about it*, I think. *Should I make something up?* “You know what? I was, actually,” I say, deciding that I’m tired of pretending otherwise. “They weren't my best years. Scorpia can fill you in on most of it,” I say, standing up, deciding I need air.

“Catra,” Adora says, reaching for my arm.

“I just need a minute,” I say, squeezing her hand, before walking away.

--

“Hi buddy,” I say, not even opening my eyes when I hear Melog hop onto an adjacent branch. I’m sitting on a nice perch, three times higher up than the third floor of Deepwood, where the cool air bristles through my fur, helping to calm my thoughts and sober me up.

“I felt your anger back there,” they say.

I open my eyes, and release a drawn-out sigh. “Yeah. And just when I thought I was getting better.”

“You controlled your anger, and you were honest. This is an achievement, is it not?”

“I suppose. I just don’t want to talk about that shit with a bunch of strangers, you know?”

“That is understandable. Though I think they were more interested in how you came to be with Adora, than the torment you suffered all those years.”

“The two are kind of linked in places, though.”

Melog huffs. “You should have just told them Mermista’s version.”

“Hah, yeah,” I say. “I was a bad kitty, now I’m a good kitty, who happens to be in love with Adora.”

Melog’s jaw raises into a smile. “Don’t forget the emotional-buddy-kitty part.”

“How could I?” I ask, leaning over and ruffling their fur.

Melog rubs into my hand, and moves onto my branch, resting their snout on my thigh as their chest bursts into a low rumble.

“Did… Did Adora tell them about the heart?”

“Not in detail. She just said you helped her to save the world.”

“Okay,” I say, feeling relieved. “I don’t want her treating it like it wasn’t special, is all.”

“She never does that.”

“It was the first time I opened up to her,” I say, clutching my arm. “I think I was more terrified of how she’d react than the fact the heart was about to kill us both.”

“I know.”

“I still can’t believe she feels the same, Melog.”

“I know.”

--

I walk back towards everyone, pausing in my track when I see Calisto, Mauve, Zara and Adora all hunched forwards in a very small circle, discussing something.

“Am I interrupting something?” I ask, twitching my ears.

“Yay! You’re back!” Adora says, standing up and throwing her arms around me.

“Where’s everyone else?”

“They went to bed,” Adora says, resting her cheek against mine. “I was -hic- waiting for you.”

“Oh, sorry,” I say, trying to steady her as she wobbles around. “You should have gone back. I’m okay.”

Adora wraps her arms around my shoulders and presses her nose to my face. “Boop!” she says, laughing. “Boop boop boop.”

“Haha, stop it,” I say, leaning back. “Moron.”

“You should take her to your room,” Calisto says, smiling warmly. “And make sure she drinks plenty of water.”

“Will do, thanks.”

“Wait!” Adora says, jabbing a finger towards Mauve. “You promised you’d tell me how you got your scar!”

“Hah! Stubborn fool,” Mauve says, standing up and folding her arms. “Fine. We are friends now, after all.”

Zara takes a deep breath, closing her eyes. “A gargantuan attacked our last village. All fur, tooth and claw, and four times bigger than any Amazon.”

“They usually keep to themselves,” Calisto says, grimacing, “but this one was rabid.”

“It killed my wife,” Mauve says, sighing. “I took a mortal wound, too. And… as I lay there dying, my golem… she…”

“So you *do* have a golem?” I ask, twitching my ears, noticing Melog’s ears prick up too. “Where is she?”

“Gone,” Zara says, sighing, and placing a hand on Mauve’s shoulder. “The last of the three that the first ones entrusted to us.”

Mauve sits down, resting her head in her hands. “My dear, precious Lydia… she gave everything...”

I fold my ears down. “Sorry… but I don’t understand…”

“Golems have many, many astounding abilities,” Zara says, leaning down to pet Melog. “From what we understand, Lydia gave her life for Mauve, healing her in the process.”

“That’s awful!” Adora says, furrowing her brows. “I mean -hic-, it’s great you’re alive, but…”

Mauve nods her head. “Now all I can do is make sure I’m living my best life, as she would have wanted...”

“Well, shit,” I say, wrapping my arms around Melog protectively.

“I am not going anywhere,” they say, appearing amused.

“That’s so sad,” Adora says, bursting into tears, and wrapping her arms around Mauve. “I’m so sorry.”

“Get her home safely,” Mauve says, blinking back tears and smiling softly while she pats Adora’s back. “We will see you all in the morning.”

“Or the afternoon,” Calisto says, winking. “Take your time, and enjoy your rest.”

“Thanks, everyone,” I say, placing Adora’s arm around my shoulder. “Come on, idiot.”

“I wish to spend time with this one,” Melog says, before turning around and following Mauve. “I will see you tomorrow.”

“Bye, buddy. Look after her.”

--

I manage to get Adora back to our room, somehow preventing her from stumbling over the edge of the various bridges and wooden platforms along the way.

“You are so pretty, and so sexy,” Adora says, falling through the door as she opens it, and landing on the floor. She raises a hand up and opens her palm. “See?” she asks, conjuring the same mini-catra she formed earlier.

“Change that to something else, Adora. Seriously,” I say, holding my hand out, and helping her to her feet.

“Okay, done,” she says, clambering to her feet and summoning a small Melog statue.

“You’re getting good at that,” I say, quickly closing the door, then turning to face her. “But we need to get you some water, and get you to bed.”

“No, let’s stay up!” she says, “We can talk about stuff, like how much I like your -hic- *eyeballs*,” she says, poking her fingers below my cheeks.

“Haha, you idiot! I can’t talk to you in this state.”

“Oh, I have an idea!” Adora says, before shimmering up in size into her She-Ra form.

“Adora, what the hell-”

“Shh,” she says, placing a finger on my lips. She closes her eyes, and a glow surrounds her whole body for a few seconds. Then she blinks at me, and widens her eyes. “Wow! I can’t believe that actually worked!”

My jaw falls open when I notice her slur has completely gone, and her eyes are now as focused as ever. “Adora. Did you just-”

“I healed my drunkenness! Yay!” she says, clapping her hands. She shimmers back down to her usual size, steps forwards and wraps her arms around me. “I wanted to be sober for the next part....”

“Huh?”

She takes a step back towards one of the shelves in here, grinning as she reaches for her folded-up space suit. “You said I couldn't do this tomorrow, or the day after,” she says, rummaging her hand into a pocket. “But you never said today was off limits.”

“Adora…” I say, watching as she takes slow, purposeful steps towards me. “What are you…”

“I love you,” she says, taking my hand in hers and placing something into it. I look down, finding her golden wing badge, usually worn on her horde uniform belt. “Will you keep this?”

Such a simple, dumb way of proposing, I think. *But also so incredibly sweet, and so perfectly Adora*. I look down at my hand, the golden trinket glistening under the flickering, magical candlelight, then

back at Adora's eyes, full of nothing but love. And I don't think it could be possible for my heart to feel any more full of joy than it does in this moment.

"Um, say something?" Adora says, wincing. "Please? Catra, you don't have to keep it. Ugh, I'm an idiot! I'm sorry if this was too-"

"Shut up," I say, leaning forwards, placing my palm against her cheek and kissing her gently. "I'm keeping it," I mumble against her lips.

"Catra," Adora says, sniffling.

"No crying."

"Says you," she says, kissing my cheek, before breathing out a very long sigh.

"Are you okay?" I ask, raising an eyebrow.

"I'm just... relieved. They said I should do this, but…"

"They?" I ask, flicking my left ear.

"Zara, Calisto and Mauve. I spoke to them after the others went to bed. I told them you sounded okay with the idea of proposing," she says, laughing, "and the next thing I know they're telling me to do it right now, and they were all so excited for us. It was sweet."

"Lucky for me I gave you some space then."

Adora kisses me, softly. "I would have asked eventually, either way."

"Or I would," I say, kissing her, then chuckling. "I can't believe you brought that thing with you."

"Oh come on, you know it's my lucky charm…"

"I guess it's my lucky charm now," I say, purring quietly as I stroke her face. "Now, let me think... what can I give you in return…" I say, taking a step back and starting to undress myself. I peel off layer after layer, until all that remains is my underwear. "Ah, I've got it," I smirk, slowly pulling down my briefs, then dangling them on the end of my finger. "All yours, my love."

Adora blushes brightly before taking my offering. "Do I have to wear them right now?" she says, biting her lip. "They're a little damp, is all."

"I'd rather you weren't wearing anything right now, to be honest."

"Is that so?" Adora asks, running her gaze up and down my form, before she quickly starts to undress, and I help her strip, the two of us giggling, before we remove my sports bra and throw it to one side.

"Ready to conquer another planet?" Adora asks, stepping forwards and placing her hands on my waist.

"Always," I say, leaning forwards and kissing her, again and again, while pushing her towards the bed, but at the last second she grabs my waist and turns us around, pushing me to the mattress, kissing me hungrily.

And then it's like I can't kiss her enough, can't touch her enough, can't get enough of her tongue against mine. Our hands work in a frenzy, all touch and longing, all need and desire. But I notice Adora still hesitates when it comes to her touch, and she holds her trembling hand at my waist.

"Adora," I say, taking her hand, and shifting it towards my abdomen. "Why do you always hold back?"

"I don't know," she admits, meeting my gaze. "I guess I'm still worried I'll do something wrong, or take things too far, or mess up somehow."

I laugh, "Are you dense? You've had your tongue on me, and your hands. And we're kind of engaged now, so I think we're good to go."

"Uh…"

"I mean all the way," I say, blushing slightly. "I want to feel you, Adora."

Adora inhales deeply, then leans down and kisses me, slowly this time. Her leg slides between my thighs and I welcome the pressure, groaning into her kiss, digging my fingers into her back while she explores me with her hand, feeling all around the dip of my waist, then across my ribs and towards my breast, and I try to be patient... but it's impossible.

"Wrong direction, Adora," I mumble, grabbing her wrist and pushing it downwards.

"No," Adora says, and I widen my eyes in surprise.

"Huh?"

"I'm going to take my time, and you're going to lay back and enjoy it."

"Uh," I find myself lost for words, my throat turning dry at the sight of her stern glare. "Okay."

Adora props herself up on her elbows and smiles smugly. "I'll make it worth the wait."

I'm not sure I'll survive this, I think, closing my eyes and savouring every touch she gives me, enjoying her hand, exploring freely. Her lips caress across my cheek, resting beneath my ear where I feel her tongue dart against the sensitive skin there, forcing an inferno to blaze between my legs, and the deepest of groans to escape my throat.

Adora's form shudders above me. "Hmm, did I just find something new?"

"Uhuh," I say, only barely aware that I'm grinding into her thigh, feeling delicious pressure build up. "Ah… ah..."

Adora moves her leg away. "Not yet."

"What! Come on!" I growl, writhing up into nothing.

Adora chuckles and I'd be infuriated if I weren't so far gone, if Adora's hand wasn't on my painfully stiff nipple, if my breast and torso weren't raising up of their own accord into that velvety, warm palm of hers. A tiny voice in my head tells me I'm showing weakness, but it's drowned out by every inch of my body telling me I need this, need her, need everything she'll give me.

“Do you, now?” Adora asks, her breath hot against my ear, and I curse when I realise I’ve been talking out loud, fueling that damn smugness of hers.

“I’m going to kill you if you don’t stop teasing,” I groan, forcing my eyes open. And only then do I realise she’s looking at me in a whole new way, her eyes a shade darker than I’ve ever seen. Only then do I think that maybe… just, maybe... Adora’s struggling to hold on, too.

“If you kill me I can’t do this,” she says, trapping my stiff nipple between two fingers. “Or this,” she says, pressing her lips to my neck and biting, *firmly*, at the skin beneath the short fur.

“Ah! *shit*,” I hiss, throwing my head back into the pillow, squeezing my eyes closed. I grab behind her neck, pulling her biting, teasing mouth more tightly against my flesh, enjoying the ripples it sends down my spine.

“You like it?” Adora mumbles.

“Uh.. uhuh.”

Adora teases me. I don’t know how long for... all I know are her hands, and her lips, exploring every single crevice of my body, touching everywhere apart from the place that’s screaming for her touch the most.

“Adora,” I say, batting my tail around. “Are you seriously going to make me beg?”

“Hmm, not this time,” she says, gliding her hand slowly down my abdomen, and past my thinner, darker fur.

“Ah!” I gasp, immediately, shamelessly writhing into her touch, enjoying the sensation as she rolls rough circles against my wet, swollen bud.

“You’re wet,” she says, her voice sounding hoarse, her fingers dipping into my entrance.

“Okay, that does it,” I growl. I pull her ear to my mouth, and tug her earlobe between my teeth before snarling. “Will you *please*. Just. Get. Your fingers inside of me, now.”

Adora’s body turns rigid above mine, and it’s like I can almost hear the final threads *snap* while her fingers slowly ease into me. But then, she pauses, sighing against my neck. “Catra…”

“Please,” I say, my heart pounding in my chest. “Don’t make me ask again.”

She raises her head and peers down at me, her eyes appearing darker than ever, her face surrounded by long, messy strands of hair. “I love you,” she says, before pressing her lips to mine, and I cry out when something inside of me gives way and I finally feel her, touching me in a place I’ve never felt her before.

“Adora,” I gasp, digging my fingers into her shoulders, barely keeping my claws sheathed.

“Are you okay?” she asks, her hand stilling.

“Please, just for once,” I whine, lightly digging my nails into her flesh. “Stop worrying, and stop holding back, okay? I need you…”

Adora gasps and I feel her ease herself out, then back into me, keeping pressure held where I need it, slowly picking up the pace until she’s thrusting firmly in time with my hips, the wet, wanting sounds

from my body barely audible over the sound of our gasps and groans.

“More,” I say, and she must have added a second finger, because I suddenly feel more stretched out, more full.

“Is this okay?” she asks, panting against my lips.

“*Yes*...” I whimper, thrusting my hips into her hand, “Adora, harder.”

She groans, writhing herself against my thigh and curling her fingers deep inside of me, over and over. *I want her*, I think. *I need her, faster, harder*, and I know I must be saying it out loud because she’s doing everything I ask for, until she places her lips at my neck and bites, *hard*, and then everything becomes blurred.

All I know are her relentless fingers, wetly gliding into me and coaxing out one white hot, burning pulse after another, each rocking through my whole body, searing more hotly than the last.

Don’t stop. I love you. Oh fuck, Adora, Oh... fuck.

“Adora!” I cry out her name, digging my fingers into her back and clamping my mouth to her neck, muffling my scream as the most intense, glorious spasm yet rips through me. “Ah… ah,” I pant, feeling warm aftershocks ripple slowly through my body, until their heat pools within my chest, settling there.

I leave my lips at Adora’s neck, lazilly kissing her, tasting the salt of her sweat, barely even noticing when she gently removes her hand.

“Wow,” she whispers.

I slowly prise my eyes open, watching as she raises her fingers to her lips and smirks before sucking them, one at a time. If I weren’t so spent it’d make me want her all over again.

I take a few deep breaths, and shake my head, chuckling. “Enjoying yourself?”

Adora smiles and lays half on top of me with her leg folded over my abdomen, her arm across my torso, and her nose pressed to my cheek. “You’re trembling…” she whispers. “Are you okay?”

“Yeah,” I say, stroking a hand through her hair. “Just a little overwhelmed.”

“I know the feeling.”

“Hmm. I love you.”

“I love you too,” Adora says, kissing my cheek. “You were amazing, by the way.”

“So were you,” I mumble, lazilly trailing my fingers over her back, until I feel something wet, too wet to be sweat. It takes me a few seconds to realise what it is, and then I hiss air between my teeth. “Adora…”

“Hmm?”

“Turn around.”

She leans up and twists around. Behind her shoulders, there are several long, red scratches, some of which are deep enough that they're bleeding a little. I feel the warmth drain from my face as my heart starts to pound in my chest, and it's like suddenly, I can't even breathe.

Adora reaches a hand out. "Catra…"

"No!" I say, shuffling away from her, folding my ears down. I raise my hand and look at my claws, finding blood there, her blood, just like before, and it takes every ounce of willpower I have to stop myself from retching. "No..."

"Catra, stop it," Adora says, grabbing both of my wrists and pinning me down to the mattress, pressing her full weight on top of me. "Stop. I liked it, Okay? It felt good."

"You… what?!"

"They're not even deep. See," she says, closing her eyes for a couple of seconds, before she glows briefly, "all gone."

"But…" I say, gulping for air, my heart hammering. "I can't keep hurting you. I can't."

"Did it hurt when I bit your neck?"

"Yes," I say, remembering how her teeth felt, and how it drove me more than a little crazy. "I mean, no? I... liked it."

"Exactly. I liked you losing control, and I liked you scratching my back," she says, before resting her lips beside my ear. "I liked it so much that I came really fucking hard, or have you not noticed how damp your thigh is?"

"Adora," I gasp, feeling my panic swiftly abate, replaced with a whole new feeling of longing, of *need*. I raise my hips up, hoping she understands.

She does. And this time, Adora doesn't make me wait, doesn't hold back. Before I can take another breath her teeth are upon my neck, her fingers are inside of me, and she's thrusting into me faster and harder than ever, and it takes less than a few seconds for me to unravel all over again, ice-cold fear replaced with burning hot need, radiating through me, from my core, to my chest, all the way up to the tips of my ears.

"Adora!" I yell, choking out her name as a slow, violent spasm erupts through me. I ball my hands into fists and cling onto her with my forearms, until the feeling ebbs away into delicious, trembling aftershocks. And then I lay beneath her, shaking, but feeling far much more relaxed. Until I feel Adora start to move away, that is. Until she starts to remove her hand.

"No, stay," I say, flattening my palms against her back, and pushing my nose into the crook of her neck, "just for a while. Just stay right where you are."

"Okay," Adora says, keeping her hand and fingers there, keeping her weight pressed above me, keeping a part of herself inside me, filling my senses, grounding me. "I'm here. I love you."

And then, I start to cry. I don't even know why, it just comes out all by itself, and I try to stop it but that only makes it worse. Adora doesn't say a word, she just keeps herself where I need her, just like I've asked her to, while I hold her, sobbing, feeling everything I've boxed up inside of me for so long overflow and spill out against her shoulder.

--

I don't know how long I cry for. But once I'm done, my eyelids feel swollen, and there's a warm glow within my chest that makes me feel strangely relaxed.

I relax my grip on Adora, and clear my throat, sniffling. "Uh…"

"Hey," she says, pulling away to look me in the eyes, before she smiles smugly. "Can I move my hand yet? I think my skin is turning wrinkly."

"Hah!" I push at her shoulders. "I'm not sure you should be complaining, Adora. I bet you've wanted to have your hand there for years."

"Pretty much," she says, before looking at her hand and proudly sucking her fingers dry.

"Pfft. Do I taste that good?"

"You do, actually", she says, cupping my chin and softly stroking her thumb against my cheek. "Hey, Catra."

I smirk. "Hey Adora."

"Are you okay?"

"I think so. Sorry. Not sure what came over me."

Adora sits up between my legs, then takes one of my hands, and runs her thumb across the tips of my bloodied claws. "Shall we clean these up?"

"Not the worst idea," I say, sighing.

We both stand from the bed and head into the washroom, where Adora turns the tap on, and prepares a warm cloth with soap.

"I meant what I said, you know," Adora says, taking my hand in hers and dabbing the cloth around my fingers.

"What, that you have a weird claw fetish?" I ask, stretching out my claws a little, so that she can clean behind the grooves.

"Are you telling me you don't like it when I dig my nails into your back?"

"What? No…. shut up," I chuckle, watching as she finishes cleaning the last two digits. "That isn't the same."

"It kind of is, though," she says, rinsing the cloth, then kissing the tips of my fingers. "If you ever do hurt me, I'll tell you. I'll stop you. I promise. And we'll work it out from there."

I feel my shoulders sag in relief. "Promise?"

"I promise. Also," she says, blowing a loose strand of hair from her face. "I was disappointed you didn't do it again in round two."

"Adora," I chuckle, swatting at her shoulder.

“Maybe I didn’t drive you crazy enough...”

“Shut up! Haha!”

She wraps her arms around my shoulders, and kisses me tenderly. “How are you feeling?”

“Good. Really good,” I say, pressing my nose to hers, smiling widely. “And maybe a little embarrassed.”

“Hey, we all need a good cry sometimes.”

“I told you,” I pout. “I don’t like crying.”

“Nobody does, stargazer,” Adora sighs, brushing a few strands of my hair from my face. “But it’s what makes us human.”

“That reminds me!” I say, grinning from ear to ear. “I called you my love. And they heard.”

“So you did,” Adora says, lowering her eyes to my lips. “When are you thinking of claiming your prize?”

“Hmm. Naked She-Ra, to do with as I please...”

Adora nods, and bites her lower lip. “Can’t wait to see what you have in mind.”

“We’re going to need thicker walls, so let’s wait until we’re back home.”

“You know, the palace doesn’t have sound-proof walls either.”

“True, but we’re also going to need a bigger bed.”

“Good point,” Adora says, taking my hand in hers, and kissing my knuckles. “Ready for round three?”

“Yes, but I’ve worked up quite an appetite,” I say, licking my lips.

“Oh, should we see if there’s any food left?”

“That’s not quite what I had in mind, Adora.”

“Oh.”

--

The next morning, and after neither of us have had much sleep at all, Adora wakes me up with a loud “Tada!”

I prise one eye open, laughing when I find her standing there wearing nothing but my red panties. “Pfft, hah! Thought they were too dirty for you.”

“I cleaned them in the sink,” Adora says, shrugging. “What do you think?”

“They suit you.”

“I won’t be able to wear them every day though,” Adora says, pouting.

“So, we’ll just repurpose the elastic into a couple of hair ties or something,” I say, shrugging. “Once you’ve worn them out, that is.”

“We’re allowed to share more than one thing, you know.”

“Are you saying you want more of my underwear, Adora?”

“It does feel kind of sexy,” she says, blushing.

“Does it now?” I purr, lowering my gaze to her navel, then beckoning her over with my finger. “Come here.”

“But we’ll be late for breakfast,” Adora says, straddling me on the bed.

“Too bad.”

Adora leans down, her hair tickling my face, her lips an inch away.

Suddenly, a thunderous *bang* resonates through the air, and the ground trembles.

“What the hell?” I say, flattening my ears.

“We’d better check it out,” Adora says, kissing me quickly, jumping from the bed, and pulling on her spacesuit.

The ground continues to shake, and I quickly put on my own underwear and suit, then grab my winged broach and fasten it to my breast, clutching at it tightly, hoping beyond hope that this place isn’t going to fall down with us stuck on it.

The door bursts open and Glimmer stands there, appearing pale. “It’s Entrapta’s hut, come quickly!”

We take her hands and a moment later we’re there, finding Entrapta crouched down with her eyes wide, and her gaze fixed on the viciously swirling, purple vortex that’s spinning around a couple of feet in front of her.

“I’m... not sure this was their intended purpose,” she says, the relics sparking and smoking beneath the portal. “but it *is* fascinating.”

“Can we close it?” Bow asks.

“I believe it’s closing by itself,” Entrapta says, pointing a pigtail towards the swirling mass. “It’s already smaller than when it first opened.”

Zara bursts into the room. “What in the four goddesses…”

“Accidental portal,” I say, shrugging. “It’s gonna close, hopefully.”

Glimmer suddenly gasps, and all of the colour drains from her face. She jabs her arm into the portal, then snatches it back, wincing.

“What the hell, Sparkles,” I say, checking over her forearm, finding several deep, bloodied grooves cut into it. “Adora, can you fix this?”

Glimmer stares into the portal while Adora frowns, then grunts. “I... I can’t!”

“Perhaps the portal is blocking Etherian magic,” Entrapta muses, resting the tip of a pigtail beneath her chin.

“Mother…” Glimmer whispers, before trying to lunge into the portal. Adora grabs her arms, stopping her, but she wriggles in her grip and tries to break free. “My mother is in there! I heard her! Can’t you hear that!?”

“What?!” I say, pricking my ears up. Sure enough, there's the faintest whisper of a haunting melody, almost masked by the howling, violent winds of the portal. “Holy shit.”

“Glimmer… Are you sure?” Adora asks, raising her eyebrows.

“I can hear it too,” I say, gritting my teeth. “Someone’s definitely in there.”

“It’s her,” Glimmer sobs. “I’d recognise that song anywhere… she used to… she used to sing it to me, when-”

“Calm down, princess,” I say, placing my hands on her shoulders.

“I estimate the portal will close in fourteen seconds,” Entrapta says, frowning. “And I don’t think I’ll be able to create another. Freak accident and all.”

Adora reaches her hand towards the portal, but I swat it away. “Stop being dense, Adora. You won’t survive without She-Ra.”

“But we will,” Melog says, rubbing their snout against my thigh. A strange, blue glow emanates from them and quickly surrounds me. “Our magic is powerful, and ancient.”

I smile down at them, feeling grateful that they always feel what’s in my heart, even when it’s some kind of spontaneous insanity. “Are you sure?”

They nod, and I don’t waste another moment. I kiss Adora quickly, telling her *I love you*, and *I’m sorry*, before I hop onto Melog’s back and we leap through the shrinking void, into the unknown.

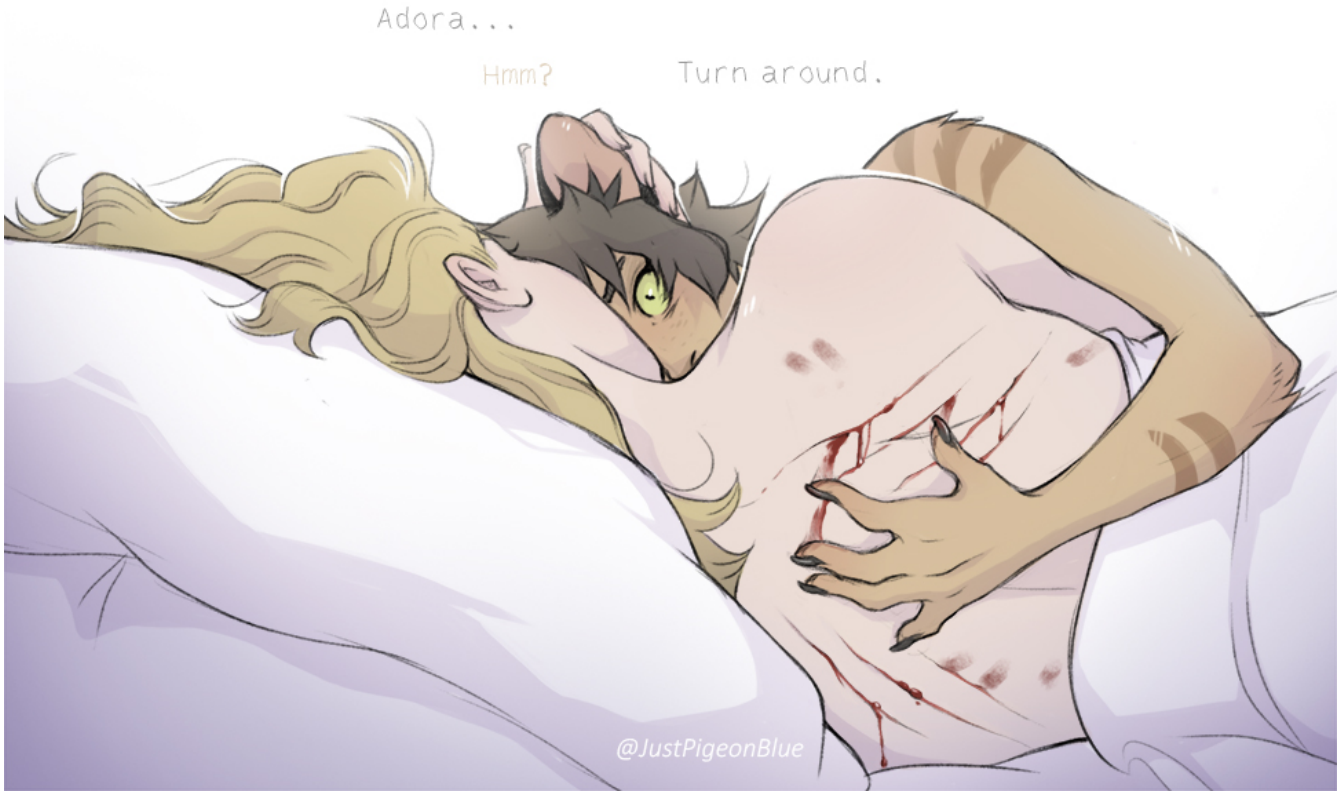
Chapter End Notes

Bow: Wow, that was some party!! I knew we wouldn't let you guys down.
Zara: Oh yes, I feel it was definitely one of our better ones.
Mauve: Hah! Understatement. I had a hangover for two days.
Catra: So you're literally going to ignore the fact that Melog and I Just... you know what, fine. I don't care.

Thanks for the help again, BlueEyesAndHair! You rawk x x

Bonus one shot - Catra claims her prize. Set "some time" after the main story.

PigeonBlue has broken my heart with this amazing work. It captures the moment perfectly.


Adora...
Hmm?
Turn around.
@JustPigeonBlue

Guts and Golems

Chapter Summary

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

I squint my eyes and peer ahead through seemingly endless purple and black swirls, wondering how long this tunnel goes on for. Just when I'm starting to worry that we might be trapped here forever, in some kind of motion-sickness hell, we burst through the other side, into thin air.

"Oh, shii-"

I yell as we fall, reaching my hands for Melog's mane, and pulling myself close to them. We fall turning head over heel, the wind hurtling past my fur, the ground and the sky a dizzying blur as we spin around.

"This is not good," Melog says, whining.

I manage to climb back onto their back and straighten out our spiralling fall, holding on for dear life. "No shit!" I yell, squinting my eyes and watching helplessly as the red, barren ground hurtles towards us at an alarming rate. *Well this was a mistake*, I think, snapping my eyes shut just before we hit the floor.

Something slams into my stomach, winding me, and I feel my fall roughly broken. I open my eyes and peer up, finding an angel holding me in one arm, and Melog in the other. She flaps her huge, majestic wings once, twice, then lands us all safely onto the ground, before she puts us down and glares at me.

"Who are you?"

"You're Angella, right?" I ask, rubbing my bruised abdomen. "I'm, uh-"

"It matters not. You are trespassing, and making an *awful* rukus. Leave at once!"

“Look,” I say, rolling my eyes, “we’re here to rescue you, so just-”

“What on Etheria are you talking about?” Angella scoffs, spreading her arms wide. “Rescue me? From my own palace?”

I peer around, flattening my ears, finding only crimson, rocky ground, with a few small dust devils blowing around. Above, there’s a dirty-orange sky with no sun to be found anywhere.

Angella places her hands on her waist. “Well?”

“Um,” I say, waving into the distance. “There’s nothing here.”

“You’re clearly quite mad,” Angella says, spreading her wings wide then thrusting them down, sending dust and grit into my eyes. “And I have other matters to attend to.”

When I blink away the dirt, she’s nowhere to be seen. “Well, fuck.”

“This is not good,” Melog says, bumping their snout against my leg.

“So you keep saying,” I say, shaking my head. “Remind me why we came here?”

Melog huffs, appearing amused. “You wanted to play the hero.”

“Oh, come on.”

“It’s true.”

“No I don’t, Melog. I just thought we could help. Turns out we can’t, if *that* was anything to go by.”

“You are giving up so easily?”

“Maybe,” I say, clutching my arm, “just...tell me you have a plan for getting us out of here.”

“Of sorts. It is something I have never tried.”

“You’re not really filling me with confidence here, buddy.”

“We will be okay,” Melog says, walking ahead of me. “I saw her fly in this direction, come.”

I sprint towards them, then hop on their back. “Okay. Hopefully we’ll catch her.”

--

We walk for what feels like hours, not that I can know for sure when the sky never seems to change colour, and there’s no sun to guide me. Then I see it again, just in the corner of my eye, something I’ve noticed four times now. *Someone is definitely following us*, I think, twisting my head around. But I find nothing but wide, open and parched terrain.

“What is it?” Melog asks.

“I’m not sure,” I say, leaning down against their mane. “Feels like something is following us.”

Suddenly, Melog halts abruptly, kicking up dirt and pricking their ears prick forwards.

“What is it, buddy?” I ask, crouching down. “Have you seen them, too?”

“It cannot be.”

“Huh?”

I peer ahead in the same direction as them, then rub my eyes a few times. Walking towards the two of us is a long-limbed, humanoid golem, with two golden swirling spheres for eyes.

“Do you know them?” I ask, watching as the grey visitor slowly steps towards us, their feet somehow making no sound as they move.

“You…” Melog says, tilting their head up at them. “But you died! How can this be?”

The huge, stone creature bends down, and places their hand on Melog’s snout. I’m about to shove them away when I notice Melog’s fur turning an almost luminescent purple, and their jaw raising into a wide smile.

The form speaks, and it’s like hearing metal creak against stone.

“I have missed you too,” Melog says, butting their head into the other golem’s hand.

“Melog, hi,” I say, prodding their mane. “What’s going on?”

Melog turns to face me. “This is Aria. An old, dear friend, from a long time ago. I had almost forgotten them.”

Aria bends down and tilts their head, their golden eyes glowing brightly as though questioning me.

“Uh, hi. Any friend of Melog is a friend of mine,” I say, holding a hand out.

The giant reaches their arm out and presses one thick finger into my palm, their touch surprisingly gentle, and warm. Then I hear their voice in my head. It’s so soft, and so quiet, almost how I’d imagine a mother might sound... if I’d ever had one.

“You. Love. Melog?”

“Uh, yeah. Of course.”

“Good,” they say, their small mouth spreading wide, into something that could almost be called a smile. *“I love Melog.”*

Melog sniffs around Aria a few times, then peers up, whining quietly. “What are you doing here? I saw you perish.”

“I am dead?” Aria asks, tilting their head. *“I do not remember this.”*

“Oh,” Melog says, appearing crestfallen. They sit down and remain quiet for a while, as does Aria.

“Melog,” I say, sitting down next to them. “What is it?”

“Aria is not really here,” they say, and for the first time for as long as I’ve known them, I see Melog’s eyes appear damp. “This is a memory. Nothing more.”

I wrap my arms around Melog, trying to offer whatever comfort I can, while I squint up at the towering form. Sure enough, it seems to fade away for just a moment, before appearing corporeal again. “How come we’re seeing this?”

“Possibly a side effect of our being here.”

“So… do you think Angella can see a whole palace?”

“I imagine so,” Melog says, tilting their head. “When you first came here, did you ever experience anything like this?”

“Hmm,” I say, furrowing my brows. “It was hard to tell what was real and what wasn’t.”

“Then we will have to be careful. Such a place could drive us insane,” Melog says, standing onto all fours, and shaking their fur. “Come, we must find Angella.”

“But what about-”

“They are not real. And if Angella has been here all this time…”

I sigh. “So you think we’re too late?”

“She is likely mad, yes,” Melog says, huffing. “But we must try to save her. It is why we came.”

I hop onto Melog’s back before we race away from their oldest, dearest friend. And for the first time, I feel Melog’s pain. *Never knew it worked both ways*, I think, blinking away tears.

--

Eventually, I notice Melog start to tire, so I pat their back a few times to get their attention.

“You wish to stop?”

“Yes,” I say, hopping from their back, then peering up at the dust-filled sky, finding it the same dark orange as always. I scan around the horizon, wondering how it can just all look the same. The *exact* same.

“Is something the matter?“

“Let’s at least work out if we’re going in circles,” I say, before crouching down and scratching a deep *X* into the ground. “Also, we should stop for a while. I don’t want you getting exhausted.”

“I am fine.”

“Melog…”

They groan, and sit down almost aggressively, glaring at me accusingly. “If it will please you, I shall rest for a minute.”

“Yes it will please me,” I say, chuckling. I sit down beside them, and lean back against their chest, enjoying how it rises and falls behind me, until my eyelids begin to feel heavy. “Hey, Melog…”

“You wish to know more about Aria.”

“Only if you want to talk.”

“It would be easier to just show you...”

“Huh, what do you-”

The next thing I know I feel myself dragged backwards, impossibly tugged at for just a few moments, until I find myself looking across the vast horizon of a planet I've never seen before, lush, green and beautiful.

I try to speak, but I can't, and try to look at my hands, finding nothing. I feel myself start to panic.

Do not worry. Melog's voice, clearly spoken in my mind. *This is merely a vision I am sharing. Think clearly, and I will hear you.*

You could have warned me, I think, grateful to feel their amusement in return. *And since when can you share memories? And why didn't you do it sooner?*

I shall explain later. For now, watch. Listen.

My view on the planet's surface blurs as I speed forwards, hurtling across the foliage and then coming to a sudden halt within a vast, densely forested woodland. In here, towering golems are lumbering around, some appearing gold from head to toe, some silver, others grey, and some a mixture of two or all three colours.

They look just like Aria, I think, watching the gentle giants as they go about their business.

It is our natural form, Melog explains. *When we are not bonded to a mortal, that is.*

The scene fades away to blackness and I feel myself become corporeal, albeit in a very different body to my own. I open my eyes, slowly blinking, finding two golden, glowing orbs peering right back.

Melog's thoughts echo around. *Thousands of years ago, I came into this world, alongside Aria.*

Wow, I think, looking down at my hands, each finger no bigger than a twig. *Am I you right now? You're tiny!*

Yes, this is normal, they explain. *We grow, like mortals. But we do not age, or die.*

Aria stretches both arms up and yawns, then smiles widely. "We are born!" they exclaim, sitting up, and leaning forward, looking straight into my eyes.

"We are," I say, standing up, feeling elated at this chance of a new, exciting life. I reach both hands out and Aria returns the gesture, pressing their palms to mine.

Golems are always born in pairs, Melog explains, *but we do not know why.*

Wait, I think*, Aria was your brother!?*

Yes. It can be likened to having a sibling.

Oh, I think, feeling my heart clench. *You don't need to show me more. I know it must be hard for you.*

I do not mind. In fact, perhaps it helps.

I feel myself tugged away from Melog's newborn form, and then a new reality blurs into my vision, whereby Melog shows me flashbacks of their long, peaceful life with Aria and the other Golems.

We were happy...

I watch them all flourish, thanks to the natural magic of the planet. They were one with their ecosystem, one with nature. They helped tend to the natural gardens, help wounded or sick creatures, and even keep the rivers flowing and the rains falling. The eldest among them were as tall as the tallest trees, their forms covered with moss and flowers.

Wow, will you get that big? I think, peering up at one of the behemoths.

No. We do not grow much bigger than our bondmates.

I'm not sure I believe that, not with how many tiny steaks you eat…

I feel Melog's amusement wash over me. *Our kind do not actually need to eat, as you can see. Magic works just as well.*

Yeah, you kept that one quiet, I think, watching as Melog and Aria continue to grow, until they're at least half the size of a behemoth. *Wow, you guys got big...*

Krytis was rich in magic. It did not take all that long, if I recall. Perhaps just a few hundred years.

Oh, is that all, I think, feeling Melog's amusement, warm in my belly. But then, that feeling turns to ice, and I watch, appalled, as the first ones arrive, ship after ship landing on the planet, without a care in the world as their thrusters burn acres of land to a crisp.

Other than their recklessness they were not hostile, at first, Melog explains. *But eventually...*

I watch through Melog's eyes as they first discover the miles of land turned barren, first one's tech boring into the ground. Moments later a behemoth storms into view, their shambling, angry mass a sight to behold as they slam their gigantic arms around, wrecking the machines, and injuring or killing the people working there.

We still tried to find a way to make peace with the Eternians, until...

--

"Why?" Aria asked, as they peered down at the first ones. The small humanoids peered back with a mixture of curiosity and greed, before they raised their strange guns and shot out ropes that spun around Aria's form, binding them tightly, forcing them to the ground.

Melog tried to intervene, only to find themselves ensnared in the very same way. And then, they were both dragged away by a machine.

"We must stop them," Melog said, as their form was dragged across uneven earth. They summoned all their strength, fought desperately against their bindings, but it was not enough. "They are capturing us."

"I shall stop them," Aria said.

Melog chuckled, amused that as always, Aria was a golem of few words. A moment later Aria's eyes glowed more brightly than ever, and they roared as they stretched out and snapped their ropes, then walked free and tugged at Melog's binds.

"Stop!" one of the small ones commanded.

But Aria swatted them away, like a fly. And a moment later, one of the other eternians pointed a very different-looking weapon at them. Melog could only watch in horror, struggling with their last few binds as the first ones blew Aria to pieces with their arcane technology.

Normally, a golem would perish when their birthmate died. But instead, Melog went into a vicious, feral rage, and swiftly killed the ones that killed Aria.

Melog lost count of how many they had killed after that, and of how many scars they'd received upon their own form. They never stopped fighting, never stopped rescuing their kin from the greedy eternians trying to take them away for who only knew what purposes.

And then, as though fate couldn't be any crueler, other invaders arrived to Krytis. It was an entire army clad in white, with green, soulless eyes. They swiftly defeated the first ones, and were soon moments away from destroying the planet itself, or what was left of it.

But In one final, desperate plea, the planet itself spoke to Melog, and imbued within them every drop of magic, every essence of life that remained. And so, Melog *grew*. To impossible, beyond-gargantuan proportions, perhaps half the size of Krytis itself. The invaders didn't stand a chance. Their ships were swatted away, hundreds of them destroyed by each swipe of Melogs gigantic, clawed hands.

Melog watched as the few remaining vessels escaped, and then, they quickly became exhausted. They rapidly shrunk in size, smaller and smaller, until they were barely the size of an eternian. There was nothing left around them. No life. No magic.

Melog despaired, and roamed the bleak, lifeless planet, slowly starving to death, until they stumbled across one of the temples that the first ones had left behind. There was enough magic harvested there to last Melog hundreds, perhaps thousands of years.

And so that is where Melog stayed, the final, surviving guardian of Krytis. Or perhaps, they were Krytis itself.

--

And then I hid in their ruins. Sleeping. Resting. Forgetting, or trying to.

I feel myself float above Melog's resting form, and when I next open my eyes, I'm grateful to find myself back in my own skin, feeling the familiar weight of my own body. I hold a hand out, stretching my fingers open and closed a few times.

"Wow," I whisper, standing up, and dusting myself off. I kneel in front of Melog, and lean over, resting my forehead on theirs "I'm so sorry," I say, feeling Melog's pain still throbbing in my chest.

A few moments later, Melog opens their light blue eyes, and I lean back, sitting upright. "Why would you apologise? You were the one that rescued me from such solitude."

"You know what I mean," I say, clutching my knees to my chest. "That was awful."

Melog huffs. "Which part?"

"All of it!" I exclaim, "I knew prime was a piece of shit… but I never realised the eternians were as bad."

Melog's eyes glow more brightly. "Adora is proof that they are not all bad."

“Hah, that’s what I told her!” I say, smiling.

Melog stands up on all fours and shakes their fur vigorously. “We should make haste.”

“Okay, but I have more questions,” I say, hopping on their back as they break into a steady trot.

“I am listening.”

“First of all, how come you didn’t show me all of that sooner?”

“Our bond has recently become stronger.”

I twitch my ears. “Meaning?”

“In simple terms, I can now use all of my ancient magics with you.”

“Is that how you’ll get us out of here?”

“... yes”

“I didn’t like that pause, Melog.”

“We will be fine.”

“Sure,” I say, rolling my eyes. “So, are you Krytis? Or are you Melog? That was pretty intense, buddy.”

I feel Melog’s form shudder as they snort out a long laugh. “I am not sure. Perhaps both. And yes, it was.”

“And, the golems that the first ones took... do you think that’s how some ended up in Deepwood?”

“Yes. They stole many of my kind in the end,” Melog says, their fur turning bright red for a few seconds. “We are *not* property.”

“Let’s see if we can rescue them,” I say, ruffling my fingers behind Melog’s mane.

“I would like that,” they say, appearing calmer. “But then again, perhaps some of them are happy, like Lydia was.”

“Did Mauve tell you that?”

“She told me enough. Their golems were revered, and loved. They were not slaves.”

“I guess that’s something,” I say, feeling relieved. “Okay, so there’s one last thing that’s been bugging me...”

“I have never seen you so curious,” Melog says, their pace slowing as they twist their head to face me.

“I always knew you felt my emotions,” I say, tilting my head, “you never told me it worked both ways, though.”

Melog huffs and peers up at me, as though amused, before snapping their head to face forwards again.

“What!?”

“You cannot. It does actually work one way only.”

I frown. “No, because-”

“Those are your *own* feelings, Catra. It is called sympathy, perhaps even empathy.”

“Oh.”

Melog picks up their pace again, and we keep running, with no sign of Angella anywhere. Just when I’m losing all hope of us ever finding her, I spot a mark in the ground up ahead.

“Wait, is that...” I begin, hopping from Melog’s back once they slow down. I walk a few more paces, then groan at the sight of the same *X* I clawed earlier. “Melog, we’re going in circles.”

“I am certain I went in a straight line.”

“Hmm, now that you mention it,” I say, looking more closely at the ground, then pointing forwards. “Your paw prints go all the way up there, and back there,” I say, gesturing my thumb backwards.

Melog groans. “Perhaps we need to rethink our approach.”

I press my palms to my waist and squint up at the murky skies, then sneeze loudly when a waft of dust blows past my nose. “Oh. That’s it!” I say, remembering something peculiar about Angella’s greeting.

Melog pricks their ears up. “Hmm?”

“How loudly can you roar, buddy?”

“Extremely.”

“Then let’s make some noise.”

Melog wrinkles their nose, raises their snout and then *roars*, loudly enough to echo all around us.

“Angella!” I yell, cupping my hand to my mouth. “Hello! How do you like our little *ruckus*?”

Melog snorts in amusement, then roars again, louder than the first. “Do you think she will hear?”

I raise my eyebrows and smirk, pointing into the sky. “It seems so.”

A couple of moments later she lands before us, feet stomping into the ground. She bats her wings a few times while scowling down at us. “Just what is going on here?!”

“Hi, Angella,” I say, peering up at her. “We wanted to chat, that’s all.”

Angella furrows her brows, looking between Melog and I. “Just who are you? Why were you falling through the sky? And why are you still here?! Nobody stays, you know. One minute they’re here, the next, poof! It’s as though I’m imagining things.”

I reach my hand out and grab her arm, and she flinches at the contact, turning wide eyed.

“I already told you, we came to rescue you,” I say, loosening my grip on her arm. “We’re… friends of Glimmer. She’s waiting for you back home.”

Angella’s gaze turns cold as ice, and she slaps my hand away. “Do you think me a fool? I was talking to my daughter moments ago, before you started all of this noise!”

“But she’s not rea-” I begin, then stop when Angella’s glare becomes fiercer still.

“Guards! Take these imposters away. And put a gag on them, they’re giving me a headache.”

“Woah! What the-” I begin, startled as a pair of hands appear from thin air, their cold, steel touch gripping my arms just as the rest of their forms shimmer into view. And then, as though it were here all along, a vision of the palace itself unveils in a wide arc, starting from my feet and soaring into the skies, which swiftly turn from orange to blue.

“Interesting,” Melog says, shaking their fur. “It seems we are in her reality, now.”

“That’s one word for it,” I mutter, looking up at the two guards who’re holding me captive. Their faces are concealed behind long masks, similar to the brightmoon guards I saw back in the war.

“Take the cat too,” Angella says, pointing at Melog. “I am sure they’re working together, somehow.”

“Leave them alone!” I snap, trying to break free, wondering if it’s time to get my claws out.

“Do not retaliate,” Melog warns. “Her mental state is hanging on by a thread. We may still reach her if we play along.”

The guards wrap Melog in a large net, and drag them along, walking in an eerie silence while forcing me down the same path. We head into the Palace through an entrance I don’t actually recognise. The more I look around the more I realise that most of the palace looks wrong, and clearly distorted in places. Doors and arches are skewed to one side, or appear half the size that they should. Paths twist in on themselves in spirals but don’t lead anywhere, and the corridor we’re walking down seems to go on forever.

Suddenly, I find myself standing in some kind of dungeon without ever having travelled there. There’s dull, grey bricks all around, some of which have thin streams of moisture trickling down their gritty surfaces. Beneath our feet, there are uneven, smooth cobblestones.

I grit my teeth, feeling more desperate than ever to retaliate. “Melog…”

“We will be okay.”

We’re thrown into a cage, landing in a heap behind the thick iron bars, and I almost laugh at the irony, knowing that this is what I deserved all along.

“Once, Brightmoon didn’t have cells, you know,” Angella says, locking the door, then pocketing the key. “But then, we didn’t get strangers falling from the sky and talking absolute poppycock, either.”

“Will you just hear what we have to say?” I ask, grabbing onto both bars. “Please?”

“Oh of course,” Angella says, rolling her eyes, “I have nothing better to do than attend to a couple of strangers who are clearly only here to cause trouble. The guards will bring you some food shortly. Goodbye.”

“Wait-” I say, cursing under my breath as she walks away, vanishing from the area. “Damn it!”

Melog groans loudly. “Hopefully she will come back.”

“How the hell did we get in here, anyway?” I ask, examining the dark-bricked room we’re trapped in, then peering along the corridor outside the bars, which is illuminated by a few magical torches.

“I suspect Angella has been here so long that the very fabric of the place changes on her whim.”

“So it… reflects her mood?”

“Perhaps. I was feeling nostalgic when Aria appeared, after all.”

“Really? How come?”

“Your bravery reminded me of them,” Melog says, huffing quietly.

“And look where my bravery got us,” I say, sitting down on the small mound of straw on the floor, and pulling my knees into my chest. “I don’t know if we can help ourselves now, let alone Angella.”

“For now, let us rest,” Melog says, curling into a ball.

“I can cut through those bars, you know,” I say, sighing.

“If she does not come back, we will have no choice.”

“Fine, we’ll do it your way, for now,” I say, snuggling up against them, and closing my eyes. “I’m tired anyway.”

“Me too.”

--

I open my eyes and leap to my feet, startled to find Angella staring right at me from the other side of the bars.

“Why are you still here?” she asks, furrowing her brows.

“Because you locked us up!” I exclaim, holding my hands out.

Melog hops to their feet and nuzzles their snout to my waist. “Be gentle with her.”

I crouch down, and ruffle their fur, then peer back up at Angella. “Sorry. I didn’t mean to snap.”

Angella’s glare softens, and she almost smiles. “How... strange.”

I stand up and walk towards the bars slowly. “What is?”

“I can’t… I can’t remember the last time I had an almost human conversation, or had anyone talk back to me, let alone apologise. It’s as though you are *really* here. Have I truly lost my final shred of sanity?”

I hold out my hand, just in front of the bars, palm up. “How can I prove to you that we are real? That we’ve come for you?”

She looks at my hand, and hesitates, before reaching her own hand out and clutching her fingers around my hand. “The others… they talk in whispers. And their feet… they don’t even make a sound... “

I squeeze her hand. “While we’re noisy, and rude. A bit like your daughter, probably.”

Angella actually *laughs*, and it’s such a beautiful sound that I can't help but look up at her in awe. “Perhaps I have gone mad. But if that’s the case,” she says, pulling the key out of her pocket, and unlocking the door, “at least I’ve fabricated some half-decent company.”

“That’s the nicest thing anyone’s ever said to me, “I say, walking outside of the door, with Melog close behind.

“You said you wanted to talk?” Angellla asks.

“Yeah but,” I say, flattening my ears. “Does it have to be in here?”

“Oh, how rude of me,” Angella says, closing her eyes. A moment later we’re surrounded by clear blue skies, and we’re standing in the west courtyard, with that dumb-ass horse fountain nearby, spewing water from its mouth.

I sit on one of the benches around the fountain, and Angella sits beside me, before resting her elbows on her knees.

“I don’t know where to begin, honestly,” I say, scratching behind my hair.

“You mentioned you are a friend of Glimmers?”

“Yeah. I am,” I say, sitting upright and resting my back against the bench. “She’s really grown up, you know? I think you’d be proud of her.”

Angella closes her eyes for a few moments, then opens them and peers into the distance. “How old is she now? Assuming I believe you, that is.”

“Nineteen. And uh, she and Bow…”

Angella raises her eyebrows and sits upright, chuckling. “And now I know you are a figment of my imagination. I always dreamed those two would end up together, after all.”

“Well, they are,” I say, smiling.

“And what other nonsense would you have me believe?”

“Well,” I begin, taking a deep breath, “three years ago you saved us all by staying behind, in this dimension. You closed a portal, and stopped our whole universe from imploding.”

“I... “ Angella frowns, then shakes her head quickly. “That is absurd!”

“It isn’t. You saved us all, and you stopped Adora from sacrificing herself. I know you remember.”

Angella leans forwards, pinching the bridge of her nose between her finger and thumb. “Has it really been three years? I was counting, you know. I’m sure it is closer to a year.”

“Time could work differently here,” Melog warns.

“It’s been three years in Etherian time,” I say, feeling anxious at the idea Adora could have been freaking out for several days by now.

“I see.. And what of Adora? How is she?”

“She’s fine,” I say, smiling. “More than, actually. To be honest, everyone’s doing pretty great…” I say, pausing to take another deep breath, “... including Micah.”

Angella jumps to her feet and glares down at me, breathing heavily.

“Look, I have no reason to lie to you,” I say, standing up and holding my hands out. “The Horde banished him to beast island, he was never killed. You *have* to believe me.”

Angella balls her hands into fists, and grits her teeth. “You need to leave. And do not return.”

“No. Not without you,” I say, placing a hand on her forearm. “You’re coming back with us. It’s why we came here in the first place.”

“I cannot trust you after you’ve told me such fanciful tales. You are yet another figment of my imagination, a sign that I really am losing whatever senses I had left.”

I tighten my grip on her arm. “You’re scared, I get it. So much has changed, and you’ve been trapped here all along. You’re scared it can’t be real, you’re scared it’s too good to be true. Well I’ve been there! But are you really telling me you’d miss out on seeing your family again, maybe even your own grandkids, just because you’re *frightened?*”

Angella sniffs, and her arm trembles beneath my grip. Her shoulders sag and she looks into my eyes, tears streaming down her cheeks. “Can I truly, *finally* go home?”

“You can. We have a Melog,” I say, crouching down and ruffling their fur.

“She must be certain,” Melog says, peering up at me. “I can only do this once, and it is one way only.”

“Angella,” I say, smiling. “We’ll only get one shot at this. Are you ready to come home?”

She nods, and her eyes become determined. “Yes. I am tired of being a coward.”

Melog begins to glow, and the blue barrier that surrounded us when we first jumped through the portal spreads all around me, and then Angella.

“What is this?” she asks, looking at her hands.

“A protection spell,” I say, half guessing. “The ride back can be a bit bumpy is all. This will keep us safe.”

Melog butts their head into my legs. “We will use your anchor to return home.”

“My anchor?”

“Adora. You must close your eyes and think of her, have her flood your senses. Tell me once this is done.”

“Hmm, easy,” I say, closing my eyes. It isn’t difficult to think about her at all. Her beautiful blue eyes that pierce through mine, her captivating voice telling me that she loves me, her salty-vanilla smell

and taste, and that smug little smile which always makes my heart skip a beat. “Done.”

“Remain focused,” Melog says. They make a guttural sound, and moments later there’s a quiet, crackling sound in front of me, followed by the sensation of wind flowing forwards, whipping strands of my hair against my cheeks. “Now slice open this portal, and imagine you are forging a path home, to her. She must be in your heart, Catra.”

I open my eyes, finding a field of throbbing energy pulsing around in front of me. My heart warms at the idea of coming home, of having Adora’s lips upon mine, and I hold onto that feeling while I rake my claws down. Just a moment later a purple, swirling portal booms into existence, spinning wildly. On the other side, I can see everyone sitting in their seats on Darla’s bridge, but they don’t seem to notice us.

“You did well,” Melog says, huffing. “Come, we must hurry.”

“Time to go home, your majesty,” I say, smiling up at Angella. She pauses, as though unsure. “Hey, this is your one ticket back to see your family. Don’t blow it.”

“I-is that really them?” she asks, walking with me.

“Yeah. Keep a tight grip on Melog,” I say, doing the same. “You first.”

Angella nods, and stares dead ahead while walking into the small entrance, her hand reaching behind to hold onto Melog’s mane, and I walk just behind, resting my hand on Melog’s rump, and I’m moments away from entering the portal when an iron grip suddenly digs into my shoulders.

And then, I’m yanked backwards, torn away from Melog. “No!” I yell, reaching a hand out, watching as Melog turns their head and roars, before being sucked into the purple vortex.

“Aww.” A hauntingly familiar voice purrs by my ear, and I twist my neck to face the owner. “Did you miss your ride home?”

“What the *fuck?!*” I hiss, standing up and looking at a version of myself that I barely recognise, half of her face blacked out, glitching, and her voice a weird, metallic echo of my own. She places her hands on her hips, and shakes her tail around viciously.

“I’ve been watching you,” she says, chuckling. “When did you become so soft? It’s pathetic.”

I open my mouth to respond, but then her claw rakes across my shoulder to my chest, cutting deeply.

“Soft, *and* slow,” she says, tutting to herself before raising her claws again.

This time I’m ready. I duck and slide to one side, wincing at the pain in my chest, before I leap forwards and grab her wrists mid-air, pinning her to the floor. “Why are you doing this?” I ask, gritting my teeth. “You’re me, right?”

“So you *do* still have some fight in you.”

“I asked why!”

“Pfft, haha!,” she says, scowling. “I couldn’t stand seeing myself like this. I guess I’m just fixing a terrible mistake.”

“You’re one to talk,” I say, squeezing her wrists more tightly.

The next thing I know she darts her head upwards, sharply butting it into mine and sending stars behind my eyes. I try to recover but lose precious seconds, enough time for her to rake her claws another two, then three times, and I cry out, the pain sending tears to my eyes. I buckle to my knees, watching my vision blur as blood oozes out from the fresh gashes.

“Seriously? That’s it?” the other-Catra asks, cupping my chin in her palm, forcing me to look up at her. “*This* is what I’ll become? *This* is my future?”

“I’m...” I say, coughing up blood, then smiling, “stronger than ever.”

She grimaces, and squeezes my jaw, almost hard enough to break bone. But then, she inhales sharply, looking down at my chest, her eyes widening. “Is that…” she says, appearing wild-eyed. She crouches down, and snatches Adora’s pin from my suit, peering down at it. “Why do you have this?”

“Hah, idiot,” I say, chuckling. I grab onto my left arm, trying to stop the blood pouring from one of the deeper gashes. “Why do you think?”

“She…” the other Catra says, her face crumpling. “She forgave me?” she asks, holding up the winged brooch. “She even… “

I nod, then stand to my feet, slowly, hissing at the sharp pains in my thighs. “We got engaged recently, actually.”

“How?” she asks, twitching her ears. “Why?”

“I’ll probably ask myself that,” I say, coughing up an even bigger glob of blood, “every day. I love her. She loves me. That’s all that matters.”

She scowls. “When did I get so soft? It’s making me want to throw up.”

I chuckle, “Yeah, tell me about it.”

My alter ego looks down at her hands, then up at me. “After everything I’ve done… there’s still hope?”

I lean forwards, and wrap my arms around her. “Yeah. I’m proof, aren’t I?”

The other Catra stiffens in my embrace, but then, slowly, carefully wraps her arms around me. “You… you need to go back to her.”

“I’m not sure I can, honestly.”

She takes a step back, appearing sorrowful, then carefully places the badge back on my suit, securely fastening it to the outside pocket. “It looks good on you.”

“You should see what I got her,” I say, chuckling. I fall to my knees, and cough up more blood, struggling to breath. “Wow. I forgot how deeply I can cut,” I say, coughing again.

I collapse onto my side, peering up at the other Catra, watching as she sits down and places a hand on my cheek. “I’m sorry. I messed up. I always mess up.”

“No. Not always,” I say, resting my hand on hers.

Her mouth stretches into a smile, before the black mark on her face fades away, and her appearance alters until it looks just like mine. And then, her form becomes like mist, dispersing into the air as though she were never really here at all.

--

“Fuck,” I mutter, peering down at my bloodied form, then clambering slowly to my feet. I take a few deep, rattling breaths, rocking around unsteadily, my blood dripping to the floor.

There’s no pain, I think, remembering the mantra I’d repeat in my head every time that Shadow Weaver would hurt me. *This is nothing. I can’t even feel it.*

I take another long, deep breath, straighten my back and focus on the one task at hand. *Going home*. So, for just a few seconds I block it all out, that screaming agony from my shredded muscles, that crippling fear that this is probably going to kill me, and I grit my teeth, yelling while charging forwards, diving into the shrinking portal as quickly as I’m able.

And then, I feel a hundred cuts slice into me all at once, too many times for my mind to even register. All I know is pain, coursing through me, and it’s like my body isn’t even mine anymore, a burning hot numbness from head to toe screaming at me to pass out, my own cries so loud that they’re *all* I can hear until Adora’s voice rings out even louder still.

“CATRA! “

And then, my screams die in my throat.

I’m barely even aware that Adora’s arms are around me, so warm, and so, so strong. Or that she’s already turned into She-Ra, or that she’s surrounding me with that glorious, warm glow that’s going to make everything better. Except I can hear Adora crying, whimpering.

“It’s not… it’s not working...”

“It’s the same as my hand… you can’t heal portal wounds,” Glimmer’s voice, so quiet that I barely even hear it.

I prise one eye open to look at Adora, and I notice she’s covered in blood, from her neck down.

“A-Adora, you’re bleeding,” I say, raising a trembling hand to her collarbone.

“Shh, shh, baby, it’s okay,” she says, picking me up. “Medical bay, NOW!” she yells. *Hah*, I think, *she’s so hot when she’s giving orders. So hot*.

I blink slowly, finding it incredibly hard to open my eyes afterwards. “What’s...h-happening?”

“Just hold on, baby. We’ll fix this. We’ll fix it. Just… don’t… don’t leave me. Okay?”

“Hah, I’m not going, anywh-”

I feel my head loll to the side, and I can’t move it. I’m just forced to stare down at my own arm, seeing what must be dozens of deep lacerations down my flesh, and endless streams of blood trickling down the deep crevices, pooling down onto the steel medical table.

Over in the corner I spot Scorpia holding Melog, who by some miracle hasn’t gone into a frenzy. Their eyes are staring intently into mine, and I’m sure they’re trying to say something... I just can’t

make it out. Angella is standing next to them, holding Glimmer and Bow, but they're just looking at me and crying about something. *Idiots*, I think, *you're back together… what's wrong with you…*

Then I feel Adora press her forehead to my temple, feel her hands cup beneath my ears, and hear her beautiful voice. "Hold on, baby. I love you."

I struggle to take another breath, and this time when I blink, I can't open my eyes again.

"Catra… baby… *please*…"

Adora's voice, fading into nothing. *Hah, baby... it's growing on me*, I think, smiling to myself as the world fades to black.

Chapter End Notes

Adora: ...
Catra: ...
Sea Hawk: Adventure!!
Mermista: Read the room, sheesh...

BONUS(?), please enjoy a broken heart, courtesy of Marin and this stunning artwork. Let's all cry together.

BONUS #2 (wow I'm spoilt), Rus apparently thought it'd be a great idea to draw this scene.

WHEN DID YOU BECOME SO SOFT? IT'S PATHETIC.
WHY ARE YOU DOING THIS?
YOU'RE ME, RIGHT?

Magic is Love

Chapter Summary

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

The awful, agonising pain finally stops, and I'm able to open my eyes. I find myself standing on the floor of the medical bay, naked, and without a single injury in sight. I stretch my toes, noticing that the metal floor doesn't feel cold beneath my feet, and my body feels lighter, somehow.

"What- Oh," I say, glancing upwards, realising that I'm standing at the foot of the cot on which my other, motionless form lays. It's completely drenched in blood. My jaw is slightly open, my head is tilted to one side, and my eyes are tightly closed. "That's… that can't be...."

I walk around the room, looking at everyone, trying to get their attention. But, they can't see me, and I can't hear them. There's Angella, with her eyes tightly closed, and tears rolling down her cheeks. She's still holding Glimmer and Bow, both with their faces buried into her chest, their torsos shuddering.

"Uh, guys?"

Melog is sitting next to the steel table, with their snout resting next to my hand. I'm grateful that they haven't changed colour, haven't freaked out. They're just sitting there attentively, as though waiting for something.

"This is some kind of prank, right?"

Entrapta is standing by one of the medical terminals, staring blankly at the single, flat line that scrolls across the monitor in front of her. She taps the screen with the end of her pigtail a few times, then grabs a handheld device and hovers it over my stretched out arm, sealing up one open wound after another, until Scorpia stops her, that is.

I see her say something, but can't hear a single word. The next thing I know, Entrapta is shaking her head, talking animatedly and trying to push past Scorpia.

"What the hell is going on?!" I ask, my voice echoing around me.

I watch as Scorpia pulls Entrapta into a tight hug. Entrapta's shoulders slump, and she drops the device to the floor, wrapping her pigtails around Scorpia's shoulders, and sobbing against her chest.

"Oh, come on! I'm not..." I mutter, holding out my hand, flexing my fingers, a chill traveling up my spine when I realise the digits are slowly becoming translucent. "... dead?"

I leap towards my body on the cot and try to press my hands against it, but I pass straight through, until I'm crouched on the floor beneath the bed.

"No…" I say, peering down at my clenched fists, banging them silently against the floor. "No, no, no!"

I raise my head, and spot Adora sitting against the wall beside the bed. She's not She-Ra any more. In fact, she looks smaller than ever, her cheeks drenched in tears, her knees clutched tightly into her chest. I crawl next to her and reach out a hand, but I can only watch, horrified, as she starts to bang the back of her head against the wall, over and over.

"Stop it!" I say, my gut wrenching. "You'll hurt yourself, idiot."

Thankfully, Perfuma rushes over there and stops her, pulling her into her arms. Adora becomes motionless within the embrace, vacantly staring through me, and past the cot. She just stays there, unblinking, barely moving, and if not for Perfuma's hand rubbing down her back, I'd think that time had stopped, somehow.

"Adora, I'm sorry. I… I didn't want this," I say, standing up and holding my hands out in front of me, spreading my fingers wide, choking back tears as they fade away to nothing. "I… I wanted to spend my whole life with you," I say, my heart aching. "I wanted us to grow old together, doing all the dumb, boring stuff that old people do."

My forearms become see-through, and I grimace, my gut twisting in cold, icy fear as the harsh reality of everything hits me. *It's over*...

Then I feel myself gently tugged at, pulled away from the floor until I'm floating a few inches in the air, powerless to stop the invisible force. "No, wait! Not yet!"

I can't leave her like this, I think, watching fresh tears roll down Adora's cheeks. *Will she be okay? What about Melog and the others?*

"Please," I whimper. "Let me stay..."

I'd do anything to take another breath, to feel her heartbeat next to mine, and feel her touch.

"Please," I croak, watching my tears trickle down, watching my form fade further and further into nothingness. "Please, I want…"

I float higher and higher, until I'm directly above my lifeless body. In just a few moments, I won't even be inside Darla anymore. I won't ever see Adora again. I don't even know if I'll exist at all, or what comes next.

A thick knot forms in my throat, and I scream out one final, desperate plea...

“I WANT TO LIVE!”

Suddenly, there’s a blinding blaze on the floor beside the bed, and Melog pounces onto my cot, their orange form poised on top of me. They open their jaws wide in a silent, defiant roar.

“Hey Melog,” I whisper, watching my tears drip through their back. “Calm down. And look after Adora for me, okay?”

Melog lays down on my body, and looks over their shoulder, staring directly at me.

“Your wish has been heard.”

“What?”

“My soul, to your soul.”

My mind is suddenly filled with a vision of endless stars, swarming towards me, and planets, life forms, all so new, all so alien. And then Melog, as that small, magical being, as they are first born into their world, ready to live countless stories, and experience countless adventures.

“My heart, to your heart.”

I feel a sudden, heavy thud in my chest, my arms become completely visible again, and a strange, tingling numbness floods through my fingers.

“Melog… what are you doing,” I whimper, watching as their form bursts into a brilliant white glow.

“My life, for your life.”

“Stop it!” I exclaim.

“Do not be afraid, Catra. I will always be by your side.”

I watch as their form evaporates into a golden mist, each particle seeping down into my other body.

“Don’t you dare, Melog! *Don’t. You. DARE!*”

Suddenly, I’m yanked towards the table and pulled into my body, feeling a desperate, hungry breath fill my lungs, and just a moment later, a hot, burning heat searing through me. It's so agonisingly painful, but also beautiful, somehow, because I feel Melog, feel the very essence of them flooding into me, all the way to my marrow. For the briefest moment it’s like I’m sailing through the stars, weightless, surrounded by their warm embrace.

“I love you.”

“MELOG!” I yell, hearing my own hoarse voice ring in my ears. I reach out for them and clutch them tightly to my chest, feeling their form shrink down, smaller and smaller, until there’s nothing left in my hands.

--

I become numb, feeling nothing for a short while, and then slowly, steadily my limbs start to tingle, and my senses return. I feel myself panting, hear my heartbeat ringing loudly in my ears, and I snap

my eyes open, noticing that several pairs of hands are holding me down.

I blink a few times, looking from one person to the next, finding their eyes wide. “Uh, hi?”

“Catra!” Adora chokes my name out, and buries her head into the crook of my shoulder, sobbing loudly.

“What’s going on?” I ask. I try to sit up, but realise I’m still too numb to move. “Where’s Melog?”

“T-They…” Adora mumbles, but she doesn’t finish the sentence.

“Adora,” I say, managing to turn my head to face her, pressing my nose to hers, feeling an icy dagger pierce through my heart. “Where are they?”

Adora shakes her head, her beautiful blue eyes ringed red with grief. She bites her teeth together in a grimace.

“No…” I groan, closing my eyes. “No. Damn it. *No!*”

The room turns eerily quiet, save for the sounds of everyone’s sobs, and their heartbeats, all so loud in the devastating silence.

“I’m so sorry…” I whisper, feeling my limbs gradually thaw from cold numbness to a tingling, fuzzy warmth. It stings like hell, but nothing compares to the ache in my chest, spilling out, and flowing down my cheeks.

--

It’s only when my hands start to regain their feeling that I notice a steady pulse throbbing within my grip, and at first I think maybe it’s just the blood pumping through my veins. Until, that is, I notice a definite small bulge in there, held tightly against my chest.

“Adora,” I say, looking down at my hands. “Can you help me sit up?”

“Of course…”

I carefully sit up, leaning back against Adora’s torso, and slowly, gently lower my hands. Then I choke back a sob when I realise what I’m holding.

“What is it?” Adora asks, resting her chin on the top of my head.

There’s a hand-sized, curled up ball of fur, quietly snoring in my stretched out palms. It slowly unwinds itself, revealing the tiniest glowing eyes, oversized paws and a small pot belly.

“Mew?” the burgundy kitten says, looking up at me, tilting its head.

I burst into tears. “Melog!?”

“Mrrp,” they say, as though agreeing.

Adora reaches a trembling hand out. “Is… is it really them?”

“I-I think so,” I say, carefully running my fingers across their back. They jump up into my touch, then headbutt Adora’s hand, bursting into the loudest purr, so loud for someone so tiny. But it sounds like Melog, and hearing it warms my heart.

--

“This is astounding!” Entrapta says, her eyes wide. “Perhaps I should run scans, to ascertain if it’s still the same Melog.”

Then I suddenly remember, with complete clarity, Melog, and everything they said just before I passed out.

You must express the will to live, Catra. Listen! Our bond is strong enough that I shall not perish. Are you listening? Catra! Please! Say you want to live! Just say the words, and believe them! You must want it with all of your heart, otherwise I cannot use my spell.

“No need,” I say, sniffling, “it’s them. They just have a bit of growing up to do.”

“It appears they used a powerful, and costly spell,” Angella says, stepping forwards and stroking a finger down Melog’s fur.

“Yeah… they did.”

Angella bows her head. “I have… much to process. For now, please understand that you have my heartfelt gratitude, for all that you’ve done.”

Hah, wait until you hear the full story, I think, smiling anyway.

Scorpia coughs and fidgets on the spot. ”Um, are you… are you okay now?”

“Well, I’m not dead anymore,” I say, placing little Melog on my shoulder, swinging my legs over one side of the table. “So there’s that.”

Scorpia’s eyes appear damp, and her lower lip quivers.

“I’m joking. I’m fine,” I say, trying to step off of the table. “Stop crying already, sheesh.”

“Hey, be careful,” Adora says, placing her hands around my waist.

“I’ll be okay,” I say, smiling as I fold my arms around her shoulders. “I’m just a bit wobbly.”

Adora’s blue gaze never leaves mine, as though she’s afraid I’ll vanish. She helps me to my feet and tips her forehead to mine, where I feel a purr erupt in my chest.

“Hey, Adora.”

“Hey, Catra,” she says, sniffling.

“Aww, not calling me baby anymore?”

Adora bursts into a wet, messy laugh, and the next thing I know everyone has their arms around the two of us, cocooning us between them. “Hah, idiots,” I say, sniffling.

“I am so grateful that you are both okay,” Perfuma says, tears springing to her cheeks.

“You definitely had us worried!” Bow says.

“I-I can’t believe you did all that...” Glimmer says.

I raise an eyebrow at her. “I’m a royal guard, remember. And I want a pay rise after this.”

“Done,” she chuckles, wiping her cheeks dry.

“I’ve never been involved in such a big hug!” Entrapta exclaims.

“Me neither,” Scorpia says, beaming. “Isn’t it great?”

Angella spreads her wings and wraps them around everyone, and I close my eyes, yawning sleepilly. “Man, I could sleep for days.”

Angella coughs quietly. “Alright, everyone. Let’s give them some space.”

Their arms fall away, but Bow clears his throat, and nods at Adora. “She *really* needs to rest.”

“Huh? I’m fine,” Adora says, yawning, and looking anything other than fine. Her cheeks appear gaunt, her eyes ringed with dark circles.

“Adora,” I say, pressing a palm to her cheek. “How long was I gone for?”

“Approximately four days,” Entrapta says, tilting her head. “Ooh! Did time pass differently in there? Was it faster? Or was it slower?”

“Slower,” I say, peering around the room, grimacing at the sight of the red streaks all over the table, all over myself, and all over Adora. “Shit. Is that really all mine?”

Adora nods, tears welling above her cheeks. Then she stumbles, and I dash forwards, stopping her before she falls.

“Okay, we’re going to bed,” I say, carrying Melog in the crook of my arm, then placing one of Adora’s arms over my shoulder. Bow takes the other, and we help her outside of the medical bay.

--

Bow and I help Adora down onto the bed, and Scorpia follows just behind, placing a large bag onto the floor.

“It’s just a few snacks and drinks.”

“Good idea,” Bow says. “She hasn’t eaten in days, nevermind slept.”

“Alright already!” Adora groans.

I rest a hand on Scorpia’s shoulder. “Hey, thanks.”

“Happy to help. You know me!” she says. But then she bites the corner of her lower lip, appearing uncertain about something.

“Is something the matter?”

“I was kind of... hoping we could look after them for you,” she says, tipping her head towards the tiny Melog in the crook of my arm. “Perfuma says you two have enough on your plate.”

“But-”

“She’s right,” Bow says, placing a hand on my shoulder. “Adora seriously needs to eat, and you both need to rest.”

“I’ll bring them back in the morning, all happy and fed. I promise,” Scorpia says, holding out a pincer. “We’re going to try some tiny steaks, aren’t we little buddy?” she says, smiling as Melog hops onto her claw. She raises her hand to her shoulder, and Melog hops off, butting their tiny little nose into her neck, causing her to giggle.

“Thanks,” I say, feeling a lump form in my throat. “Say goodnight to everyone for us.”

“We will do,” Scorpia says, waving as she, Melog and Bow leave the room, the door quietly sliding closed behind them.

--

I kneel down in front of Adora and press my palm to her cheek, noticing how badly she’s trembling. “Hey, don’t pass out on me, idiot.”

She chuckles. “I’ll try.”

“You’re going to eat,” I say, turning around to rummage inside the large bag. “And it isn’t up for discussion.”

“I’m not hungry.”

“Adora!”

She looks down at me, grimacing. “I thought I’d lost you,” she says, tears streaming down her face. “You were so hurt, and I... I couldn’t do *anything*,” she says, looking down at her shaking hands, still covered with patches of my blood, like the rest of her.

“Adora,” I say, pushing the bag to one side, leaning forwards, and placing my hands over hers. “I’m okay.”

Her face creases up and she bursts into tears, shaking her head.

“Shh, hey. It’s okay,” I say, standing up, and pulling her head to my abdomen. I rest my hands behind her head and gently stroke her hair.

“You died!” she exclaims, wrapping her arms behind my back and clinging to me, her shoulders heaving as she sobs.

“I’m here.”

“There was s-so much blood.”

“I’m here,” I say, straddling my knees on the bed around her thighs, wrapping my arms around her shoulders and squeezing her tightly. “See? I’m not going anywhere.”

We both roll to the side, and I hold her head against my chest, purring quietly, reassuring her over and over again that I’m okay. I tilt my head down and press my lips to the top of her head, my heart wrenching with every fresh sob that she makes.

But eventually, she calms down. She pulls away to look up at me, her face stained with tears, her cheeks pink.

“You’re all snotty now,” I say, smiling.

“I don’t care.”

“Will you please eat something?” I ask, resting a palm on her cheek. “For me?”

She nods, then sits up and wipes the back of her hands across her cheeks. I sit up and kiss her forehead, before bending over the edge of the bed to retrieve the bag from the floor. Then I sit cross-legged beside her, and pull out a small, pink-frosted cake.

“Open up,” I say, leaning forwards and moving it towards her mouth.

I catch the faintest of smirks on Adora’s lips before she opens her mouth, and I pop the tiny cake inside. “Chew…. good. Now swallow.”

Adora wipes the sugar from her lips, and my heart soars when I see a smug little smile creep onto her lips. “You’re seriously feeding me?”

“Enjoy it while it lasts,” I mutter, holding another cake in front of her. “Eat.”

--

Seven cakes, a bottle of water and two protein bars later, Adora’s face is thankfully a healthier shade of pink.

I release a long, drawn-out sigh. “You’re hard work.”

“I’m not the one jumping through deadly portals,” Adora mumbles, twisting open another bottle of water.

I tear open a protein bar and start to chew on it. “Makes us even, though.”

“Huh? Oh.” Adora says, frowning. “I guess. Now I know how hard it is to watch someone you love-”

“That’s not why I did it,” I interrupt, taking another big bite, then finishing the bar off. “You know that, right?”

“Well... you do like to prove a point.”

“Hah! I saw a chance to fix a mistake and I took it,” I say, twitching my ears. “I didn’t really give it much thought. So I guess I get it too, I mean, the impulsiveness.”

Adora’s eyes widen. “Catra, this makes you a hero!”

“If you ever call me that again I’ll gouge your eyes out.”

“You acted with pure selflessness! You’re a her-”

I press my hand to her mouth. “Stop. I seriously don’t like that word.”

“Okay,” Adora mumbles.

“And besides,” I say, removing my hand from her lips, “after all that, I think I’m going to be a little more selfish.”

“Oh?”

“Yup. I want a long, happy life with you, and if that means putting myself first, so be it.”

“You may as well just propose at this point,” Adora says, grinning.

I tilt my head, smiling as I tap the winged brooch on my pocket, which is somehow, miraculously still in one piece. “Did you seriously forget?”

Adora gasps, and her eyes widen. “Almost! I just… the last few days have been,” she says, sighing, “well… not great.”

“Yeah. I bet. Sorry for making you worry…” I say, sighing. “But no take backs, okay?”

“Never,” Adora says, smiling. “But… I uh, can’t remember what I did with your underwear.”

“Haha! I’ll find you a fresh pair, idiot.”

“You love me really.”

I lean closer to her, and rest my chin on her shoulder. “Yeah. I do,” I say, kissing her cheek.

For a while, the air feels lighter. We both finish off the contents of the bag, and then I start to tidy everything up. I stand up and place our rubbish into the recycler, and when I turn around I find Adora standing up, running her hands frantically down her uniform, then peering at her red-stained, trembling fingers.

“Come on, let’s get you cleaned up,” I say, grabbing her hands.

“What about you?” she asks, sniffling.

“Yeah, okay. This needs to go into the trash,” I say, rolling my eyes. I place my winged brooch safely into a drawer, then quickly strip out of the stained, shredded remnants of the space suit, and throw it away.

“Your turn,” I say, gently helping Adora to undress, placing her clothes into the wash basket.

She runs a hand up my bloodied arm then gently trails her fingers over the top of my shoulder, to my neck. “I really thought I’d lost you…”

“You can’t get rid of me that easily,” I say, smiling. I take Adora’s hand and lead her into the shower room, then press a few buttons until there’s a warm, wide circumference of drizzle falling down from the ceiling.

Adora steps towards me and tips her forehead to mine, her tears visible through the gentle streams of water. “I love you.”

“So kiss me, already,” I whisper, nudging my nose against hers..

Adora’s lips curl upwards ever so slightly, and she captures my lips in a tender, loving kiss. “You’re really here…”

“I am,” I whisper, running my palms down her back. “Kiss me again.”

We take our time, cleaning each other between dozens of soft, gentle kisses, the colour of the water changing from red to pink, and then finally see-through.

“Better?” I ask, pushing Adora’s damp hair behind her ears.

“Much.”

--

We walk bare-footed across the soft carpet of the bedroom, hand in hand. Adora pauses before the bed, and pulls my naked form against hers, trapping me in her warm embrace. “We should probably get some sleep,” she says, smiling.

“Definitely,” I say, collapsing onto the bed alongside her. “I’m exhausted…”

“Me too.”

We pull the covers over ourselves, and I press my nose to hers, smiling. “Sweet dreams, my love.”

Adora yawns, and rests her hand on my waist. “Mmm. Love you, stargazer.”

I watch as Adora’s eyes slowly close, and her smile flattens out, her lips slightly parting into a light snore. *That didn’t take long*, I think, reaching a hand up and stroking her soft, blonde hair, still damp from the shower.

Not long afterwards I fall asleep next to her, dreaming of the stars, and places that I’ve never seen before.

--

I wake up before Adora does, and tussle a few strands of her hair around my fingers. A few moments later her eyes crack open, then she blinks a few times before smiling widely, my heart throbbing at the sight.

“Have I ever told you how beautiful you are?” I whisper, my throat dry.

“Hmm, twice. That was your third.”

“Hah, you actually count?”

“Well maybe if you’d say it more often, I’d lose count.”

“Well,” I say, leaning forwards and kissing her. “You’re beautiful.”

“That’s four.”

I chuckle, resting my hand behind her neck. “So, beautiful. Do you think Entrapta soundproofed the room yet?”

Adora’s smile reaches her eyes. “Do you care?”

“Not really,” I say, rolling on top of her, resting my hips between her thighs. “They should all be in the canteen by now anyway.”

Adora peers up at me, and wraps her arms around my shoulders. “Hey…”

“Hey Adora,” I say, smirking.

She nestles her fingers into my short strands of hairs, and her jaw parts open. “Are… are you really here?”

“Huh?” I ask, tilting my head.

“I… I kept dreaming that you were. I mean, I didn’t sleep much, but when I did… you were here. Just like this.”

“Oh,” I say, dipping the sides of my brows. I lean down and kiss her, trailing my teeth along her lip, just a little. “I’m here. I promise.”

Adora sniffs, her cheeks appearing damp. “Catra….”

“Hey, come on,” I say, wrapping my arms behind her shoulders, pressing my entire body down against her. “I’m here. You can feel me, right?”

Adora nods, digging her fingers into my shoulder blades. “But…”

“What is it?” I ask, pulling back, peering down at her as I stroke the back of my fingers down her cheek. “Adora… What’s wrong?”

She blinks up at me a few times, and takes a deep breath. “I need to feel you *more*.”

“Uh,” I say, my heart suddenly beating faster. “What do you mean?”

She leans up and rests her lips by my ears. “I… need you to not hold back. To be rough.”

“Adora…”

“Please,” she says, trailing her nails behind my neck.

My spine shudders at the contact. I stare into her light blue eyes, and find that same vulnerability that I noticed last night. It’s so strange, seeing it on Adora. It’s so new. And I’d do anything to make her feel better, anything at all.

“Anything for you, my love,” I purr, leaning down, and kissing her gently. She nestles her fingers into my hair, and kisses me eagerly, her tongue darting across my lower lip. I chase it with my own, and then trap her lip in a teasing bite, delighting at her gasp.

“Anything?”

“Just tell me if I hurt you, okay?”

“I… kind of want you to, though.”

I blow out a puff of air. “Adora…”

“Fine,” she says, pouting.

“You’re an idiot,” I say, chuckling. I kiss along her jaw to her ear, and nibble at it gently, before biting it more firmly.

“Yes…” Adora sighs, her hips raising beneath mine, causing my fur to raise up along my back.

I feel a low growl rumble in my throat while I lower my hand, traversing slowly down her torso. But Adora has other ideas. She grabs my hand, and squeezes the end of two of my fingers, causing my claws to pop out slightly, then forces the digits across her own torso, her body shuddering at the contact.

“Adora,” I say, heat pooling between my legs. “What are you…”

“You can’t hurt me,” she says, looking up at me, still gripping my fingers.

“But I… I don’t want to *cut* you,” I say, gritting my teeth.

“You don’t have to make me bleed,” she says, taking my fingers to her lips, and kissing my fingertips. “Just let me feel something. Just a little.”

“Okay,” I sigh, returning my lips to hers, my hand trembling as I unsheathe my claws, ever so slightly, and roam the tips of my nails across her bare flesh. The effect is instantaneous, she moans against my lips, and grinds her hips upwards, her wetness soaking my abdomen.

I wrap a leg over her thigh and trail my hand lower, leaving only the faintest of marks across the ridges of her abdomen. Then I sheathe my claws and travel further, past her curls, where I find her delightfully swollen bud.

Adora grabs my wrist and pushes my hand further down, cupping her other hand behind my neck, capturing my gaze with hers. “Catra,” she gasps. “Make me feel you.”

I moan as I dart forwards and capture her lips, thrusting two fingers into her, curling into her wetness. Her head falls to the pillow, and her groans are devoured by my hungry kiss.

“M-more,” she says, panting the word against my lips.

“Like this?” I say, speeding up my motions, feeling breathless at the sounds she’s making.

Adora nods, then turns her head to the side, exposing one side of her neck. She peers up at me, her silent invitation hanging thickly in the air.

“Adora,” I gasp, lowering my lips to her neck, sucking, kissing, nibbling, revelling in how her gasps become higher pitched, and how she somehow grows even wetter against my hand.

“Harder.”

The tone of her voice is so deep, so demanding, that it barely even sounds like her anymore. I growl, and suck her flesh between my teeth, biting her hard enough to bruise.

“Catra!” Adora cries out, grabbing wildly behind my back, digging her nails beneath my fur, pressing hard enough for me to feel the sharpness.

“I’m here,”I say, sliding my free hand beneath her back, unsheathing my claws, and raking my fingers across her flesh, just enough that it might hurt in any other circumstance.

“F-fuck! I’m…”

“Look at me,” I say, pulling my face away from her neck while I thrust my fingers into her, over and over, keeping my nails dug into the skin behind her shoulders. “I’m here, forever. I’m yours, forever.”

She opens her eyes, her gorgeous blue gaze never leaving mine while she unravels beneath me, choking out my name, gushing against my hand, pulsing against my fingers, riding out one peak after another.

Eventually, her hips collapse to the mattress, and I flatten my palm against her back, hoping that I haven’t drawn blood. I pepper a few kisses against her neck, wincing when I find several bruises there.

“Shit,” I mutter.

“Don’t worry,” Adora says, smiling softly. Her form glows ever so slightly, and the blemishes swiftly vanish.

I roll off of her, and rest on my side, watching as she turns to face me. “And your back?” I ask, wrapping an arm around her, and running my palm around the smooth skin of her shoulder blades

“It’s fine. I promise.”

“Are… are you okay, though?” I ask, reaching my trembling hand towards her cheek.

“Well I am *now*,” she says, shifting forwards, wrapping her arms around my waist, and pressing her nose to mine. “Thanks… for doing that. I just… um...” she says, blushing. “Really, really needed it.”

“Did it work?” I ask, resting my lips on her cheek. “I mean, did it help?”

Adora sighs contentedly. “Yeah. It did.”

“Good.”

“Sorry,” she says, wincing, “if that went a little out of your comfort zone.”

“It’s fine,” I say, running my hands up her back. “I guess I just have to get used to my kinky girlfriend.”

“I think you mean kinky fiancee.”

“Oh shit! Fiancee,” I say, grinning from ear to ear. “I can’t wait to say wife.”

“Hmm, me too,” Adora says, nuzzling her nose next to mine, resting her lips an inch away from my own.

Then suddenly, she’s on top of me, straddling one of my legs, and biting her lower lip into a smile. She grabs my other thigh, raises it and presses her core down to mine, a delicious, wet heat pooling between us.

“A-Adora,” I gasp, chasing the sensation, and pushing myself tightly against her. “Ah… I can feel you… ”

“Good,” she says, leaning back on her arms and holding herself up, while moving her hips in tight, controlled movements.

“You… you feel amazing,” I say, grabbing onto her thigh and grinding tightly into her, our bodies joining together perfectly.

“Catra,” Adora gasps, her thrusts becoming wilder, harder to meet, “I’m already… oh… f-fuck...”

“Adora!” I choke out her name, heat blossoming between my legs. I match her movements, grinding my core and my bud to hers over and over, until I see stars in my eyes and I’m feeling dizzy, almost blinded by the intensity of the feeling.

When it ebbs away I collapse to the mattress, chuckling. “Where did *that* come from?”

Adora lays flat on her back, laughing, before she raises her head. “Just something I wanted to try.”

“Well, I liked it,” I say, purring.

She holds herself up on her hands again and peers at me through slatted eyes. “So did I,” she says, thrusting herself against me.

I raise my eyebrows. “Again?”

Adora nods. “Again.”

“Okay,” I say, rolling myself against her. This time I pay more attention to her, watching her beautiful face, watching how her lips fall open, how her body writhes into mine, and especially how her abdomen tenses with her efforts. I listen to her groans and her gasps, and feel her wetness pool between our legs.

“Catra, a-ah... I’m…”

I watch, wide eyed as Adora comes again, her whole body shuddering, her voice hoarse, desperate, and before I know it there’s a red hot spike burning through me too.

“Adora, ah,” I gasp, thrusting into her just as eagerly. “Ah… fuck!”

I grit my teeth and close my eyes, riding out the intense waves, until I collapse to the bed, a sweating, trembling heap.

“Wow,” I whisper, peering down and watching as Adora sits up, then crawls above me.

“Hey Catra,” she says, smiling as her eyes meet mine. Her cheeks are bright red, and her hair is a complete mess, knots of it framing her face.

“Hey Adora,” I say, leaning up and kissing her lips, then her cheek. “My beautiful fiancee,” I whisper, gently tugging my finger through one of her many hair knots.

“Six,” she says chuckling.

“Seriously. You need to stop counting.”

“Hmm,” she says, pressing her nose to mine. “You’re here. You’re really here.”

“Yeah, I am,” I say, kissing her softly. “And I’m really sorry that I put you through all that.”

A smug smile appears on her lips. “I guess you’ll just have to make it up to me.”

“Isn’t that what I’m *literally* doing?”

“Yeah I’m gonna need more.”

“Hah! You’re insatiable.”

Adora licks her lips, straddling my thigh before sliding her hand down my torso, then past my abdomen, where her bright blue gaze turns a shade darker. “I can’t help how much I want you.”

I wrap my tail around her arm and tug it encouragingly. “So what are you waiting for? I’m yours, aren’t I?”

Adora groans, and kisses me hungrily. I feel her fingers enter me, stretching me out, and I whimper into her mouth, grinding my hips into her hand, surprised to find myself aching for her touch all over again.

“Y-you’re drenched,” Adora says, gasping against my lips, thrusting her fingers into me.

I reach a hand down along my thigh, resting it between her legs, groaning loudly when I find the same. “Says you,” I growl, curling my fingers inside of her.

“F-fuck, Catra!”

“I love it when you swear,” I say, thrusting my hips against her hand while she does the same. “Do it again.”

“Ah, fuck, fuck…”

We grind against each other, and into each other, our free hands digging into each other’s shoulders, until Adora cries out loudly, her body spasming against mine, her walls tightening around my fingers. It sends me spiraling over the edge too, and I wrap my tail tightly around her arm, pulling her against me while I ride out one wave after another.

“I… I love you, so much,” I say, panting against her neck, enjoying the aftershocks.

“I love you too,” she says, finding my lips with hers, curling her fingers into me a few more times until she gently removes them. “I really, really do.”

I reach my free hand behind her neck, and thread my fingers into her hair. “And you really are beautiful, you know.”

“Seven,” Adora says, placing her hands beneath my ears, tussling my hair between her fingers. “And you're beautiful, too.”

“Pfft, hahah!”

Adora traps my lips in a slow, lazy kiss. “You are. You take my breath away.”

“Stop being a sap,” I chuckle, smiling so widely that it hurts my jaw. Then I wrinkle my nose, sniffing at a sudden, salty scent. “Wait, is that…”

“Bacon!” Adora exclaims, her eyes gleaming, and drool appearing at the corner of her mouth. “Bacon, bacon, bacon!”

“Okay,” I say, laughing, “let’s get dressed.”

--

We walk into the kitchen, and my heart soars when I see mini-Melog on the middle of the table, sitting on a plate, with a tiny steak hanging from their mouth. They release it when they spot me and run across the table, hopping onto Scorpia’s shoulder, and then landing on my open hand.

“Hey, did you grow already?” I ask, scratching their head with my other hand. “You look like you did.”

“Well they managed to eat four of these somehow,” Scorpia says, peering over her shoulder at me and beaming. “Told you we’d look after them.”

“Yeah, thanks,” I say, sitting next to her, then helping myself to bacon and eggs from the massive heap of food in the middle of the table. “This is a lot of food, Bow.”

“Oh, that was me,” Angella says, smiling. “I haven’t cooked for a long time. It’s been rather refreshing.”

“I didn’t even know you could cook,” Glimmer says, resting her chin on her palm. “Does this mean we’ll get your cooking back home?”

“Hmm. Quite possibly.”

“You’ll have to ask Dumpling about that,” I say, cutting into a fried egg, and passing a small triangle of egg white to Melog, who happily grabs it from my fork.

“*Dumpling?*”

“That’s a long story,” Bow says, wincing. “You have a lot of catching up to do, your majesty.”

“From what I hear, you can call me mother now, surely? You are dating my daughter, are you not?”

“MUM!” Glimmer says, turning beet-red.

“Uhhh,” Bow says, scratching behind his head.

Adora sits down next to me and pours us both a glass of orange juice, before scooping about twenty bacon rashers onto her plate, and swiftly stuffing them into her face.

“She’s eating again!” Perfuma says, clapping her hands. “Thank goodness.”

“Adora, *chew*,” I say, rolling my eyes.

She wrinkles her nose at me. “Fiiine.”

I feed Melog a few more pieces of egg and bacon, feeling my heart swell as the sight of their teeny tiny pot belly, and then I hear a cough from across the table, turning my head to find Angella looking right at me.

“So, my brave little rescuer,” she says, peering at me over her cup of coffee. “Are you ever going to tell me your name?”

“Uhh,” I say, feeling a chill run down my spine. I look at Glimmer, wondering if she’s ever actually told Angella about me, or if she’d know me by name, then at Bow, who appears equally unsure.

Angella suddenly laughs. “Oh, your faces. Did you actually think I wouldn’t know?”

“Haha,” Adora laughs nervously, looking between us. “What’s happening…?”

“I’ve seen and heard countless intel on this little ball of terror,” Angella says, pointing a finger straight at me. “Isn’t that right, Catra?”

“You *knew?*” Glimmer asks, wide eyed. “Why didn’t you say anything?”

“Well, we’ve been too busy catching up, darling,” she says, smiling at Glimmer before resting her elbows on the table, and looking at me, then at Scorpia and Entrapta. “Seems we have quite a few

Horde defectors amongst us."

"Ah, uh, hi your majesty," Scorpia says, blushing. "I'm actually really a princess, can you believe it?"

"Oh I know," Angella says, sipping at her drink. "I assume you finally claimed your birthright, then? The black garnet?"

"Wow!" I say, grinning widely. "How many spies did you have?"

Angella narrows her eyes at me. "Several."

"I'm… sorry for building robots to attack you," Entrapta says, sighing. "I just like doing science."

"Glimmer has already told me about you, my dear. And Scorpia too. She did remain oddly quiet about Catra, though."

"What's to tell," I say, shrugging. "I led the Horde, but then we found bigger fish to fry."

"Prime…" Angella says.

"I filled her in on all that, too," Glimmer says, looking down at her hands. "Including how you guys saved us all."

"Hey, that was Adora, not me," I say, shrugging.

"That's not true," Adora says, leaning across and wetly kissing my cheek, "and you know it."

"Aha, so I was right," Angella says, looking at myself, then Adora.

"Huh?" I ask, twitching my left ear.

"Catra. Do you want to know how I worked out you were *actually* real?"

"And here I thought it was my speech that convinced you."

"Well, it certainly helped," Angella says, chuckling. "Even if I were mad, I'd never in a million years imagine a Horde commander would come to rescue me," she continues, one corner of her lips rising to a smirk. "Especially not one with a giant cat in tow, and most certainly not one who was engaged to Adora, of all things."

"WHAT?" Everyone exclaims.

"Oh, you're good," I say, grinning.

"You know, she's always worn that thing," Angella says, pointing at the brooch on my chest, before clearing her throat. "Well, then. I believe congratulations are in order?"

"ADORA!" Glimmer yells, jumping to her feet and balling her hands into fists. "WHY DIDN'T YOU TELL ME?!"

"I, uh," Adora says, holding a bacon rasher an inch from her mouth.

"It was the night before I vanished, so give her a break, Sparkles," I say, wrinkling my nose.

"We need to make a *cake!*" Bow says, his eyes shining. "RIGHT NOW!"

“I’m so happy for you guys!” Scorpia says, jumping to her feet, storming behind us and placing her pincers on our shoulders. “I think I’m gonna cry!”

“Please don’t,” I say, chuckling.

“My heart is full of joy for you both,” Perfuma says, lacing her fingers together. “Adora, what did Catra give you in return?”

Adora almost chokes on her piece of bacon. “She, uh, she...”

I pout, shaking my head rapidly at Adora.

“I... can’t say.”

“Oh, I see,” Angella says, smiling while narrowing her eyes. “You know, Micah and I share our undergarments, too.”

“MUM!” Glimmer says, turning bright red.

Angella laughs, then shakes her head. She peers down at her hands, and furrows her brows. “Well, then, shall we get down to business? I know we spoke of this recently, but we need to stop the Horde-”

“No, mum,” Glimmer interrupts, resting a hand on Angella’s arm. “There is no Horde anymore, remember?”

“Oh, then that meeting was in… the other place.”

“Don’t worry,” Entrapta says, beaming. “Your brain should be back to normal after a few weeks.”

“We should go back to Etheria,” I say, wiping a few crumbs from my mouth. “The sooner we get her home, the better.”

“Agreed,” Glimmer says.

Adora folds her arms and leans back in her chair. “We should let the Amazons know you’re okay first.”

“You just want to perv on their muscles again,” I mumble.

Adora wraps an arm around my shoulders. “They were actually really upset, you know.”

“Yeah, they tried their best to help,” Bow said, his shoulders slumping. “But nobody had a clue what to do.”

“So we took the relics onto Darla, and tried to replicate my mistake,” Entrapta continues. “But…”

“Let me guess,” I say. “They’re broken.”

Entrapta nods.

“Did you ever figure out what they were for?” Glimmer asks.

“Yes. They can create a portal to Eternia!” Entrapta exclaims, before shrugging. “Or they would, if I… I hadn’t messed up.”

Glimmer walks over to Entrapta, and places her hands on her shoulders. “But your mistake is what got us here. It brought us all together.”

“But... Catra got hurt, and Melog is… small, now.”

“Hey, everything happens for a reason,” I say, smiling, then reaching my finger to my shoulder to stroke Melog’s tiny mane. “And look, Melog is fine, aren’t you buddy?”

Melog raises their head and burps quietly.

Entrapta smiles brightly. “I see. Well, we promised the Amazons we’d return the relics, so that should be our next stop.”

“Or we could ask very nicely if we can hold onto them,” I say, peering sideways at Adora. “It could be a way home, if we fix them.”

“I *am* home,” Adora says, kissing my forehead. “And I think I’ve seen enough portals to last me a lifetime.”

“Hah, can’t argue there.”

--

“Okay,” Adora says, pressing her hand to her armrest. “Is everyone ready?”

“I can’t wait!” Calisto says, leaning forwards in her chair and grinning. “I’m going to meet so many new people! Are they all as nice as all of you? Do you think I’ll find a wife?”

“Remind me why she’s here?” I ask, twitching my ears.

“Because I’m an ambassador! Zara made it so!” Cal says, grinning widely.

“How long are you going to pretend you don’t like her?” Adora asks, twisting around to face me, a smug smile appearing at her lips.

“Shut up!”

“Darla,” Entrapta says, leaning back in her chair. “Tell a joke.”

- *Joke request acknowledged...*

- *A friend and I are going out to get new glasses. After that, we’ll see.*

“Haha!” Bow snorts out a laugh.

“Not funny,” I say, rolling my eyes. “Come on guys, Micah is waiting for us.”

“Shouldn’t we call ahead?” Perfuma asks. “It might be a bit of a shock otherwise.”

“We’re out of range at the moment,” Entrapta explains.

“Let’s just surprise him anyway,” Angella says, chuckling. “I can’t wait to see his face.”

“Mum, that’s mean!”

“I know your father better than you do, dear. He’ll love it.”

“And on that note,” Adora says, chuckling. “Darla, take us home.”

- *Acknowledged.*

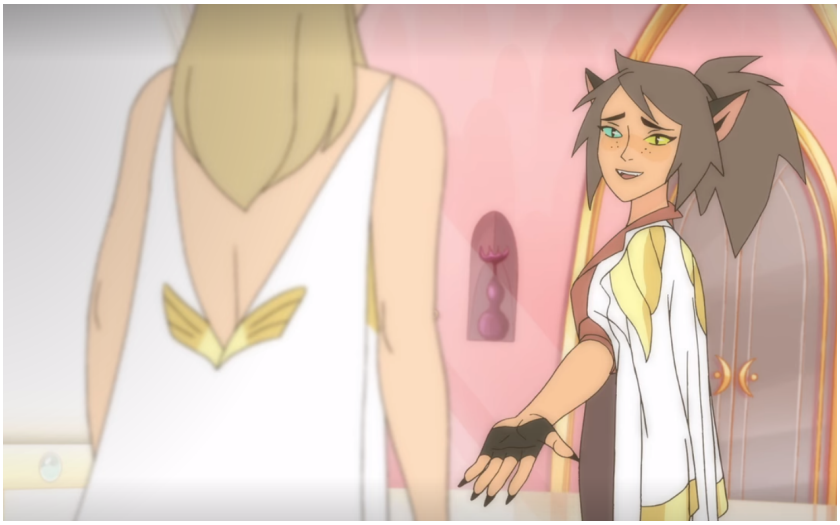
Chapter End Notes

Scorpia: Oh boy, I miss tiny Melog! They were so cute!
Catra: Hey! They're still cute!
Adora: Yeah they are, aren't you, Melog.
Melog: Yes. I am cute. :3

BONUS, is it getting hot in here, or is it me? Thanks, Marin for feeding the gays. Yummy.

The Brightmoon Festival

Chapter Summary



Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

I'm roused from a pleasant dream involving Adora and a very creative use of her sword (the one that can turn into anything, or so she says) by none other than the woman herself, thrashing her arms and legs around.

"Adora," I groan, pushing her shoulders until she's at least an arms length away. "Not again…"

She dozilly punches her arms forwards, not that I'm sure they could really be called punches when there's literally no weight behind them. *Then again, she did catch me in the eye that one time*, I think, rolling my eyes.

"Pew, pew," she mumbles.

"Yeah, you get 'em tiger," I say, chuckling to myself. I stretch out and then wrap my arms around her, cocooning her arms and legs between my own, and rolling on top of her. "Oh look, you won."

Adora snorts, and groggily opens her eyes. "Huh? Won?"

"Who were you beating up this time?" I ask, relaxing my hold on her, and lazilly resting my form half atop hers, stroking a hand down her side.

"Oh no, was I doing it again? Sorry," Adora says, wincing. "Perfuma says it will stop, eventually…"

"Wanna talk about it?"

Adora scrunches up her face. "It was bacon."

“Haha! What?!”

“Bacon came to get it’s revenge on me,” Adora says, turning wide eyed. “Giant rashers of it! With big pointy sticks!”

“Sounds terrifying,” I say, purring. “Hmm, you’re an idiot.”

“I’m your idiot,” she says, stroking a hand down my back, forcing my purrs to grow louder still.

Suddenly, there’s a knock at the door. “Guys?” Glimmer's voice, muffled through the door. “It’s 11am. What are you… you know what, never mind,” she continues, thumping what sounds like her head against the door. “Just hurry up, you’re missing all the fun!”

“We’re having plenty of fun, actually!” Adora yells.

“Ugh… *Adora!*” I say, gritting my teeth, shoving at her shoulders until I’m prised up over the top of her, with my arms straightened. “Remind me why I’m marrying you?”

Adora cocks an eyebrow, smiling smugly. “Do you remember what we got up to last night?”

“Guys,” Glimmer says, sounding increasingly agitated. “I don’t hear you getting ready…”

“Then stop listening!” I yell.

“That does it. I’m coming in. Make yourself decent.”

“What!” I yell, scampering to pull the blanket up over us both, with Adora giggling the whole time.

The door bangs open and Glimmer stands there, arms folded, pouting. “Seriously? You’re not even dressed?!” she says, staring somewhere above us and turning wide-eyed. “And what the… what happened to the bed? And the *wall?!*”

I thin my lips into a line. “Woops.”

Adora carries on laughing, barely even to speak between words. “She…s-she…”

“Do not finish that sentence, love,” I growl.

“Okay, I can’t deal with this right now,” Glimmer says, storming over to the foot of our bed. She gently raises her hand to her shoulder and helps Melog down, resting them on the end of our duvet, where they yawn sleepily. “I have things to do. So will you please. Get. Ready.”

“Yes boss,” I say, scrunching up my nose.

“And Adora, you can explain all of *that* to my mother,” she says, pressing one hand to her forehead while waving the other in the general vicinity of our destruction. “Honestly! You just had almost a week in space together, where you were *supposed* to be resting and getting all of *this* out of your system. And then you come back and *wreck* the place on your first night back! And you have the audacity to sleep in!”

I blink a few times, watching as she pinches the bridge of her nose.

”I just... don’t believe you two. I don’t,” she says, vanishing after finishing her little rant, as though never here.

I duck under the covers, peering at Adora and watching as she continues to laugh, her cheeks turning redder and redder while she attempts to talk between fits of giggles.

“S-she could have at least, haha!” Adora says, bursting into another fit of laughter, “closed the door. Rude!”

I shake my head, feeling laughter bubble up from my throat. “pffft…ha... haha!”

It’s infectious. Before I know it I’m laughing loudly with her, and just when we both stop, one of us starts the other off again.

“T-the headboard,” Adora says, pointing upwards and almost crying. “Hahaha!”

“S-stop it,” I say, wiping tears from my eyes. “It’s not funny! Adora!”

“Then why are you laughing?”

“Pfft, because... the *wall*… haha!” I peer upwards, finding several claw marks ripped into the plasterboard, and large chunks of it folded over and dangling down.

Adora’s gaze follows mine, and her laughter dies down to a throaty chuckle. “Hmm. Someone got a little wild.”

I bite my lower lip into a smile. “Shut up.”

Adora throws the covers from us, then strokes her hands down my thighs. “Why? It was hot. You were amazing.”

I lower myself to her, and kiss her slowly, pushing my leg between her thighs and groaning when I feel how wet she is.

“M…ating…?”

Adora and I both gasp, and I sharply turn to face Melog, watching their tiny form uncurling on the foot of our bed. They look at us from their upside down position, their blue eyes glowing brightly.

“Buddy!” I say, clutching the sheets to my chest, and scurrying over. “You can talk? Already? It’s only been a week!”

Melog sneezes in response, then sits up, scratching their ear. “Mating.”

“Seriously. That’s your first word?”

Melog nods. “Mating.”

I peer back at Adora, finding her sitting upright, the covers held to her chest as she stares wide-eyed at Melog. “Adora? What’s wrong?”

Adora shakes her head quickly, then blinks a few times. “I… I can hear them too.”

“What?! No way!” I say, grinning widely.

She rushes over and bends over next to me, stroking Melog’s head. Then she looks at me, her brows furrowing. “I’m… I’m sorry!”

“Huh? Why?” I ask, tilting my head.

“It’s… your special thing. I don’t want to take that from you.”

“You aren’t,” I say, kissing her cheek. “It’s just another thing I get to share with you.”

“But… Why can I...”

“Hmm, could be because we were both there when they woke up, after...”

Adora nudges her shoulder to mine playfully. “Or it’s because we’re engaged. Maybe they can tell us once they’re bigger.”

Melog makes a quiet whining noise, almost like a sigh, before staring at the two of us. “Steaaak.”

I laugh. “And that’s your second word. Of course it is.”

“Aww, they’re hungry,” Adora says, standing up and rushing over to our bedroom door, closing it. “We should get to the party before they starve.”

--

I’m busy looking in the dresser mirror, deciding whether to fasten the last button up on my red blouse or not, when Adora steps behind me, and wraps an arm around my waist.

“Leave it open,” she whispers, placing her other arm over my shoulder, and resting her hand on my collarbone, just beneath the loose material.

“Okay,” I purr, taking her hand in mine, and raising her fingers to my lips, watching her watch me in the mirror.

“How do the boots feel?” she asks, nuzzling her cheek against mine.

“Hmm,” I say, peering down at the soft grey leather, and wiggling my toes within the confines of the shoe. “Comfortable, but at the same time… weird.”

Adora squeezes her arms around me tightly and kisses my cheek. “You know you can go barefooted, right?”

“True, but,” I say, turning around to face her, and looping my arms around her neck. “I only need my toes out if I need to make a quick getaway.”

“I suppose there’s not an awful lot to run from anymore.”

“Not that I can think of,” I say, smirking. I quickly shift my form around hers, reversing our positions and pushing her against the dresser, resting my hands either side of her on the wooden surface. “There are some things I might run *towards*, though.”

“Such as?” Adora asks, biting her lower lip while peering down at my mouth.

“Such as you, wearing that damn open-backed dress,” I purr, running my palm up the white, silky garment, and pressing my fingers into the dip of her waist.

Adora smiles smugly. “Didn’t you get all this out of your system last night?”

I kiss her, trailing my tongue along her lip. “I’m not sure I could ever get enough of this.”

“Actually I’m pretty sure you asked me to stop after our fourteenth-”

“Pfft, idiot,” I say, silencing her with another kiss, roughly pushing my hips to hers, causing the small bottles of perfume atop of the dresser to fall over with a loud rattle.

“But… We need to feed Melog,” Adora gasps, twitching her hips ever so slightly towards mine.

“We… we do,” I say, shaking my head to clear the sudden brain-fog. “Shit, I’m a terrible mother!” I exclaim, pushing away from the dresser and hurrying towards the bed. I stroke Melog’s sleeping form and turn around to scowl at Adora. “It’s your fault for being so damn irresistible.”

Adora blushes and tucks a few strands of her loose hair behind her ear.

“Steaaaak,” Melog says, glaring at me accusingly.

“Okay, come on buddy,” I say, helping them up onto my right shoulder. “Oh! They’re a little heavier!”

“Are you sure?”

“Yup,” I say, heading over to the wardrobe. I grab my new white and gold-trimmed jacket and flick it over my left shoulder, then clip it in place. “Hey look, now we match!”

“You look…” Adora says, licking her lips. “Beautiful and handsome at the same time. How is that even possible?”

“Because I’m amazing,” I say, winking and holding my hand out. “Come on, let’s get to this dumb party.”

--

We head out of the bedroom, and then down the west hall towards the center of the palace. The celebration, or *Brightmoon Festival* as they’re calling it, is being held in the eastern courtyard. The one with all the stalls and restaurants. Apparently a few of the Amazons arrived today, after Entrapta went to go pick them up in Darla, that is.

“You look deep in thought,” Adora says, squeezing my fingers.

“I was thinking about the party. And the Amazons.”

“Oh, yay! I can’t wait to see them again.”

I wrinkle my nose, and blow out a puff of air.

“You can’t *still* be jealous…”

“I’m not,” I say, shrugging. “You know it takes me a while to like people, Adora.”

Adora hums to herself as we walk through the western entrance into the central gardens. She purses her lips and looks at me, as though in two minds about speaking.

“What? Spit it out, dummy.”

“I actually think you’re getting better at it, you know, the whole making friends thing. In fact, you seem happier in general, lately,” she says, smiling widely. “I’d love to take all the credit, but I’m guessing Perfuma is helping you as much as she is me.”

“Shit!” I say, freezing mid-step.

“What is it?”

“Ugh, damn it. I was supposed to get a dumb book three days ago…”

“So go get it now,” Adora says, pointing towards the south side of the garden. “We’re already here, so you might as well.”

“Yeah, I don’t think I can face her wrath again.”

“She *really* doesn’t like it when you don’t do your homework.”

“Tell me about it,” I say, shaking my head. “The worst part is, she pretends she’s cool about it. But you can tell she isn’t.”

“Okay, well I’ll look after our little pup,” Adora says, gently taking melog from my shoulder and resting them in the crook of her arm, “and I’ll get them all fed while you take care of your book thing.”

“Thanks love,” I say, kissing her cheek. “You’re the best.”

“Yeah I am,” she says, turning back to grin at me, before heading towards the eastern exit.

--

A short while later I step into the library, my golden heels clacking on the dark wooden floor, and I scan my gaze quickly up and down the stacks of shelves until I find the *M-O* section.

“Okay... M… i...,” I mutter, lightly tracing my fingertip across the alphabetically sorted books. “Ah, got it,” I say, pulling out the book in question, titled *Mindfulness for the many*.

I flick through the leatherbound book a few times before snapping it closed and tucking it under my arm, and I’m about to head back to the bedroom to drop it off when I notice Angella’s mural out of the corner of my eye.

I pause mid-step, turning to face it, clutching the book to my chest. *It feels like so long ago*, I think, as I slowly step towards the coloured tiles. *So long ago that I just… lost my shit, right here. But then, if none of that had happened, would I still be here now? Would things have gone the same way? I might never have been talked into therapy. I might never have started to heal.*

I hear footsteps approaching from behind, and peer around my shoulder, watching Angella approach. *And*, I think, smiling, *I might never have rescued her*.

“Catra,” she says, standing beside me. “Shouldn’t you be at the party?”

I peer up at her, wincing. “I was just on my way. I had to get this first,” I say, nodding down at my book.

“Ah. Perfuma’s orders, I assume?”

“Yeah. I keep forgetting to read it, and she gets all cranky about it.”

“I’m sure she has your best interests at heart,” Angella says, before raising her hand and running her fingertips across the tiny mosaic tiles. “You know, we really ought to replace this.”

“Huh? But why?”

“Because I am more than a memory now,” she says, nodding her head down towards me. “Thanks to you, and Melog.”

“Oh, right,” I say, sighing. I’m wondering how to tell her the truth, that I caused it all in the first place, and my lips part open while I try to find the words. But then Angella rests her hand on my shoulder, and gently squeezes her fingers.

“Glimmer told me, by the way. About your… involvement with the portal.”

“Oh,” I say, sighing. I glance upwards, expecting to find her furious. But instead, her expression remains neutral. “I was going to tell you. I just wanted you to not hate me, at least, for a little while longer.”

Angella shakes her head, and crouches down, until her eyes are level with mine. “I do not believe you were yourself at the time. Not even a little bit.”

I flatten my ears, clutching my book more tightly to my chest. “That’s no excuse.”

“It is not. But when one tries as hard as you have to change, and to heal, then... it can be forgiven, at least.”

I sniff, and look down at the floor. “I… don’t think I deserve that, honestly. But thanks.”

Suddenly Angella swoops forwards and pulls me into her arms, holding my head against her chest. “Dear, sweet child. I know how they raised children in the Horde. I even managed to save a few, you know. The fact that you are here today, and are so clearly loved, is testament to the strength of your heart.”

“But… “ I choke, feeling tears stream down my cheeks. “I could have… I mean, I didn’t have to-”

“We *all* make choices that we regret,” Angella says, pulling away and looking at me, smiling sadly. “I know this more than anyone. All we can do is press on, and try to do better. Try to *be* better. And you have outdone us all in that regard.”

“Do you really think so?”

Angella nods and stands up. “I do. Come along then, the festivities are just getting started, and our resident not-hero really ought to be there.”

--

We make it as far as the central gardens, before bumping into Kyle, Lonnie and Rogelio.

“Catra!” Lonnie shouts, waving me over.

“Are these friends of yours?” Angella asks.

I wrinkle my nose. “It’s... complicated.”

“Your majesty,” Kyle says, bowing at the same time as the others.

“Oh, there’s no need for any of that,” Angella says, smiling. “Any friends of Catra are a friend of mine.”

“Uh,” Lonnie says, forcing a smile. “Sure. We go way back.”

“Well then, I’m sure you all have some catching up to do,” Angella says, before ruffling her hand into my hair, and smiling down at me. “I’ll see you at the party, trouble.”

I watch as Angella heads towards the exit, then I blow out a long puff of air, and hug my book to the front of my chest, struggling to understand why she’s being so nice to me, never mind the strange, unfamiliar feelings it stirs.

“Wow,” Lonnie says, raising her eyebrows. “The queen sure seems to like you.”

“Yeah. I guess so,” I say, shrugging. “So what’s up? I thought you didn’t want to see me again.”

“We heard what you did,” Lonnie says, folding her arms and raising an eyebrow. “Sounds like saving people is your thing now. Never would have seen *that* one coming.”

“No. It really isn’t,” I say, frowning.

“First you saved Glimmer,” Kyle says, raising one finger at a time. “Then Adora and probably all of Etheria too, and then Angella!”

“Alright already! Just… stop making a big deal out of it.”

Rogelio grumbles and barks out a few weird sounds, before placing his hand on my shoulder.

“He said he’s proud of you,” Kyle says. “I think we all are, whether you like it or not.”

I twitch my ears, trying to ignore the lump forming in my throat. “Whatever.”

“So are you coming?” Lonnie asks. “Gotta say, I’m looking forward to being at an *actual* party.”

“Yeah, in a minute,” I say. “I need to drop this off first.”

“We’ll see you there, then?” Kyle asks.

“Uh, probably.”

Lonnie pumps her fists in the air. “Come on boys, it’s drinkin’ time! Wooo!”

“Idiots,” I mutter, sniffling as they walk away.

--

I hear the noise from the festivities reverberating all the way down the eastern hall long before I arrive. There’s the constant drone of people talking, high pitched giggles and squeals of excitement from small children, and a band playing music, their drums echoing all around.

When I step out into the courtyard I raise my eyebrows in surprise. The food and drink stalls are trimmed up with decorations, and packed with people eating and drinking. There are balloons everywhere, and brightly coloured streams of paper floating through the air as if by magic. *It probably is magic, actually*, I think grabbing a red strip of paper in my hand.

"Holy shit," I mumble, peering around, narrowly avoiding a couple of young Salinean kids as they run around, giggling. "Hey, careful!"

"Sorry!" they both say, grinning toothilly before running in the opposite direction.

It's a clear, dry day, warm but not boiling hot, which is a good thing because I'm really not dressed for any kind of heat right now. *There might even be rain later*, I think, peering at the clouds in the distance.

"Hey, Catra!" Spinnerella waves from up ahead. She and Netossa are sitting outside the same juice stall that Scorpia and I sometimes drink at, except it looks a little different with hundreds of coloured streamers taped along the front of it.

I join the two of them, sitting in one of the vacant seats. "Hey guys. What's up?"

"Nothing much. Just staying hydrated," Netossa says, nodding at the jug on the table. "Help yourself."

"Thanks," I say, pouring myself a glass of lime juice, and leaning back in the chair.

"Adora was looking for you, by the way," Spinnerella says, beaming. "She said to tell you she's gone to get food."

"Shit," I say, glugging down my drink, "I'd better go find her."

"Hey, not so fast," Netossa says, narrowing her eyes. "There's a rumour going around that you've destroyed your bedroom wall, somehow. Care to fill us in?"

I feel heat rush to my cheeks. "No, I don't."

"Sweetheart, don't pick on her," Spinnerella says, placing a hand on Netossa's arm. "Though I have to say, it sounds like you girls are having lots of fun."

"Ah, to be young and in love," Netossa says, placing her hand over Spinnerella's.

"I think I'll leave you two lovebirds to it," I say, standing up. "Thanks for the drink, by the way."

"Any time," Netossa says, smirking and then puckering her lips. "Say hi to Adora for us."

"Ugh, whatever," I say, putting the glass down and scowling at Netossa, before turning around and heading towards the main courtyard. I hear them both giggling as I leave, and it makes my cheeks burn all the more. *I'll never hear the end of this one*, I think. But then I smile to myself, knowing I'd do it all over again.

--

I arrive at the main courtyard, having lost count of how many people I've bumped into along the way. Usually it'd irritate me but the buzz in the air is palpable, and everyone's spirits are high.

There are long tables set out, each covered with light purple tablecloths, and teeming with various foods, snacks and drinks. Along one side of the tables there's a makeshift cooking area, with several outdoor grills and a marquee providing shade from the occasional bright sunlight.

I grab an apple from one of the fruit bowls, and bite into it while heading towards the grill, finding Dumpling there. He's facing away, busy preparing sandwiches.

"Hi Dumpling," I say, swaying my tail slightly. "How's it going?"

"Brother!" Dumpling explains, spinning to face me, holding a butter knife in his hand. "I have missed you, so much!"

I burst into laughter, noticing Dumpling's bright pink hair, and an even brighter sleeveless pink leather jacket with rainbow badges, and stubby silver spikes all around.

"Missed you too, buddy," I say, tilting my head. "You look ridiculous by the way."

"Thank you, brother!" Dumpling says, smiling brightly. "The market sells so many wonders."

"Oh yeah, tell me about it," I say, grinning toothilly. "I hear Stan's been keeping you busy?"

"I'm learning so much," Dumping says, winking at me. "He is *really* good in the kitchen!"

"Catra!" Stan beams, walking into the grill area while carrying a large transparent container, full of various meats. "So good of you to finally join us. I saved the best steak for you, yes? A big, fat, juicy T-bone."

I lick my lips, and feel my belly growl. "Sounds perfect. I just need to find Adora first."

"Brother Adora already went to the dining hall," Dumpling says.

"Uhh…"

"The big, orange tent," Stan says, pointing towards the large, grassy outdoor area which spans outwards from the east side of the courtyard. "If you give me five minutes you can take this with you!"

"Hmm, yes please," I say, quickly finishing off my apple.

"You heard the lady," Stan says, placing his hands on Dumpling's shoulders. "Let's get grilling!"

"Yes, brother!" Dumpling says, blushing brightly, then watching closely as Stan tenderises the meat, salts it, and throws it on the burning-hot grill.

"Only use salt to season. And make sure the grill is hot, yes!"

Dumpling nods.

"A minute or so, turn. Another minute or so. Turn!"

"Make it rare, Stan," I say, rubbing my hands together.

Stan twists his head around to face me. "As if I don't know that by now? Hah!"

I chuckle, watching the two of them work together, with Stan patiently explaining what to look for, such as juices seeping from the surface of the meat, and how soft it should feel to know how cooked it is. *Hmm, they make a cute couple*, I think, eagerly holding my hands out when they pass a plate across.

“Wow, that’s huge!” I say, grinning widely. “Thanks, boys.”

Stan wraps his arm around Dumpling’s waist, and Dumpling’s eyes sparkle. “I can now make big, bony steak!”

“Haha!” Stan laughs loudly, slapping Dumpling on his bottom. “It’s t-bone, I told you this! The bone is shaped like a T!”

“Oh, of course!”

I smile widely at them both, before heading towards the table with salad and rolls, which I stack up onto the side of my plate. Then I hurry towards the orange tent, being careful to not bump into anyone.

--

I walk beneath the shade of the giant, orange marquee cover, wondering how I’ll ever find anyone in here. The area is huge, at least four times the size of the kitchen, with at least twenty long, wooden tables set out. I run the numbers quickly in my head, and work out that there’s room for around four hundred people, although it’s only at half capacity right now.

I step across the dry grass, peering across the rows and rows of tables, looking for at least one familiar face when suddenly, I’m roughly tackled from the side.

“There you aaare!” Adora says, throwing her arms around me and kissing my cheek. “You were gone for ages!”

“Woah! Steak” I say, gripping the plate protectively.

“Wow, that’s a big one, -*hic*-.”

“Adora,” I say, wrinkling my nose. “Are you drunk, already?!”

“Lil bit,” she says, smiling smugly. “It’s their fault!” she says, pointing towards the table in the far corner, where I can see the amazons standing around, each of them busy swigging down one large drink after another.

“I hope Micah brought enough booze for them,” I say, shaking my head while following Adora to the table, where I finally spot everyone else.

“Catra!” Calisto says, raising a glass, alongside Mauve, Zara and three other bronze-skinned Amazons that I don’t recognise.

“Yay! You’re here!” Scorpia says, beaming. She and Perfuma are both covered head to toe in coloured chalk. “You missed the colour run!”

“Sounds messy,” I say, sitting down next to Scorpia, grabbing cutlery from the center of the table, and eagerly slicing into my steak. I pop a small piece into my mouth, my eyes watering at the perfect salty taste, and soft, tender texture.

”There’s another in an hour,” Adora says, sitting on my right and resting her hand in her chin. “I waited for you, so we can do it together.”

“Thanks,” I mumble, taking another bite of my food. “That’s so thoughtful of you.”

“I’m a good girlfriend, and you know it,” Adora says, scrunching up her nose.

I put my knife down and point my index finger to her forehead, then push it gently, just like I used to do when we were kids. “You’re okay, I guess.”

“Shh, you looove me,” Adora says, taking a swig of her drink. “Also, you should try one of these. They’re yummy.”

“What are they?”

“There’s like lemon, and orange, and other fruity stuff,” Mermista says, before taking a sip.

“And *plenty* of alcohol,” Sea Hawk says, winking.

“Wouldn’t know, since I’m not allowed it,” Frosta says, folding her arms. She sips at a smaller cup, frowning at everyone over the rim of her glass.

Perfuma starts to refill everyone's drink, and nods towards my empty cup. “Would you like to try it?”

“Sure, why not,” I say, shrugging before returning to my delicious steak. “Where’s Melog, by the way?”

“They’re asleep on my lap right now,” Scorpia says, grinning widely. “They’re soo -*hic*- cute, shhh.”

“Hah, are you getting tipsy? That's not like you.”

“When there is no danger, we can all loosen up a little,” Perfuma says, placing the filled-up glass next to my plate. “But still, please do not feel pressured. We would all understand.”

“I just want you to try it cos it’s tasty,” Adora says, beaming. “Besides, I don’t need you to be drunk to get my way with y-”

I kick her under the table, and she yelps, rubbing her calf.

“No danger other than my loud-mouthed girlfriend,” I mutter.

“Fiancee.”

“Girlfriend, fiancee, but mainly pain in my ass,” I say, rolling my eyes. “So, where’s everyone else?”

“Entrapta is watching us all from that hut over there,” Scorpia says, tipping her head towards the distance. “Bow and Glimmer are… Um, you know, I have no idea. They were here earlier.”

“They did appear to leave in a hurry,” Perfuma says, a small smirk apparent on her lips as she presses her fingertips together. “I am sure they are peacefully… meditating together.”

“Hah, meditating,” Adora snorts, resting her chin in her palms. “Good one.”

--

I'm half-way through my steak when a flurry of movement catches my attention, and I twist my head to find a group of pale bodies stumbling in, barely holding each other upright.

"Haha!" Adora suddenly bursts out laughing. "That's… that's amazing!"

"Wow, they're so pretty" Perfuma exclaims, clapping her hands.

"You've got to be shitting me," I say, quickly swallowing down my current mouthful.

The clones appear somewhat less than sober, each one dusted from head to toe in coloured chalk. And every single one of them has brightly-coloured hair, from every colour of the rainbow. Some have stripes of two colours. Some with three. And then there's one with bright red hair, spiked up into an impossibly tall wedge.

The spikey-haired one notices me looking, and wobbles over to where I'm sitting. "Catra. -*hic*- Thank you for your earlier advice. I hope this is better?"

I burst out into laughter. "Seriously? Are all clones this goofy? I thought it was just Dumpling."

"Dumpling helped us to find the dye!" the clone says, beaming proudly.

"Okay, spike. Whatever you say."

"Spike? Is that my name?"

"Um."

"I like it, very -*hic*- much! Thank you, Catra," he says, beaming widely. "I feel like I want to become very punk-rock. Or at least I think that's how they say it."

"Literally nobody says that, Spike."

"Well then, I shall return to my brothers," he says, pointing at nothing in particular, then stumbling, and landing flat on his ass.

"Brother!" the others yell, quickly surrounding him and helping him to his feet.

I watch as they flock to a vacant table, and begin to pour more drinks. *A bunch of drunk clones*, I think, chewing on my steak. *What could possibly go wrong?*

"Well they're having fun," Adora says, chuckling. "I guess you'll have to name all of them now."

"Um, no. Not gonna happen," I say, shaking my head, and returning my attention to the rest of my food. Or at least, to the empty plate where it used to be. "What the hell?! Melog!" I exclaim, watching their tiny form drag the large slab of steak across the middle of the table.

"Hah, they must be hungry again!" Mauve says, picking the steak up, with little Melog refusing to let go and dangling in the air. "If you let go, I'll cut it up for you, small one."

Melog opens their mouth and sits down, watching Mauve attentively.

"I mean sure, I didn't want it anyway," I mutter, shrugging, and grabbing my drink.

"Catra," Mauve says, passing a triangle of meat to Melog. "Adora told us what happened. How is it that they survived?"

“I don’t know for sure,” I say, pausing to sip at my drink. “But they said we had a strong bond, so I guess that helped somehow. Uh, not that I’m saying you and Lydia didn’t-”

Mauve smiles. “I am not offended. Lydia and I were very close, but had only been bond mates for a few days.”

“I’m sorry…”

“Don’t be,” Mauve says, passing over the last four pieces of steak on a small plate, for Melog to chew on at their own pace. “They have returned to the cosmos, at least, that’s what they told me during the… process.”

“Damn golems just doing whatever they want, huh,” I say, peering over my glass as Melog chews into the second piece of steak. “Where are you even fitting all of that, buddy?”

Melog looks up at me, and burps, before continuing to attack the meat.

“Aww, so cute,” Adora says, her eyes almost sparkling as she watches them. “I wonder what Swifty is up to these days.”

“Still not seen them?”

“You talking about the annoying flying rainbow horse?” Huntara asks, and I almost jump out of my seat.

“How the hell do you sneak up on people like that!?”

Huntara smirks, and peers down at me. “If you’re nice to me, maybe I’ll show you one day.”

“You’ve seen swiftwind?” Adora asks.

“Yeah, he’s chilling out in the wastes. Says he’ll be back in a couple of weeks.”

“Why the hell would he be- you know what, I don’t care,” I say, shrugging.

“Anyway, where’s all the booze!?” Huntara asks loudly, resting her hands on her hips.

“We have the booze!” Zara yells, holding up a jug and then downing the contents while the other amazons cheer her on.

Huntara grins toothilly and storms towards the several crates of alcohol that the Amazons seem to have stockpiled around the table. She grabs an entire keg, pops open the cork at the bottom, and holds it above her head, glugging the contents for two minutes solid before burping loudly. “Ah, I needed that. They ran out in the other tent.”

Calisto watches the whole thing with one eyebrow raised, and a smirk curling up one side of her lips. She holds a hand out towards Huntara. “Hi, gorgeous. I’m Calisto. But you can call me Cal.”

“And you can call me interested,” Huntara says, beaming widely as she takes Cal’s hand, raises it to her lips, and kisses her knuckles.

“I guess she’s found a wife,” I say, muttering the words quietly. Adora hears though, and bursts out laughing, then almost falls off of her chair.

--

A few drinks later, I'm feeling comfortably buzzed. Scorpia and Perfuma are snoozing on each other's shoulders, as are Mermista and Sea Hawk. Frosta has gone back to her kingdom, thanks to the snazzy new teleporters. Melog is fast asleep on their plate, having somehow finished off the rest of the steak, and the Amazons are as loud, drunk and boisterous as ever, probably due to the fact that they're trying, and failing, to out-drink Huntara.

"Hey, baby," Adora says, nudging herself against my shoulder. "Let's go do the paint thing."

"Sure, sounds fun," I say, standing up and stretching out. "Mauve, can you keep an eye on Melog?"

"Of course," she says, smiling. "I doubt they will move any time soon, though."

"Thanks," I say, taking Adora's hand, and stumbling out of the marquee with her, only then realising that I'm more than a little drunk. I squint up at the overcast sky, and then across the courtyard, smiling at the sight of children running around with balloon strings in their hands.

"Oh hey, it looks like you," Adora says, pointing at one of the balloons.

"That's just an orange cat, Adora," I say, shaking my head. "How wasted are you?"

"Wasted enough that I feel like pouncing on you, right now."

"Well," I say, chuckling, "That's good to know. But please don't."

"Awww…"

"Can you imagine the outrage," I chuckle, following her further and further across the dry, grassy field. "Adorable little Adora, in a public -*hic*- sex scandal. Tsk tsk."

"I meant somewhere private," Adora says, pouting. "I know a place."

"Is that so," I say, gripping her hand more tightly. "How about we do this dumb paint thing, and then you show me."

"It's not dumb! It's fun!" Adora exclaims, tugging my arm, and leading me towards a large fenced area, within which are several colourful, squishy-looking slides and obstacles. "And we're just in time!"

"Oh wait, that's -*hic*- the guy from Crabs r us, isn't it?" I ask, narrowing my eyes at the guy standing in front of the entrance gate.

"It's Cranky Crab," Adora says, laughing, "And yes, that's D."

"Hello ladies," D says, his long moustache twitching as he smiles at me, then gestures into the entryway. "Go on in, it's just getting started."

"What, that's it?" I say, frowning as I follow Adora through the entrance, and into the area proper.

"I told you people will forgive you," Adora says, quickly kissing my cheek, before tugging me towards the other contenders, who're already lined up in a row. "Now, get ready to lose."

"Wait, I don't even know what we're-"

“Go!” Micah yells, his voice amplified by a large cone.

“-doing,” I say, watching everyone storm off ahead, before grunting, kicking off my boots and jacket, and then breaking into a sprint, quickly catching the others up.

I clamber up the first obstacle, a long, steep slide, and I’m halfway up it when Adora’s head peers over from the ledge at the top. “Hey, Catra!”

“What?”

The next thing I know she throws a small pouch at me, and it hits my shoulder, exploding on impact, a rainbow of chalk blasting into my face. “Seriously?! Just you wait!” I yell, redoubling my efforts.

I soon climb to the top of the slide, finding lots of the same, small pouches that Adora threw stacked up in buckets, and I grab a few, tucking them into my trousers before dashing onto the next part of the obstacle course.

“Gotcha,” I mutter, running alongside Adora then elbowing her out of the way and leaping ahead of her. I spin around mid-sprint and launch a pouch straight into her chest, turning her into a walking rainbow.

“Haha!” Adora giggles, pausing to reach down her bra and pull out another one of the small sacks.

“Oh, nicely improvised,” I say, ducking under the projectile, and then running ahead of her. “But you’re too slow, Adora.”

Adora smirks, and watches me as I stumble into a pit, falling headfirst into a mountain of coloured sand. “Maybe you should pay attention to where you’re going,” she says, reaching down and taking my hand, helping me up. “Though I know you can’t help but stare at me.”

“Whatever,” I say, kissing her chalk-covered cheek and quickly dashing away, or I would have, if not for Adora tugging at my blouse, sending me hurtling back into the pit. She turns around and blows me a kiss, before running ahead.

“You… you little shit!”

--

Some time later, Adora and I finish the race, placing dead last and second to last. “Ladies and gentlemen, the heroes of Etheria!” Micah says, laughing loudly while slowly clapping his hands.

I point a finger at him. “Hey. I told you not to call me that.”

“Sorry, our hero and not-hero!”

Everyone cheers and claps, and I roll my eyes, taking a bow alongside Adora. Then she wraps an arm around my shoulder and we walk towards the drinks stand, helping ourselves to some chilled lemonade.

Micah joins us, wafting his hand at his face. “Man, it sure is hot.”

“Yeah, it’s getting warmer,” I say, holding the cold glass to my cheek. “And sticky, too. There’s going to be a storm.”

“So, did you both enjoy the race?”

“It was awesome!” Adora says, grinning widely, before taking a few steps backwards. I frown, wondering what she’s up to.

“Yeah, it was kind of fun,” I say, swigging at my drink. “Adora cheated, though.”

“Hah, says you!” She exclaims, before reaching down her top and pulling out another small sack, and grinning maniacally before she launches it at me.

“Adora, no!” I laugh, holding my free hand out, and bracing for impact. But it never comes.

“Well *that* was unexpected,” Micah says.

“Um, Catra?”

I open my eyes, startled to see the pouch levitating in front of me, surrounded by a familiar, blue glow, and my first instinct is to look around for Melog. But, then I remember that they’re back in the tent, fast sleep.

“Is that,” I say, knitting my brows together, watching as the blue glow fades, and the pouch falls to the floor. “Was that me!?”

“It appears so!” Micah says, beaming.

“This is nothing to smile about! What the hell just happened!?”

“Melog gave you part of their life force,” Adora says, stepping forwards and resting her hands upon my waist. “So maybe you got their magic, too.”

“It’s a plausible explanation,” Micah, says, holding a hand to his chin. “Well, I guess you really are a MAGI-cat now, huh?”

“Actually, a lot of my people can use magic, or they could. Hence the name,” I say, shrugging. I notice Adora’s surprised expression. “What? I’ve been reading up on it, that’s all.”

“Magicats really are one of the more mysterious races on Etheria, you know,” Micah says, holding a hand to his mouth and whispering. “Some say they’re from a different planet entirely.”

“Yes, but that’s probably just a wild rumour.”

“If it were true, though,” Adora says, grinning, “it’d mean we’re both from other planets!”

“I’m pretty sure I was born here, Adora.”

Micah raises his eyebrows. “How can you be so sure?”

I twitch my tail. “Because sometimes I remember… *stuff*. Ugh, I’m not talking about this right now,” I say, shaking my head, and looking down at my hands. “I need to get my head around whatever the hell Melog’s done to me first.”

“Hey, you’ll be okay,” Adora says, pulling me into her arms, and kissing my cheek. “And whatever they’ve done, it won’t be anything bad. We’ll work it out,” she continues, resting her lips by my ear and whispering. “Just imagine all the fun we can have if you can turn us invisible…”

“I’m… going to pretend I didn’t hear that,” Micah says, smiling awkwardly.

I raise an eyebrow at Adora, thinking she’s just made a really good point, when suddenly, the skies above rumble loudly, and small droplets of rain pour down. I tip my head backwards, close my eyes and sigh, enjoying the cooling drops of moisture on my face. But then they turn into larger, faster drops, and before long it’s a complete downpour.

“Shit! My boots!” I exclaim, running back down the side of the obstacle course, my bare feet slapping across the suddenly sodden ground, and Adora giggling as she follows behind.

“See you in an hour, girls,” Micah yells. “It’s the main speech! Don’t forget!”

“We won’t!” Adora yells back.

--

“Oh no, they’re drenched!” I exclaim. I stand under the shelter of the entryway, tip the boots upside down, and watch streams of water trickle from them. “And my jacket’s even worse.”

“For what it’s worth, you look incredibly hot right now,” Adora purrs, running her gaze over my drenched clothing, the red shirt and black trousers stuck to my skin.

I peer up at her, only then noticing the outline of her curves beneath the damp fabric of her white and rainbow-splotched dress. “You always think I look hot,” I say, chewing at my lip. “You’re just a horny little shit, Adora.”

She steps forward and rests her lips next to my ear. “Says you. I see you looking, baby.”

“Hmm. So, what were you saying about a private area,” I say, running my finger over the coloured chalk on Adora’s nose, smearing it across her face.

Her lips stretch into a huge, smug smile, and she takes my hand. “Follow me.”

--

Some time later we race towards the main courtyard, finding that all the tables have been removed, and a huge crowd of people are standing around, facing a raised platform that’s at the edge of the area, just where the grill was earlier.

“Did we make it?” I ask, flattening my shirt down.

“I think so,” Adora says, her cheeks still appearing flushed from our little adventure. “At least it’s stopped raining now.”

I lace my fingers with hers, and we stand at the back of the crowd, waiting.

“Oh there you are,” Glimmer says, hurrying over to us. “Come with me!”

“What, why?” I ask, as we follow her around the outskirts of the bustling crowd.

“You’ll see,” she says, holding out her hands, which we both take. A moment later we’re inside an enclosed area, but I can still hear the din of people talking nearby.

“Glimmer?” I ask, frowning.

“We’re behind the stage. Don’t freak out, but Mother wants to give you both medals.”

“Um, how about no.”

Adora wrinkles her nose. “Yeah, we don’t really need-”

“Guys, it isn’t for you,” Glimmer says, folding her arms, and shaking her head. “I-I mean it kind of is, but it’s also for the people. Some of them lost their homes, or more, these past few years. The celebration may have lifted their spirits, but they need heroes. They need to feel safe.”

“But I don’t-” I begin, peering at Adora. She looks back at me and shrugs.

“It’s just a ceremony. It doesn’t cost us anything, Catra. And if it helps...”

“Fine!” I snap, folding my arms. “But I’m retiring after this.”

--

We stand behind the platform, and listen in while Angella and Micah address the audience. They talk about peace, and hope, and everything that I guess people need to hear right now, but I don’t pay much attention because Adora’s looking at me in that certain way that always gets my attention, a smug smile creeping onto her lips.

“What?” I ask, grinning.

“I was just thinking about earlier,” she says, her cheeks turning pink.

“Adora,” I laugh, feeling warmer all of a sudden. “Stop it. Seriously.”

“Maybe we could try that invisibility thing later… I know you can work it out.”

“Invisibility thing?” Bow asks, raising an eyebrow.

“She has Melog’s powers now.”

“WHAT?!” Glimmer whispers loudly. “Since when?”

“I don’t know if I can turn invisible, idiot!” I say, barely keeping my voice down. “I don’t even know how I did what I did!”

“Even if she could turn invisible, that’s the first place your mind goes? Seriously, Adora?” Glimmer asks, prodding a finger into her chest.

“Hey,” Adora says, folding her arms and smiling smugly. “I meant I could help her work it out. I never said why, so that’s your own filthy mind at work, Glimmer.”

“Yeah, Glimmer,” I say, batting my tail against her arm. “You and your filthy mind.”

“What, but I-”

And now, please join me in celebrating the heroes of Etheria!

The crowd suddenly roars loudly, sounding even wilder than the day Angella came back, just a week ago, where we held a smaller, impromptu celebration for whoever happened to be around at the time.

“Okay, you’re up,” Glimmer says, rolling her eyes. “Don’t be nervous, you don’t have to talk or anything.”

“But maybe smile, or wave at least,” Bow says, wincing.

“Fine,” I say, narrowing my eyes at the two of them. “By the way, Bow’s shirt is on inside out.”

I chuckle to myself, watching their expressions become mortified, and then take calm, controlled breaths while Adora and I walk out onto the platform together.

“Catra, Adora,” Angella says, bowing her head slightly. “We are all so incredibly grateful for your selfless deeds. You have saved us all, some of us more than once, actually.”

The crowd laughs, and I kind of zone out for a while, looking across the endless rows of people. There’s so many faces, so many people, and not one of them is looking at me like they hate me, or like they’re repulsed in any way. They’re smiling, and cheering, and it’s just so... *surreal*.

“Catra?” Angella asks, holding a medal up.

“Oh, sorry,” I say, dipping my head.

Angella places the loose red loop around my neck, and I grab the fist-sized golden star at the end of it, peering down at the small writing etched on the back.

Catra. Thank you for saving us all, but more importantly, for saving yourself. Always look forwards, and never forget that you deserve to be loved. -A

I feel a lump form in my throat. “Um, thanks,” I mumble, glancing nervously at the crowd.

Adora turns to face me, and takes my hands in hers, smirking. “Hey. Want to put on a show?”

“What? No, Adora-”

She leans forwards and presses her lips to mine, much to the delight of the roaring crowd. And then, before I even know what’s happening she shifts up into She-Ra, holding me up while never breaking the kiss. The crowd loves it, yelling and cheering more loudly than ever, and when they start to chant our names I get caught up in the moment, eagerly kissing her back, smirking against her lips.

“Thank you, heroes!” Angella yells, waving to the crowd. She places her hand over her mouth, quietly adding, “perhaps you two should retire to your room. Do try not to destroy any more walls, though.”

“We’ll try, your majesty,” Adora says, grinning before carrying me to the back of the stage.

“Adora! What the hell was that!?” I exclaim, shaking my head.

She shrinks back down to her usual size, and winces. “I’m sorry. I just… got carried away...”

“Carried away? We just made out, right in front of everyone!”

Adora smiles smugly. “Now that you mention it, yes *we* did. I’m pretty sure you were kissing me back, after all.”

“Pfft. You’re just a bad influence,” I say, resting my hands behind her neck, and pulling her close to me for a long, sensual kiss. “But I kind of like that I’m so irresistible to you.”

“You really are,” Adora says, squeezing her hands into my butt.

“Pfft, stop it,” I say, laughing.

“But it’s so squishy,” she says, pouting.

“It is not squishy! It’s firm!”

“It’s squishy *and* firm.”

“Okay, can you both *please* stop talking about Catra’s ass,” Glimmer says, pinching the bridge of her nose.

“Nice show, by the way,” Bow says, grinning. “You really got them going.”

“I think they got each other going more,” Glimmer mutters.

“Hey,” Adora says, puffing her chest out, “at least we can dress ourselves properly after a good-”

“Do *not* finish that sentence, Adora,” I say, placing my hand over her mouth.

“Anyway, there’s an after-party going on for the next few hours,” Bow says, his eyes widening with excitement, “in the orange tent. Please say you’re coming.”

“Well she was earli-”

“Adora. No.”

Glimmer holds her hand to her mouth, covering a sudden snort of laughter.

“Don’t you start, sparkles,” I say, frowning. “We were headed there anyway. I have to check on Melog.”

“Yay! Party! Party!” Adora says, walking beside Bow, the two of them raising their fists into the air and cheering each other on.

“Do you ever feel like they have *too* much energy?” I ask, walking beside Glimmer.

“Ugh, tell me about it,” she says, her shoulders slumping. “I just want to go to bed.”

“Me too. But we’ll let them get it out of their system first, right?”

“Right.”

--

The rest of the day goes by in a blur, until it’s just myself, Melog and Adora on the rooftops of Brightmoon palace, laying down side by side on a blanket and staring up at the countless dazzling stars which are scattered across the night sky.

“Well, that was some party,” I say, squeezing Adora’s hand.

“You can say that again,” she says, smiling at me, then bursting into laughter. “I can’t believe Sea Hawk set fire to our table.”

“Pfft. Or that the clones did the conga.”

“You led them!” Adora says, laughing more loudly. “It was *your* idea!”

“Hey, Lonnie was practically pouring alcohol down my throat.”

Adora’s laughter dies down a little. “You seem sober enough now, though.”

“I am,” I say, taking a deep breath. The air is crisp and clear thanks to the storm, and it’s a much welcome change after the humidity earlier on. “It was a nice idea, by the way. Coming up here again.”

I notice Melog shift on my abdomen, and peer down, finding that they’re now on their back, still very much asleep, with their tiny paws in the air. I chuckle to myself, and can’t help but stroke my finger across their fluffy little belly.

“I guess it’s our thing now, right?” Adora asks, her blue eyes piercing into mine.

“Yeah. It is,” I say, tearing my gaze away from hers, and peering up at the stars above. “Hey, I was thinking…”

“Hmm?”

“I’ve heard some rumours about this place… well, it’s underground. Hidden away somewhere.”

“You mean Halfmoon?”

“Wait,” I say, twitching my ears. “How do you know about it?”

“I always thought you’d want to chase down your people at some point,” Adora says, shrugging. “So I’ve been doing my own research.”

“Of course you have,” I say, shaking my head, and grinning. “Maybe we could go look for it some day.”

“Yeah,” Adora says, running her fingertips along my open palm. “Maybe we could.”

“But I still think we should look for Eternia, too.”

“One thing at a time, stargazer,” Adora says, lacing her fingers with mine, and squeezing them tightly. “How about we get married first?”

“Hah! Just like that, huh?”

“Tomorrow?”

“What?! No!” I say, grinning from ear to ear. “Please don’t tell me you’ve arranged something.”

Adora pouts. “I might have.”

“Adora!”

“Fine, I’ll cancel it then.”

“You know what, don’t. Let’s do it.”

Adora’s eyes widen. “Really?”

“Yeah. Really. If we only live once, we should make the most of it, right?”

Adora grins. “I hadn’t actually arranged anything. But now I’m going to.”

I shake my head, smiling. “You’re *such* an idiot.”

“Yeah, I know,” she says, blinking at me slowly.

And I blink back, my heart feeling more full of warmth than ever. I finally get it. It isn’t just that I’m in love with her. It’s that Adora is my person, my soul mate, and she always has been. Just like I’m hers, and I always will be.

“I love you,” I say.

“I love you, too.”

I smile, staring back into her beautiful blue eyes, knowing that whatever happens next, be it finding out where we came from, working out my strange, new magic, or even exploring the furthest reaches of space, we’ll be okay. Because from now on, we’ll be there for one another. Together always, and forever.

- x -

Chapter End Notes

Mermista: Wait, that's it? There's no more?
Sea Hawk: Does it matter? You can always read it again!
Mermista: Ugh. But I want moooore.
Adora: Oh! We could make another book and call it "Lesbians in space!"
Catra: Adora. No.

Three months and 120k words later, it's a wrap! Thank you, dear readers, for following me on this adventure, and even forgiving me the occasional cliffhanger. It's been an absolute blast.

Bonus: In case you missed it, this is the scene that caused the bedroom destruction.

Oh and here's the cheeky sex scene from this chapter!

BONUS#2, LOOK AT THIS BBY (and their momma)!> Thanks, dessertsoul1217!!

ALMA
MIRAMONTES

End Notes

Thank you for reading - if you liked this story, please leave kudos! :)
Feel welcome to leave comments, feedback & ideas / headcanons (so long as you don't mind them potentially being used!).

Come say hello on my blog-thing or my twitter!

Join our she ra discord! It's very gay! (Grownups only, please)

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!